What if I trust - A crimson Tale

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by ForthehonorofMe

Summary

What if Catra stays in the Crimson Waste in S3, after Scorpia offers to stay with her?

Catra decides to go for it, to leave her old life behind and make a new start. She stays in the Crimson Waste and is the new leader of it. She has everything she ever wanted. She is free and serves no one.
Still it´s not perfect. Catra feels something missing.
One day an intrudor shows up and is messing up her life that has just been put right.
And this time she may not be able to restore it ...

Notes

This is my first work.
English is not my first language, so feel free to correct my writing! Also any form of (constructive) criticism is welcome! :)

Chapter 1

Catra:

„Didn´t you hear me? Move faster, you idiot!" The lizard with the ugly face nods terrified and hurries up to pile the boxes full of new weapons and then bolts out of the hall. An eye – rolling Catra looks after the assistant, who manages to get out of her sight as soon as possible. With her head shaken, the Magicat turns away and looks down at the boxes at her feet.

Cautiously she bends down and pulls out a saber to take a closer look. The weapons are in a really good condition, she observes satisfied. The dexterity of the Crimson Occupants is getting better. Not yet perfect, but much better than it was a year ago.

A faint smirk comes across her face, as she remembers the little knife she took from one of those gang idiots a year ago, at her arrival at the Crimson Waste. It had been sloppily processed, no comparison to these new pieces. Satisfied, she puts the saber back in the box to look at the rest of the contents. The weapons are very different: Swords, arches, slingshots and one weapon Catra likes in particular. It was invented just recently by some of the talented engineers of the former gangs: Some kind of pistol, which is held with both hands and from which stones the size of the palm of the hand are shot at their victims.

For Comparison, the Magicat´s gaze snaps to her own weapons. A dagger and the whip she took from Tung Lashor back then. Both weapons are always strapped at her belt, because even if she is the leader of the Crimson Occupants, she´s not so stupid as to believe that she can wander around unprotected and be safe. Even in her own room. Not that anyone dared to attack the strongest of the Crimson Waste, but still. And it doesn´t bother Catra to constantly walk around armed.

She is used to that permanent vigilance. In a way it almost feels native, because at this point the Crimson Waste doesn´t

distinguish itself from the Horde. The thought of her former home immediately creates a dark cloud over Catra`s good mood. Anger grips her, as she resolutely waves her hands to vanish it and turns away. She forbids herself to think about her previous life. She left it behind and made a new start. At least that is what she tells herself. Resolutely she marches out of the small hall.

When she steps out the door, she turns to the two guys she has posted as guards in front of the room. "No one enters this room without my permission. We can´t risk the boxes to be stolen. Understand?! And tomorrow you will take them to the Warehouse!", Catra demands harsh and louring. Inwardly she has to grin, as she notices the legs of the guards beginning to flicker. "Y-yes, strongest!", one finally replies. With a silent nod the leader of the Crimson Waste turns around and leaves the building made of stone. It is much more resilient than the previous shacks the occupants called their home.

When Catra steps outside, she remembers how she changed this circumstances a year ago. How she turned a few refugee villages into strong and robust cities. For that she used the knowledge she gained back in the Ho- She stops herself from continuing that thought. Back when I lived another life, she corrects herself.
But she didn´t change everything.

Composed, Catra strolls through the streets out of the city and into the unspoiled part of the Waste. Here she pauses for a moment and stretches her face towards the bright afternoon sun. It shines warm at her face, and because she does not perceive anyone in her vicinity, she allows herself one moment of tranquility. To let go of the thoughts that bother her. To just be herself for one secound. But she doesn´t succeed.

This isn´t news for Catra, so she just blinks a few times towards the sky and continues her walk. She can´t relax, can´t let got. The risk of someone stabbing her in the back is too high.
To prevent that she has to stay in control.

At a rockface she stops and jumps up gritty. Her claws find a lot of grip under the rough, uneven rock, and so she starts climbing the wall. She climbs effortlessly in the hope that her occupation will steer her thoughts in other directions.

There was a time when it was different. Back then she could relax, felt safe, at least as far as the circumstances allowed. She was able to trust.
When this thought penetrates her consciousness, she grabs a new hold with her hand, but misses and slips. Before she knows it, she falls a few meters into the deep. Startled, she rams her claws into the rock as hard as she can and roars in pain as the stone scratches her nails like a huge sharp file. But her maneuver works and she can slow down her fall in order to find the right footing again. She pauses for a moment and only hears her loud gasps and the soft whistling of the warm wind.

As she looks up at the end of the rock face, anger and ferocious determination grab her. She can´t be stopped by something like that. She's Catra, she's been through a lot worse. Such a small rough rock will not conquer her! Spurred on by her thoughts, she feels new energy flowing through her muscles and makes a determined leap upwards. And then another. And another one. After a few jumps, she reaches the end. As safe as a cat, she lands on the top of the rock face in one leap and lets her gaze wander over the new perspective like a military leader over a newly conquered land. The view from up here is breathtaking. The blue sky contrasts beautifully with the red of the sand and the rocks of the desert. The city can be seen from the distance as a white dot between all the red.

Thoughtfully, Catra looks at the horizon. Of course - the Crimson Waste can, especially for outsiders, be a place of hell that hides death traps everywhere and, if you are not careful, devours you alive. But this place is more than that. It has a wild beauty about it, raw and untouched, which cannot be tamed by anyone and which does not follow any rules. A little like herself, thinks Catra,

now almost amused. She has given the Crimson Occupants a little structure and better living conditions, but she has not changed the desert itself. Nobody could do that, and she doesn't even want to.

Absently, she gazes at the land at her feet before feeling pain in her fingers. Immediately she remembers the painful maneuver and looks down at her hands to assess the damage. Little rivulets of blood run between her fingers and her claws look terrible to say the least. A couple of nails just broke off, others splintered or split open.
But it is not permanent damage. Her claws will grow back quickly. Even if it's a shame.

Catra grumpily clenches her hand into a fist and looks into space. She should have been more careful! If only her thoughts hadn't distracted her so much! A snort full of frustration escapes her and she furiously kicks a stone away from her foot. Usually she is in control. She is focused and doesn´t let herself get distracted. In her position she cannot allow even one mistake. And yet it happens. Not often, and not accidentally. Only when she thinks of -

Quickly, the Magicat suppresses her thoughts by simply starting to run. She runs away, as fast as she can. Maybe her thoughts can´t reach her then, maybe they aren't running as fast as she is. Maybe she can escape them.

Hours later, long since evening, she reached the huge building in the middle of the city. It is the first building erected in Catra's name and has many functions. She can gather the residents of the Crimson Waste in the great hall, important things can be planned, discussed and managed, and sometimes parties are also held here. But most importantly, this is where Catra has set up her room. That´s exactly where she´s headed, because she is tired from running so much. Before she went back into town, she did a quick wash of the cat so that no one notices how exhausted she

is. That would be a sign of weakness, and weakness is not allowed here if you want to survive.

Tired, but in a much better mood than a few hours ago, she pushes open the front door and ignores the guards standing next to it. Purposefully, she walks through the corridors, heading for her room when a voice holds her back. "Catra, there you are! I was already worried!" As the Magicat turns around, she sees Scorpia running towards her. She knows Scorpia means well, but she can't help rolling her eyes. Instead of responding to her concern, she changes the subject. "I didn't see you this morning, Scorpia. Why didn't you go to the gun inspection? I told you that's your job!"

The tall woman immediately grimaces in front of her, full of remorse. "Ohh, I'm so sorry, Catra! But I had such a nice chat this morning with that snake woman from the kitchen. I must have forgotten the time ... But she made such excellent sandwiches! I begged her to give me the recipe, but you wouldn´t believe how stubborn - " "Okay, okay! I got it!" Catra interrupts her and gasps in annoyance. At the same time, she admonishes herself not to sound too harsh. Scorpia is the only one she trus - ... the only one which she is sure of that Catra really matters to her and doesn't just obey her because she's the strongest. So she takes a deep breath before declaring, less harshly, "Just make sure it doesn't happen again." She hesitates before adding, "It would be ... easier to have help next time."

Scorpia's expression brightens and a look of surprise crosses her face. Her eyes seem to take on a new glow as she eagerly agrees. "Yes, of course! That won't happen anymore. I promise!" Before she can prevent it, Catra winces at the last word.
Promise.
She hates that word. Fortunately, hardly anyone uses it here. Not like these princesses, who make promises as easy as breathing,

only to break them at the first opportunity. If Scorpia noticed the Magicat's mood change, she doesn't show it. "Oh, and I have something to show you! Come on, you'll love it for sure!"

Catra groans as Scorpia grabs her hand and pulls it with her. "Urgh, Scorpia, please! I don't feel like looking at anything right now. That can wait until tomorrow, I want to go to bed!" But Scorpia doesn't seem to hear her at all. Since she doesn't feel like discussing, Catra lets the big woman drag her along and hopes that it won't hold her up for too long. Finally, the two of them stop in front of the great hall. Scorpia steps forward and grabs the door handle. She almost seems embarrassed. "You know, I'm not sure you will like it, but of course I hope you will, I mean if not then it's okay too …"

Beside Scorpia's babbling, Catra's ear begins to twitch because she can hear feet from the room. Her muscles tense instinctively, but before she can think about it, Scorpia tears open the doors and the Magicat stares completely unprepared into a mass of faces that are looking at her curiously. She struggles to resist the impulsive urge to jump back and instead looks inquiringly at Scorpia. "What's that supposed to be?" The other person grins. "Happy Anniversary, Wildcat!"
The Magicat looks back into the room, confused. Most of the city seem to be gathered here. And now, as if the woman next to her had given the crowd a sign, they break out in unanimous roars in cheers.

She notes with surprise that the cheers apply to Catra. Then she discovers a banner hanging over one of the windows. ´One year the strongest´, it says. Still confused, but no longer so tense, she looks at Scorpia, who steps into the room next to her. "An anniversary celebration?" concludes the leader and Scorpia nods. "Today it has been exactly a year since you took the lead here. I thought that may be a reason to celebrate." Catra blinks for a moment, then swallows her surprise and turns back into the calm, strong, controlled leader. With a self-assured grin, she walks across the room, people willingly make way for her.

"Well, if that is the case...," she calls out loudly and climbs the platform at the end of the hall. There is a stone armchair on top. A throne, others would call it, but Catra does not define it as such. Thrones are for princesses. She wasn't one. This is simply a seat that had existed before her, and only the strongest of the Crimson Waste was allowed to sit on it. On a throne one signals one's own superiority. Catra uses the stone chair to keep an eye on her entourage. When she reaches the armchair, however, she freezes. And with her the crowd behind her.

Someone is already sitting in the armchair.

Chapter 2

Catra:

“Tung Lashor?” Catra ejects, genuinely surprised to see him here. In HER place, of all places. The oversized lizard grins at her and bares its sharp teeth. "See you again, Catra!" He literally spits out her name and pierces her with his gaze. Catra realizes that the whole thing is only there to intimidate her, but that would not work. Almost bored, she puts one hand on her hip and shifts her weight onto one leg while she looks at him disinterestedly. "The last time I saw you, you were up to your neck in quicksand. You know, when you tried so pathetically to fight me."

A murmur goes through the crowd and the Magicat can hear how everyone is eagerly pushing a little closer to the spectacle. Her words turn the lizard's pupils into narrow slits in front of her. Oh yeah, he's mad at her. Good. Anger means loss of control. She triumphantly watches how Tung Lashor's body tenses further as she continues: "Honestly, did you make an effort at all back then? Even a small child would have been harder to defeat!" Her ears twitch as a few laughs penetrate the otherwise quiet room. That only incites the former leader further. With an angry face he yells at Catra: "I want a revenge! Back then you worked with tricks. You don't deserve this place!"

Her response consists of a raised eyebrow. Inwardly, however, it also begins to simmer in her. Whether he wanted it that way or not, Tung Lashor hit a sore spot. Next to her someone is climbing the stairs. Scorpia. She looks at the Magicat questioningly. "Shall we take care of it?" Before the tall woman can go a step further, Catra's arm snaps to the side and stops her, eyes still on the lizard. "No," she says aloud, but calmly. A small, evil smile forms on her face. "Let him. Everyone should see who 'deserves' to be the strongest of the Crimson Waste." Then she turns to the crowd and shouts even louder: "Besides, there should be a show, or not?"

Approving calls come in response. Tung Lashor seems anything but enthusiastic about her formulation. Electrified by his anger, he rises from the stone armchair and approaches Catra. "This is not a show, this is my revenge!" He growls. The little evil smile turns into a wide, hungry grin on Catra's face. "We will see about that."

Like hungry animals, the two begin to circle each other. But Tung Lashor can't stand it for long. Without warning, he rushes forward and tries to push Catra off the steps. However, she is prepared for it and evades. The lizard reaches into the void and almost falls from the steps itself, but he can still catch itself. Snorting, he turns to his opponent. This one still grins challengingly. "I'm over here, old lizard!" He dares a new attempt and rushes towards Catra, but she leaps backwards and lands elegantly with her feet on the seat of the stone armchair. Tung Lashor growls angrily: "Do you want to keep evading or do we finally start fighting?" The smug smile doesn't go away when Catra replies, "I thought you'd never ask." Then - without warning - she leaps at him and jumps in his face. The lizard did not expect such a direct attack, which is why he cannot evade in time and is knocked to the ground.

Catra can catch herself and gets to her feet in a flash, and before Tung Lashor can imitate her, the Magicat gives him a hook on the chin. He tries to reach for her and gets hold of her hair. When he tears out a few of them, Catra begins to hiss angrily and without further ado gives him a powerful kick in the stomach, which throws him off the stairs. With a groan he hits the ground hard. When he wants to get up, Catra grabs her belt and takes the wip. In an instant, her arm snaps out and she throws the wip out. Tung Lashor can only watch helplessly as he is wrapped in the whip like a rope in the blink of an eye. Meanwhile, Catra jumps elegantly from the steps and lands directly in front of her opponent, who is tied up in front of her. A surprised, grim sound escapes him as she holds her dagger to his throat. "I would say the fight is over," explains Catra, almost purring.

For a moment she gleefully gazes at the hatred in the lizard's eyes, which does not contradict. Then she turns away from him and shouts into the crowd: "Does anyone else want to challenge

me?" Nobody dares to speak up. Catra triumphantly holds out her arms and yells: "Who is the strongest of the Crimson Waste?" Thereupon enthusiastic calls ring out with her name. "Well, now that this has been resolved, we can finally celebrate!" This statement receives almost more approval. As the crowd begins to amuse themselves, the Magicat takes a look at the still tied Tung Lashor. "Scorpia, take care of him." Scorpia, who has been standing at the edge of the stairs the whole time, nods eagerly. "Naturally!" Catra thinks she hears a trace of pride in her voice. But maybe she's wrong. Satisfied, the strongest of the Crimson Waste turns to the stone armchair and climbs the steps to take her DESERVED seat.

For a while she observes the hustle and bustle and the exuberant atmosphere. She hardly participates in it herself, but lets herself be praised a few times by some residents who have since become drunk. After a few hours, however, she has had enough. Without an explanation, she gets up and leaves the room. The celebrants are not bothered by it. Probably they didn't even notice. Instead of going straight to her room, she makes a little detour to the roof. Hardly anyone goes up here, as the building is very tall and most of the residents are afraid of heights.

Catra, on the other hand, likes to be up here. Here she has her peace and quiet, and the view is similar to that from the top of the rock face at noon today. Except that it is already deep night, the air is now cold and it is in the middle of the city. The fresh air is good for her after being in for so long. For a moment she listens to the partying, whose noise her ears can still hear. It's been a year since she landed here. A year since she decided to stay here with Scorpia and build a new life for herself. A HAPPY life. And she was. Happy. Or not? She has everything she wants: everyone here obeys her, she has proven several times that she is the strongest. She can do what she wants, go where she wants and no one contradicts her. Everything seems perfect.

Yet Catra can't shake off the feeling that she was hoping to somehow ... feel different. At the same time, she cannot explain what is wrong with her. She has everything she always wanted.

She feels a stab in her heart at this thought. No, she corrects herself. That is not completely correct. She stares darkly at the horizon. Not 'everything' she always wanted is here.

The Magicat immediately feels as if she has betrayed herself. A torrent of frustration and anger builds up in her stomach. This is nonsense! She furiously hits the cold stone below with her fist. She has everything she needs. She doesn't WANT any more! The anger at herself is now so strong that she has to breathe loudly and deeply a few times to calm down. Catra is sure she is just confused. It's been a long day, that's all.

"Catra?" Scorpia's voice pulls her out of her thoughts. She hears someone climbing the stairs to the roof, but doesn't turn around for fear that her face might reveal her emotions. "There you are! Hey, are you okay?" She hears the tall woman's footsteps approaching and nods. "Yes." Still looking straight ahead, she hears Scorpia sit down next to her. It's quiet between the two for a moment before Catra lowers her head and hesitantly says: "That was a good idea. The party, I mean." "Oh!" She doesn't look, but is almost certain that Scorpia's cheeks are turning a light pink.

"Do you think so? I mean, thank you! It's nice that you like it!" "Hmm" Catra draws her legs towards her and puts her head on her knees. Scorpia does the same and for a while they are both just silent next to each other. The woman with the white hair seems to notice that the Magicat doesn't want to have a conversation at the moment. At some point her eyes fall on Catra's hands. She breathes in with a hiss. "Catra! You are hurt!" The Magicat's gaze brushes her hands almost bored. The hand with which she hit the stone earlier still has a little fresh blood on her knuckles. "It's nothing. It will heal fast.", she explains, to drop the subject as quickly as possible. Her words don't seem to reassure Scorpia, however.

"It's best to have a healer take care of it. It could catch fire." "I said I'm fine!", Catra exclaims irritably and her gaze snaps to the person next to her. Scorpia opens her eyes in shock and the Magicat immediately regrets her reaction. So she takes a deep

breath and says in a calmer tone, "I appreciate that you're worried, but I'm fine." Then she gets up and turns away. "I'm tired. See you tomorrow!" She still hears Scorpia saying good night to her before she climbs off the roof and makes her way to her room.

The next morning, Catra gets up early, as she does every day. However, she does not leave the room immediately, but looks at her hands. The blood on her fingers and knuckles has long since dried. Maybe Scorpia is right, she thinks. It doesn't hurt to wash off the blood. So she grabs a bucket of water and a rag and cleans her hands from the red remains. She works very quickly in order to have as little contact as possible with the water. Then she looks at her broken claws. She'll have to cut it, she realizes regretfully. Otherwise, the nails could break even further. She looks around uncomfortably in the almost empty room for a suitable tool. She doesn't like the thought of having to defuse one of her innate weapons. But it has to be. In a small chest of drawers she finally discovers a kind of file and with a heavy heart begins to work on her claws.

When she's done, the claws are quite a bit shorter and blunt. The only thing that keeps Catra from falling into a miserable mood so early in the morning is the thought that they are growing very quickly. Before she leaves the room, she looks again at her reflection, which is reflected in the water of the bucket. It hardly looks changed, she notes. Her hair may be a little longer than it was a year ago, but she still wears the same face and clothes. The red, torn pants, the bright red bodysuit and the dark jacket that she had taken from someone. She is surprised to find that the sight ... disappoints her. As if she was expecting a change that didn't happen. In order not to have to think about it any further, she tears herself away from the reflection and walks out of the room.

At lunchtime Catra sits on the stone armchair again and is just in the process of distributing some food supplies. Since the Magicat took over, the Crimson Waste has worked more like a unit. Everyone still stands for himself and Catra hasn't mutated into a

benefactress either. It is just a strategy. There have been many fights and disputes over food. As Catra, as leader, distributes the available food to areas, a large part of the reasons for riot disappears and that in turn makes the work of the Magicat easier. It also strengthens her position.

Scorpia is with her and helps her. She would never say it out loud, but in the last year Catra has learned to be comfortable around the woman with the white hair. She doesn't feel so lonely then, and it is good to know that someone who cares for her is around. In a little pause, she notices from the corner of her eye how Scorpia rubs her eyes. A sign of tiredness. A year ago she would have ignored her behavior. Now she decides to speak to her about it. "Did you sleep at all?" Scorpia's cheeks turn pink when she realizes it has been blown. She puts a hand on her neck, embarrassed. "Well, the guys celebrated a long time yesterday ... But don't worry, it won't affect my work!"

The Magicat almost smiled. Of course, Scorpia believed she was all about the quality of the work. Because even if Catra is really fond of Scorpia, she is extremely careful about showing it. As she has learned, she is abandoned by all the people who mean something to her. "Forget about work and go catch up on your sleep.", she therefore orders, shaking her head, careful not to show any emotions. "I can't work with you if you're not fully functional." She tries not to sound too rude, so she looks Scorpia in the face and puts on a soft expression.

Now she also notices the woman's disheveled white hair, as if she had just fallen out of bed this morning. Scorpia meanwhile looks surprised, but then beams at Catra and spreads her arms as if to embrace them. But then she decides against it, for which the Magicat is very grateful. "Thank you, Catra! In a few hours I'll be fresh and relaxed and I can give you a hand! You won't regret it!" With these words she runs out of the hall and waves goodbye with a big grin.

Shaking her head, Catra is about to go back to her work when her ears twitch. She hears someone running towards the hall and a

few moments later pushing the doors open to rush towards her. It's one of the city guards, Catra realizes. A fairly tall lizard, whose name she doesn't know. She can remember positioning him in front of the city because he looks so terrifying with his size and countless scars. At the moment, however, he doesn't look scary at all. He looks rather nervous. "What's going on? Why are you bothering me while I'm working?", Catra wants to know, annoyed, and straightens up to look more impressive. The guard begins to report eagerly: “Forgive me, strongest, but an intruder has entered the city!" Immediately the whole body of the Magicat tenses. It is only with difficulty that she suppresses the onset of her fur. Instead, she stands up and sees the guard firmly in the eyes. "What? Where?" "On the north side. Half an hour ago. But the five of us finally overpowered him."

The tension in her body eases, but only a little. "Good. Are there any dead?" The guard shakes his head. "A few injuries, but we can keep working." "Was it an outsider? And was the intruder alone?" A nod in response. Catra looks the man in the eye and takes a step closer. "Are you absolutely sure?" "Yes, strongest. He's not from the Crimson Waste. And there was no one else there." "Let the area be searched anyway. We have to be safe. What did you do with the intruder?" "He's captured and kept safe." After hesitating, he adds: "And ... the intruder wants to speak to you."

This statement makes Catra raise her eyebrows suspiciously. "With me?" A nod. "He asked about the leader." A thousand thoughts go through the Magicat's head. What´s that all about? Why is a stranger intruding into the Crimson Waste now of all times? And why does he want to talk to her? "Fine", she finally says, smiling coldly. "He should get his 'audience' from me. That way he can answer a few questions." Her hand slips casually to her belt as she turns around. “Get him!” She orders. The guard nods and runs out of the hall. Meanwhile, Catra takes a seat on the stone armchair again. She is ready to let the one who dared to penetrate here feel his mistake. And she is curious. She wants to know what causes a person to go to the Crimson Waste and mess

with its residents. It smells like an act of desperation. Or a suicide attempt.

Your thoughts are interrupted when the door opens again and the guard walks in. "The prisoner is here!" he informs Catra and she nods. "Bring him in!" The door opens again and four guards enter, dragging a person with them in their midst. Catra instantly forgets to breathe. The person is handcuffed and her head droops, causing her blonde ponytail to fall forward.

The Magicat is captivated by the sight, shocked by what to expect. When the guards arrive right in front of the stairs, they stop. Catra silently pleads for a moment that she could turn back time. That she never calls these guards in and that the kneeling person in front of her would not raise her head under any circumstances. But fate is not gracious to her. So she has to watch how the figure slowly lifts its head and looks up at her. Catra knows what is coming, and yet the sight hits her as hard as a punch. Large, blue-gray eyes look at her with the same horror that she feels. "Catra?", asks Adora with that voice that is as painfully familiar as her own.

Chapter 3

Catra:

For a moment, Catra is caught in a state of shock. It's Adora. She is really here. Her former best friend and later worst enemy kneels at her feet and looks just as surprised as she is. Then the Magicat catches herself again and tries to keep a calm demeanor. 'I'm in control. I'm in power ´, she reminds herself. With these thoughts she puts on a small smile that doesn´t reach her eyes.

"Hey Adora," she almost purrs, now completely in control of her posture, determined to postpone all questions and feelings until later. The blonde woman still looks at her in shock. "What are you doing here? Are you -" It takes her a moment to put the puzzle together. "You are the leader of the Crimson Waste?"

As if it were a matter of course, Catra crosses her legs and leans back. "Why? Does that surprise you?" Adora opens her mouth, but remains silent, not sure what to reply. A spark of hurt forms in the belly of the Magicat. Adora actually seems to have less confidence in her than she thought.

The silence of the prisoner gives Catra time to examine her more closely. Her clothes and face are filthy, presumably from the long journey, and her ponytail falls disheveled over her shoulders. Catra cannot detect any serious injuries, only a superficial cut runs across the left cheek. And despite all that, she's still as beautiful as a year ago. The Magicat grits her teeth. It infuriates her that there is nothing that can deface Adora.

But she swallows her frustration and focuses on the situation. Calmly, the Magicat leans forward to look Adora in the face. "I have to admit, I wasn't expecting you here. What is the heroine of Etheria looking for in the Crimson Waste, of all places? And all by herself?" Her pupils narrow into slits. "You are alone, aren't you, Adora?" She watches the facial expressions of her arch enemy closely when she replies: "Yes, I came here alone."

Adora doesn't even flinch and looks straight into Catra's eyes. The blonde woman has never been good at lying, especially not to Catra. That is why the Magicat believes her. She nods to the prisoner. "Good. And why are you here?" "Because I need help." Those words let Catra almost lose her composure. She expected a lot, but not this. Unable to hide it, her smile widens. The Magicat was therefore right: Adora is apparently indeed desperate.

"Help?" she hooks up and supports her chin with one hand. Adora nods. Her face is twisting in pain. No physical pain, but internal agony. "To fight the Horde. They are getting stronger every day, we have to stop them!" Catra looks disinterestedly at her claws.

"I thought you and your FRIENDS were already fighting over this job. Since when do you need help with it?" From the corner of her eye, Catra notices Adora tears welling up. "They can't help. We were lured into a trap and the Horde kidnapped Bow and Glimmer! The other princesses are in the process of evacuating the inhabitants of Etheria, but even together we hardly stand a chance! Hordak is getting stronger ... "

When Hordak's name is mentioned, Catra's fur stands up, but she tries to ignore it. Playfully disinterested, she drops her hand and looks back at Adora. She refuses to show her open interest in the next question, though she really wants to know the answer. "Hmm and why doesn't the oh-so-powerful She Ra just take care of it? After all, she has always managed to get on my nerves!" When She Ra's name is mentioned, the guards react with a confused look. Here in the Crimson Waste, She Ra is nothing more than an ancient legend. Another reason why she likes living here. Catra ignores their gaze and concentrates on the prisoner.

A suspicion creeps into the Magicat when she sees the dejected expression of the enemy. "I ... don't have the sword anymore.", Adora whispers, choked. "They ... they stole it when they kidnapped Glimmer and Bow too." Catra raises her eyebrows in surprise. It is quiet in the hall for a second. Then two. And then Catra can't take it any longer and bursts into roaring laughter. She can't help it. It sounds so absurd! The great and powerful princess

warrior is defeated because her magic toy has been taken away from her!

The guards flinch at the strange noise. They have never experienced the strongest of the Crimson Waste like this. She didn't even smile last year. Except maybe when she was alone or with Scorpia. When the Magicat calms down, she wipes her eyes with one hand and leans over to Adora again. "Okay, so I'll sum it up: You're totally screwed!" Adora's shoulders drop a bit and she lowers her head slightly.

"That's why we need help! There were rumors that the Crimson Waste is not as deserted as it is always said. I was hoping to raise an army here or at least recruit a few warriors to fight with us in the rebellion! Then we would have a chance against the Horde! "

Adora cannot hide the despair in her voice. Something stirs in Catra at the sight of her and she doesn't dare look too long into the gray-blue eyes that look at her hopefully. Instead, she swallows her emotions and cocks her head in curiosity. "And why exactly should I help you?"

The prisoner stretches her chin forward and looks stoically at her counterpart. "Because you won't be safe from the Horde either. After conquering Bright Moon and the other realms, Hordak will also take on the Crimson Waste. But we can prevent that if we work together!" Catra leans back, snorting. "I can manage him on my own. We can defend ourselves." "Are you sure about that?" Adora throws in and does not let go of the Magicat's gaze.

"You know the Horde, you know what they are capable of and how far they will go to achieve their goals. Do you think you will be able to do something about it?" With her eyes she seems to want to stab Adora when she replies sharply: "I am the strongest of the Crimson Waste. If I want something, I'll take it. Be it someone else's weapon or victory over a war."

The determination in her voice silences Adora. Catra can see her thinking about her words. Then she replies: "The more unite in

this war, the higher the chance of winning. Please, Catra, help the rebellion!"

The Magicat slowly tilts her head and pretends to be thinking hard. "Let me think about it for a moment , uhh... No!" Adora's eyes widen and the spark of hope in them disappears. Again Catra feels something in her stomach area, but she decides to ignore it and instead grins broadly at Adora.
"It sucks to be let down, doesn't it?"
Before Adora can reply, the leader directs the word to the guards. "Put her in a cell and guard her well!"

The addressed nod and roughly grab Adora by the shoulders. Meanwhile, Catra gets up and goes down the stairs until she reaches Adora. Smiling, she grabs Adora's chin and forces her to look her in the eyes. "Looks like your mine now, Adora." For a moment she looks at the widened eyes of her counterpart before she gives the guards a sign to start walking. Together they drag the prisoner to the door. She defends herself against the handles. "No, please! Catraaa!"

Yet the Magicat does not reply, but watches as Adora is transported out of the room. Next to her, the guard who arrived first clears his throat. "You knew the intruder, strongest?" He wants to know with a mixture of confusion and curiosity. With a scowl, she turns to him and hisses. "That is none of your business!" Casually, she marches out of the hall and strolls into her room. However, as soon as she has closed the door behind her and is certain that no one can watch her, she tumbles to her knees and drops her cool, serene masquerade.

Suddenly her emotions overwhelm her and push her to the ground. Adora is here. In the Crimson Waste. The Magicat's breath is shallow. Anger rises in her.
How dare Adora show up here and mess up her life ?! She made a conscious decision a year ago to leave the horde and everyone who has ever betrayed her behind. Especially this blonde traitor.

Her world had been in order, she had everything under control, had the life that she wanted, and then this ... this Wannabe-princess shows up and reminds her of everything she wants to forget ?!

And babbles about war and aid and the end of the world. A sound of indignation escapes Catra's mouth.
How dare Adora question her position! Not trusting her to be able to stand alone against Hordak! She has no right to do so. Catra took power in the Crimson Waste within a day and earned the respect of all creatures there. Within a year she built robust cities, constructed dozens of weapons and deployed warriors to establish her position and make the Crimson Waste safer.

But dear Adora probably didn't think about that any further. Tense, Catra lets her short claws scrape the floor. Of course, Adora doesn't think about it any further. After all, it is none of her business. It is not part of her problem. Her problem is her trapped ´friends´. They are everything that matters to Adora.

But she can forget to save them. She is no longer She Ra, the savior of Etheria, but simply a prisoner who has succumbed to the mercy of her enemy. This thought is somewhat satisfying in Catra. Now it's HER turn. She won. She defeated She Ra. The Magicat waits a while for this thought to fill her with joy.

Or with satisfaction. Happiness. Any of those stupid, positive feelings. Instead, she just feels empty. That unsettles her. At the same time, as so often, it makes her angry at herself. What's wrong with her? Now she has - finally - after all these years, really EVERYTHING she wanted. And yet she doesn't feel well. A frustrated sigh escapes her as she mumbles: "I thought winning would be different ..."

Suddenly she feels her emotions and thoughts lie on her like a load weighing tons, and she just feels exhausted. Tired, she looks out of her window, in which the late afternoon sun is shining. Whatever, she thinks and gets up to lie down on her couch. She sure just needs a few more hours of sleep, like Scorpia, and she'd

be better.
Then she would be able enjoy her victory.

Chapter 4

Catra:

She is shaking all over but does not dare to move. Her ears hear everything. The noises are louder than usual tonight. She hears the howling wind, the clanking footsteps of the Horde soldiers striding through the corridors. Worst of all, she hears Shadow Weaver's creepy voice, ominously sounding in front of her bedroom. She can almost feel the creepy eyes on her, just waiting to discover another mistake in order to be able to punish her appropriately. The little girl's fur stands on end as she imagines she can feel the dark shadow tentacles wandering over her skin.

To protect herself, she bends her ears, embraces her knees with her small arms and presses her eyes tightly together. She doesn't want to see or feel anything. She just wants to get out of here. "Pssst" Startled, Catra squeaks and looks around. Her heart almost stops when she cannot discover anything. The other children have been sleeping for hours. Then there is a soft voice: "Catra? Are you awake?"

Reluctantly she stretches her head over the edge of the bed and looks down. There she meets blue-gray eyes that look up at her. But since Adora's eyes are not so good, she cannot see her friend. That's why the little Magicat doesn't look away when she whispers back as confidently as possible: "No." When she hears Catra's voice, Adora brightens up. "Do you want to come down to me?"

She doesn't answer for a few moments. Then Catra gets up and quickly climbs down to crawl into bed with Adora. The blonde girl has already lay down again. Catra curls up at the foot of the bed without touching Adora´s legs.

It's quiet for a while. Then Adora asks: "Why aren't you sleeping? Are you scared?" Her voice sounds hesitant, cautious. Catra wants to contradict her, but says nothing, for fear her voice might

tremble. Instead, she watches the blonde girl who stares at the ceiling and takes a deep breath before confessing: "I'm scared."

Catra raises her head in surprise. "Of what?", she whispers softly. Adora also raises her head and looks in the direction in which she suspects the Magicat. "Of the dark." Catra blinks a few times. She didn't know that there were things Adora was afraid of. "I'll watch over you.", she promises. Her friend doesn't reply, but her shoulders seem to relax. "The noises are so loud." Catra confesses her fear after a few moments. While doing so, she observes how Adora’s gaze becomes gentle and she assures: "I'm here."

Carefully she reaches out a hand and Catra takes it. So the two lie down again. Catra curls up against Adora´s legs and squeezes her hand. And with Adora´s warmth and her smell it is suddenly very easy to forget the loud noises around her and to fall asleep peacefully.

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With a pounding heart, Catra wakes up. It's the middle of the night. For a moment she is confused, doesn't know where she is, and why Adora isn't lying next to her. Then it comes back to her. Frustrated, she knocks the blanket away. It has been two and a half years, and she's still not used to sleeping alone in a bed. That she dreamed of THAT memory of all things doesn't make it better. It feels like old wounds are being reopened. Not just the pain and the loss of a friendship. Her fears also seemed to be shaken.

It´s as if she can now hear all the nocturnal noises clearly again. She usually does that too, only it seems to have been made worse by the dream. As stupid as it was, she has not been able to completely put aside her childish fears of the loud noises. Not even in the Crimson Waste. She hears everything. A couple of crickets chirping outside, the footsteps of the guards patrolling the hallways. Someone who is dropping something a floor below her. She winces like a frightened animal and is immediately annoyed by this reaction.

Sullen, she lies on her back and closes her eyes to go back to sleep, but the noises only seem to get louder. Now she also feels an uncomfortable scratching on the stone floor. One of the residents has to drag his weapon on the floor as he walks past the main building. Catra groans and sits up.

She's no longer the scared little girl she used to be, but nightly noises still make her ... nervous. Since she doesn't seem to be getting any sleep, she gets up and walks to the window to breathe in the fresh night air for a moment. Since it is always warm in the Crimson Waste, the windows have no panes. So she can look up to the night sky unhindered. Clearly, she sees the single planet, the moon, that shines weakly on the city, which is almost as bright as day. At least to her. Shaking her head, she lets her gaze wander through the empty streets, through which a lost soul scurries only now and then. Catra cannot imagine how others with less visibility can live at night with a basically pitch black vision. They miss so many details, lose their bearings so easily.

That reminds Catra of something. For a moment she weighs the thought, wants to discard it, banish it from her head. But then she turns away from the window and reaches for her jacket to slip on. Quietly, the Magicat leaves her room and begins to sneak through the corridors. It doesn't take long to reach the basement stairs. The corridor here is lit with a couple of torches, which gives human eyes scant light.

Once at the bottom, she reaches a wooden door with two guards standing in front of it. Two of the guys who were in the hall this afternoon, Catra recognizes. She strolls calmly towards the two of them. They are visibly confused to find the Magicat at this time. Without further explanation, she says: "You can go. I'll call you when I need you." Confused, the two look at their leader. "But the prisoner -" "Hurry up!", interrupts Catra harshly and scowls at them. She can see the fear of the guards, so they just nod and leave in silence.

When Catra can no longer hear her footsteps, she stares at the door in front of her. She hesitates for a moment before reaching

for the handle and pushing it down. The door has been freshly oiled, so there is no sound as she pushes it open and walks through. From here another staircase runs down, but it is narrower and significantly shorter. As silently as possible she descends the stairs and finally stops on the last step.

She is now in a small room with a few torches hanging on the walls, but they are not lit. It would be pitch black in here for a normal person. Catra knows what is to her right when she would step out of the corridor. Carefully, she presses herself against the wall and peeks out to the right of the room. It is separated from the rest of the room by an iron grille. Behind it is a bucket and a lounger with a thin blanket. There are no windows in the cell to prevent escape attempts. The Magicat recognizes that someone is slumped on the lounger and staring at the opposite wall with open eyes. Adora.

Catra has to swallow at the sight of her. Even from here she recognizes how tense the young woman is. Inwardly, the Magicat hits her forehead. That was a stupid idea. An insanely stupid one! She should get out of here. But when she takes a step back, she hits a step with her foot and makes a dull sound that sounds like a deafening noise in the rest of the silence. Adora also hears the noise and jerks around, eyes wide, trying to see something in the dark. "Who's there?", she asks demanding. Others wouldn't notice, but Catra hears the slight tremor in her voice.

After taking a deep breath, she leaves the stairs and enters the room. "Don't panic, princess," she mumbles, trying to sound amused. Adora looks in her direction and exhales audibly. It almost sounds annoyed. "Urgh, Catra, I really don't feel like playing your games now." Catra wants to reply something, something that sounds annoyed, mean and simply superior. But for some reason she can't bring herself to do it. That's why she just goes up to the grille and sinks to the side against it.

Adora hears Catra's footsteps and the scraping clothes on the bars as she frowns. "What are you doing there?" "What does it sound like?" "Like ... nothing." "There you go." Ready to defend herself,

Adora stands up and turns to face the bars. Her look is suspicious. "What's your plan? Do you want to torture me until you can get any valuable information out of me? Or are you just bored?" "No! I just thought ...", Catra begins, grateful that Adora can't see the uncertainty in her face. Then she adds quietly, "Maybe you don't want to be alone in the dark. Whatever."

For a moment it is completely quiet in the cell. Catra watches tensely as Adora raises her eyebrows in surprise. She slowly feels for the lounger and sits down again. After that she slides back and forth on her mat a little before admitting: "It's pretty dark here. In Bright Moon, the windows are so big that the moon always gives off a lot of light." The Magicat does not reply. So she was right that Adora has not lost her fear either. Catra doesn't want to think about how much Adora wants to be near Bright Moon at the moment. Away from her. The thought hurts, so she pushes it aside. She doesn't dare to move and instead listens to Adora´s breaths. They have a calming effect, almost like ... in former times.

Suddenly the blonde woman turns to Catra and speaks again. "Are the noises still loud?" The question does not surprise Catra, after all, Adora is still the only person who really knows her, whether an enemy or not. However, she is unsure how much she wants to reveal to Adora. But here, in the protective darkness under the veil of night, it feels so safe. Catra can almost forget that they are enemies. That's why she says quietly: "Yes."

It's just a word, and yet there is an enormous vulnerability in her voice. All of a sudden, Catra feels naked, as if, despite the darkness, she has no protection to hide from Adora’s gaze. To hide who she is. And part of the Magicat doesn't want that at all. Not right now. This part just wants to enjoy the moment of calm that this strange situation brings with it. Adora responds with the same gentle look she gave Catra years ago when it came to her sleep problems. The look creates a lump in her throat. Quickly, she looks away.

"Sleep now," she mumbles, hoping it comes across as harsh. She avoids looking at Adora, but she can hear her lying down on the lounger. Then the blonde woman asks, quietly, hesitantly: "Will you watch over me?" There is a hopeful tone in her voice that does not only refer to the current situation. The lump slides down into Catra's stomach and contracts. The Magicat quickly pulls her knees to her chest and explains: "Don't fool yourself into it. I'm only doing this here so that you are not exhausted when you are supposed to be useful to me."

Adora’s answer comes in a mumbled and incomprehensible manner, but it becomes clear that she does not believe her. A little later, Catra listens to Adora's deep, calm breaths and allows herself to relax. Her mind is buzzing around, but she's too tired to think about how stupid this is. Too much she concentrates on the comforting calm that spreads within her and on Adora´s presence, whose quiet sleeping noises wrap around Catra´s body like a blanket and let her slowly slide into sleep.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

TRIGGER WARNING!
This chapter contains a panic attack!

Catra:

A single ray of sun tickles Catra's nose as she opens her eyes. Immediately she wishes she hadn't. As she sees the prison cell in the dimmed daylight, she immediately remembers the events of the previous night. What did she think she was doing?!
A look into the cell tells her that Adora is still asleep. The Magicat quickly gets up to sneak out of the room.

If Adora doesn't catch her waking up here, she might think she was just dreaming. She is just about to slip away when she turns back to Adora and looks at her face. You can see how worried she is right now. Catra can almost hear the thoughts of her former best friend as she blames herself for not having already tried to dig through the stone with her bare hands to get to her friends and free them. For a tiny moment, Catra cannot keep from feeling sorry for her.

She immediately scolds herself for this thought. ´Adora is your friend, she deserves nothing other than to be devastated!´, she reminds herself. Snorting, she wants to turn around and leave when Adora sleepily opens her eyes and looks at Catra. The Magicat stops as if frozen and meets her gaze. The blonde's facial features change from confused to soft ... and then to confused again. "Catra?"

She quickly turns away and walks towards the stairs. "Where are you going, Catra?" Without turning around, the Magicat replies: "That's none of your business, princess." "No, wait!" Adora´s voice sounds almost pleading. Catra has already reached the first steps, and although Adora´s voice stirs something in her, she only

decides to run faster. "Please, Catra! I beg you, think again! If you help us, we can safely defeat the Horde! You can protect the Crimson Waste, and you want that, right?"

This makes the Magicat stop moving. Anger grips her as she turns and walks back to the cell. Adora is surprised when she sees the angry face of the leader. "Why did you have to come here?", Catra snaps at the prisoner. This is confused. "What?" "Why do you appear out of nowhere and endanger everything I have built? Why do you always have to ruin my life?!"

"Catra, I am not putting anything in danger! The horde is the real threat!" "The Horde, huh?! Do you see the Horde making my life difficult?" Adora looks like she wants to say something back, but Catra won't let her. The anger that has built up in her for so long has to get out. "Why are you trying to take all this away from me now by pretending I can't get along without you? Realize it: I DON'T NEED you, I never have, so finally stop trying to restrict myself!" she screams angrily.

Adora looks at her former friend with wide eyes. For a moment Catra thinks she sees pain in it, but she is too upset to care. Then the blonde woman suddenly sinks to the floor in resignation. "You are right, Catra." Surprise masks her anger for a moment. The Magicat did not expect that. Adora raises her head as she continues. "You don't need me. You have always been the stronger of the two of us. I'm sorry I made you feel different. It's me who needs you."

Catra stares at the prisoner in surprise. In all these years the Magicat would never have thought to hear these words from Adora. She can't help but laugh bitterly. "After all this time you suddenly realize that you need me?!" As if she couldn't look her in the eye, Adora lowers her sight. "No, I always knew that." Her voice sounds thick. Something contracts in Catra when she steps closer to the bars. She can't stop tears from coming to her eyes when she asks quietly, "Then why did you leave me?"

Now Adora lifts her head, there are tears in her eyes too. As she steps at the bars, she exclaims in despair, "Because I had no choice! It wouldn't have been right to stay after seeing what the Horde is up to." Bitterness and pain rise up her throat as Catra replies, "But leaving me was right?" The blonde woman shakes her head, now she looks almost reproachful. "I wanted you to come with me!" "And I wanted you to STAY with me!"

Catra cannot prevent deep pain from ringing in her voice. Adora looks like the Magicat has punched her. In order not to lose control completely, Catra takes a deep breath and turns her back on Adora. "You were ready to do everything it takes, to give up EVERYTHING to do the right thing. You were willing to give up on ME. I don't need those kinds of 'friends'. And I don't have to risk my life for them either."

Without waiting to see if Adora replies, she walks towards the stairs and almost runs upstairs. Air, she needs air. The Magicat rushes through the corridors and pushes the door to the outside. The guards next to her look at her but say nothing.

Half in her mind, she turns briefly to the guys and orders: "The prisoner must be guarded again. Put two of you in front of the door, but don't talk to her." "Yes, Strongest." Without further explanation, the Magicat rushes off and runs out of town. She runs and runs into the wilderness of the Crimson Waste. Only when she can no longer perceive any other living being apart from herself does she stop and inhale heavily. And then she can't help but scream angrily. She roars out her pain and drops to her knees as tears run down her face in the middle of nowhere.

Everything is back. The pain, the memories, the feelings. Everything that she has tried so desperately to suppress collapses on her like a tsunami. She believed that here, in the Crimson Waste, she could finally free herself from Adora´s influence. To finally make of herrself what no one has seen in her: someone who is powerful. Who is strong. Who is worthy.

But she was wrong. It doesn't even take a few minutes in Adora’s presence and everything returns. Their anger, their pain ... their vulnerability. She wipes her face angrily. Maybe she is actually weak. Perhaps unworthy indeed.
These thoughts stab her chest like daggers and she only breathes in spurts. Her chest seems to be constricting and suddenly she feels a panic rise within her, dark and uncontrollable. Catra is breathing faster reflexively, but the panic increases. Unable to move, she tries to focus on something else. Then she hears voices in her head.
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“How someone is unmotivated as you completed the course in that time i´ll never know.”

“Adora is not here to protect you anymore.”

“I´ve come to expect such diygraeful behaviour from you.”

“This was a test. You failed.”

“I´ve kept you around this long because Adora was fond of you.”

“You have never been anything more than a nuisance to me.”

“Adora did´t run away from the horde, she ran away from you.”

“Your former Force Captain has proven to be compromised, ineffective, and worthless.”

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Catra's vision blurs, she cannot breathe. In a panic, she tries to move, to SURVIVE. But she can't. Nothing works anymore. The panic has taken control. She is trapped in her own body. A pitiful whimper escapes her when she fears that she will have to die now. And then suddenly there is a light. A soft, warm voice.

“It doesn´t matter what they do to us. You look out for me, and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we

have each other.”

Slowly, painfully slowly, the panic in her sinks, pulling back into the hole from which it crawled. After a while, Catra's vision clears up. Her lungs suck in fresh air, she can breathe again. When her mind returns, she notices that she is lying on her side on the dusty floor. For a while she doesn't dare to move. Only when she is sure that she will not have to die does she breathe. deeply and carefully moves her hand. It can be bent as easily as usual.

Catra stands up carefully so that she is sitting on the floor. She doesn't trust her legs yet, so she remains seated and stares at her hands. What was that? She had a panic attack. She's never had one. At least not to that extent. She has lost control. It must have been too much, concludes the Magicat.

Actually, this realization would have made her angry that she is so weak and that she can be defeated by a panic attack. But the shock is still too deep in her bones. To calm herself down, she lets the warming sun on her face distract her. Tender rays of sun wander over her fur and dispel the shadows on her body. Over time, Catra's muscles relax and her heart beats at a normal pace again so that she feels strong enough to get up again. A little wobbly on her feet, she makes her way back into town.

It takes a while, but eventually Catra reaches the city limits. As soon as she passed it, her posture changes. She walks upright and puts on her hard, impenetrable expression so as not to let her attack of weakness show. Most people do not dare to stare at or provoke the Magicat any longer while she is walking through the streets. That´s why she can reach the main building unhindered and slips inside. After a few flights of stairs she reaches her room and is about to go in when she meets Scorpia.

“Whoops, sorry! Didn´t see you there, Wildcat!”, the tall woman apologizes as she balances a tray full of food. Catra raises an eyebrow, irritated. "What is this, Scorpia?" The addressee notices

the Magicat's gaze on the tray. Suddenly she looks embarrassed. "Well, I haven't seen you this morning and thought you don´t feel well and you might want a late lunch?" A little overwhelmed, Catra winks at the woman in front of her. At the same moment she feels how hungry she actually is.

"Uhhm .. well, bring it to my room then." Scorpia seems relieved when she nods eagerly and the Magicat follows into her room. She doesn't have a table, so Catra sits down on the floor. Scorpia puts the tray next to it and then stands in the room for a moment, indecisive. Almost embarrassed, Catra reaches for a piece of bread and looks at the floor. "Are you waiting for a written invitation to sit down?"

Scorpia breathes in audibly as if she hadn't expected this invitation, and the Magicat can't blame her. The big woman sits down next to Catra and starts to talk about what she did this morning. Usually it annoys the Magicat when Scorpia babbles to herself, but today she's grateful for it. It distracts her from her confused thoughts while she satisfies her stomach.

After a while she is full, but makes no move to move. Instead, she pulls her knees to her chest and stares into space. Scorpia does not escape the behavior either. Worriedly, she looks at the strongest of the Crimson Waste. "Everything OK?" Catra bites her lip before she asks: "Do you know about Adora?" A nod. "Some of the boys talked this morning that we have a prisoner named Adora. And that she wanted your help." Catra snorts and continues staring at the wall.

Scorpia carefully looks sideways at the Magicat. "Do you want to talk about it?" "No." Catra's voice sounds exhausted. Both are silent for a while, until Catra asks quietly: "Do you sometimes think of the past? About the time at the Horde?" For the first time, Scorpia doesn't seem to have a flood of words ready. "Well, I mean, yes ... I think so. Sometimes I think of our old friends there. Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio ... and what we went through together. And of course I often think of Entrapta and the fun the

three of us had. You know, as a Super Pal Trio. I wonder what they're doing and if they´re fine. "

The tall woman notices Catra's scrutinizing look as she quickly adds: "But I don't regret coming here. The horde was nothing for me. I mean, it's nice here, the climate is good for me and I'm happy. And so are you. You're happy, aren't you? " Her words sound cautious, hesitant. Catra is silent for a moment. Then she exhales audibly. "I .. I think you should go now. I want to rest before I get on with some chores later." From the corner of her eye the Magicat notices how Scorpia's shoulders sink down. "Oh yes of course."

She sounds disappointed, but gets up quickly and is about to step out the door when Catra holds her back again. "Scorpia?" The tall woman looks at her questioningly. Catra swallows and takes her eyes off the wall to look at her. "Thank you. For the food." A smile spreads across the Scorpion woman's face before she leaves the room.

After a few minutes in which Catra collects herself, she also leaves the room and takes care of some tasks that are due today. Fortunately, it doesn't take long before she's done with it and has time to herself. To be alone, she moves to the roof of the main building and lets her thoughts wander while she lets her eyes wander over the city. She thinks of Scorpia's words, and also of the argument with Adora this morning.

After making the decision to stay in the Crimson Waste with Scorpia, she was determined to leave it all behind. To forget her old life and start all over again. Yet her past haunted her for a whole year, and yesterday it managed to catch up with her. What should the Magicat do now? Run away again? Hoping to win the race against the past this time? It seems hopeless to her.

But what is the alternative? Release Adora? Even helping her save the friends and the world that her best friend left her because of? This thought arouses two different feelings in her. Defiance because Adora didn't deserve better. Because she should see what

it's like to lose the people who are most important to you. And something like ... resignation. Because Catra cannot forget the blonde woman's gaze. Desperate and lost. Ready to give up on herself to save her world.

That look seems to haunt Catra, and although she struggles against it, it touches her. He speaks to the small part in Catra's heart that Adora cannot forget. Who longs to be with her again. Make you laugh. Not to be alone anymore. To be 'happy' with her.

No matter what she tries, she cannot escape the chains that bind her to Adora. Maybe she never wanted that. When Catra perceives these thoughts, which she has suppressed for an eternity, she snorts in frustration and hits the stone floor with her fist. Her ankles protest in pain when the abrasions are reopened, but Catra doesn't care. The pain is a distraction from their confused thoughts.

To stay focused, Catra takes a deep breath.
Okay, she has several options how to proceed:
First, she lets Adora rot forever in the cell. However, the Magicat then has to constantly struggle with the certainty that Adora is not far from her.
Second, to finally separate from her past: She can let Adora go alone, knowing that she will run headlessly into her doom.
Third, she could send some members of the former gang with Adora to help her. However, Catra does not trust these guys enough, and she does not believe that they are actually fighting lizards with full commitment for another realm.
Or the fourth option ... The thought costs another sigh. Fourth, she goes with Adora and prevents her from doing any stupid thing that will cost her her life.

The Magicat doesn't know how long she sat there on the roof and brooded, but at some point she gets up with a deep sigh. She made a decision.

Chapter 6

Adora:

Even though the Crimson Waste is a desert, it's surprisingly cold down here. And gloomy. Even during the day, the sun only lights up Adora’s cell dimly. Shortly after Catra left this morning, one of the guards came and gave Adora something to eat. After that she was left alone. It drives her crazy. The whole time she has been walking up and down the cell and cannot rest. Her thoughts are only on worrying about Bow and Glimmer.

It was now five days since Adora had last seen them. If only she would have been more careful! Too many times she hits the bars in frustration. Instead of at least attempting to free them, she is now stuck here. With Catra. The thought of the Magicat creates a tangle of mixed emotions in her stomach.

Adora heard rumors before her trip that the Crimson Waste had a new leader. It was these rumors that gave them the idea of coming here in the first place. But Adora would never have dreamed of finding her former best friend! When she saw her sitting on that throne, she couldn't believe it. It seemed like an eternity since they last met, and at the same time it felt like only yesterday. And as if their first meeting wasn't strange enough, yesterday night topped it off.

It was like they'd just forgotten all their rivalries and been ... friends again. But whatever was that night is gone this morning. A stone forms in Adora's stomach when she thinks about the terrible argument from a few hours ago. When Catra had thrown her pain openly in her face like a hand grenade she was not prepared for.

Since then she has been thinking of the words of the Magicat. And again she feels guilty from back then. That she wasn't more persistent. That she gave up on Catra so easily. And in a small part of her heart she still feels something. Something like ... longing.

Irritated, the blonde woman shakes and begins to wander back and forth in her cell. She doesn't have time to deal with her feelings now. She has to save her friends! And take back her sword! So maybe all is lost ... But how is she supposed to get out of here? She has already thought through all the escape routes. It even occurred to her to try to dig through the stone with her bare hands! But none of the ideas are actually helpful. She has to let Catra do that: she gives her prisoners no hope of escape. A desperate sigh slips from her as her thoughts wander back to her friends.

What would the two of them do if they were in Adora´s situation? Glimmer wouldn't hesitate long and teleport them all out, Adora recognizes immediately and has to smile sadly. Bow would try to ambush the guards. Perhaps he would have the perfect arrow with him, which is filled with sleeping pills or can blind you or the tip is made of a cactus or - "Do you want to keep walking until you pass out from exhaustion?" suspects a familiar voice, amused.

Startled, Adora turns around and sees Catra leaning against the landing, her arms crossed and her watchful eyes fixed on Adora. The blonde woman didn't hear her coming. Curse her talent in sneaking! "How long have you been standing there?" Adora wants to know and tries to hide how embarrassed she is that she didn't notice Catra. The Magicat twisted its mouth into a grin. There is no longer any sign of the pain on her face this morning. But Catra has always been good at covering up her feelings.

"A while." gives it vaguely to embarrass Adora even more. But this is now occupied with another question. "Why are you here?" It is quiet for a moment. Catra's grin disappears. Instead, she puts on an impenetrable expression, "I've been thinking." Adora raises an eyebrow in irritation. "About what?" "I'll do it." Adora opens her mouth in surprise and closes it again.

Catra holds the blonde woman's gaze as she approaches her and continues: "I'll help you free your friends and get your stupid sword back. But a few things should be clarified." Her tone is hard and harsh, but Adora hardly notices it. She feels a growing hope.

Now she would be able to save her friends after all! She has a chance! When she sees Catra's serious expression, she suppresses her thoughts and concentrates on the woman in front of her. "And that would be?"

Concerns rise within her, unsure of what the Magicat will say next. "First of all: only I will accompany you. Nobody else." "But -" Adora wants to protest. Together they would hardly have a better chance than alone. Not even with the other princesses. But Catra continues: "However, I will send reinforcements if we need them." That's not what Adora would like to hear, but she takes what she gets.

"Second: when I go with you, you have to realize that I'm not your sidekick following orders. I'll help you, but that doesn't give you the right to order me around." Adora protests mentally. She would never have done that! She knows herself that Catra doesn't listen to anyone anyway. On the other hand, she is aware that sometimes she unintentionally plays the leader. That already got on Glimmer's nerves in the past. Catra seems to know that too. The Magicat continues to speak, and her gaze bores even more into Adora´s eyes.

"Third, you should know that I'm not doing this for you. I still have an account with Hordak that I want to settle." Adora swallows, ignoring the stinging that suddenly spreads in her chest. At the same time she wonders what happened between Hordak and Catra. She nods silently so that Catra can finish speaking. "And finally," she explains, "my help is tied to a condition. Something in return."

The way Catra emphasizes the words makes Adora feel sick. What does Catra want from her? The Magicat knows them better than anyone. She knows Adora will do anything to help her friends. What will she ask of Adora with this knowledge? What will the price of a chance of salvation be? Swallowing, Adora looks at the woman in front of her before she hesitantly asks: "And what should I do for you?"

Catra's pupils narrow to slits when she replies with no apparent emotion: "In return, you will disappear from my life. Forever. As soon as the matter is settled, I don't want to see you anymore."

Adora can't stop her gasping. She expected a lot. Bad, criminal, humiliating things that Catra would ask of her. But THAT? Somehow this request feels worse than anything expected. The stinging in her chest reappears. Pain. It hurts her that Catra so openly shows that she no longer wants her in her life. But if that's truly what she wants ... and if it helps save her friends, then she would accept that request.

So Adora nods and replies flatly: "I agree." The Magicat's only response is a blink. For a moment, Adora wondered whether Catra might have hoped that Adora would resist this demand. Then the Magicat says, "Good. Scorpia will bring you some food later. We'll be leaving tomorrow morning." With that she turns around and leaves the room. And leaves the blonde prisoner with an even more confused carousel of thoughts than before, a stone in the stomach area, but also a spark of hope in her heart.

Catra:

"You are really leaving?" Scorpia exclaims in horror. Catra took her to her room after she was with Adora and told her about her plan. The Magicat shrugs her shoulders unimpressed. "I'll be back in no time." Scorpia looks at her allie with concern. "Why don't you let Adora go alone? Who knows what could happen to you! Do you have any idea what Hordak will do to you if he gets his hands on you? Have you thought about the whole thing well?"

Catra lets out a snort when she replies: "Oh, believe me: I thought about it for a long time and went through all the possibilities. In the end, that's the best choice. If I let Adora go, she runs blindly into her doom without doing any damage to the Horde. Also, this is the perfect opportunity to take my revenge on Hordak! He's supposed to pay for wanting to send me to my death! And if I solve the Horde problem now, we won't have to worry about it to defend the crimson waste. "

She turns her face to the window so she doesn't have to look Scorpia in the eye. Yes, that's why she's coming. Now all she has to do is convince herself that there aren't others. After taking a deep breath, she looks back at the large woman next to her.

Her worried look still hasn't gone. Catra sticks out her chin almost defiantly. "And besides, I can take care of myself. I conquered the Crimson Waste within a day, so Hordak will be a piece of cake for me. I can do it." Surprisingly, a gentle smile appears on Scorpia's face, which confuses the Magicat. "I know that.", explains the tall woman and puts an arm around Catra to pull her close. "We can do this."

Catra quickly wriggles out of the grip of her counterpart before asking: "We?" Scorpia grins broadly and winks. "I'm definitely not going to let you go alone, Wildcat!" "Oh yes, you will.", contradicts Catra and tries to ignore the warmth that Scorpia's words cause in her. The tall woman looks horrified. "But we are a team!" "You´re right.", confirms the Magicat and looks tall woman in the eye. "And that's exactly why I have an important task for you."

She hesitates for a moment before raising a hand and placing it on Scorpia's shoulder. It is very rare for Catra to seek physical contact on her own, so Scorpia seems to realize how important what she is saying is to her. "In the time that I will be gone, you will replace me here."

Scorpia gasps in surprise, and before she can reply, Catra adds, almost gently, "I need you here. I know you're up to the task." For a while Scorpia seems to have no words. "Catra, I ..." Then she takes a breath and looks determinedly at the Magicat. "I will not disappoint you!" A small smile appears on Catra's face. "That's what I'm expecting."

And then Scorpia can no longer hold back and closes Catra in a tight hug. Exceptionally, the Magicat doesn´t push her away. Maybe because she knows it means a lot to Scorpia.
Maybe beacause Catra feels inside that she needs that hug as much as Scorpia does at the moment.

Maybe because it could be the last time the two of them see each other.

Chapter 7

Adora:

Adora was a little afraid of the second night she would spend in the cell. For a short time she felt the wish that Catra would come down to her again and stay with her. That she didn't have to stay alone in the dark. But she didn't come. Adora could have guessed it. The contempt in Catra's eyes has made it clear that she wants to spend as little time as possible with her former friend. However, sometime in the evening, Scorpia had come to her cell.

She didn't speak to Adora, but put a bowl of food in front of her and lit the few torches in the room. Without saying a word, she left again. The light that the torches gave was not much, but enough to release the tension from Adora´s muscles and to give her at least a few hours of sleep. She has no idea why Scorpia did this.

Maybe Catra told the tall woman about her fear in order to humiliate her. However, Scorpia doesn't seem to like the prisoner very much, so she's unlikely to make it any more pleasant on Adora on purpose. The blonde woman was just happy and didn't ask any more about motives.

When she wakes up this morning, the torches have burned down and sun is rising. She doesn't have much time to herself when she hears the door to the basement open. Instead of Catra, who Adora is awaiting, one of the lizards that guarded her cell comes down the stairs. With a fixed look he walks to the cell door and picks up a key. "The strongest wants you. We bring you to her. If you fight back, there will be violence." Adora wants to protest, but then only decides to scowl.

There's no point in messing with these lizards. And Catra told her that she will help. She must now hope for that. It was the anchor that hopefully would save her from drowning. When the guard unlocks the cell door, which opens with a loud squeak, Adora has

to smile at her metaphor. She is in a desert and is thinking about drowning ... The guard gives her a suspicious look, but says nothing but pushes her out of the cell. "The strongest says we shouldn't put you in shackles. But if you try to escape, that's your end."

"Pf!" makes Adora and looks defiantly at the guard. Why should she flee now? She would run away from the only chance to win this war. Because, as much as she dislikes this thought, she needs Catra. The guard begins escorting the blonde woman up the stairs. Adora stumbles over a step and falls on her nose.

Immediately she feels a throbbing pain on the bridge of her nose, but it just seems to be a light bruise. The lizard behind her doesn't care, but grabs her upper arm and rudely pulls her up. Adora stumbles with him and has to control herself not to step on the tail of this lizard. She does this for her friends, she recalls. For Glimmer and Bow, for Glimmer and Bow, for Glimmer and Bow. This mantra calms her down while she is maneuvered through countless corridors and climbs up several stairs.

Adora loses orientation after the first few minutes and gives up trying to find her way around here. Instead, she notices how little decoration this building contains. As she understood it, this is the main building in town. So you could compare it to the castle in Bright Moon. However, it is in enormous contrast to Adora's home. But it doesn't have much to do with the Horde or the Fright Zone either.

Everything in here seems neat and functional, but it lacks the dark and creepy. This is not a place where Adora would want to stay long, but she doesn't have the feeling that the fear is being provoked here. She wonders if Catra had anything to do with it. Whether she is possibly responsible for it, and if so, whether she consciously created this place.

At some point they come to a standstill in front of a door. It is simple and made of wood. So inconspicuous that Adora almost overlooked it. One of the two guards accompanying her steps

forward and knocks twice. "What?" Catra's annoyed voice comes muffled through the wall. Immediately the guards feel insecure. "We ... we bring the prisoner, strongest."

It is evident that the guards are afraid of Catra. Adora has to resist a smile. At the same moment the door is thrown open and a grim-looking Catra examines the people in front of her door. Her expression brightens a little when she sees Adora.

"Oh, good. About time! You guys will be faster next time, understood?!" The guards nod eagerly so as not to upset Catra before the Magicat waves her hand and sends them away. Adora now stands alone while Catra turns away and walks back into the room. Confused, Adora stares after her, unsure of what to do. The Magicat calls through the open door: "Are you coming now or do you want to stay there forever?" Baffled she follows the Magicat.

After closing the door behind her, Adora is surprised to see that this must be Catra's bedroom. She looks with interest at the bare walls and the lounger that is set up in the middle of the room. There is a small chest of drawers in the corner, otherwise the room is empty. Adora is astounded at how little comfort she finds here. It is little different from the sleeping quarters in the Horde. A thought creeps into the blonde's consciousness that frightens her: Catra has never known anything other than this.
Does she consciously live so minimalistically or is it because she doesn't know anything better?

Adora immediately thinks of her soft, oversized bed in Bright Moon and the many decorations in her room. It is in a similarly great contrast to Catra's room as the stone building to Bright Moon Castle. "Good morning to you too." Catra scoffs when Adora has stood still in the room for so long. "Cat got your tongue, princess? Or are you still asleep?" "No." Adora mumbles, but doesn't know what else to add. Shaking her head, Catra continues to strap her weapons to her belt.

"Why did you bring me here?" Adora finally wants to know when the Magicat runs to the small chest of drawers and opens a drawer. "Um, maybe you forgot, but we wanted to go on a trip through the desert today." "No, I mean why here?" Adora waves her arms to mark the room. "What, would you have preferred to be dragged into the great hall again so that I can give a dramatic speech in front of the city about how we will go out and save the world with nothing but our heroism and the magic of friendship?" The sarcastic tone with a hint of amusement in Catra's voice could not be ignored.

Adora´s eyes continue to wander through the room, although there is nothing new to discover. She shrugs her shoulders, knowing full well that the Magicat is watching her. "Well, I would have expected that rather than ... THAT." She points to her surroundings. Catra arches an eyebrow when she finds what she's looking for in the drawer and pulls it out. "You princesses have to make a theater out of everything. Well, the dramatic appearance was more Hordak's style. I thought we'd just get out of here without causing a stir. You will manage that, She-Ra, won't you? And besides," Catra explains, before Adora can get angry about the teasing, "I wanted to give you this."

She tosses her the item she pulled out of the dresser. Adora instinctively reaches out and catches the object. It's the extendable rod, the blonde realizes with surprise. The lizards had taken it from her when she was captured. Holding it in her hands again fills Adora with tremendous relief. With a weapon in her possession and no bars in front of her, she feels a lot less helpless. "Uhm ... thanks." She looks at Catra, who is already taking care of her own equipment.

"Whatever. Here, take this." She tosses Adora a small bag. Inside is some food and a bottle of water. While Adora is putting on the bag, she sees the Magicat doing the same with a second bag. "We're leaving immediately. You have everything you need, princess?" For the first time since entering the room, Catra looks directly at her. Adora nods resolutely. "I don´t need anything else." "Good. Come on then."

The Magicat walks purposefully past Adora out of the room. The blonde woman follows her out into the corridor. It doesn't take long to get to the exit of the building. Catra ignores the lizards guarding the door and walks outside, relaxed. Adora feels the guards eyeing her suspiciously, so she hurries to follow the Magicat outside. Catra walks confidently through the streets of the city. Adora hardly has time to look around, although she is curious to find out more about life here.

But the mission has priority, she recalls, and accelerates her pace until she walks right next to Catra. The Magicat throws her a sideways glance, but stays silent. The whole situation makes Adora nervous. She feels like a shadow of herself. Concern for her friends fuels the constant fear she feels. The unfamiliar environment weakens her self-esteem, and being practically alone doesn't make it any better. The fact that she is on the road with Catra of all people to save the world tops it all off. Adora is so confused. And unsure. She doesn't know what to think or feel or how to behave.

She throws a sidelong glance at Catra, who is staring at the path in front of her. The blonde looks at her for a moment. Outwardly, her companion hardly seems to have changed. She has the same long hair, that snub nose and that beautiful two-tone eyes of the Catra from a year ago. But is it also the same Catra? Has she changed in the last year? And if so, is that good or bad?
Is there anything left of the Catra, who was the most important person in her life for 18 years?
The thought makes Adora feel sick. At the same time, she is annoyed that after all these years she still hasn't given up hope. She´s such an idiot...

"You are staring at me like I've put a mouse in your bed." Catra comments and pulls Adora out of her thoughts. She didn't realize she was staring for so long. Embarrassed, she turns her gaze to the street. Now the questioning look of the Magicat is on her. "Sorry. I was just thinking." "Spit it out, princess." Adora quickly claims: "I was wondering if you've scratched someone's eyes here already." Half of it is meant as a joke. Her own words make her

think of a childhood incident. Catra scratched one eye out of Octavia and insulted her.

Adora can't help smiling. That day Catra came to her and told her about it. Adora took her side and insulted Octavia. In retrospect, they got in a lot of trouble for this, but it was fun. She remembers chuckling as they ran down the streets of the Fright Zone to hide from an angry Octavia. The two had been holding hands the entire time. It's a fond memory. A look to the side shows Adora the corner of Catra's mouth twitching.

"Maybe a guy or two who aggravated me too much." she admits. A sound escapes Adora´s throat, which resembles a suppressed grunt. "What did the guys do to you to aggravate you? Did they have a 'dumb face'?" With a shrug, the Magicat replies: "That too. One guy flamed me and called me 'little kitty'. The other one poured a bucket of water over me when he tripped over his own feet." Adora´s eyes widen. "Oh oh. I bet no one dared to do that again." "No." is the simple answer of the Magicat. Adora cannot say whether Catra is serious or amused about it.

They walk on in silence until they reach the end of town. From there it seems as if Adora’s head is clearing up a bit. As if she now has a clearer view of her goal. Her gaze slides over the seemingly endless expanse of the desert before she resolutely shrugs her shoulders and with renewed courage begins to stomp off. After a few meters she is stopped by a voice. "Uhm, Adora? Where exactly are you going?" The blonde woman stops and turns to Catra, who has not strayed an inch from the city wall, but is watching her companion waiting.

As if it wasn't clear, Adora replies slowly: "To Bright Moon?" The Magicat tilts her head and points in the opposite direction. "In that case you have to march that way, princess." Now Adora is the one who tilts her head, confused. "But I came this way too! It's the fastest way through the desert!" Catra bites her lip and is silent for a moment, as if she were struggling with something. Seconds later, however, she doesn't seem to be able to take it any longer and snorts. "The fastest way? You have probably explored the

whole desert on your way if you come from the opposite direction. How long did it take you to get here? Three days?"

"Four." Adoraa admits contrite. And only if you only calculate the time in the desert. "I just thought the desert was pretty big." The blonde woman tries to defend herself, but this only leads to Catra starting to laugh heartily. Adora´s cheeks turn pink with embarrassment. At the same time, she can't help but notice how beautiful Catra's laugh sounds. Even if she's making fun of Adora. Involuntarily she wonders when she last heard the Magicat laugh so openly.

"Ohh Adora!" Catra gasps and even wipes a tear from the corner of her eye. Then she reaches for a dry branch that is nearby and begins to draw a map in the dusty ground. In the meantime she has recovered. "Here is the city." she explains to Adora and points with the branch to a point in the sand. "And there is the border of the desert. You have probably crossed it here." It marks a point in the sand. "And here you passed according to your information." ends Catra. Adora looks at the roughly drawn map and is ashamed. The map is shockingly accurate and shows very well how big Adora´s detour must have been.

"So your tracking skills haven't really improved since the Horde." speculates Catra, strangely enough, with no mockery in her voice. Adora protests, still embarrassed: "What´s that supposed to mean? I'm good at orientating!" She even got tutoring from Huntara, a former Crimson Waste resident. However, that probably didn't do that much. Catra is still grinning. "Of course. You only didn´t get lost back in training because you followed the tip of my tail." "I was almost always the first to finish!" "Only because you passed me in the last few meters."

The blonde woman opens her mouth and closes it again. Then she decides to just drop the subject. She punched Catra lightly in the side to take away the satisfaction in her face and mumbled: "Whatever. Will you show me now how we can get out of here the fastest way?" The self-confident grin remains, but Catra does not

go into the topic any further but points in one direction. "That way." Together they set off.

Chapter 8

Catra:

"So what's your plan?" Catra wants to know after a while as they are hiking through a purple canyon. Her original plan was to ignore Adora as much as possible, but when she discovered the detour Adora had taken on the outskirts ... something changed. It felt like Catra had gotten a crack into her protective cocoon of hatred and anger. For a long time she had had to laugh heartily and without malicious ulterior motives.

That something like that happened to Adora just happened ... ´Adora´. It showed Catra that despite the years she hasn't really changed, and for a moment it just felt good to be with her. Meanwhile, Catra has regained her composure and has returned to her original plan. However, she needs to know what to expect in this mission. So she throws a sidelong glance at her companion. Adora brushes her gaze and puts a hand on her neck, embarrassed. "Uhm, well ... I'm open to ideas." At this point, Catra couldn't resist to hit her forehead with her hand. "Of course you have no plan, dummy."

Offended, Adora crosses her arms as they walk side by side. "I have a plan!" "Oh yes? Then let's hear it!" "We'll return to Bright Moon as soon as possible, meet the princesses, storm the horde, get my sword, save my friends and defeat Hordak!" "Uhuh" replies Catra, not convinced. "That really is a master plan." "I never said he was done.", the companion defends herself. "Then I suggest you think about something. I don't think Hordak will be impressed with your plan." "I said, I'm still thinking-"

Adora begins, but Catra interrupts her by stretching out an arm and preventing her companion from going on. "What" starts the blonde woman, but Catra is already busy concentrating on her surroundings. Your ears have started to twitch. Something is

approaching, she just can't tell from where. She turns vigilantly around her own axis and watches the rocks around her. Then she smells it. The Magicat turns to Adora in a flash and puts her hand on her mouth.

The blonde backs away and squeaks in shock, but Catra does not loosen her grip. "Quiet!" she hisses and drags her to a nearby crevice. It's barely big enough for two people, but Catra somehow manages to squash herself and her companion into it.
With Adora in her arms, she stands pressed against the inside of the crevice, one hand wrapped around Adora´s chest, the other on her mouth. "Whatever you do, don't move or make any noise now!"

The seriousness in her voice makes it clear that she is not playing games. There's hardly enough space in here, but Adora manages to suggest a nod. However, Catra doesn't want to take any risks, so her hand stays on Adora´s mouth, just not so tightly pressed. They pause like that for a few moments, and Catra turns her gaze to look outside. Then she hears it. Steps. A dark shadow becomes visible.

Adora, too, has her eyes fixed on the exit and freezes when she sees the shadow. It's an animal, a kind of black panther with four hooves. Searching, the creature lifts its head in the air and looks around. It knows we're here, thinks Catra, holding her breath. And it is up to prey. Then the animal suddenly turns its head and looks in their direction. To prevent Catra's bright eyes giving her away, she presses her eyelids together and hopes that Adora will do the same.

She hears a rumble that must come from the being. Then steps that slowly move away. But Catra does not dare to move, any more than her companion. She listens until even her good ears can no longer hear the creature's footsteps and can no longer perceive its smell. Only then does she dare to open her eyes and breathe normally again.

At the same time, she becomes aware of what kind of situation she is in: In the semi-darkness, Adora´s back pressed against her front, one hand wrapped around the blonde's chest, the other on her mouth. Blonde hair tickles her nose. A strange feeling arises in her when she is so clearly aware of Adora 's closeness.

But she suppresses it and instead whispers: "The coast is clear." Adora, too, now dares to move again. Together they squeeze out of their little refuge and step outside. Due to the renewed brightness, Catra's pupils contract when she looks around. No, no more trace of the other being. Good. Meanwhile Adora sucks in the fresh air and asks confused: "What kind of thing was that?" "A Deryll." explains Catra and brushes a few strands of hair from her face. "A dangerous predator that is not uncommon here in the Crimson Waste. And this one was on the prey."

Now Adora looks a little perturbed at the Magicat. "And we were the prey?" Catra shrugs. "Almost. Derylls don't have a good nose, but they have sharp eyes. If they spot you, you have little chance of defeating him." "Oh. Well, I didn't expect that." The Magicat throws back her head and looks at the blonde woman questioningly. "What, did you expect this to be an easy walk? This is still the crimson waste we're talking about."

Shaking her head, she continues her walk. It really borders on a miracle that Adora made it to the capital on her own almost unscathed. Especially without She Ra. On the other hand, it's Adora she's talking about here. This woman accomplishes everything she puts in her pighead. The corner of her mouth twitches when Catra thinks about it. Adora just looks at her inquiringly. "What's so funny about that?" "Nothing at all. Let's move on."

When the blonde woman catches up with her, she looks around, disturbed. "Are there any other beings like this here? Do I have to be afraid that some giant spiders will attack me here?" Catra can hear the joke in her voice. Surely she must also think of the event when Adora and the Magicat were once trapped in the She Ra ruins and were chased by a couple of giant robot spiders.

In response, Catra shrugs. "Not if you pay attention." Adora stops in horror. "Wait. What?" Catra can hardly help grinning as she walks on relaxed. When Adora realizes that the Magicat has screwed her, she runs after her. "Hey! CATRA!" Now Catra has to laugh and starts to run too.

At some point the evening comes and Catra decides to set up camp in a small cave. It takes some persuasion with Adora, because she doesn't seem to think in the least of a rest. Typically Adora. She would go through the next few days without interruption to get to her destination. Eventually, Catra can get her to sit down and lean her back against the wall of the cave while they eat some of their provisions together.

They use no campfire. In the Crimson Waste it is warm even at night and the smoke and light would only attract wild animals. While Catra devours her last bite of dried meat, she sees Adora guiltily gazing out at the open country. "We should go on. Every minute we waste, Glimmer and Bow wait with the Horde and who knows what they must endure!"

Rolling her eyes, the Magicat stretches. "Now calm down, princess. Even if your energy reserves seem to be infinite, I need my deserved portion of sleep to function. So if you want us to have a chance against the Horde," says Catra, while she inwardly shakes her head over herself. She would never have thought that she would use words like that. "then for heaven's sake relax!"

Adora doesn't seem reassured, but at least she lets go of the landscape and instead looks at her companion. "Second," explains the Magicat, "We will move forward much faster tomorrow." The blonde woman frowns. "Why are you so sure about that?" Catra grins confidently. "I'll get us a means of transportation." "What a - " "Let yourself be surprised." interrupts the Magicat, because she has no desire for a discussion. Instead, she takes up her original theme again.

"And third: stop worrying about your friends. Nothing will happen to them. Hordak usually doesn't care about prisoners." At the

word 'usually', Catra feels her throat being uncomfortable scratchy. Yes, most of the time Hordak doesn't care about his prisoners and he doesn't even think of torturing them.
Lost in thought, her fingers wander down her neck.
Hordak is more interested in punishing those who make mistakes, she thinks bitterly.

Adora:

Adora has noticed Catra's change of mood and gives her a concerned look, but says nothing. Even if she is curious and wants to know what Catra is thinking about, she hardly believes that the Magicat will really confide in her. She put on this look that already means in her childhood that she doesn't want to talk about it. So Adora is looking for another topic of conversation instead.

"Hey," she finally begins and looks for Catra's eyes. When she finds them, she puts on a small, careful smile. "Thank you. That you come with me and help me. It means a lot to me." For a moment Adora thinks she sees a flash of vulnerability in the beautiful two-tone eyes, then she blinks and the Magicat's face closes when she averts her gaze. "Somebody has to make sure that you don't do anything stupid."

Outrage seizes Adora and covers the serious mood that has prevailed up to now. "Hey, I never do anything stupid!"
Unimpressed, Catra crosses her arms and looks again into Adora ´s eyes, this time composed. "You ran alone and in complete despair into the Crimson Waste, the most dangerous area of Etheria, and wanted to beg a few lawless gangs with no morals for help. I would call that quite stupid."

Snapped, Adora wants to contradict her, but remains silent. Catra is right. If you look at it that way, the plan really wasn't that clever. She must have been lucky that Catra was the leader of the

gangs. Catra, who is watching her and knows exactly what is going on, grins triumphantly. "I didn't have a choice!", the blonde woman defends herself.

"Still. It was stupid." Before Adora can reply, Catra continues: "Whatever. Anyway, I'm not doing this for you. I just want to get revenge on Hordak." Adora immediately forgets her outrage and perks up. She tilts her head with interest. "You said that before. Why do you want to get revenge on him? What did he do? Has it anything to do with the fact that you live here in the Crimson Waste?"

At her questions, Catra's fur stands on end. Now she's the one staring out at the horizon. Quickly, Adora adds: "Forget it, you don't have to talk about it." The Magicat does not reply or look at her, but her muscles seem to relax. The two are silent for a while until Catra mumbles: "We should got to sleep." Only now does Adora notice that Catra has distracted her from her worries. Reluctantly, she looks out into the night until she sighs resignedly. The Magicat is right, there is no point in storming restlessly out into the night. Besides, they would be moving faster tomorrow.

So Adora nods and lies down on the stone floor. It's cold, but the blonde doesn't freeze because of the warm air. Catra too curls up on the floor and turns her back on Adora. The warrior is once again aware of the darkness that surrounds her. But she swallows the rising fear and looks at the Magicat's back. Catra is here. That thought has calmed her in the past, and it still works now. Even if their relationship is now ... more complicated. Luckily it doesn't take long before Adora slips into unconsciousness.

Chapter 9

Adora:

The next morning the women get up early. Since they hardly have anything with them, they are quickly ready to move on. Catra explains that it is not far to the next town. There she would get the ´transport´. Adora can't get any more information out of her, and so the two of them are silent for a large part of the way.

In order not to be overwhelmed by her worries again, Adora takes a closer look at the surroundings they are crossing. And she is impressed. When she first hiked through the desert on her own, she ignored her surroundings. Her eyes were clouded with concern for her friends and the urge to seek help. but now she is struck by the beauty of the desert.

It's a different form of beauty like the one of Bright Moon or the Whispering Woods. It's a raw, unprocessed, natural beauty that can't be seen at first glance. How could you, if there are so many dangers in this place that can distract you? Thoughtfully, the blonde woman averts her gaze and looks at Catra, who is walking next to her.

For so long Adora wondered what happened to Catra. In retrospect, it's almost ridiculous that she didn't think of it earlier. The Magicat is made for mastering the Crimson Waste. The land and she seem alike: both are wild, free and untamable. Curiously, she looks at how Catra frowns in concentration and looks around to decide which path to take.

Adora would love to know how the Magicat got into the Crimson Waste. Why she is no longer with the Horde, but wants revenge on Hordak for some reason. But Adora doesn't want to urge Catra. She has no idea what this is between them, but she doesn't want to risk destroying it. In addition, Adora knows from the past that Catra doesn't like to talk about her vulnerability.

"... And that's why you mustn't touch it under any circumstances, understand?" Catra's voice pulls Adora out of her thoughts. She looks up, confused. "Uhmm what?" She meets the reproachful look of the Magicat. "Seriously, princess? Did you pay any attention to what I said?" "I, uhm ..." Embarrassed, the blonde woman puts a hand on the back of her neck. "To be honest, I was a bit distracted." Catra lifts an eyebrow and crosses her arms.

After a moment, she groans and shakes her head. "I can't believe you actually made it through the Crimson Waste without getting eaten or killed!" "Hey! I can take good care of myself!" "Hmm ..." Without warning, Catra grabs her companion's elbow and pulls her to her side. "Then why did you want to run into the huge, unmistakable cactus in front of you?"

Surprised, Adora glides away from Catra to the path in front of her and she realizes that the Magicat is right. She almost actually walked into this monster without even realizing it. When stepped on, she looks down. A sigh sounds next to her, then Catra runs ahead and says: "You have to be more careful, Adora." The fact that she addresses the blonde woman by name makes Adora sit up and take notice. Catra's tone is also strange. Kind of ... serious.

The Magicat continues and looks back at Adora. "You must not be inattentive for a moment in the Crimson Waste, otherwise this place will devour you. And you must never lose sight of the path in front of you, because otherwise -"
"Catra, watch out!"
Adora only realizes at the last second that Catra is heading straight for an abyss. Since she turned to Adora, she doesn't see it herself. Adora’s warning makes her head spin around, but then she already steps into the void and falls into the depths. Startled, she screams.

Adora jumps forward and at the last moment manages to grab Catra's arm. The blonde woman lies flat on her stomach in the dust and holds Catra's arm with one hand, which is dangling in the air.
"I got you!" the blonde woman gasps and pulls her former friend

upstairs. Shocked by this sudden fall, Catra climbs up and lands next to Adora on the safe ground.

"Everything OK?" the blonde wants to know and looks for injuries to the Magicat. She just looks to the abyss in disbelief. "I ... I fell.", Catra recognizes in shock. Adora looks worriedly at her companion, but she doesn't seem to be missing anything physically. Catra stares at her hands in disbelief. "I was distracted and didn't pay attention to the way ... and fell."

Adora doesn't understand why the Magicat is thrown off track, so she gets up and holds out a hand to her companion. "That was an accident. It can happen to anyone." Catra's head turns to the blonde. Something disturbed enters her eyes. "But it doesn't happen to me! I know the Crimson Waste! I know about its dangers! I always pay attention, I don't get distracted, I don't lose control. I mustn't! Otherwise-"

Worried, Adora kneels next to Catra again. Little did she know that the Magicat was putting herself under such pressure. Carefully, she places a hand on her companion's shoulder. "Hey." She waits until Catra looks at her. Really looks at her, not just through her. Then she puts on a small smile. "It's okay. Mistakes happen. Nobody is perfect. And you are not alone, remember? I take care of you like you take care of me."

When Adora sees the vulnerability in the eyes of the Magicat, she doesn't dare to utter her promise from ages ago. However, she hopes Catra can read it on her face.

´Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.´

They sit like that for a moment. Adora thinks she can finally feel the bond that has existed for years. Then Catra shakes off her hand on her shoulder and breaks the connection. Adora stands up silently and hopes that she doesn't see how hurt she is by this gesture. Catra looks at her from the side and mumbles: "We ... we

should move on." Adora feels a stab in her heart because she is not sure whether Catra is only referring to her situation or something deeper.

The blonde nods and runs after the Magicat, which is now looking straight ahead on her way. The mood is oppressive. Adora doesn't like the fact that she can't get through to Catra. So much does she wish they could just be friends again. Forget what happened. It may sound crazy, but what Adora said to Catra, she means seriously. She feels comfortable around Catra. And sure. At least that's how it used to be.

Of course, she knows that Glimmer and Bow would protect her too and are her best friends. But it's not the same. They didn't get through what Adora and Catra had to go through. They know Adora, but not inside out. Just as Adora doesn't know them one hundred percent. That's normal and it's okay. It just doesn't close the hole that has been in Adora’s heart since she left the Horde. She hoped so much at the time that she would still be able to convince Catra until she finally banished hope to the farthest corners of her heart when Catra disappeared.

And now? Now Adora no longer knows what to believe. Whether Catra is on the good side, the bad side or maybe somewhere in between. She only knows one thing: since the night Catra came to her cell, she has felt it again. That quiet, darned hope that the friendship between the two may not be completely lost after all.

So absorbed in thought, Adora does not notice how time flies. At some point it is already noon when Catra has been raising her voice for a long time: "Here we are. The next town begins over there." Adora looks up in surprise and sees the crowd of houses and the hustle and bustle of people around them. "There you can get us the means of transport?" she wants to know. Finally Catra turns and looks at her. A mischievous smile appears on her face. "You could say so."

There she was again, old Catra. There was no sign of her eruption a few hours ago. Instead, she waves Adora to her side. "Come on,

you're in a hurry, aren't you?" Together they reach the city and start wandering the streets. Catra seems to know her destination because she walks purposefully past the houses and bends in a certain direction. At some point she stops in front of a hut with a thatched roof and stone wall. She turns calmly back to the blonde woman. "Wait here."

Then she runs to the hut, where a large lizard guy is standing in front of the entrance. He has crossed his arms and looks grim. When he sees the Magicat approaching, his eyes widen and he stands up straighter. Unimpressed, Catra stands in front of him and they exchange a few words. The lizard guy looks dissatisfied until Catra snaps her fingers and something catapults into the air between her fingers. The lizard catches it and twists it in his fingers before disappearing through the door. Adora thinks she recognized a coin. With a satisfied expression, Catra turns to her companion and waves her over.

Confused, Adora crosses the street and approaches the Magicat. "And?" "Everything is fine." At the same moment the same lizard guy appears again, this time with a key in his hand. He waves the women with him and leads them around the building to another entrance, which turns out to be a door to an enclosure.

Adora watches with surprise as the guy unlocks the door and goes inside. There are several animals in the enclosure. "What ... what are they?" the blonde wants to know. They look like the lizards from the gang, just a lot more ... animal. And they all have a reddish pattern on their back. The tall guy, unimpressed, takes something from the wall, a kind of harness, and puts it on two of the animals. Then he leads them out of the enclosure.

Frightened, Adora steps back when the big animals walk past her. Although they walk on all fours, they come up to her chest. Catra, on the other hand, is completely unimpressed. Relaxed, she takes the reins from the waiting guy. He nods to her and then disappears behind the building. "That", Catra explains with a self-satisfied grin, "are wind salamanders. The fastest beings of the Crimson Waste. And our means of transport!"

Adora watches in shock as Catra pats one of the animals on the head. The salamanders do not look malicious, but still ... restless. Like they can't wait to move. "What?" the blonde woman croaks. "You can't be serious. We should ... ride? On these things?" The smile on Catra's face becomes challenging. "What? Are you afraid of a challenge, Adora?" She almost purrs the last word. "Me? Pf, never!"

As determined as possible, she walks up to the salamanders and looks at them. Meanwhile, Catra holds out the reins of one of the animals. The blonde woman takes it uncertainly. "Um ... they don't have a saddle."

"And? Your winged horse doesn't have one either. Don't be such a princess." Catra swings elegantly on the animal's back as if she had already done it a thousand times. Swallowing, Adora looks at her salamander, which is impatiently running its tail across the floor. 'All right,' she thinks. `Just pretend it's Swift Wind you're riding with.' Determined, Adora reaches out her arms and pulls herself up on the animal. Probably not quite as elegant, but almost as quickly she sits on the back of her salamander as well. She immediately notices the slight difference in altitude. And the warm, leathery skin of the salamander. It feels strange, but not bad.

One look at Catra reveals that the Magicat has not let her out of sight. Grinning, she nods in the direction of the street. "Ready?" Without waiting for Adora to answer, she begins to ride out of town. "Wait, Catra! How do you control this thing?" Adora wants to know, but by then her salamander starts to move by itself and follows the first one. Adora takes a while to get used to the feeling. It was similar, and at the same time, not the same as Swift Wind. When they have reached the city limits and look out over the vastness of the desert, Catra looks at her companion. "You okay?" she wants to know. She seems to be serious, so Adora nods.

"A little strange, but yes." "Good." Then the mischievous smile returns on Catra's face. "The last one at the border has to wear

sparkly dresses for a week!" Before Adora realizes her word, the Magicat gives her salamander a sign and the two rush forward. In doing so, they leave behind a small cloud of dust. "Hey!" shouts Adora indignantly and rides behind. "That's not fair!" Catra's laughter can be heard from far ahead. "The whole life is not fair! You better hurry up, princess!" Ohh, Catra would regret that! Now the fighting spirit awakens in Adora too, and she urges her salamander to run even faster. She would win this race!

Chapter 10

Adora:

They ride at this pace for a few hours until it begins to gets dark. At some point, Catra stops at a rock face. Confused, Adora stops a few meters from her and looks at the Magicat. "What's going on? Why are we stopping?" The Magicat points to the horizon behind her, where the sun is already setting. "It's not far to the national border, but it's getting dark. There is no shelter here, but the rock wall here protects us from at least one side when we are resting here."

While running, Adora was able to use up the energy that had built up in her for days and made her feel so restless. She feels that she has covered a very large part of the route today and that calms her down a bit. Now she feels much more relaxed at the thought of resting.
So she nods to Catra, who ties her salamander to a rock, and dismounts from her own animal. Together they sit down between the two salamanders to use them as a visual cover. Salamanders in rocky areas are not uncommon, Catra explains, while the two eat some of their supplies that they have previously stocked up in town.

The women are silent for a while and stare at the horizon. Adora leaned her back against the rock face and put her head back to look up at the dark sky. Catra, who is sitting next to her, has her legs drawn to her chest and her head on her knees when she breaks the silence at some point. "He banished me."

Surprised, Adora turns her head to her companion. She is both surprised that the Magicat is starting a conversation and what she is saying. "What?" The Magicat has her tail wrapped around as she stares at the ground. "Hordak, I mean. I have ..."
Catra takes a deep breath before continuing. It is obviously difficult for her to talk about it. Adora waits patiently for the Magicat to be ready. "I have made a mistake."

Her whole body seems to tense at these words, but Catra continues. "I let Shadow Weaver escape. She betrayed me and ... and left me behind."

The tremor in Catra's voice also makes Adora’s heart tremble. "Catra ..." Confused, Adora looks at the Magicat and thinks of the shadow woman who now lives in Bright Moon. It was not clear to her what consequences Shadow Weaver's change of sides had for Catra. "When Hordak found out that she escaped because of me, he ..." The Magicat swallows and her hand unconsciously wanders to her throat.

Adora is angry when she sees how disturbed Catra is by these memories. Anger at Hordak, not even knowing exactly what he did. And anger at herself for not being there to save Catra from him. She feels the need to punch and scream the wall behind her. An old protective instinct that wakes up as soon as it comes to Catra. And which the blonde could never turn off completely. But as much as Adora wants to scream: She is silent so as not to interrupt Catra.

"He wanted to kill me. With this ... THING, this invention that takes the air you breathe, to suffocate you. He wanted to do it in front of the Horde, to set a warning example. But then he changed his mind. Instead he banished me to the Crimson Waste in the hope that I would rot there. " The anger in Adora´s belly is getting stronger and stronger. Catra had to go through it all alone. Adora was not with her to prevent it. If she hadn't had enough reasons to hate Hordak, Shadow Weaver and the Horde before, then at least she will now.

The Magicat emits a bitter laugh. "But he underestimated me. Within a day I put the gangs under my leadership and became the strongest of the Crimson Waste." The anger fades a bit, into the background. Impressed and shocked at the same time, Adora looks at her former friend. "So this is how you came to the Crimson Waste and became the leader.”, mumbles the blonde. Catra doesn't reply, just stares into space. "The whole time I was wondering where you are." Adora confesses quietly, more to

herself than to Magicat. Even quieter she adds: "I was afraid you were dead."

The Magicat's ears twitch in surprise, but she does not turn her gaze to the blonde. "As you can see, I'm still pretty much alive. Despite my failure." The bitterness in her voice makes it clear how little Catra thinks of herself. Now Adora cannot help but turn her upper body to her companion and look at her intently. "Catra, you are not a failure. You never were! You subdued an entire region within a day!

You survived the horde! And you don't owe that to anyone but you.

You led the toughest gangs in the country for a whole year! Just see what you can achieve if you want to. The Catra that I know reaches everything that she imagines. She doesn't care what others think of her. She doesn't care how many stones are put in her way. She still manages to reach her goal because that´s just how she is!"

Adora doesn't know what's wrong with her recently. Why she comforts her enemy. But since they started their journey, she lost more and more of her conviction that Catra is her enemy. Meanwhile, the Magicat is finally seduced by Adora’s words to look at her companion. Her eyes reveal a vulnerability that Catra does not often show. Adora is almost breathtaking when Catra replies, "I lost Shadow Weaver. This IS a failure."

Now it's Adora who sounds bitter. "Shadow Weaver is a genius at using and manipulating the people around her. It's not your fault. She could have taken advantage of anyone else like that." It's quiet for a while. Catra Adora doesn't agree, but she doesn't protest either.

Catra:

This time the silence is a restless one. Catra doesn't know what to say. Adora´s words surprise her. She longs for them and at the same time fears that she might not be serious. Or that everything is just a dream. When she finally looks at Adora next to her, she sees the blonde woman's gaze on her. Adora´s eyes wander up and down her, a worry line on her forehead.
Finally her gaze catches on Catra's hands. Startled, she lets out her breath. "Catra, what happened to your hands ?!"

Absently, the Magicat stares at her hands. The short claws are already growing back, but the small cuts and grazes have not yet healed. Quickly, she clenches her hands into fists and hides them in front of her chest. "Nothing. It was just a stupid accident. They heal quickly." The worried expression on Adora´s face doesn´t leave when she looks at the fists of the Magicat. The Magicat doesn't understand why Adora wants to take care of her. Two days ago she was trapped in a cell because of her.

And yet the genuine concern in Adora´s eyes touches something in Catra. It reminds her of their time together in the Horde. Back then it was not uncommon for her to get injured during training sessions. However, Adora was always there, always making sure that Catra was fine. The blonde woman's thoughts seem to be heading in a similar direction as she mumbles: "You were always particularly proud of your claws because they gave you so many advantages in combat. Even though you always used them, they weren't often broken.
And you took good care of them. After every training session, you made sure that your claws were in good condition are still sharpened and none of them cracked. Sometimes you spent almost an hour with it! And if someone bothered you, you hissed angrily. Sometimes I sat next to you and just watched. "

Catra listens with fascination to Adora’s statements. She is surprised at how many details she can remember.
How much she noticed back then.
Then Adora looks up and meets the eyes of the Magicat. It's like

she ´s waking up from her memories. The blonde woman carefully holds out a hand. "May I see them?"

Catra cannot escape the softness of Adora’s voice, so she loosens her fingers from her chest and lets Adora take her hands. Like something precious, Adora gently pulls Catra's hands a little closer to her face and examines the damage to it. The Magicat is watching her very closely.
With her blue-gray eyes she explores every small scar, every crust of blood, every scratch on Catra's fingers. And there is nothing in the blonde woman's gaze but gentleness and ... affection.
Catra shudders. Terrified, she tries to hide her reaction.

There is something extremely intimate about this touch, as if Catra was putting all of her vulnerability in Adora’s hands. At the same time, Adora´s gentle touch of her hands feels like balm for the tortured wight of the Magicat. As if this touch alone had the power to heal not only Catra's external injuries on the hand, but also her soul. It feels good. And yet Catra is ... afraid. Fear of indulging in this good and of being disappointed and dropped in the next moment. She tries to pull her hands back, but she doesn't move.

Instead, she inhales the gentle touch of Adora´s fingers like someone who is about to suffocate. After a few minutes - or was it just seconds? - the blonde finally lets go of Catra's hands and looks at the floor. She seems embarrassed about something. Does she regret being so caring to Catra? But then the blonde says quietly: "Thank you for telling me all this, Catra."
Apparently unmoved, the Magicat shrugs her shoulders, but can still feel a tingling sensation dance over her fingers. "It wasn't a secret." Adora lifts her head and looks at her. "But it's not easy to talk about either."

For a moment, Catra does not let go of her companion's gaze. She allows herself to look at the face in front of her.
That big, dumb, beautiful face.
The bright blue eyes that shimmer silver in the darkness. The long nose. The healing scratch on the cheek. The small strand that has

come off her ponytail and falls into her large forehead, on which small beads of sweat have formed. The full, pink lips that are slightly pinched together.

It's not fair, thinks Catra, that this woman is so beautiful. The same thought occurred to her in the great hall when she saw Adora for the first time. This time, however, she doesn't feel so much anger, but ... something else. Maybe admiration? No, this feeling is different.
It feels ... desiring.
Startled, Catra blinks and shakes her head to drive away her thoughts. Adora also seems to have been trapped in her thoughts until just now, because she hasn't moved. She too now turns away and looks up at the stars.

If Catra hadn't been so busy trying to banish her thoughts, she might have noticed the slight blush on Adora´s cheeks.

The next morning, when Catra wakes up, she feels something warm on her stomach. At first she's too tired to open her eyes and doesn't care. However, when this something moves a little, Catra squeals, startled, and opens her eyes. She lies on her side and finds Adora´s head pressed against her stomach, her face snuggled into her short fur, which is under the thin bodysuit. Her knees are drawn up, similar to Catra's, she has drawn her hands to her chest.

Yesterday they fell asleep at least two meters apart. Adora was probably very active in her sleep again and must have found her way to Catra's stomach somehow. For a moment the Magicat is too surprised by this sight, then she clears her throat resolutely. Adora should wake up before Catra can come up with the idea of finding this touch pleasant.

But for some reason Adora is not on her feet as fast as usual. Instead, she rubs her face sleepily against Catra's stomach. That tickles, and the Magicat would have laughed out loud if she hadn't pressed her lips together so hard. So Catra resolutely kicks the blonde's shin with one leg, which is within reach. "Hmmm what..."

comes the indignant reply from Adora, who doesn't even think about getting up, let alone opening her eyes. Catra can't help but smile when she comments: "You're drooling on my stomach."

There is no reaction for a second. Then Catra can feel how Adora processes the words, and suddenly her whole body freezes and she opens her eyes. She jerks her head back and stares at Catra's stomach, which is only inches away from her face. Suddenly Adora blushes. "Oh, I ... I'm sorry, I didn't realize that!" "I noticed." Catra comments dryly and gets up. In doing so, she struggles to remove the smile from her face.
When she takes a look at her stomach and actually discovers a small drool mark, the Magicat can no longer contain herself and grins broadly.

Adora also jumps up and laughs nervously. She avoids looking Catra in the face. When she realizes how embarrassed the blonde is, it incites Catra. "So, did you sleep comfortably?" she teases to cover up her own embarrassment. Adora laughs in agony. "Haha, uhm ... I, I think I'll get my salamander ready. We have to go slowly and -" The blonde woman stops as she turns around. She forgets any embarrassment as she looks around, worried. "Wait a minute ..." She turns on her own axis until she looks back at Catra. She too now understands the problem. "Where's the second salamander?"

Chapter 11

Adora:

"He ... he's gone." whispers the blonde, stunned. Catra's expression becomes serious and she turns her gaze to her own salamander. He's still sitting next to the rock face. However, he seems more restless than yesterday, presumably because his partner is no longer there. When the Magicat's gaze slides back to Adora, she crosses her arms. "You didn't tie him up, did you?"

"I" starts Adora and looks embarrassed at the salamander that is still there. "I seem to have forgotten that somehow ... But look at him! Who wants to be tied down ?!" Catra covers her face with one hand. "This is to prevent the animals from running away or getting eaten at night!" The accusation in Catra's voice leads Adora to cross her arms as well.

"Swift Wind does fine without a leash and he never runs away!" "This isn't your neighing rainbow pet, it's a Wind Salamander! These animals should take us to the border, but they can only do that if you take care of them!"

The two women just stare at each other for a few moments before Adora finally sighs in frustration and turns away. "I'm sorry, okay ?! I don't know the Crimson Waste. This is all new for me! I have no idea how to behave or survive. I need you for that!" Again there is silence. Adora doesn't want to turn to the Magicat yet. She is still struggling with her frustration.

Angrily, she kicks a small stone through the sand. Now she's already preventing herself from saving her friends faster! It's a disaster with her! She has to get her sword back as soon as possible so that she can be She Ra again. She Ra doesn't make the same mistakes as Adora. She Ra can save the world and her friends. But for that Adora has to hold out and pull herself together. She must not fail anymore! She has to stop being so reckless!

Behind her, Adora hears a sigh. Catra's voice pulls her out of her thoughts. "What the heck... We still have my salamander. It can carry us both." The blonde turns around with renewed hope. "Can he do it?" Catra nods and studies Adora´s face as if she can read her mind. "Yes, but he won't be that fast. We'll probably need half a day." Feelings of guilt want to arise, but Adora quickly suppresses them and concentrates on Catra, who is already hanging on her bag, running through her hair once and then goes to the salamander that remains.

While Adora puts on a bag and realigns her ponytail, the Magicat unties the salamander and swings elegantly on its back. Waiting, she looks at Adora when she doesn't move. "Are you coming now?" The blonde is seized with uncertainty as she approaches the fast animal. "Where should I sit?" For a moment, Catra lifts an eyebrow before she smiles. "I definitely won't let you steer. So sit behind me."

That's actually not what Adora meant. But she suppresses her insecurity and begins to pull herself up on the animal's back. After kicking her legs awkwardly for a few seconds, Catra grins broadly and puts up a hand to help her up. Adora gratefully grabs it and lets herself be pulled up. "Sitting up is really not difficult." comments the Magicat, but without mockery in the voice.

Adora stares at the back of the Magicat a few centimeters in front of her. "And ... where should I hold on? It's not like salamanders have a mane that you can grasp." She sees Catra's long hair boil when the Magicat shakes her head. "You're especially stupid today." she recognizes without turning to Adora.
"Wrap your arms around me. But hurry up a bit, otherwise we will need the whole day to the frontier."

Adora is embarrassed when she stares at Catra's back again. Then she follows the instruction and reaches out her arms to tentatively wrap them around the Magicat's waist. This automatically causes her to lean closer to the body in front of her. Immediately she perceives the warmth that emanates from the Magicat. In

addition, the blonde now also perceives the well-known smell that always surrounds Catra. It makes her feel at home.

Her cheeks turn red as Adora tries desperately to keep her hands calm and not think about the abdominal muscles that she can feel under the bodysuit. Have they always been there? Adora is so preoccupied with her perceptions that she does not notice Catra signaling the salamander to set off. But the Magicat also seems unusually quiet. Maybe she's also hanging in her mind.

During the whole ride, Adora can´t get these confusing thoughts out of her head. It's stupid that she's acting so insecure. She has known the Magicat all her life, why is it so strange for her to touch her now? Why does it suddenly feel so different?
So ... intimate.
At the same time, Adora has to resist the temptation to lean her head on Catra's back. The ride on the salamanders is more exhausting than you think, and all the time suppressing the feelings that arise because she clings to the companion is also exhausting.

However, she does not want to offend the Magicat. In the past, Catra didn't like being touched by others, except for Adora. Back then the two were inseparable, the half of the other. But then they became enemies. Strangers, who are even closer than anyone else could be. And now? Now they don't seem to be enemies or friends. Adora has no idea how to describe the current relationship between her and the Magicat. She doesn't even know what she WANTS her relationship with the Magicat to be.

On the one hand, she feels comfortable with Catra and wishes to simply pick up where they left off years ago. On the other hand, she can't just forget what happened between them. How many people Catra hurt. And Catra doesn't seem to be able to forget it either. Or to want. With an oppressive feeling in her stomach area, Adora turns her gaze from the horizon, which she constantly keeps an eye on, and looks at the back of the Magicat's head.

She remembers the condition she has to meet when this is all over. Catra's wish never to see her childhood friend again. To banish her from her live. It hurts every time she thinks about it. Despite everything that drove the two apart, Adora thought that she still meant something to the Magicat.
But apparently she's wrong.
And this fact hurts more than any wound Adora has ever suffered.

"We are nearly there." mumbles Catra, who hasn't said a word for hours. Blinking, Adora’s dark cloud of thoughts dissolves and her gaze falls again to the horizon. There she discovers a chain of trees, the edge of a forest. That is where the frontier must be. "At last!" shouts Adora, relieved. Looking at something familiar gives her confidence. "From there it's about four days to Bright Moon." If all goes well, they can do it even faster.

In fact, it only takes a few minutes for them to reach the limit and the salamander to stop. Adora lets go of Catra and immediately begins to miss her body heat. This thought doesn't make any sense. They stand on the border of a desert, so it is warm enough. To distract herself, she focuses on sliding off the mount. Catra imitates her, but much more skillfully. Without looking at Adora, she turns to the salamander and takes the dishes from him. Then she gently slaps him on the back. "Come on, find your girlfriend!" Fascinated, Adora watches as the salamander hisses away. "Will he be fine on his own?"
"He's a creature of the Crimson Waste. Of course he will."

The Magicat's expression is very reserved as she turns away from the desert and looks at the edge of the forest. Adora steps up to her side with a frown. "Is everything ok?" Catra crosses her arms without looking away. She swallows before mumbling: "Everything is fine." Before Adora can ask any further questions, the Magicat starts moving. The blonde woman hurries to keep up with her. At the same time she keeps giving her scrutinizing looks from the side.

Somehow, Catra suddenly behaves differently. More tense. not quite so self-confident anymore. Could it be because they have

left the Crimson Waste? Perhaps the thought of an unfamiliar area makes her as insecure as Adora, and while the blonde regains her self-confidence by leaving the Crimson Waste, Catra leaves her comfort zone. When she looks at Catra from the side, Adora suddenly feels the need to give comfort to the Magicat. That's why she gives her a smile. "Hey, everything will be fine."

Her companion turns her head a little to look at Adora. Her eyes are tense. And although she probably doesn't want to show it, Adora sees the uncertainty in her eyes. The blonde hesitates for a moment before haltingly reaching for the Magicat's hand and enclosing it. Catra averts her gaze and Adora fears that she has gone too far. But the Magicat makes no move to break away from Adora’s hand. So they walk silently into the forest, hand in hand.

Catra:

The forest they cross is not familiar to Catra. She may have already seen it on maps, but she cannot consciously remember it. Not knowing where she is going or what to expect gives her an unsettling feeling of loss of control. She can't control what happens. From now on she has to rely on Adora and that... scares her. Ironically, the person who abused her trust, who threw her away, is now the person she has to trust.

As they walk past tall trees, Catra throws a sidelong glance at Adora. The blonde has frowned and is looking forward with concentration. A few years ago Catra would not have thought about such things. She trusted Adora blindly, they endured so much. Adora was the only person the Magicat ever trusted unconditionally.
Until she left her.
The reason that kept Catra up in her shitty life, ran away to get a better life for herself.
A life as a celebrated heroine. A life in Bright Moon with new, "good" friends.

These thoughts have always aroused incredible anger in Catra. But now? Now she just feels empty. Something has changed since

she met Adora again. The last few days that she spent with Adora have changed something. Now she just feels exhausted. Tired of constantly being angry with Adora, who took the chance to escape the Horde. Because she is stubborn and always has to do the right thing. Because that is just how Adora is. Because that's the only way she can be … happy.

Catra is taken aback by this thought. When she again observes Adora´s concentrated expression, she struggles with herself before she opens her mouth. "Hey Adora?" The blonde woman seems surprised that the Magicat is starting a conversation. She turns her head to her questioningly. "Yes?" Catra looks at the beautiful blue-gray eyes for a moment before continuing: "How is it Bright Moon?" The young woman next to her breathes in loudly, apparently not expecting this question. "You have already been there, you know how it is there." The Magicat can no longer withstand the blonde's gaze, so instead she looks at the path ahead. "'I know what it looks like there, yes. But what is it like to live there? Are you ... Are you happy?"

Adora ponders the question for a moment. "Well ... I think so. I feel good there. It's very ... different from what we're used to from the Horde. People don't judge you by how useful you are. Most of them don't. There are no training plans telling you how to live your life. And if you fall, your friends will help you up again. People live peacefully under Queen Angella's rule. They follow her not out of fear, but out of respect that she earned. She's wise and patient. At least when Glimmer doesn't goad her! " Adora giggles.

"I like living there because I know that my friends support me no matter what. And when I make mistakes, they help me fix them." Catra knew that she would only hurt herself if she asked Adora this question. And yet she is surprised at how much her chest hurts when she hears how well Adora is doing there. Without Catra. The Magicat is silent in order not to show any emotion. But Adora notices that something is wrong with her companion. She does not speak to her directly about it, but continues to speak. This time there is a certain sadness in her voice as she says softly: "You would like it there."

Her words surprise Catra. With a raised eyebrow she spotted: "Why, do I look like a happy pillow princess to you?" Adora smiles, but her gaze remains serious and insistent. "No. Because the people there are free." Free. A word that has meant so much to Catra all her life. But does she even know what it means? Freedom? She always believed that it was all she needed to be happy. To be free and to be with Adora.

Then their ways parted and she clung to what she could still achieve: control over her life. And self-determination. In the Crimson Waste, she can do whatever she wants and she has control over herself and others. That was what drove her.
But now, when she thinks about her actions, she wonders if those things actually meant freedom. Or whether they would put her in chains that she had made especially for her.

The Magicat is just about to respond when her eyes see something flash through the thicket in front of them. "What's this?" she wants to know and goes faster. Adora walks close behind her because her hands are still clasped. Startled, Catra loosens her hand from Adora's and runs a little faster to hide how embarrassed she is about the situation.

But Adora hardly seems to notice, because in the next moment they have crossed the thicket and are standing in a clearing. Catra's tail begins to twitch restlessly as she stares at the stone building that has been worked into a rock wall. At the foot of the building there is a round entrance, the doors of which are locked. "That" mumbles Adora reverently and takes a few steps forward, "must be a She Ra ruin."

Chapter 12

Adora:

"A She Ra ruin?" Catra asks behind Adora, while the blonde steps closer to the entrance. The doors are made of solid stone. Surely they haven't been moved for centuries. Fascinated, the blonde woman runs her fingers over the edge of one of the door leaves. Even if she no longer has the sword, it is still as if she can perceive the energy around her. Behind her she hears Catra taking a few steps closer, albeit much more hesitantly. "What makes you think that?" she wants to know.

Adora points to the inscription, which was carved into the walls and which has already looked a bit weathered for a long time. "This is the font of the first ones." "You mean those runes that no one can read?" "I can read it." explains the blonde and follows the signs. "It says ´Exteria´." As soon as the words leave her mouth, the signs suddenly light up and the heavy doors start moving and opening. When they are open, they reveal a dark corridor. "Wow. That's not scary or untrustworthy at all." Catra comments sarcastically, but Adora thinks she can hear genuine discomfort in Catra's voice.

Adora, on the other hand, has an idea. "It looks like a kind of tunnel system. The first ones may have used it as an abbreviation to be able to cross Etheria faster! This saves time and we can get to Bright Moon faster!" Adora is filled with enthusiasm when she turns to the Magicat, who is still staring skeptically at the entrance. "I don't know. That sounds very theoretical. How do you know where we have to go? The last time we went into one of these ruins, a couple of giant robot spiders wanted to eat us."

For a moment, Catra's words dim her confidence because her concerns are not unfounded. But then the blonde shrugs her shoulders resolutely. "We have to try. Maybe the place has a technical map because I'm She Ra ... I mean 'was'. We must leave no stone unturned."

She reaches out a hand to the Magicat and looks at her intently. "Please, Catra. Let's at least try."

After a moment the Magicat groans and rolls her eyes in exasperation. "Urgh, fine. But only so that I can tell you in the end that I was right." In the next moment Adora feels warm fingers that lie in the palm of her hand. The touch makes Adora feel better immediately. With fresh courage she turns back to the entrance. "Let's go!" Together they enter the dark corridor. As soon as they step through the gates, they close with a squeak, leaving the Magicat and Adora in complete darkness.

"Great." murmurs Catra. Adora gets a little insecure. "There must be some kind of light mechanism here ..." She tries to look around, but no chance. Her eyes are not made for this darkness. She becomes concerned as she realizes again why she normally wants to avoid the dark. After clearing her throat she quickly asks, "Catra? Can you look around for a keypad? Or a torch? Anything that causes light? Your eyes are better than mine." She hears Catra muttering worried: "I can hardly see anything here either."

Adora raises her eyebrows in surprise and looks to the side, without spotting the Magicat. Not even her eyes, which normally glow in the dark.
If even Catra's vision is clouded here, the darkness cannot be natural. It may be artificially created to keep intruders out. She feels a slight tug on her wrist as the Magicat moves and pulls Adora with her over her connected hands. "I think there's something over here. Argh, I can barely see it."
Well, Adora can't see anything at all, so she listens to Catra's descriptions.

"It's one of those signs on the wall again. I think it's framed. But I can't read it." "Can you describe it?" Catra describes the shapes, outlines and lines that she recognizes on the wall as best she can. It takes a while, but finally an idea of the rune forms in Adora´s head. "Hm, that could be a password. It sounds like ´Solerio´"
A buzz goes through the corridor. Terrified, the women flinch and go into attack position, when it suddenly becomes light.

Lanterns on the walls give off a bluish light that illuminates the corridor. The walls shimmer in similar colors to the other ruins that Adora has entered so far. And yet this one feels different. She just can't tell whether it's positive or negative. Catra next to her sighs. "Well, that doesn't look very trustworthy to me, but it's not like we have a choice." Together they start moving and walk deeper into the corridor. For quite a while there is nothing but the path in front of them and the blue lights that they pass.

The monotonous environment causes Adora to lose her sense of time, so that she cannot say whether a few minutes or several hours have passed before they finally pass the first fork in the road. The corridor splits into three possible branches. Catra groans bugged. "Great, now this crap is turning into a maze too!" Annoyed, she crosses her arms and looks at Adora. "Any ideas, ´She Ra´?" "I'm not sure", Adora explains, embarrassed, and looks at the narrow corridors.

"Actually, I expected that there would be some kind of Light Hope system here that could point us in the right direction. Maybe there was a system before, and it was destroyed sometime in the last thousand years ..." "Can't you use your She Ra magic to move us forward? With a magic compass or something?" Immediately a knot forms in Adora´s stomach and she looks at the ground. "I can't do anything without the sword ..."

Her voice is weak. It infuriates her that she feels so helpless without the magic sword.
Without She Ra, Adora is just ... Adora. She is not enough.
Catra seems to realize that she has hit a sore spot. Her face is locked when she loosens her crossed arms and punches Adora in the side. Surprised, the blonde stumbles a step forward, and Catra decides: "Then we'll do it the old way."

"And that would be?" "Your gut feeling." Now Adora is the skeptical one who crosses her arms. "I would prefer a sophisticated strategy." "Well, unfortunately we don't have the time for that. Come on, Adora: Concentrate and look at the corridors. Which one do we take?" Encouraged by Catra's

determination, Adora stares again at the turn-offs until she hesitantly points to the left. She cannot say whether her gut instinct is trying to tell her something, or whether she just wishes it was so. "That one." The Magicat nods and walks purposefully towards it.
"Then we'll take that one."

Together they go the new way. This corridor isn't quite as bright anymore, but apart from a little nervousness, Adora isn't afraid. Catra's expression is relaxed, but her gaze remains alert. She doesn't trust this place. Of course not, after all, she hasn't had any good memories with She Ra yet. The blonde is just thinking about what she can do to make the Magicat more secure as Catra suddenly stops.

"Everything okay?" asks Adora. Catra tests her nose in the air. "Something is wrong here. It's been so quiet here all along." "Because it is an abandoned ruin." "But it's almost TOO quiet. I can't even hear insects or any mechanism noises, and that's what you should expect here." Adora takes a step to the side and leans her back against the wall. "The technology here is over a thousand years old, it's definitely already -" she begins when the wall suddenly gives way under her weight and presses a button.

Thereupon an eerie tremor goes through the corridor. Catra's tail stands up as the earth begins to tremble. "What's happening?!" she screams in horror. Adora wants to run to her to support her when suddenly roots shoot out of the wall next to her and wrap themselves around the blonde's body at lightning speed. Within a second she is tied to the wall.

"Ah!" she exclaims, both frightened and angry because this attack comes as a surprise. "Adora!" Catra screams worried and leaps towards her to help her. Then the ground tears up and reveals an endless depth. Catra is so focused on Adora that she cannot save herself in time. Desperate, she jumps to the side, but does not make it to a safe base. Instead she falls into the abyss.
"CATRA!" Adora screams in panic and holds out a hand that she can free from the branches around her.

At the last moment, the Magicat intercepts her fall by clinging to the side of the abyss. However, she can hardly find a hold, the surface is smooth and her nails are still too short. That's why she dangles dangerously loosely over the black nothingness, her whole body tightly pressed against the wall.
Panic rises in Adora. She feels how the roots wrap themselves more and more tightly around her body, but all her thoughts revolve around Catra. She has to help her, and quickly, or she wouldn't last much longer.

"Adora!" Catra calls again, this time she can't suppress the panic in her voice. "Hold on!" replies the blonde and writhes under the roots. They don't seem to be made out of normal plants. It feels more mechanical. More robust. As much as Adora squirms and struggles against it, she cannot escape the grip of the roots.
"Come on ..." the blonde murmurs between clenched teeth and presses. The roots seem to bend, but their strength doesn't give in for a second.
She Ra could sure tear those roots apart, but Adora couldn't. She is too weak.

"Do something!" the Magicat begs. "I'm trying, but it just doesn't work!" Adora wails desperately. "I don't have the sword, I can't transform!"
"Forget that stupid sword! You are She Ra! Do something, but do it quickly!" "But-"
Filled with fear, Adora watches as Catra reaches out a hand to reach up and instead slides down a bit. "ADORA!" Catra screams in panic and now looks directly at her handcuffed companion.

At that moment Adora can see the sheer fear in her eyes. Suddenly she is the little Magicat from the past and her best friend again, whom she trusted, who she loved and protected. Who has been the most important person in her life for eighteen years. And who is now in mortal danger and needs Adora´s help.

Suddenly Adora feels something rise within her. Something powerful. She stops fidgeting and instead becomes calm and closes her eyes in concentration. This something in her becomes

stronger, it wanders from her center through her veins into her limbs and fills her with power.
She takes a deep breath, loses all her doubts, pushes all her thoughts aside except for Catra and opens her eyes.
Then she pushes.

The roots burst, one after the other, and after a few moments Adora has twisted herself with the last grip and sprints to the place where Catra hangs over the abyss. Quickly, she throws herself on the floor and extends one arm down over the edge but cannot reach Catra. The Magicat stretches out an arm, but the distance is still too great. "You have to jump!" shouts Adora, whereupon Catra looks at her with wide eyes. "Are you crazy?!" Still feeling this superhuman calm and security within herself, she looks at the Magicat and promises:
"I won't let you down."

Catra returned her gaze hesitantly. The blonde knows how much she is asking of Catra. It's not just about her life, or that she might fall into the abyss. It's about trust. A trust that has been destroyed before. For a moment, Catra looks Adora in the eye, and whatever she finds there convinces her to jump. With all her strength she leaps upwards, and before she can plunge into the depths, Adora grabs her wrist and holds her tight. Then she pulls them up, still posessed by that immense strength.

As soon as she has pulled Catra up and brought her to safety next to her, this strange feeling suddenly leaves her. As unexpectedly as it has spread within her, it also withdraws again. But right now she can't concentrate on that anyway. All she can think of is Catra next to her, breathing as hard as she is. "Are you okay?" The Magicat does not answer immediately. She gasps and takes a few deep breaths. She stares at Adora in disbelief before finally nodding.

The worrying knot in Adora’s stomach loosens with relief, but she fears that they have not survived everything yet. The earthquake has not stopped yet, and now some rocks are loosening from the ceiling and falling to the floor due to the constant tremor. The

blonde quickly grabs Catra's hand and pulls her to her feet. "Come on, we're not safe yet."

She doesn't even wait for an answer. Instead, she starts running. Catra follows her. Both cling to each other's hand as if their lives depended on it.
Well, it kind of does.
Together they run through the corridor and Adora silently prays that it is not far to an exit. And that they don't set any more traps. Boulders fall to the ground next to them, missing the women by a hair's breadth.

They keep running. Hold on, thinks Adora. It is not far. Just keep running. Then - finally - they reach the end of the corridor, which is closed by a large, heavy door. Adora recognizes some First One ´s writing on it, but cannot read it. There is barely enough light for her eyes here. "I can't see the sign!" Adora exclaims, trying to suppress her panic, and looks at the Magicat. "Catra, what does it say?" She cannot see her companion exactly, but believes that she is leaning closer to the door, concentrating.

They hear a rumble behind them. Worried, Adora turns around and instantly her blood freezes in her veins. The tremor of the ruin has become stronger, and now not only are individual chunks falling from the sky, but the entire ceiling seems to be transformed into a hail of rocks.
"Catra!"
"One second!" she hisses back, just as stressed as Adora, and squints even further. "It's the same sign as on the entrance doors!"

Adora understands and immediately throws herself against the door with all her weight while she shouts: "Exteria!" Only when she has said the word does the door make way. Catra helps her brace against the door and make the opening large enough for them to slip through. Behind it they see a bright light, but they have no time to think about whaat might expect them, because at that moment a particularly large boulder loosens directly above them and threatens to bury them under itself.

Adora instinctively pushes Catra out of the danger zone through the opening and out into the open. She hears a surprised hiss, but is already busy diving through the opening herself and leaps out into the open. She lands rudely face down on the floor. Just in time, it seems, because at this moment there is a tremendous noise from the ruin, then a clatter and dull noises of collapse. It seems the corridor has collapsed behind them.

Then suddenly it is quiet again.
Adora has become so used to the constant rumbling and humming of the earth that she needs a moment to orientate herself. Also because the sudden brightness is not good for her eyes and she cannot see anything around her for a few moments. But finally she blinks a few times and realizes that she is lying in a small clearing.

The entrance behind her looks more like a cave entrance than the ruin they entered. So they must have actually come a little further inland. She is overcome with relief at this realization. She's not sure if this was actually a shortcut, but at least it doesn't seem to have stopped her. Quickly, she gets up and looks at Catra, who is kneeling next to her on the grass and looks disturbed at the buried entrance.

"Hey" Adora gently puts a hand on the Magicat's shoulder. "Are you really okay?" The Magicat shudders, but nods. "Yes, i´m fine." Then she looks up at the blonde and tilts her head while she wraps her arms around herself. "I'm really fed up with hanging over abysses." Now Adora has to grin and helps the Magicat on its feet.
"We´ll try to avoid all abysses from now on."

The corner of Catra's mouth twitches too, but then the expression on her face changes and becomes serious. "Adora, what was that?" The blonde shrugs her shoulders. "I guess the tunnels saw us as intruders and wanted to get rid of us. And I think I set this trap off when I leaned against the wall -"
The Magicat shakes her head. "No, I mean what was going on with you in there?" Confused, Adora looks at Catra. "What do you

mean?" "You pulled out those metal roots as if they were grass. And ..." Catra swallows. She seems insecure as she continues. "Your eyes lit up."

Adora takes a step back in surprise. "What?" "Not for long, but I saw it clearly. It was a blue glow, almost exactly like ..." She doesn't have to finish the sentence, because Adora understands. ´Almost like when she is She Ra´.
Confused, Adora thinks about the feeling she had when she was trapped. All she could think about was saving Catra. And then suddenly there was this powerful feeling. All at once she felt so strong, so confident. Just like when she is She Ra.

Could it be? Was that She Ra? But there was no transformation. She can't do that without the sword.
She stayed Adora.
And yet she has done things for which she needs the strength of She Ra.

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

WARNING:
this chapter contains a panic attack

Catra:

Neither of them mentions the strange incident again as they move on. Catra not, because she has no idea about She Ra magic and doesn't want to admit being interested in it. And Adora not, because she probably doesn't want to think about it. Because in her typical way she regards it as a problem whose solution she does not know or does not want to know and therefore suppresses it. At least that's what the Magicat suspects.

When evening falls, Adora and Catra are in a forest. Since there is no cave or other shelter in sight, the women decide to climb one of the tall trees and spend the night there.
Catra arrives at the top a lot faster and crouches leisurely on one of the thick branches while she watches Adora follow her. The blonde sits on the branch closest to Catra and leans her back against the thick trunk. "You took your time, huh? I almost fell asleep!" Catra smirks. Adora answers by sticking out her tongue.

Climbing is one of the few things that Catra is the better of the two at. She has to smile when she thinks about how they used to climb to the top of the mountains of junk in the Frightzone. From there, the world has always felt so small. And Adora was always with her. Up there they laughed together, complained about the hard training, and dreamed of how one day they would rule Etheria together.

Usually she shuts herself off from these memories. They only bring pain and suffering. But something is different tonight. Right now it's very easy to let it happen. To not fight back. While Catra is thinking about her memories, she hears Adora sigh. As she

turns to face her, she sees the blonde lean her head back and stare at the night sky. "Do you remember how we used to want to sleep in the open air?" she asks. Adora doesn't see it, but the Magicat nods.

"Shadow Weaver forbid it." Catra remembers bitterly. And before she knows it, she slips out: "And she has forbidden me to ever talk about it again or to get such an idea that could put you in danger. My stupidity should not lead to your disadvantage."
"Catra ..."
She doesn't see Adora´s face, but can hear the guilt in her voice. But she can't really concentrate on it. Someone seems to be wrapping a rope around the heart of the Magicat and is now trying to strangle it. At least that's what it feels like.

Catra has always gotten the bigger trouble. Even if it wasn't her fault. She always had to hold out for the consequences.
A well-known wave of anger wells up inside her,

but then she remembers something else.

"You ..." she begins to stammer softly to concentrate better. "You ... cried that night. After Shadow Weaver sent me away, I found you in the bedroom while you were wrapping yourself in your blanket. Your eyes were all red. You hid from the others because you didn't want anyone to see you like that. I ... sat down next to you and asked you what's going on. You told me the reason why you so much want to sleep in the open air. "

Catra takes a deep breath so as not to let her voice shake, then she continues.
"Because you heard rumors of lights in the sky.
´Stars´, as you called them.
You sobbed and said how much you wanted to see stars. Only once. Because you heard they scare away the darkness of the night.
But Shadow Weaver ... "

She falters because the fight inside her is getting too big.
For so long she has suppressed this memory. It is difficult to consciously allow it now. To no longer defend herself against it.
Gradually her memory becomes clearer and she can now see little Adora's tear-streaked face in front of her, telling her sniffling what happened.
Something is tightening in her heart. She swallows quickly and concentrates on continuing to tell.

"Shadow Weaver told you that your behavior is childish. That there are no stars. That...that you should forget this ridiculous wish because it ... is meaningless. And that you need to focus on your career instead, if you want to achieve something and not let anyone down."
Catra stares dazedly at her hands. They are trembling. It is as if something breaks inside of her and is put back together at the same time. Overwhelmed, she clenches her trembling hands into fists and tries to swallow the lump in her throat.

She remembers again.

That Adora was so sad broke the Magicat's heart back then.
She hated Shadow Weaver for it.
And she hated herself.
Because a tiny part of her had been glad for a moment that she wasn't the only one who had been hurt.
That feeling didn't last long, only fleetingly, but it was there. And now?

Now Catra seems to be overwhelmed by her emotions. Her eyes are wet, and yet she dares to look to the side. She is surprised to find that Adora also has tears in her eyes, but she doesn't look at the Magicat.
With a trembling voice she says: "I thought if I could see these stars, then ... then I no longer have to be afraid. Of the dark. Then ... then I would no longer be weak."

The lump in Catra's throat is getting thicker and thicker. It is as if Adora had torn down all the walls that Catra had ever built around

her heart with this one sentence.
Before she can stop herself, she whispers: "You have never been weak, Adora."
A tear rolls down her cheek, and she hopes Adora can't see it in the dark.

Surprised, the blonde turns her head to Catra. Her cheeks are also wet with tears. Then she smiles and holds out a hand. "That day you freely hugged me for the first and last time." Adora remembers, and the warmth in her eyes gives Catra goose bumps.
It's true, she only hugged Adora once because the gesture is so intimate for her. She never had a problem with Adora touching her or vice versa, but hugs ... Hugs meant comfort and security, and that was something that she had hardly had in her life. Except for Adora.

Tingling warmth spreads in Catra's heavy heart. None of her self-protecting barriers work anymore, so she takes Adora´s outstretched hand and crosses her fingers together. It feels good. Right. Damn, what is wrong with her?

They sit there for a while and are silent. It's a pleasant silence. Except for the forest noises, which the Magicat can hear loud and clear, but it doesn't bother her tonight. The thoughts inside her do not whirl around like a storm, but flow slowly like a river.
She's not the only one suffering from Shadow Weaver. Perhaps Adora was not abused to the same extent physically, but still mentally.

She's pushed that fact for far too long, and now it feels like a little revelation. As if someone had pulled a scarf from her eyes that had previously consisted of anger, hatred and selfishness and blurred her vision. Her realization takes away a large part of the anger towards Adora that has been her daily drive for so long. It doesn't relieve the pain caused by Adora's betrayal, but it does make Catra better understand why Adora left.

The Magicat hears how her companion's breath becomes steadily calmer, until she finally perceives a slight snore. With a smile, Catra slides back and forth on her branch until she too has found a comfortable sleeping position. When she falls asleep, her fingers are still entwined with Adora's.

The next morning, the women climb down from the tree before sunrise to continue their journey. The forest they are crossing is small and so they pass it quickly. In the next few hours they wander through wide, colorful fields.
Adora claims to know which way to go, and while Catra isn't particularly happy that they aren't using a map, she believes Adora. As they walk, they hardly speak a word to each other. The blonde does not address the previous evening, and the Magicat is very grateful for it. She doesn't know what to think about it. How to feel.

The situation with Adora was confusing from the start, but it seems to get more and more confusing over time. The resentment and hatred that Catra had for Adora seem to be fading into the background, and the Magicat is not sure how to think about it. On the one hand, it feels relieving. As if her negative feelings were always just a burden that she is now ready to shed bit by bit.

On the other hand, those feelings were all she had left. She relied on her anger and resentment, they were an anchor in Catra's life. A constant that gave her security.
It scares her that she can't rely on it anymore.
It scares her that, at the end of this journey, there might be nothing left for her.

"Hey Catra", begins Adora suddenly. Inquiringly, the Magicat turns her head to her companion. "I was just wondering if -" She interrupts herself and stops. With wide eyes she points past Catra and yells "Is that a mouse ?!" "WHAT ?!" Catra's fur stands up immediately and she winces while looking around frantically.

"Where ?!" But she cannot discover anything. Instead, she hears a bright laugh next to her.

The Magicat grimaces and straightens up again, while the tension eases from her limbs. “Seriously, Adora? After all this time?” Adora laughs heartily and lifts her stomach, and Catra can't help but notice how beautiful her laugh sounds. She hasn't heard it in a long time ...
"I'm sorry," the blonde gasps half-heartedly and continues giggling. "I just had to know if you were still falling for it." Her tail twitches back and forth in dissatisfaction while Catra crosses her arms. "Are you done laughing?" A few small tones escape her mouth, then Adora has caught herself again and she sits up too, still with a grin on her face. "Yes, now I'm done."
"Well, then I can finish you off now."

Faster than Adora can blink, the Magicat has pounced on her and thrown to the ground. It happens so quickly that the blonde cannot defend herself against the grip and Catra finally holds her to the ground, her body above Adora's. The blonde is now the one who looks surprised and confused. "Catra, what are you doing?" Their faces are only inches apart when Catra explains with a triumphant grin, "I just wanted to know if you're still as easy to pin as you used to be."

To confirm it, she flicks her tail once and brushes Adora´s legs in the process. For a moment, her desire to be rogue fades and instead she stares as if caught at the face in front of her. She feels Adora´s warm breath on her skin, they are so close. All she had to do was bow her head slightly and they would ...

Suddenly Adora braces herself against Catra's grip and before the Magicat can react, the tide has turned and she is lying in the grass, Adora above her. The blonde grins triumphantly as she presses the Magicat's arms to the ground. "And what do you say now?" Adora wants to know playfully, a challenging twinkle in her eyes. This spark has always spurred the Magicat on. Adora is strong. As for physical strength, she is definitely superior to the Magicat. Still, Catra smiles. "Not bad. But you forgot one thing."

Adora frowns without releasing the pressure on Catra.
"And that would be?"
In response, Catra lifts her tail and uses it to tickle Adora under one of her arms. She winces in surprise. The Magicat has been waiting for this moment and pushes herself up with all her weight. In a flash she grabs Adora´s shoulders and whirls her around until she is finally pushed into the grass again. Adora gasps and struggles, but Catra holds her tightly. As she moves her face closer to that of the blonde, she stops fighting and stares into the two-tone eyes of the Magicat. Catra triumphantly holds her mouth to the prisoner's ear and whispers:
"I know your weak points, Adora."

Her voice has suddenly taken on a dark tone and she even purrs the last word. When she pulls back a few inches to look into Adora´s face again, she pauses. The blonde stares at her with red cheeks and her whole body slacks as her heart starts to beat much faster.
Catra tilts her head slightly to one side and continues to watch her. The purring of the Magicat has always had this speciific effect on Adora. Catra can't say exactly what the blonde is feeling about it, but the Magicat always liked the reaction.

Suddenly Adora swallows hard and she asks: "Can ... can you let go of me now? Please? We have to move on." The Magicat pauses for a moment, snorting, before letting go of Adora and straightening up elegantly. The blonde, on the other hand, remains on the floor for a moment before she seems to wake up from a rigidity and also straighten up.

"You started." Catra comments with a shrug and walks away so that Adora doesn't spot the blush on her cheeks. Only now does she realize how close she has come to Adora. They practically lay on top of each other. The Magicat shakes. They used to do that all the time when they fought. There is no difference now. Right?

The women hike on for a few hours and tease each other, careful not to have body contact again, until they finally reach a village. Or better: the remains of a village. Both women stop when they see the village. Catra is overwhelmed by the shock that grips her. She sees collapsed houses, broken streets, and smashed objects lying around everywhere.

Not a single building is left standing. Some parts look burned down or exploded. It's a mess. A silent mess. Not a sound can be heard from the rubble. Not even the wind whistles. The landscape is deserted.
It feels ... dead.
Wrong.

Catra looks at Adora, who is also looking at the village in front of them. However, her face looks more sad than shocked. This is not the first time the blonde has seen this rubble.
What happened here? the Magicat wants to ask, but when she turns her head again to the destruction, she discovers her answer: Between all the broken pieces, Catra can see some remains of robots.
Robots of the Horde.

"This village was called Zeras." Adora explains quietly next to her. "Bow and Glimmer took me here about a year ago. It was a cheerful place." The blonde smiles sadly. "Full of life. The children played in the streets, the adults worked in the fields and in the evening they gave She Ra a little party. It wasn't grand or splendid, but people laughed and sang and danced. We were only one day there, but it felt so peaceful." The Magicat does not escape how Adora tenses and her hands clench into fists.

"A few months ago, Hordak wanted to besiege the city of Malidas. It is not far from Bright Moon. On the way there, the troops passed this village ... and destroyed it." Catra instinctively wants to fold her ears and run away.
She doesn't want to hear it.
It does something to her that she cannot control. Which she fears. But she remains rooted to the spot, her gaze not turned from the

rubble. "A scout informed Glimmer, Bow and me in good time and in the end we were able to defend Malidas."
Adora swallows.
"But we only found out about Zeras when it was too late."

As if paralyzed, Catra takes a few steps towards the village, walks to the rubble and looks around again. The shock at this sight still has it´s grip on her.
Before that day, she didn't think for a moment about what would happen when she encountered the deeds of the Horde.
The Horde itself, yes, Hordak, yes, but not his actions. His motives. His violence.

Over the past year she has gained a certain distance from the Horde. She has built a new life for herself, got to know another side. Sure, the Crimson Waste is not a prime example of normality, but still the Magicat was able to get an idea of what is considered "normal" outside the Frightzone.
Not everyone there is a loner, Catra has learned.
She has seen families, mothers who care for their children, friends who stand by one another. Presumably, these social ties are much rarer in the desert than in other places, but they do exist.
Knowing that this village was full of such happy, innocent people makes her want to punch something.

The Magicat swallows as she imagines how she would feel if she had stayed with the Horde.
If SHE was the one who attacked this city. If she had watched this village gradually being dismantled.

She wouldn't have cared, Catra notes bitterly.

She would have been so selfishly focused on harming and defeating Adora that she wouldn't have cared what she had to do to get it.

And now? Now she feels a lot of things. Shock. Shame. Anger. Anger at the Horde, but most of all anger at herself.
She had been angry with Hordak for always ignoring her. For

never appreciating her work. For only focusing on himself and his goals and that he didn't care about anything else.

Now Catra has to find out that she is no better than him.

"Catra?" She's probably even worse. She used to not even CARE whether she was good or bad. The main thing for her was that it served her cause. She caused so many sacrifices. Hurt people. Destroyed homes. All to get back at Adora. To defeat her. To prove once that she doesn't need her.
"Catra?"
She thought she was showing strength. She believed she could prove herself one day. Instead, with these actions she has shown nothing more than that she is weak. That she always flees from her problems.
She is lousy. Useless. Worthless. Pathetic. Without control.
Panic builds up in her stomach as she realizes these things.

"Catra, answer me! What's wrong ?!"
The Magicat tries to look away from the remains, but cannot move. Only now does she notice that she has started to tremble. Her vision becomes blurred.
"Catra, snap out of it!"
She thinks she sees a blonde woman in front of her, believes she is being grabbed by the shoulders, but she cannot concentrate. Her thoughts go round in circles, do not let go of her.

The panic in her stomach intensifies and creeps up, reaches her lungs, squeezes them shut. Catra gasps, rattles, but does not get enough oxygen. She wants to say something, wants to cry for help, but the panic does not allow her. It has a firm grip on her. She no longer knows where she is, doesn't know where up and down is.
Fear grips her like a straitjacket when she hears voices yelling at her.

“I´ve come to expect such disgraceful behaviour from you.”

“This was a test. You failed.”

“You have never been anything more than a nuisance to me.”

“Adora didn´t ran away from the horde, she ran away from you.”

“Your former Force Captain has proven to be compromised, ineffective, and worthless.”

Nuisance. Disgraceful. Worthless. Failed.

She wants to scream, but she doesn't even have the strength to do that. I'm going to die, the Magicat thinks in panic, and this thought only increases the fear until she whimpers. Help, she cries in her thoughts, knowing there will be no one to save her.

Suddenly she feels something different. Warmth. No heat, but pleasant warmth that surrounds her and melt the chains of ice-cold panic. Then she perceives a voice. A real one, not one from her head. Warm and bright, it pervades her clouded senses. "Take it easy, Catra. Breathe. Everything is fine. I'm here. I won't leave you alone."
Slowly this warmth penetrates her skin and fills her inner being. It calms her lungs and relaxes her cramped limbs.

Little by little, her vision clears and she blinks a few times when she comes back to the here and now.
The Magicat finds that she is lying in the grass. The sun shines innocently on her face, as if Catra had not just been terrified to death. Her face feels wet, she was crying.
But what she is most aware of is the person kneeling right next to her and holding her.

Adora has wrapped her arms around Catra and presses her to her chest. "It's okay, Catra. You're safe. I'm here." she whispers softly but urgently. The back of the head is illuminated by the sun and colors the blonde hair in a beautiful gold. Blue-gray eyes are only inches away from her face and look at her in relief when Catra blinks and swallows. Timidly she whispers: "Hey ... Adora."

A relieved whimper escapes Adora as she puts a hand on the face of the Magicat. "Catra! Are you okay?" Catra clears her throat once to keep her voice steady and then replies, "I ... I think so." The blonde answers with a relieved sigh. So far, Catra has not dared to move, but now she carefully lifts one arm to support herself while straightening her upper body and thus freeing herself from Adora´s arms.

Immediately she feels the loss of heat and would like to fall back straight away. Adora’s embrace felt so secure. So safe. But she has to stay focused. What happened? Quickly, she goes through the events. She had a seizure. Right in front of Adora.
Worried, she looks at her companion. What would she think of the Magicat? Now that she's seen how weak she actually is? How she cann´t even control herself? Would she laugh? Find Catra's behavior repulsive or contemptuous?
But Catra sees nothing in the blonde's eyes but relief and worry.

"Are you really OK?" Catra nods, but doesn't dare look Adora in the eye, instead she bends her legs to straighten up. Adora immediately grabs the Magicat's arms and helps her to stand. Usually Catra doesn't like to be helped, but this time she is grateful for it. When both women stand again, Adora asks: "What was that? What happened to you?"

Catra wraps her arms around her waist uncomfortably. "Nothing. I ..." "Nothing?!" Adora shakes her head in disbelief. "Catra, that wasn't 'nothing'. You collapsed! You could hardly breathe! What was the matter?" The Magicat wants to open her mouth. Out of an instinct of self-protection, she wants to bark at Adora that it is none of her business. That she should not care.

But before she can do that, her ear suddenly twitches. "What's this?" Catra mumbles alarmed and turns around, but can't see anything. Adora groans annoyed. "This is not a good time for games, Catra! I was worried!" "I'm serious, I heard something!" the Magicat contradicts bold.

A moment later a deafening roar can be heard across the square, which makes Catra's fur stands on end and Adora's neck hairs stand up.

Chapter 14

Adora:

The roar rouses something in Adora. She immediately switches to warrior mode and looks around. Catra also kneels a little and extends her claws. Her fur is bristled as her ears twitch and she turns in a certain direction. Adora turns with her when suddenly trees crash to the side on the edge of the village square and a moment later a huge animal jumps out.

The blonde is trapped for a second by the sight of the being. It has six legs and a huge, oval body that is covered with gray fur. The animal's head is also oval and as long as a human's body. Blunt but strong teeth protrude from its mouth. Adora can see four bright red eyes without pupils, which angrily turn on the two women. Without warning, the animal aims at its victims and sprints towards them. It's amazingly fast for its size.

Adora would not have been able to tear herself out of her rigidity if Catra had not dragged her along roughly and thus both of them thrown off the path of the being. The animal storms across the square without being stopped by the rubble lying around and barely misses the women. Adora has now awakened from her rigidity and takes out her staff. As a habit, she reaches out her arm and shouts,
"For the Honor of Gray- oh, right."

She is frustrated because she is no longer She Ra. Then she shakes off her feelings. There are more important things now. Concentrated, she takes the staff in both hands and looks at the huge animal that is about to turn. However, before it can rush towards the women again, Adora is faster and is the first to run. With the stick she aims at the head of the animal and jumps, but the creature turns away in time, so that the woman lands on the ground without a hit.

In the next moment one leg moves towards the blonde, but just before it can crush her it pulls its foot back and stumbles a step backwards. Adora looks up and discovers that Catra has jumped on the animal's back and is scratching it´s fur with her claws. The cattle snorts furiously and shudders. The earth seems to shake and Adora struggles to stay on her feet. Catra can hold on to the being for a few moments, but is then thrown off and lands on earth with a dull noise. “Catra!” Adora shouts startled, and wants to run to her, but the animal stands in her way.

Angry, the creature opens its mouth and roars at Adora before it tries to run towards her. This time Adora is prepared and evades. She turns around in a flash and rams her staff into the side of the animal, but nothing happens. The blow did nothing, except maybe make the creature even angrier. Before it can react, Catra jumps at it again from the side and gives one of its front legs a powerful kick. The leg kinks, but the animal's stance remains stable thanks to the remaining five.

Adora decides to use the short distraction and draws the stick again, this time aiming at one of the eyes. But then the animal suddenly jerks its big head around in the direction of the blonde and pulls her with it. Adora is thrown backwards by the unexpected impact and lands roughly in the grass a few meters further. For a moment the blonde remains dazed on the floor. "Adora!" shouts a familiar voice.

Groaning, Adora sits up and blinks. Then she sees the huge being come running towards her. Adora frantically looks around for her staff, but cannot find it so quickly. Panicking, she looks at the massive body that has now almost reached her.
She won't be able to evade in time.
So this is how it would end for her.
When the animal reaches Adora, it lifts one of its paws to crush the blonde woman.

Suddenly something hits her and throws her to the side. She rolls once across the floor and quickly stands on her feet to look back at the place where she was lying a few seconds ago. Catra stands

there, who pushed her out of the danger zone, as the Blonde recognizes now.
"Adora, run away!" she calls to her.

The Magicat, on the other hand, is not fast enough and is grabbed by the animal's paw. "Catra!" Adora shouts in fear and runs towards her. Terrified, Catra hisses and defends herself against the grip, but the thing holds her tightly. With the Magicat in its clutches, the creature suddenly turns around and runs away into the adjacent forest.

"No! Catra!" Between some pieces of rubble, Adora finally discovers her staff. She quickly grabs it and hurries after the creature.
Where did it go? She mustn't lose his trace. It has Catra!
Adora runs hectically through the forest, past broken branches and bent bushes, always following the rustling noises and the roar.

Catra saved her. And now that's why the monster caught her. That thought seems to give her an even bigger boost of energy. If something happens to the magicat ... She doesn't want to think any further. Instead she runs even faster and when the noise of the creature gets louder, she knows that she has caught up with it.

Her pace slows and she stops behind a tree when she spots the animal. After a moment of fear, she also discovers Catra, who is still caught in the grip of the being and vigorously resists it. "Let go of me, you disgusting beast!" she squeals and scratches the paw that holds her. But the animal hardly reacts, just roars and opens its mouth to devour Catra with it. "No!" shouts Adora and leaves her hiding place.

At lightning speed she runs towards the creature until she is under its mouth and rams the rod up with all her strength to close the large jaw. Surprisingly, it works, and the unexpected force from below shakes the being. Adora takes advantage of this moment and strikes as hard as she can on the paw that is

clutching Catra. Then the grip loosens a little and Catra does not lose any time. She kicks as hard as she can and finally frees herself from the grip. With one leap she lands on the floor and gasps.

Adora is breathing heavily, partly because she is still out of breath from rurnning, and looks over at Catra. "Everything okay?"
"I'm fine, princess." replies the Magicat roughly without looking at her. Then she yells: "Watch out!" and sprint a few meters backwards. The animal kicks the two women with its legs, and Adora also has to move quickly to avoid being hit.

But the animal is clever. With one leap it jumps forward and catches Catra on her tail. She screams in surprise and wants to claw into the ground, but the animal has grabbed her again and pulls her to it. "No!" Adora shouts and draws the staff, but unexpectedly the animal lifts one of its legs and hurls Adora away. His claws catch her on the left hip and she cries out in pain as the landing of the fall presses all the air out of her lungs.

For a moment, her vision is black. Then she hears a panicking voice: "Adora!"
Blinking, she opens her eyes and sees how the creature opens its mouth again a few meters further to devour Catra. The Magicat struggles desperately, trying to escape her fate, but the creature does not intend to let her slip away a second time. "No!" Adora wants to shout, but there is only a croak in her voice.

She wants to pry up when a raging pain runs through her body. The fall and the claws of the creature have left their mark on Adora, but the blonde doesn't have time to worry about it now. With clenched teeth she gets up and takes her staff.
Ready to give all she has left, she screams: "HEY!"
The creature stops moving and looks almost disinterestedly at Adora. With shaky legs, she takes a step towards the creature and, trembling, raises her staff.
She is weakened.

She wouldn't hold on much longer. But she has to. She would fight to the last breath if she had to to save Catra. She looks resolutely into the creature's glowing red eyes when suddenly a wave of shock hits her.
She feels a strange power flaring up within her. Her vision blurs, instead images flicker past her eye.
Memories. Not her own, however, but those of the being before her.

Adora cannot move, she can only endure it. She sees memories of how the being has lived peacefully in this forest for years. Side by side with the people of Zeras.
Until one day the soldiers came with their red flags. They destroyed everything with their weapons.
The village, the forest, the life.

The blonde woman sees how the creature's eyes turn red as it sees the destruction in its entirety for the first time.
Then the shock wave is over. The power vanishes. The images disappear, their vision clears up again. She stares dazedly into the red eyes that are still fixed on her ...

...and suddenly Adora understands.

All at once she becomes very calm as she purposefully puts one foot in front of the other and looks at the creature. The being also seems to have noticed a change, it may also have felt the foreign power, because although it still looks angry, it does not seem to be sure whether it should attack.
"You are angry. And sad. I understand that." Adora begins calmly as she slowly approaches the animal. "It was people who destroyed your home. That's why you're attacking us. But we don't want to harm you or the forest here. I'm also sad about what happened here. And I'm really sorry that we couldn't prevent it."

It seems as if the being can understand her. At least it hasn't moved, just keeps staring at Adora. Now the blonde is standing directly in front of the huge animal, and it lowers its head to face

her. Adora looks it in the eyes and says: "I promise that I will do everything I can to ensure that something like this never happens again."

Then she reaches out a hand, and although the reason within her screams that she is insane, she carefully touches the animal's head and puts a hand on the gray fur. It's amazingly soft. A tremor goes through the animal, and suddenly Adora can feel something like a delicate connection between herself and the being. She doesn't know what happens to her when her palm begins to glow and the animal's red eyes turn a soft blue. The blonde woman feels how the creature's anger gives way and calm settles down instead.

The animal slowly lowers its leg, with which it was previously holding Catra, and loosens its grip on the Magicat. Adora can't read the expression on her face, but it seems to be a mixture of surprise and amazement. The animal slowly pulls its head back and loosens itself from Adora´s hand, the glow of which goes out. Then the being turns around calmly and disappears into the forest.
This time without destroying plants or roaring angrily.

Relieved, Adora looks at Catra and gives her a triumphant smile. "Well that wasn't that difficult."
Then suddenly all of her strength leaves and she collapses. "Adora!"
Her vision blurs and she can no longer keep her eyes open when she is seized by an enormous tiredness and drawn into the blackness.

The next time she opens her eyes, she doesn't immediately know where she is or what is wrong with her. Then she hears a voice next to her. "Adora! You are awake!" Blinking, she notices that she is sitting leaning against a tree trunk. Catra kneels in front of her and looks at her worriedly. Her tail twitches restlessly back and

forth.
It is already dawn around them.

"How long have I been gone?" Adora wants to be confused. "Half an hour maybe? I don't know, what matters is how you are. Do you feel dizzy? Are you in pain?" The blonde wants to say no and sits up a little further when a sharp pain runs through her hip. Frightened, she moans and wants to get up, but a couple of hands push her back to the tree. "Don't. You shouldn't move now. This beast got you pretty badly."

Confused, Adora looks down at herself and discovers a large red spot on her left hip that stains her jacket and shirt. And a ball of cloth soaked in blood that Catra presses against the wound. It looks familiar to her, but she doesn't recognize it immediately. Only when she looks back at Catra does she see that the Magicat is sitting in front of Adora without her jacket and is looking at the blonde unmoved. She takes the blonde's hand and places it over the soaked ball of fabric so that it doesn't slip before she leans back.

"You seem to be stable conscious. Do you think I can take my eyes off you for a few minutes without you jumping on a giant animal and challenging it to fight?" Adora is not sure if Catra is joking, so she just nods, still confused. Where does Catra want to go now? But the Magicat doesn't go into it any further, just nods, turns around and disappears into the forest.

Confused, the blonde looks after her. She notices a small campfire that was lit next to her. She frowns and wonders if it is actually wise to start a fire here. But since they are no longer in the Crimson Waste, it gets chilly in the evening, and after what happened earlier it doesn't seem as if anything else wants to attack them in this whale here.

A little more relaxed, she leans her head back against the tree trunk and closes her eyes. The fight exhausted her, and the wound doesn't exactly make it any better. But for the time being,

Catra is fine and the two of them are safe. She opens her eyes again. Catra IS fine, isn't she?

At this moment, as if called, the Magicat appears between the trees and walks towards Adora. Her face is locked and she is holding the women's two pouches in her hand. They must have been lost during the fight. When she reaches the injured woman, Adora quickly asks: "Are you okay? Has the creature hurt you?" Catra raises an eyebrow as she digs into one of the bags. "You're sitting in front of me bleeding and asking ME if I'm hurt?"

She shakes her head, her lips pressed together slightly. "Don't worry, princess. Except for a few scratches, I didn't get anything." Then she kneels and pulls a bandage out of the bag. The blonde looks surprised at the white roll. "You took bandages with you?" The Magicat shrugs its shoulders. "I like to be prepared. I also know what I get myself into when I travel with you. Sooner or later you will end up getting hurt."

Her words sound unusually snappy. Not that Catra has been nice to Adora the last few years, but she seemed very different in the last few days. More open. More like a friend. But now? Adora frowns. "What's wrong with you? Why are you so snappy?" "I'm not!" Catra hisses and avoids looking at the blonde. Her fur stands on end and her tail curls around her body.

Now it's clear to Adora. She knows this reaction, even if it hasn't happened often in the past 20 years (except for the part when she left, of course).
"You are … angry with me." Adora notes with surprise.

The Magicat does not answer, but stubbornly looks in another direction. "Why?" What did she do wrong? Then the Magicat bursts out as her head turns to the blonde. "I told you to run away! But no, you had to play the hero again!" Stunned, Adora replies: "I couldn't just leave you behind!"
"Why not, after all you are so good at it?!" Catra squeals.
The pain in her eyes feels like thorns that stab Adora’s heart when she looks at the Magicat perplexed. "Catra ..."

The Magicat has noticed her outburst and seems to be recovering when she closes her eyes and takes a deep breath. Then she goes on speaking softly, but doesn't look at Adora. "You could have died ... You are hurt because of me. That wouldn't have happened if you had run away."
Her stomach contracts when she hears these words. Against the advice of the Magicat, she leans forward and holds out a hand, ignoring the pain. "Catra" begins softly but firmly.

She gently puts a hand on the Magicat's cheek and turns her face so that she has to look the blonde in the eye.
"I won't leave you behind again."
The vulnerability in Catra's gaze almost breaks Adora’s heart, so she smiles confidently. "Besides, I'm fine. Nothing happened to us.
We take care of each other, remember?"

For a moment Adora is captivated by the beautiful two-colored eyes that look at her so openly and that reflect the flames of the campfire. A few individual strands of hair hang over the red mask and frame Catra's beautiful face. Adora looks at the small freckles, the snub nose, the fangs peeking out of her mouth, and the full, seductive lips.
For a moment she feels a deep desire to be as close as possible to this woman, to pull her close, to bury her hands in her hair and -

Catra releases Adora´s hand and clears her throat to find her voice again. "Your wound still needs proper treatment." she explains simply and looks to the side. Adora´s gaze wanders to the ball of cloth that she is still holding on her hip and nods. "Should I take off my clothes?" She gets hot at the idea, but since Catra is still looking at the floor, she doesn't notice. The Magicat nods and slides back a little so that Adora has room.

The blonde loosens her hand from the ball of fabric on her side and carefully begins to unbuckle her belt and take off her red jacket. That still works quite well, but when she tries to peel off the sleeves of her top, she breathes in hissing, because pain runs

through her body like lightning. Resigned, she drops her arms and looks at Catra, who has kept her eyes down. "Can you help me?"

The Magicat answers by dropping the bandage and the bag and then kneeling right next to Adora. She carefully pulls the two sleeves off Adora´s arms and then grabs the shirt by the stomach to slowly push it up. In doing so, she is careful to detach it from the wound, which releases the fabric with a smacking noise. Adora every now and then winces and bites her lip, but doesn’t make any sounds.

The women don't look at each other all the time. It's a strange situation. Adora doesn't know why. They used to see each other in underwear all the time.
But the fact that Catra is so close to her now, and that she's practically undressing her, feels so ... intimate.
In an unusual but good way. Catra's fingers leave a tingling sensation in the places where she touches Adora's bare skin. In the meantime, Catra has pushed the top up so far that she can pull it over Adora’s head in one go. Now Adora is just sitting there in her bra.

To distract herself from the unfamiliar feeling, the blonde takes a look at her wound, which is now exposed. Her hip is covered in blood so she can't see much, but it doesn't look like a deep wound. At least that´s something.
In the meantime, Catra has grabbed the blood-smeared clothes, including her own jacket, and got up. "There's a little stream nearby. I'll go wash out the blood and get some water to clean your wound. I'll hurry up." Before Adora can react, the Magicat has turned around and has disappeared back into the forest.

Chapter 15

Catra:

Catra eagerly pulls the clothes through the cold water and rubs out the red stains as best she can. In doing so, she tries to suppress the thoughts that are circling through her head and causing chaos. Her emotions are a mess too.
The water feels uncomfortable on her fingers. She would like to pull her hands out of the cold water, but the blood has to be washed out. And she has to fill water to clean Adora´s wound and to be able to bandage it.

Adora. She saved her, didn't leave her alone, even when Catra told her to. It makes her angry and at the same time she is ... relieved? Grateful?
And when she took off her top ... The cold water brings her back to reality, but doesn't quite manage to cool her mind. She quickly wrings out the clothes and fills a small bottle with water before rushing back to Adora. The blonde is still leaning against the tree trunk, her head tucked back, her eyes closed.

When she hears the approaching footsteps of the Magicat, she looks up. Catra quickly avoids eye contact and tries not to stare at the barely covered upper body. ´Pull yourself together´, she thinks as she kneels on the floor next to Adora again and carelessly tosses the wet clothes next to her.
Now she has to concentrate on the wound. Quickly, she opens the water bottles and looks at the wound on Adora´s hip. She's still bleeding, but not quite as intensely.

Adora supports herself with both arms on the trunk so that she is not in Catra's way. The Magicat hesitates and now looks briefly into the blonde's face. "This will hurt." A faint smile flits across Adora´s face when she replies: "Bring it on." She doesn't waste any time and does as she is told. She quickly dips the water over the open flesh to rinse the dirt out. Adora hisses and tenses her body, but doesn't complain.

Resisting the urge to watch the muscles in Adora´s arms alternate tensing and relaxing, Catra concentrates on her task instead. As thoroughly and quickly as possible, she dabs the wound and removes the blood stains from the skin around it. Then she unrolls the bandage and begins to wrap Adora´s stomach area with it. She secretly hopes that the wound will stop bleeding soon because they only have this one bandage.

She works quickly, but as gently as possible so that Adora doesn't have to suffer unnecessarily. None of the women says a word during the trial. While she repeatedly wraps around the blonde's waist to wrap the bandage, Catra cannot help but inhale the blonde's scent. It calms her down, and her thoughts no longer seem to swirl around as they did a short time before, due to the constant work and the familiar smell.

Finally, when it is dark except for the campfire around her, she is finished and carefully knots the end of the fabric. "Done." she mumbles and slides back a bit to examine her work. Adora also leans forward and looks down at herself. Her ponytail has now completely dissolved and her hair falls openly over her shoulders. In the firelight it looks like shimmering gold, Catra thinks, fascinated by the sight.

She just loves the sight of Adora with her hair down. She always has. Adora seems satisfied with the result, because when she lifts her head, smiling. "Thank you, Catra." Afterwards she turns to look for her outerwear. The Magicat makes a dismissive gesture and hopes that in this light she does not see the blush on her cheeks. "Whatever. I just wanted you not to bleed my jacket any more -" She pauses when her gaze falls on Adora´s bare back, which the blonde has now turned towards her.

"What?" Adora wants to know, who has noticed that something is wrong. Catra doesn't answer. She stares as if spellbound at the scars that are clearly visible on Adora´s back.
"Catra, what's wrong?" the blonde wants to know and turns her head to the Magicat. Catra steps closer to the blonde sitting on the floor and kneels behind her.

As if in a trance, she reaches out a hand and stops in the air before she can touch Adora. But the blonde doesn't protest, so she reluctantly puts a few fingers on the welts that start in the neck and end below her bra. "Those scars ..." Catra swallows as she runs over the scarred skin and Adora shudders. "That was me, wasn't it?" Adora´s face becomes serious and she looks down without answering.

"At the battle in Bright Moon ..." concludes the Magicat further, still shocked by the sight.
She knew that she hurt Adora with her claws. She just never believed that such scars would appear. Ugly scars that would stay on the blonde's back forever. Those welts must have caused excruciating pain. Catra knows how much damage her claws can cause. But to see it now ... In the person who once meant everything to her ... and who is anything but indifferent to her now ... To know that she is responsible for this pain, suddenly leaves her feeling unrestrained guilt.

Why did Adora bother to save her when she hurt so many people? She's not worth it. Only today this village and now Adora ... Is there anyone in the world whom she has not harmed?
"It's not as bad as it looks." Adora mumbles and turns her head to the Magicat. She thinks she has misheard. "No? These scars say something else. I hurt you, Adora. I WANTED you to suffer. I ..." She swallows when she feels tears well up. In a whisper, she asks: "Why didn't you just let me die?"

Shock shows on the blonde's face as she turns completely to Catra. "I beg your pardon?!" It sounds like a rebuke. "I only hurt people. Especially you. I've always made your life bad. I hindered you when you were in the Horde and fought you when you went to the other side." Catra keeps her gaze lowered so as not to have to look at Adora. Her hands are trembling, so she clenches them into fists.

"Shadow Weaver was right." she whispers in a choked voice and feels how iron chains are wrapped around her. "I am a distraction for others. I am useless. It would be best if I disappeared from

your life." For so long she has tried to fight back against Shadow Weaver. To prove that she is worth something. That she can go far. And in the end the woman who always had too much power over Catra still wins.

She doesn't want it, but the tears are rolling down her face without her being able to prevent it. Then she feels warm fingers under her chin, which gently lift her head and let her look into a pair of beautiful blue eyes. In a stern voice, Adora commands: "NEVER say that Shadow Weaver is right ever again." Her thumb gently strokes over Catra's cheek, who only looks silently into the eyes of the person in front of her.

Adora clears her throat before continuing. "I told you yesterday that I am happy in Bright Moon ..." she begins gently, and immediately Catra is afraid of the words that would now follow. She doesn't want to hear from Adora that she is better off without her. Therefore her muscles tense and she wants to lower her gaze, but Adora holds her chin tight to look at her intently. "However, I wasn't always happy there. The beginning was especially difficult."

Catra's ears twitch in surprise. To hide her tension, she jokes in a broken voice: "Why? Too cozy there?" A faint smile forms on Adora´s mouth, but she shakes her head. "No. On the contrary. I couldn't ... I wasn't feeling comfortable." She lifts her head and looks into the eyes of the Magicat. "That was because of you. You weren't there. That was bad for me. I had sleep problems for days because I had to sleep alone in a bed. And everything else was strange too because you were never there. That felt so unfamiliar.., so ... wrong."

She exhales audibly while Catra's muscles relax. At the same time she feels surprise. She has never dared to wonder if Adora misses her. She was too afraid of the answer. "Bow and Glimmer are my best friends ... but they could never replace you." Adora looks uncertainly into the eyes of the Magicat, who stares at her speechlessly. She wants to say something, but she doesn't know what.

Again the blonde's thumb strokes Catra's cheek, and it has such a calming effect on Catra that her whole body relaxes. "You are not a distraction, Catra. You never were. You have been the most important person to me all my life and ..." Adora takes a deep breath and closes her eyes before spraying again. "You are still important to me now. We've both made mistakes, but that doesn't change the fact that I want you with me. Plus, you've saved my life countless times in the past few days. I wouldn't be here at all without you. "

A few strands of hair fall into her beautiful face, and Catra's throat constricts at how breathtaking the woman in front of her is. The flames next to them cast dancing shadows on her face and seem to challenge Catra. The Magicat notices breathlessly that Adora has still not let go of her face. And that they are so close that the Magicat can feel the young woman's breath on her cheek. Her heart seems to be beating twice as fast as before.

"Can you say that again?"
Catra whispers and her eyes wander to the blonde's mouth, which is only inches away. Those lips twist into a smile when she quietly replies: "I want you with me, Catra." This sentence sounds so wonderful that Catra shudders.
The whole situation feels good. Comfortable. Secure. Safe.
Too safe. Too good to be true.

Fear grabs her heart and pulls her out of this feeling of safety. Almost jerkily, Catra pulls her head back and thus slips Adora´s gentle grip. She quickly looks to the side and tries to keep her expression neutral as she gets up and reaches for the wet clothes.
"Catra?" Adora´s voice sounds uncertain. Carefully. She is probably afraid that she did something wrong.

Catra clears her throat so as not to have a husky voice and explains: "I have to hang the clothes up. Otherwise they won't be dry by tomorrow."
"Oh. Of course." Is Adora disappointed?
Catra can't tell, she can't see the blonde's face because she has turned her back to hang the clothes over a low-hanging branch

near the fire. The fear that has settled inside her is slowly receding as she can distract herself enough not to think about what was just about to happen.

When she is done, she turns back to Adora, who has meanwhile leaned back against the tree trunk and is now staring absently into the flames. Catra sits down next to her, albeit with due distance, and hands her the last of her food supplies from one of the bags. It's a piece of bread. Not much, but it will do. Plus, anything is better than the disgusting ration bars they had to eat back in the Horde.

She holds it out to Adora without looking at her. The blonde gratefully takes it from her hand and starts to eat. The smacking noises reveal that today made Adora quite hungry. Catra would smile if she didn't have so many other thoughts to preoccupy her. She deliberately ignores the fact that hunger gnaws at her too. She doesn't need it as much as the blonde next to her.

The Magicat pulls her knees up to her chest and rests her chin on them. "Tomorrow we'll have to replenish our supplies from somewhere. Fortunately, it's only two days to Bright Moon." The smacking next to Catra stops. Adora seems to be taken aback. "Have you ... have you already eaten?"
"Mind your own business and eat, princess." the Magicat grumbles, staring doggedly into the flames so as not to give in to the temptation to look to the side.

It is quiet for a few moments before Catra's ears twitch when she hears Adora tearing the bread apart in her hands and offering her one half. "You have to eat something too, Catra." she says gently. Catra throws the bread next to her a quick look before she gazes at the fire again. "I do not want it." A grunt sounds. "If you don't take it, I'll have to deal with a bad-tempered Magicat tomorrow, and neither of us want that." explains Adora and Catra is almost certain that the blonde is smiling.

So she grabs the bread half and mumbles: "Fine. But only so you will shut up." She almost sighs in relief when the bread lands

between her teeth and in her stomach. But she would never admit that to Adora. So they both finish eating in silence until Adora clears her throat and hesitantly asks: "Catra?" "Hm?" "What happened to you earlier? I mean before that creature showed up." Catra's stomach contracts when she thinks about her collapse.

She bites her lip uncomfortably. Hesitantly she turns her head to Adora and asks: "Can we talk about it another time? I just don´t have the energy for it right now." That's the truth. Too much happened in one day, she doesn't want to clutter her head with more thoughts. Adora seems to read the request in Catra's eyes, so she nods hesitantly. "Fine. But we'll talk about it later." "Yeah, yeah, whatever." mumbles the Magicat and lies down on her back.

Tired, she turns on her side and turns her back on Adora. She just wants to sleep now. Behind her she hears the blonde lying down next to her. With space between them, of course. "Well then: good night, Catra." The blonde's voice still sounds hesitant.
Catra curls up even more, but doesn't dare to answer.
It is quiet for a while, only the noises of the forest can be heard.

But it's too loud in her head, so the Magicat can't sleep. Behind her, she hears her companion's calm, even breathing.
So Adora has already fallen asleep. No wonder.
But something is not quite right. Confused, Catra pricks up her ears and listens more closely. There is another sound. A ... rustling. Since she is sure that Adora is sleeping, she turns around and looks next to her.

Adora is actually sleeping, but very restlessly. Now Catra recognizes where the noise is coming from:
The blonde is trembling.
Since all of her outerwear is wet, she is still only wearing her bra, and the fire doesn't seem to give her enough warmth. For a moment Catra frowns at how Adora grimaces in her sleep and wraps her arms around herself, who are covered with goosebumps.
Then she makes a decision.

Carefully she crawls across the grass to the sleeping woman and slowly reaches out an arm to her. Without waking her, Catra pulls Adora´s head to her chest and puts her arms around her upper body to warm her.
This only serves to help Adora get better faster, Catra explains in silence. And she only does it because she is sure that the blonde won't notice.

And it works: a little later Adora stops shaking and lies quietly in the arms of the Magicat, her face cuddled against her chest. Heat shoots up Catra's cheeks, and she quickly turns her gaze. With Adora’s heartbeat so close to her, her smell in her nose and her calm breathing, it is becoming more and more difficult for the Magicat to keep her eyes open, and a little later she also falls asleep.

Chapter 16

Adora:

She is in an empty bedroom. It´s one of the Frightzone, Adora sees startled, and turns around. Suddenly the room changes and Adora stands in one of the prison cells. Bright green light illuminates the small room.
She is captured.
Her heart starts racing. No, that can't be true! She has to get out of here now! She wants to run to the transparent lattice wall, but is held back by handcuffs. Panic rises in her. Then somebody steps in front of her cell. Lord Hordak.

His piercing eyes are on her, mocking her. "Hello, Adora. How nice of you to finally surrender to me. You never had a chance anyway." "No!" shouts Adora firmly. "I won't let you win!"
"Oh, but I've already won. Etheria is subjugated. There is no place that I have not conquered. Your Bright Moon is also destroyed."
"No." Adora whispers, stunned. Hordak laughs.

"Oh, please. Don't pretend you're surprised. You made all of this possible in the first place. It was only through your recklessness that I was able to take this on myself." He takes out a sword from behind his back. Her sword. The blonde shakes desperately at her chains, wants to tear herself free, to fight back. But it doesn't help. Hordak continues. "Oh, and let's not forget your little friends."

Suddenly Bow and Glimmer appear at his side. Both are tied up, their clothes are torn and their bodies are brutally beaten. "Adora ..." Bow whispers weakly and looks at her pleadingly. It breaks Adora's heart. She pulls on her bonds and screams. It does not help. "Adora ..." Glimmer cries and looks at her with tears in her eyes. Her sight is lost, hopeless.

“Why didn't you help us? Why didn´t you come? Did you forget about us?" The blonde's heart breaks. "No, Glimmer, I could never

do that!" Adora contradicts through tears and shakes her chains in despair. "I will save you, I promise!" "It's too late for that, Adora. You failed." Hordak explains, smiling coldly and snaps his fingers. Thereupon red lightning strikes over Bow´s and Glimmer´s body, and both scream in agony.
"Adora!"
Their desperate voices go through the bones of the blonde.
"Adora!"
They scream and scream before, in the end, they close their eyes and let their heads droop. "NOOO!"

“Adora!” Adora opens her eyes with a scream. Breathing heavily, she looks around, can hardly see anything, doesn't know where she is. Where are Glimmer and Bow? "Adora!" A voice pulls her out of the fog of her thoughts and she feels a pair of hands on her shoulders. Then she recognizes a pair of two-colored eyes in front of her. "Adora, it was just a dream. Calm down."

The blonde only slowly remembers where she is. She is lying on the floor, the fire next to her no longer shines as brightly as it did when she fell asleep. Her whole body is cramped. Her blonde hair hangs shaggy on her face when she looks, breathing heavily, at the Magicat in front of her. Catra too is lying on the ground and holding Adora by the arms.

"Take it easy. Breathe. Everything is fine." Adora puts her hand to her cheek and notices that it is damp. Her hand is shaking.
So it was all just a dream? Hordak hasn't won yet? And her friends ... She thinks with horror of the images that are burned into her brain. The agony her friends went through. And there was nothing she could do about it.

Desperation grips her, shakes her, and when she looks into Catra's worried eyes, she can no longer contain herself and begins to cry. Her whole body trembles, whether from excitement, cold or something else she can't tell. Suddenly, two arms close around her and pull her to a warm body. One hand tentatively strokes her

head, while the other caresses her back. "It's okay." Catra whispers nto her hair, holding her close.

Adora is frozen for a moment, she didn't expect this reaction. Then she overcomes her rigidity and presses herself closer to the comforting warmth of the Magicat, to her soothing touch. And she cries. She lets her tears run free, lets all her emotions flow out that she has locked up and held back for so long. She allows herself this one moment of weakness.

In which she surrenders to Catra's strength, who surrounds her protectively and simply holds her while Adora continues to cry. Neither of them speaks a word, and for a while all that can be heard is the sobbing of the blonde. The smell and the closeness of the Magicat soothe her. Little by little, the tears dry up, her body stops shaking and her heartbeat calms down. But she does not dare to remove her face from the crook of the Magicat's neck. Therefore, she murmurs into Catra's hair.

Her voice is scratchy from crying. "I saw her. Glimmer and Bow... They were tortured... By Hordak. There was nothing I could do. He has conquered Etheria. He won. And I did nothing. I was too late, I couldn't..." She swallows before whispering, "I couldn't save them. I wasn't strong enough." Carta listens, not moving, continuing to hold Adora. Adora presses her forehead against the Magicat's shoulder. "What if this is really happening? What if the world ends because of me?" "It was just a dream, Adora," Catra contradicts soft. Adora swallows, but the lump in her throat grows larger.

"But it doesn't have to stay one. The chance of me failing is not small.... And then everything will be for nothing." She has voiced her greatest fear. That she is not enough. That she will fail and everyone will suffer because of her.
For a while, both women are silent until Catra suddenly asks, "Why do you think you alone have to save the world?"

"What?" Adora is confused and leans her head back to look at Catra's face. The Magicat looks down at her and raises an

eyebrow. "Why are you convinced that you alone are responsible for the fate of the world?" "I am She Ra. It is my duty to protect this world." "Pff, yeah right. And the rest of us have no role in this process, huh? We are supposed to sit back and enjoy the show of you single-handedly defeating the horde get yourself killed."The Magicat shakes her head and the corner of her mouth twitches. "Sometimes you just take yourself too seriously, Princess."
It doesn't sound mean-spirited. Confused, Adora looks at Catra, who continues speaking.

"Listen: it's true, you're the strongest in the rebellion, and without you there's probably no victory. But still, you alone don't stand a chance against the horde. That's the way it is. No one can defeat such a big opponent alone. but for that you have your friends. Your allies who will help you. Who want to kick the horde's ass just as much as you do. Who WANT to put themselves in danger with you and fight by your side to save this world.
I've told you before, Adora: you are not weak. Your only weakness is that you always want to save everyone single-handedly, have to please everyone and don't think about yourself. So stop worrying or doubting yourself. You have your friends, and you have me. Together, we'll figure it out. We'll free Arrow boy and Sparkles, get your sword and kick some serious horde butt. Okay?" Catra's eyes look at her open and full of softness. She hesitates before whispering softly:

„Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other."

Adora freezes and thinks she has misheard. Tears come to her eyes again, but this time not out of sadness. She twists her mouth into a smile and whispers, "Okay." The dejection in her heart turns to a tender hope. Catra is right. She is not alone. She has her friends who will stand by her at all times. Together, they would be fine.
On impulse, she wraps her arms around Catra and hugs her even tighter while burying her face in her hair.
"Thank you, Catra."
The Magicat hugs her tighter as well, though a bit hesitantly, before murmuring,

„Anytime, Princess."
So it doesn't take long for Adora to fall asleep again. This time without bad dreams.

Warm rays of sunlight shine on the Magicat's face as she sleepily opens her eyes. Confused, she blinks a few times and looks at the daylit surroundings around her. She has slept much longer than usual. A second later, she realizes why. Her lips twist into a smirk as she lowers her head and watches Adora, whose forehead is leaning against her cleavage and who is snoring softly. Her arms are still wrapped around the Magicat's waist, and Catra is also still holding Adora as tightly as she did during the night.

So it was not a dream. A stone almost falls from the Magicat's heart. At the same time, this realization makes her uneasy. If it was not a dream, then Catra came close to Adora last night. Maybe too close.
At some point during this crazy trip, the blonde has managed to tear down the protective walls around Catra's heart and nestle in it again. Silently, the Magicat looks at a loose strand of hair hanging in Adora's face.
Or has she just never left this place in her heart?

Either way, it's dangerous for Catra to get involved with Adora. She knows that. Her mind has been screaming nothing else for days.
But her heart screams louder.
For Adora, of all people.

Hesitantly, Catra releases a hand from Adora's back and brushes the strand of hair from her face. Longing grips her and seems to vibrate through her body. Oh, how she WANTS to imagine that it is easy. That she can give herself over to her feelings, let herself go all in.
That she can TRUST.

But fear keeps her from doing so. Uncertainty. Adora might tolerate her company now, because she is helpful in the fight against the horde. But what about after that? When everything is over?
Sadly, Magicat's eyes wander over the blonde's face. Catra is not a good person. She has done so much evil. Hurt so many people. How could she ever be enough for someone like Adora?

How can she be sure she won't be thrown away like a weapon that can't be used anymore?
If Adora were to throw her away.... The Magicat's heart tightens. She couldn't bear that. Not again.

Taking one last deep breath to keep Adora's scent in her nose as long as possible, she memorizes the feel of Adora's protective arms around her waist and her head against her chest. Then she releases her arms from the blonde and carefully wriggles out of her grip. She quickly rolls to her side and then picks herself up. Immediately she feels the lost warmth and wishes she hadn't gotten up. Then she pushes all her thoughts into the background and walks to the branch on which she has hung the wet clothes.

Checking, the Magicat runs her finger over the fabric and is satisfied that it is dry. She picks up her black jacket and gives it an appraising glance. Yesterday, the jacket was used to stop the blood from Adora's wound and got a lot of blood on it. Not all of it seems to have been washed out, but since the jacket is black, it is not noticeable. And besides, Catra now really has other problems than her appearance or her clothes. Her ear twitches as Adora sighs behind her and turns before calling out, "Ouch!" in shock.

Quickly, Catra slips on her jacket and turns around. Adora is now lying on her back with her face contorted and her hands on her hips. When she turned, she probably didn't pay attention to her wound. As she turns her head to the side, her blinking eyes fall on Catra and she squints her eyes in irritation. She is probably also thinking about the previous night. Quickly clearing her throat, the Magicat asks, "How is your injury?"

"Good morning to you, too."Adora murmurs sleepily, looking down at herself. A small dark spot has formed on the bandage, but that's normal. "I think quite well. Ask me again when I'm awake." As if on cue, Adora's eyes seem to fall shut. Shaking her head, Catra grabs the rest of the clothes. Yesterday seems to have strained Adora more than expected. Unmoved, the Magicat walks up to the blonde and throws her top and jacket in her face. Surprised, Adora squeals and sits up.
"Get up, princess. We need to find your palace, remember?"

Under the pile of cloth, Adora mumbles something unintelligible before finally obeying and standing up. As she stretches her arms from her and yawns heartily, Catra looks away to avoid staring too long at Adora's still exposed torso. Concentrating, she inspects her claws as she hears Adora slip on her clothes.

When she finishes and Catra looks up, she almost regrets not having memorized the sight of the half-naked Adora. But she quickly dispels the thoughts and packs up her few belongings before handing Adora one bag and the two of them walk off together without a word.

Chapter 17

Adora:

On the way, the two pick a few berries, but there is nothing more to eat than that. Back in the horde, Adora would not have minded much. There they had been basically malnourished. But in Bright Moon, she always got enough to eat. Her body is no longer used to getting too little, so the blonde can't do anything about her stomach grumbling that haunts her all day.

Catra walks beside her all the time and keeps giving her looks that reveal how noisy her stomach actually is. Adora even thinks she sees a twitch in the corner of the Magicat's mouth. Therefore, she walks beside her with a blush on her cheeks the whole time and sheepishly puts a hand on her stomach. Underneath, she feels the rough fabric of the bandage under her shirt. The steady, constant movement as she walks does not harm her hip any further, so she hardly feels her wound except for a permanent tugging. The blood stain from the white top has not washed out well, but the red jacket covers the stain so it is not noticeable.

Throughout the day, the women walk through various fields and across small valleys. Except for individual hikers here and there, they hardly discover any other people. They are all heading in a similar direction: to Bright Moon. The horde forces them to leave their villages and seek the protection of the vicinity of the palace. Adora's heart grows heavy as she thinks of the many families leaving their homes. She is not quite as downcast as she was last night, but the mood is... depressing.

Throughout the day, she barely speaks a word. Catra is also very silent. Her mood seems to be similarly lousy, and Adora wonders what the reason is. She knows the look of the Magicat. Something is bothering her, clearly. But Adora does not dare to ask. She is afraid it might frighten Catra and she would close herself off from her completely. In the last few days, she has opened up more and more, bit by bit, and let Adora take a look at her innermost being.

She has let her share it, and Adora has always considered that a great privilege.

She can't risk losing all that now. Not now, when it feels so.... good. Even at this moment when Adora is feeling permanently pressured, she's fine because Catra is with her. She can't ruin that again. Therefore, the two walk side by side in silence for hours.

By now it is late afternoon. Adora wonders if Catra is thinking about last night. Whether the same doubts still preoccupy her. That she is harming Adora, and should not be in her life. That she can only hurt her. That she is... worthless. Adora's heart tightens at the thought. How can Catra possibly believe this? Can't she see how much she means to Adora? How well the blonde is doing simply because she's there?

No, of course she doesn't see it. How could she? They've been on different sides for years. And yet Adora has never been able to hate Catra. She has often been angry with her, sometimes disappointed, sad too, yes. But deep in her heart she has never ceased to -
... care for Catra.

She casts a sideways glance at the Magicat again. She has changed. Adora senses that quite clearly. The year in Crimson Waste has done something to her. Perhaps it has allowed her to gain the distance she needed to see the wrongness of the Horde. Adora wishes for it so much. She knows Catra is not a bad person. She never was.
And she wants, as she has always wanted, for her to join the rebellion. Like, for real.

Before she knows it, the blonde imagines what it would be like to live together with Catra in Bright Moon. Peacefully. Without a horde to fight against. Adora quickly pushes the image out of her mind. She does not want to allow herself to think of a beautiful future. Not yet. Hordak is not yet defeated. And Catra...
She still has her condition. After this mission, they would part ways.

Forever.
Adora feels like she's going to throw up.

"Are you not feeling well?" Catra's voice snaps her out of her thoughts. "What?" "You look like you've been eating too many brown ration bars." The corner of the blonde's mouth twitches as she shakes her head. "On the contrary, I haven't eaten enough." As if on cue, her stomach grumbles, and Catra shakes her head, a grin on her face. "I noticed. Your stomach has been making itself known very clearly all day." "Sorry, but I'm hungry." Adora defends herself, blushing again.

"Don't worry, princess. You said it's not far to Malidas. I'm sure there's an inn there and something to eat. How does that sound?" The thought of a hot meal makes Adora drool. "Mhhh wonderful. Do you think we could find a room there for the night too?" The magicat shrugs her shoulders. "I think so. Malidas is a big city, I'm sure they'll have that there." Adora almost sighs. Instead, she stretches her arms in the air, ignoring the painful sting of the wound.
"I would appreciate a real bed."
"Quite the princess, I see."
The blonde sticks her tongue out at Catra, to which she giggles.

In fact, they reach Malidas half an hour later. It is not long before they also find an inn in the busy streets. It's not very big, but they don't care. Driven by hunger, Adora pushes open the door and enters the spacious dining room. Catra follows her and lets her eyes wander through the room.
Everything here is made of dark wood and looks simple and rustic, but inviting.

There are tables and chairs everywhere, about half of them occupied by people eating and drinking. No one pays attention to the newcomers. Against the opposite wall is a counter, where a tall, sturdy woman with two curved horns on her forehead is busy cleaning a few glasses. Determined, Catra heads for the counter.

Adora follows her and stealthily lifts her belly. She hopes to fill her stomach soon, otherwise she would not be able to think clearly. She probably already can't, after all, she's running after the Magicat like a doll without a mind. Luckily, at least her companion keeps a clear head.

When the two reach the counter, the tall woman looks up from her activity only briefly and asks, "What can I get you?" Adora looks at the woman. She has a long braid of black hair and dark eyes. Her body is broadly built and judging by the muscles on her arm, she could beat Adora in arm wrestling with no problem. The blonde tries not to stare too conspicuously at the muscles.

The Magicat seems completely unimpressed by the woman's appearance. Catra's expression is reserved as she replies, "We need a room for the night and a hot meal tonight." With nimble movements, the woman wipes over the glass and sets it down before casting another glance at Catra and Adora. This time, there is clear skepticism in it as she eyes the worn, filthy clothing. The physical examination makes Adora feel embarrassed. "Can you guys pay?" The woman's look unsettles Adora, so she looks to her companion. The Magicat is already rummaging in her bag. Calmly, she places a hand on the counter and slides a few coins toward the woman.

She shakes her head, her horns swinging back and forth. "That's not enough for both of you." "That's all we have, though," Catra growls, her face contorting angrily. Adora fears she's about to start a fight, but that's when the Magicat stops herself and closes her eyes, taking one deep breath and not seeming quite so irritated afterwards. "Listen: we've had a long journey and we're tired. Is there any other way we can pay?"

Skeptically, the woman eyes the travelers. "You have nothing with you that I can use." She pauses as she looks Catra in the face again, and points a finger at her. "But I like your mask." Astounded, Adora turns her head to the Magicat. "My...mask?" repeats Catra, caught off guard. She didn't see this offer coming. Adora reads the distaste in the Magicat's eyes as she grabs her

head and releases the red mask from her hairline. She then takes it in both hands and stares at it thoughtfully. She has been wearing this mask for years. It is a part of her.

Carefully, Adora puts a hand on the shoulder of theMagicat and looks at her worriedly. "You don't have to do that. We'll find somewhere else to go." For a moment Catra is silent, looking at the red metal in her hands. Adora does the same. They found the mask together a few years ago, the blonde recalls. They were about fourteen years old. They were playing catch, in the far corner of the Frightzone. It was between a couple of camps when they knocked over some crates during a scuffle and the mask fell out.

The kids didn't know where it came from or why it was there, but the mask came in handy for Catra. For several months her front hair had been too long and always just fell in her face. Adora suggested she try it on, and when she did, she suddenly looked so grown up. The blonde still remembers how the heat came to her cheeks when Catra asked her what she looked like....
"Beautiful." Adora mumbled sheepishly. "And strong. Like a real horde soldier." She remembers that the Magicat was embarrassed, too. "Shut up." she just muttered and turned away.
From that day on, she wore the mask all the time.

Giving it away now, just for a meal, is asking too much, Adora knows. That's why she tries to let the Magicat know with a glance that she doesn't have to do that. But then Catra suddenly looks up and looks determinedly at the horned woman.
"Deal."
Resolutely, she places the mask next to the coins on the counter. The woman nods impassively and takes the items before searching under the counters for something. Adora, on the other hand, is not so unmoved, but looks to Catra in shock, but she just shrugs.

"Do you need one bed or two?" The question throws Adora off her game. Before she can hide it, the blush rises to her face. "We're not... I mean..." she stammers, but Catra interrupts her,

"Whatever's free." The woman raises an eyebrow and looks back and forth between the travelers a few times before handing Catra a key card. "Up the stairs, third door on the right at the very end of the hall. Dinner is served here. Just sit at a table, a girl will take care of your order."

Catra nods and turns around. Adora is still overwhelmed by the events just now, and probably also by hunger, so the Magicat has to grab her by the wrist and pull her along. She drags her to a table in the corner, presumably to avoid attracting attention, and only then lets go of Adora's arm to sit down on one of the chairs. Adora follows her with mixed feelings. "Catra, I'm sure we could have found another solution. You didn't have to do this."

Now Catra looks directly at Adora. Her look is no longer tense or irritated, but calm. Calmly, she replies, "I know. But I wanted it that way." Then a small smile appears on her lips. "It's all right, really." For a moment, Adora holds eye contact. As she does so, she looks at Catra, really looks at her.
Without the mask, a few small strands are already hanging in her face again. The blonde has not seen her for ages like this. Without the mask, smiling and with this open look...
she looks like she used to. Back when their world was still intact. When the two of them had to stand up together against the rest of the world. Just like now again.

For the second time, she looks at the face in front of her that is as familiar as her own. The gold and blue of her eyes, the thick lashes, the strong eyebrows, the snub nose, the beautiful freckles, the full lips and the small fang that becomes visible through the smile.
Not for the first time, she wonders how a person can be so beautiful.

A clearing of the throat snaps her out of her thoughts and Adora breaks away from the sight. At her table is a young girl with short black hair, big blue eyes and a small pair of horns on her head. Probably the daughter of the woman at the counter. She holds a small pad in her hands and looks to Adora in a waiting manner.

"What do you want to eat?" Greedily, Adora wants to list her order, but before she does, she looks hesitantly once more at her seatmate. She doesn't feel comfortable ordering something Catra had to give up something important for.

But the Magicat only makes a throwing away hand gesture. "Go on. I want my mask to be worth it." That convinces Adora to let go of her guilt. Well, that and the growling in her stomach, so she quickly dictates her order to the girl . After the girl also types Catra's order on her pad, she disappears and comes back a short time later with three full plates. Two of them she places in front of Adora, the Magicat gets a single plate. Starved, Adora wastes no time, but pounces on the food.

In large bites she devours the plates in front of her and makes sounds of rapture. Catra watches her and presses her lips together, clearly trying to suppress a grin. When the blonde notices her gaze, she mumbles with her mouth full, "What?" "Oh, nothing." Hypocritically, Catra smiles at her, and Adora clearly sees the Magicat mocking her. Almost defiantly, she crosses her arms and mutters, still with her mouth full, "I'm just hungry!" "I can see that. You don't make a big secret of it."

Now Catra begins to giggle. "What?!" Adora wants to know and blushes. She feels embarassed.
"It's just... you still have as few manners as you did when we were kids." The blush on her cheeks intensifies as Adora finally swallows and her mouth is free again. "It's not like we got lessons in table manners in the -" She looks around before whispering, "Horde."
Catra shrugs and provocatively raises the spoonful of her own food in the air. "Still, some of us managed not to look like an animal while we eat."

"Hey!" She swats at Catra with one arm, reaching for the next bite with the other. This must look so funny that the Magicat begins to giggle. Her giggle sounds so beautiful that Adora can't stay mad at her.
Besides, it's quite difficult to look sinister while chewing. For a

while it is silent again between the two, but it is a pleasant silence in which everyone takes care of their food.

The murmur of the other guests around them is unusual after days of togetherness, but not disturbing. At some point it gets a little quieter, only to be interrupted by a loud voice. Over her plate, Adora watches Catra tense up again as the strange voice begins to speak. "Dear guests, please join me in welcoming today's performers with me for your entertainment! A round of applause for the first performer!" Adora wipes her mouth and looks in the direction the voice is coming from. Adora didn´t even know there would be some kind of entertainment program, but now she is curious.

There is a small stage that consists of a platform and a curtain. The curtain opens at that moment and a young man in a suit with blue skin and wavy hair steps out. He smiles into the audience, but his eyes have something piercing, predatory. He bows dramatically. "Thank you, thank you, too kind. My performance begins tonight with a poem about the future that was once written by Prince Peekablue and entrusted to me to take out into the world!" The man takes a breath and begins the first verses.

Some are in a foreign language that Adora does not understand, nor is the context clear to her, but she is captivated by the performance. The speaker takes the whole room on a journey with his voice, painting unknown landscapes and events with his words. The blonde is impressed and even forgets her food on the plate, because she can not avert her eyes. The others in the room seem to feel the same way. Either there is magic at play here, or this man has a real talent for captivating his audience.

When the poem ends, he bows to enthusiastic applause. Adora also joins in, and she is almost disappointed when the man disappears without warning behind the falling curtain. But only a few moments later, someone else steps out: a little girl with pink hair and butterfly wings who begins to dance as music sounds from somewhere. Adora watches the girl enthusiastically as she

hops across the stage like a butterfly across a meadow of flowers. She obviously has great talent in dancing.

Adora wishes she also had an artistic talent. She tried painting once when Glimmer encouraged her to find a hobby.
It ended up with the whole Best friend squad on the floor laughing because Adora's attempt to paint Swift Wind looked more like a multicolored potato with four insect legs and a bump. It was a fun afternoon. Adora smiles sadly as she thinks back on it, and turns her attention back to the dancing girl.

After a few minutes, the dance is over and the girl also bows before skipping behind the curtain in elation. Almost simultaneously, the fabric opens again, and a tall, slender woman with long pitch-black hair steps onto the stage in a daring red glittery dress.

Tensely Adora looks at her. With a confident look and a hint of arrogance in it, the lady strides to the center of the stage and looks into the distance as if the audience is not even there. Then she suddenly begins to sing. The song has no lyrics, but the melody is enough to once again chain everyone in the room to the stage.

Adora also listens intently and lets herself be led to other places. The song brings a certain tragedy and Adora's heart becomes heavy. She feels as if the sounds touched her innermost being. For a moment she tears herself away from the sight of the singing woman to look at Catra.

The Magicat seems anything but captivated or excited by the performance. She, too, is watching the stage, but her pupils are distorted to slits and her expression is wary, as if she could be attacked again at any time. Adora is irritated by this behavior, but when she looks back at the singer, she has forgotten her confusion. She discovers that the lady has tears in her eyes by

now as she sings the last, particularly high note. Afterwards, the air is filled with enthusiastic applause.

The lady dramatically dabs her eyes and curtsies once, finally looking into the audience. There is a smile on her face. The same smile as on the other performers: one with something greedy, predatory in it. One that doesn't match the rest of her appearance. Confidently, she lets her gaze roam over the crowd until her eyes linger on Adora.
For a moment Adora is surprised, almost frightened, as dark eyes seem to look directly into her soul.

Then the moment is over and the lady averts her eyes. In the next moment, someone else comes on stage and steps next to her. It is the speaker who has announced the artists. "That's it, thank you very much for this fabulous performance! A round of applause for our performers!" The lady curtsies again and disappears behind the curtain. The applause lasts for a moment before the murmurs and conversations begin again.

Adora also turns back to her table. At this, she looks at Catra, beaming. "That was amazing!" Unimpressed, Catra crosses her arms. "Not really. More like mediocre. And something about the performers was weird." "Why, because they were so different?" Adora doesn't understand what Catra's problem is. The Magicat shakes her head. "No. Something about them is peculiar. Everytone of them had this...look. I don't trust them."

"They're artists, Catra. They're weird, that's what they are. I know, back in the ho- ... where we grew up, there's nothing like that. But here, people are allowed to be whatever they want. And some are just weird. You're too suspicious."
Catra raises an eyebrow. "I spent the last year in the Crimson Waste. What do you expect from me?"
Adora wants to retort something, but is interrupted by a strange voice. "Good evening, ladies."

When the blonde turns around, the singer from a moment ago is standing in front of her and tilts her head down to her. A smile is

on her blood-red lips, contrasting with the dark taint of her skin. "Um... Good evening." Adora stammers, confused. The woman's smile widens as her eyes focus entirely on Adora. Something about that smile seems fake.

"My name is Lady Cheryl. I noticed you in the audience earlier. May I join you for a while?" Adora is still confused by the fact that the singer from just now is suddenly standing right in front of her, talking to her. Maybe the fact that she is sitting and staring directly at Lady Cheryl's breasts has something to do with the fact that she can't answer right away. That's why Catra beats her to it. "There are no more chairs at this table." she replies coolly and looks at the woman challengingly.

The singer's smile doesn't disappear, but it becomes a little more ... treacherous. As if she had accepted a silent challenge. "Well, if that's the case, I guess I can just grab a chair from another table." she explains elatedly, pulling a chair from the empty neighboring table at the same moment.

Catra's expression darkens as Lady Cheryl sits down close to Adora and crosses her legs. As she does so, a slit in her red dress becomes visible, running down to her thighs and revealing a view of her bare legs. Surprisingly muscular legs, as Adora realizes when she can't take her eyes off her neighbor's lap.
Only when Catra clears her throat audibly does the blonde tear herself away from the sight and stare at the tabletop with rosy cheeks.
Concentrate, Adora! she admonishes herself.

Catra's sour expression doesn't escape her, but she can't quite explain why Catra is in such a bad mood. From the smirk on Lady Cheryl's face, she has noticed Adora's stare. Demonstratively, she leans back a little further in the chair to facilitate the view of her body. "So, my sweeties, what did you think of my performance? I always like to get my criticism directly from the audience." "Oh, it was a really nice song!" Adora declares , now not quite so red.

The singer watches her with interest and tilts her head. "Really? I'm glad you liked it so much." A quick glance to the Magicat. "And how did you like it, kitty?"
Momentarily, the air around Catra seems to freeze.
Adora bites her tongue and prays that the Magicat won´t start a massacre.

Calmly, but with a death stare, Catra stares at Lady Cheryl. "Call me Kitty again and I'll scratch that pretty face of yours." Even her voice seems frozen. Adora knows Catra hates being called ´kitty´. Surprisingly, the singer doesn't shiver in fear, but starts laughing heartily. She makes a throwaway hand gesture as she exclaims, "Wow, someone's in a bad mood. Relax, darling. All right, if I can't call you that, what should I call you?"
"Preferably not at all."

"Catra!" intervenes Adora now, looking reproachfully at the Magicat. She may be irritable and dislike Lady Cheryl, but that doesn't mean she has to be so rude to her. Especially not when the singer is about to acommodate her.
Catra also looks at her reproachfully, as if Adora had revealed a secret.
Lady Cheryl, meanwhile, brushes a strand of black hair from her face. "Catra, then. Interesting." She glances at Adora. "And you are?" "Adora." the blonde introduces herself, smiling politely.

Catra, meanwhile, slaps her forehead. Curious, the strange woman tilts her head. "So, Catra and Adora. You look familiar, have I seen you somewhere before?" „Certainly not.“ Catra responses drily, more like a murmur. Meanwhile Lady Cheryl turns her upper body a little further towards Adora, who now has another clear view of the singer's breasts. Is she mistaken, or have they grown even bigger in the last minute? And wasn't she still petite and slender on stage?

Instead, Adora now sees clear muscles on her upper arms. The blonde is confused and fascinated at the same time. Once again, Lady Cheryl notices the blonde's gaze and stretches her chest out a bit more. "You like them, don't you?" she asks with a smug grin.

Adora blinks in embarrassment and is about to avert her gaze when the singer's chest suddenly starts to grow. Confused, Adora shakes her head and blinks again. What's wrong with her now? Is she hallucinating?

Then she hears a growl and raises her eyes. Catra, across from the two of them, stares suspiciously at Lady Cheryl and bangs her fist on the table.
"Okay, that's a neat trick, but you don't know what I am capable of, yet." To emphasize, she opens her fist and extends her claws. By now they have grown to their former length and look appropriately dangerous. Lady Cheryl also recognizes this and leans away from Adora.

But Catra is not finished yet.
"So stop playing games! Who are you and what do you want from us?!"
For a moment, there is a silent eye duel between Adora's tablemates. The blonde is only more confused, not knowing what is going on. Then the corners of the singer's mouth tighten into a grin and she nods appreciatively.
A shiver runs down Adora's spine when she discovers the fangs in the woman's mouth.
"You're a smart cat."

Elegantly, she rises from her chair and looks at the travelers. "So allow me to introduce myself properly." she asks, and suddenly her voice has taken on that dramatic theatrical tone again.
Adora gasps as the woman's appearance suddenly changes.

She grows a little taller and loses her curves, her skin turns a light green and her hair becomes light blonde. Her ears become more pointed and she grows a tail. Her dress also changes and turns into a black, tight-fitting suit.
They are now a completely different person.
When they open their eyes, they are yellow and the pupils are similar to Catra's slits. They grin again and bare their fangs as they explain,
"My name is Double Trouble."

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora:

"A shapeshifter." Catra murmurs in disbelief. Adora is stunned. What? A shapeshifter? She's heard of such beings, but never met one in person. On the other hand, that would explain the various appearances just now. Slowly, wide-eyed, Adora asks, "And the appearances from the show... were they all you?" The shapeshifter's grin widens even more as they nod. "Of course! Was I convincing?" Almost excitedly, they clap their hands together. "Please be honest. I'm always open to constructive criticism."

Still overwhelmed with the situation, Adora stammers, "Well, I thought that was very convincing! The performances were fantastic, and I never would have believed that there was one person behind it all!" At Adora's words, Double Trouble's eyes light up enthusiastically. "Flatterer!" Dramatically, they place a hand over their forehead and then sit down again on the chair next to Adora, expertly crossing their legs.

"Whatever," Catra growls, still scowling. She hasn't taken her eyes off Double Trouble for a second and now crosses her arms demonstratively.
"You didn't answer my question. What do you want from us?"
"Simple, darling." The shapeshifter leans forward and props his arms on the table to rest his head on it, then looks at Catra, relaxed.
"I'm curious."

This seems to puzzle Catra as well. "Curious? Seriously?!" DT nods. "Of course. Where does a performer get his inspiration if not from real life? Fascinating stories are the cornerstone of my

performance, and yours IS fascinating, anyone with a trained eye can see that right away. You are obviously trying not to stand out by choosing the farthest corner to sit in. In doing so, you stand out like one coloured dogs with only two eyes. Your clothes are a horrible mess which can only be worn by someone who has no eyes in his head or who has been on a long journey. Since the former is not the case, I'll assume the latter.
All of this together promises an exciting story that I don't want to miss!"

Adora looks at the shapeshifter. Their explanation sounds plausible in a weird way. She doesn't know if they're really here out of curiosity, but somehow she gets the feeling that they really doesn't have anything evil in mind. Or she just hopes so. "So my dears, spill the tea. Where are you from?" "From the Crimson Waste." answers Adora honestly. Catra gives her a sharp look, as if she's given too much away. DT, meanwhile, draws his eyebrows together.

"The Crimson Waste, actually? How interesting. I thought only exiled criminals lived there. According to that, did you escape?"
"Oh no, that's not it." replies Adora vaguely, not sure how much she wants to reveal. At the same time, she doesn't want to be rude. And she wants to make it clear that she is NOT a criminal. Also, DT is sympathetic to her in a strange way.
"Adora, I don't think this is a good idea." Catra warns.

The blonde gives her a look that says she has everything under control and Catra should relax. She doesn't think there is any danger from the shapeshifter.

The Magicat fires her a look back that says she doesn't agree with that at all, after all, they barely know this lizard and there's too much at stake to jeopardize their mission so recklessly.

Defiantly, Adora stares back, conveying that she should have a little faith in Adora for once. After all, she has no intention of pouring her heart out to the shapeshifter right away.

DT watches the eye duel like an exciting game, their eyes wandering back and forth until he finally clears his throat. "Oh, please forgive me, I'm being terribly pushy and that's without meeting you halfway. Would you like something to drink?" Before either of them can answer, they have snapped their fingers and the waitress from earlier comes to their table. "Three marigos please, Dana." With a generous smile, they turn to the women. "Don't worry, it's on me. After all, I want to keep your throats wet while you tell the tale."

The waitress disappears to pass on the order. Waiting, the shapeshifter looks to Adora that she would tell her story. She, however, wants to be evasive. So she asks curiously, "Why do you actually play so many different people on stage?" The expression on DT's face reveals that they know exactly what Adora is doing, but they don't seem to mind very much. They seem to like talking about themselves as much as they are curious about others.

Readily, they explain, "There are only advantages to it. The hosts pay only one performer, but get a whole show! And only taking one role at a time would be SO boring." "And does the audience know about you?" As if it's a ridiculous question, DT makes a throwaway hand gesture. "Of course they don't! That's the true art of performance, after all!"

The blonde tilts her head. "Why would you want to deliberately pull the wool over everyone's eyes?" Enthusiastically, DT's eyes begin to sparkle.
"That's the real fun of it, isn't it! The thrill of it! The challenge! It's a performer's duty to lead his audience around by the nose. To work with tricks, to create effects and worlds for people to lose themselves in. And you know you've done your job well when they can't see through the illusion. Not even after the performance!"

Adora is impressed. The words of the shapeshifter are full of passion and devotion, the blonde feels that. It impresses her. "I never thought of it that way." Adora admits, fascinated. DT smiles,

and his fangs suddenly don't seem as scary as they did minutes before.

At that moment, the waitress appears at their table with three large mugs, which she sets down before leaving. The shapeshifter courageously grabs one of the cups and takes a hearty sip. "Ah, that feels good." Encouragingly, they look to Adora. "Go ahead, sweetheart." The blonde reaches for the cup in front of her and looks into it. The color of the liquid inside reminds her a little of squashed berries. Curious, she smells it and blinks. It smells sweetish and somehow...bitter at the same time. It's worth a try.

Besides, Adora is actually thirsty from all the food earlier. So she takes a big sip. It tastes sweet in her mouth, but once the liquid runs down her throat it leaves a sharp bitter taste. It tastes good. Takes some getting used to, but it's good. Surprised, Adora notices that her stomach begins to tingle pleasantly warm. "And?" DT wants to know excitedly. On a trial basis, Adora takes another sip.

This time her limbs also begin to tingle pleasantly, and the blonde notices something else: her pain at the hip becomes less. It's as if this drink makes her pain go away. Maybe it contains some healing powers? Adora almost lets out a pleasant sigh as her constant pain is dulled. She has been able to ignore them all day, but that doesn't mean they haven't taxed her body. Now it feels like a little rest. "It tastes good." the blonde confirms, smiling honestly. Enthusiastically, the shapeshifter claps his hands. "I knew you would like it! It's Malidas' specialty."

Their gaze wanders to Catra, who eyes her cup suspiciously. "And what about you, Ki - darling?"
"I'm not thirsty." the Magicat comments dryly, crossing her arms. Adora rolls her eyes. Slowly, the Magicat's posturing is getting on her nerves. Catra can really overdo it sometimes.
"Now come on, Catra. At least try!" The Magicat skeptically eyes the cup in front of her and grasps it with both hands. She sniffs at it with her nose before she grimaces and puts the cup down

again.
"Not a chance."

Adora sighs and turns to her own cup instead. DT also shrugs his shoulders. "Suit yourself. But let me tell you, you're missing out!" Demonstratively, the shapeshifter looks to Adora and raises an eyebrow challengingly. "What do you say, darling: which one of us can empty the cup faster?"
Ah, a contest. Adora's eagerness is aroused.

Grinning, she stretches the cup in their direction. "On three."
"Adora," Catra interjects, but the blonde doesn't even listen, instead counting, "One, two, three!" Then they both gulp down the liquid as if their lives were at stake.
Adora slams the cup back on the table just a moment earlier than the shapeshifter. A few drops of the juice drip from the corner of her mouth as she grins triumphantly.

Appreciatively, DT looks at her. "Not bad. I wouldn't have expected that. I'll buy you another round for that. You up for it?"
Her hip pain has completely disappeared by now, and a euphoric feeling spreads through Adora. Maybe because she just won. She nods enthusiastically to the shapeshifter.
"Adora," Catra repeats again, looking at the blonde seriously. "You shouldn't do that."

Defiance grabs Adora as she looks angrily at the Magicat. "Stop telling me what to do! I can make my own decisions! And just because you've decided to be permanently ill-tempered now, you don't have to spoil my mood too!" For a moment Catra looks honestly hurt, then her expression shuts and she huffs, "Fine, do whatever you want!"

What is Catra thinking? Adora is not a child anymore! She doesn't need a chaperone! She is She Ra! Suddenly Adora feels the need to giggle. 'She Ra'. What kind of a strange name is that anyway?
DT looks at the two curiously. "Uhh, is there a storm rising in love paradise?" Love paradise?! Shocked, Adora looks at Catra and

blushes. "N-no, we're not-" she stammers. Then she tries again. "I mean, we're not a couple! We're... um..."

Her stammering only seems to make the shapeshifter more curious. "Yes? You're what?"
"Well... it's complicated." Adora admits and for some reason gets even redder. "Ohhh the complicated phase then, very well." DT smiles knowingly, showing their fangs.

At that moment comes the second round of Marigos. Enthusiastically, Adora reaches for her cup. With a brief pang of guilt, she glances once briefly at her companion, who has turned away and only lets out a contemptuous snort. Then the blonde represses the feelings and makes herself over the second cup. Along the way, she converses enthusiastically with DT, who tells of his beginnings as an actor.

Catra:

Shaking her head, the Magicat watches the conversation. Adora is now on her third cup and is absolutely no longer herself. Catra immediately smelled the alcohol, so she didn't touch her drink. But it seems that Adora has no idea what alcohol can do to a person. Of course she doesn't. Catra tried to warn her, but Adora wouldn't listen.Well then! Let her do what she wants! She will see the consequences for herself tomorrow.

With her arms crossed, Catra stares at the tabletop and thinks about her first time when she tried alcohol. It was almost a year ago, at one of the first parties at Crimson Waste. It tasted awful, and after Scorpia drank too much of it and looked disastrous the next day, Catra vowed never to drink it again.
The last thing she needs is loss of control and a subsequent hangover.
The former seems to be slowly setting in for Adora.

For a while now, she's been giggling at all sorts of things that aren't funny, and when she talks, she gestures wildly with her arms. If she could remember that her hip is hurt, she wouldn't do that.
But Catra won't remind her. Firstly because the shapeshifter is sitting next to her and she doesn't want to arouse their curiosity, and secondly because she's still miffed.

Adora, meanwhile, seems to have completely forgotten that Catra exists at all.
She listens enthusiastically to the shapeshifter as he tells a story that once happened to him backstage. DT also seems thrilled to have found such a talkative listener. "This is soooo incredible!" Adora laughs. "Did that really happen?" "Why yes, darling! And believe me, the poor guy didn't dare look me in the eye for a week afterwards!"

The shapeshifter also laughs boisterously at the memory. Catra hasn't stopped watching him, but her skepticism isn't quite as strong anymore. Even though Adora can be naive at times, she has a good sense of people. If she finds that this shapeshifter is harmless, then... then Catra believes her.
She doesn't trust this lizard, but she trusts Adora.
Shocked, Catra pauses.
The Magicat's heart seems to stop at this thought. She...TRUSTS Adora?
When is this supposed to have happened??

Uncertainly, she looks at the blonde, who grins and brushes a strand of hair behind her ear. The thought that she could trust this person again scares her. Being able to rely on someone again scares her.
Especially when it's Adora.
But she wants to, she realizes. She feels the urge, the longing to trust Adora.

Quickly, she pushes the thoughts away and focuses on the conversation to distract herself. DT just leans a little closer to Adora and asks, "But darling, you haven't answered my question

yet. I ask you, spill the tea: why are you here?" Catra tenses a little. Even though this shapeshifter seems to be really just curious, it's not a good idea to tell him too much. Adora, however, doesn't seem to have any concerns at all in her state. Straight out she replies, "Ohhh we just want to go to Bright Moon, to Queen An - ...Angella!" Speaking seems harder for her, but it hardly stops her from doing it anyway.

DT opens his eyes in surprise. "So Bright Moon, huh? What do you have to discuss with the queen?" "And the princesses!" adds Adora, raising her index finger in the air as if she needs to lecture the Shapeshifter about something important. The Magicat can literally see curiosity growing in DT as he leans forward a bit more. "Well, so the princesses too. You must be important people if you're meeting with the Queen and the Princesses."

"You could say that." Adora confirms, nodding cockily before giggling at something no one but her finds funny. She then exuberantly bangs the tabletop with the flat of her hand before giggling and whispering,
"You know, i am actually She-"
With the speed of light, Catra jumps up in alarm, leaping behind Adora and pressing her hand over the blonde's mouth.
"Shivering!" the Magicat finishes the sentence with a glance at the Shapeshifter, who looks up at her in surprise.

Tense, she taps Adora on the shoulder with her free hand to distract. "You are shivering, Adora. I think that's enough drinks for you." Adora, whose mouth is still covered, protests with indignant sounds, but Catra pays no attention to it. She has had enough. And Adora needs sleep now, otherwise she wouldn't get back on her feet tomorrow. Or continue to drink so much, until she finally harms herself. Catra can't allow that.

That's why she bends down and puts one of the blonde's arms over her own shoulder to pull her up. "Come on, Adora. We're going." Adora hangs her head and protests quietly, but does not resist when she is helped up. DT watches the whole thing and leans back. Their face shows tragic regret. "What a pity, darling. It

was so entertaining with you!" Leisurely they stand up and bow to the women. "Well then, it's been a pleasure. If you ever want my services - for a price - you know where to find me. I give a performance here almost every night."

Annoyed, Catra looks to the shapeshifter and nods at him. Adora, on the other hand, raises her head and waves at them with a broad grin. "Byeeee it was soooo nice to meet youuu!" DT giggles before they turn and sit down at another table. Almost relieved, Catra sighs.

Then she looks to Adora, who hangs at her side like a wet sack. "Come on. Can you walk?" Reproachfully, Adora looks at her and taps her on the chest. "What´s that supposed to mean, OF COURSE I can walk!" In confirmation, she puts a foot forward - and buckles. If Catra hadn't been supporting her, she probably would have fallen.
"Okay, maybe I can't walk after all." the blonde gives in and stares at the floor.
"My body is betraying meee!" she whines.

Catra shakes her head and almost smirks. "Alright. Let's do it another way, then. Put your arms around my neck." Adora does as instructed. Catra puts one hand to her back and with the other she reaches under the blonde's legs. She then lifts her up bridal style. Not wanting to have to think about how close Adora is to her now, Catra looks around for the stairs leading up to the guest rooms. Determined, she walks there, trying to attract as little attention as possible.

She remembers the horned Woman's directions and soon finds the room. With Adora in her arms, however, she cannot unlock the door, so she gently sets her companion down. Adora, however, still has her arms wrapped around Catra's neck and relaxes, resting her head against her chest as she leans against the Magicat. She hums to herself as she does so. With one hand the Magicat holds Adora, with the other she opens the door with the key card.

Catra quickly lifts Adora again and carries her into the room. It is not big, a bed, a closet, a small bathroom and a lamp. The Magicat kicks the door shut behind her with her foot and walks to the bed to put Adora in it. The blonde sighs in delight as her back sinks into the soft mattress. She disengages from the Magicat and turns her face into the only pillow. Then she mumbles something unintelligible. To the Magicat it sounds like, "I missed you, soft bed. I promise I won't kill you."

Groaning, Catra leans against the wall and rubs her hand over her face. "What were you thinking, drinking so much! I told you to keep your hands off it. But no, you had to stay stubborn! That's what you've got now. You are almost no longer sane. Do you know how dangerous your condition would be if you were alone? You would be totally vulnerable! Have you even thought about that?"

An incomprehensible whisper comes in response that doesn't sound like Adora is taking her words seriously. Shaking her head, Catra crosses her arms. "If you want to talk to me, Adora, you're going to have to stop making out with that pillow." In response, Adora rolls onto her side and looks indignantly at Catra. "I'm not making out with the pillow! But it's so soooooft. Almost as soft as you." She smiles lazily and reaches out a hand to Catra. "Come here." she demands.

Catra frowns and prods, "Why?"
"Just com'eeeere!" Surrendering, the Magicat follows the request and stands in front of the bed. Undeterred, Adora grabs Catra's hand and pulls her on the mattress. Surprised, Catra squeals. "What are you doing?!" "I need a new pillow!" Adora justifies herself with half-closed eyes. "One that's softer!" Catra groans and rolls her eyes.
One thing is for sure: A drunk Adora is exhausting!

Sullenly, Catra sits down at the head of the bed and leans her back against the wall before looking at Adora, waiting. The blonde gives a happy squeak and clumsily crawls to the right side of the Magicat. As a matter of course, she wraps an arm around Catra's

waist and rests her head on her chest. Surprised by this touch, Catra stiffens at first, but then slowly relaxes again.
It has been a while since Adora touched her so familiarly.
A very long while.

Except for last night, but that was a different situation. Yesterday she was upset, panicked and desperate, and needed consolation.
This time... this time it's simply because of Comfort.
Catra has missed it, she notes.
Hesitantly, she lifts her arm and strokes Adora's back. The blonde's reaction consists of a contented sigh.

"You're making it really hard for me to stay mad at you," Catra murmurs, smirking now after all. "I'm sorry." mumbles Adora ruefully, almost making Catra laugh. Then Adora adds, "Those drinks were so delicious.... and they took away the pain. And I felt so... light. Without worries. That felt nice. I wanted to feel like this... a little longer."
Catra frowns. She hadn't thought of that.
Of course, Adora runs around all the time with the constant pressure to save everything and everyone, to always be perfect, to make no mistakes. Who can blame her for wanting to hide from these things for once? To free herself from these worries?

"I understand that," Catra answers. And she means it. "But it's not a solution." She's not sure if she's talking to herself or the blonde. Quickly she adds, "And if you get a headache tomorrow, I told you so." "Yea yeaaah..." Adora yawns.
For a while they stay like that: Adora snuggling against Catra's chest, while the Magicat strokes her back. It is a strange and at the same time so familiar situation that Catra herself could have fallen asleep on the spot.

Then Adora suddenly murmurs dreamily, "I missed this..."
Puzzled, Catra inquires, although she is convinced that Adora can no longer grasp a clear thought at this point. "What?"
"You."
In the middle of her movement, the Magicat stops and looks frozen at Adora's face against her chest. She looks relaxed,

peaceful. "The first night in Bright Moon," she begins slowly, seeming to find it increasingly difficult to speak. Her tongue seems to be getting tired. "I didn't get any sleep. I cried all night. I missed you so much. And this feeling just wouldn´t fade. No matter how mean you were.... and how many times we fought.... I always missed you."

Taken off guard by this confession, Catra looks at Adora. The blonde has hinted at something like this before, but hearing it now is .... different. She can't ignore the telltale flutter in her heart as she quietly admits,
"I missed you, too." That´s it. It's out. One of the Magicat's best-kept secrets has slipped from her lips like it was nothing.
And yet it was so much.

The blonde turns her face to Catra to see her better and asks in surprise, "Really?" The hope in her voice stirs something in Catra's heart as she nods. She's not sure if her voice would stay firm if she speaks. A glow spreads across the blonde's face. Pure, radiant warm sunshine, Catra thinks in fascination, and again something stirs in her heart at the sight.

Then Adora turns again so that she lies comfortably, and the moment is over. Satisfied, Adora's head moves a little further down to Catra's belly. "Soooo fluffy..." She seems to have already forgotten about the previous conversation as she rubs her cheek against the Magicat's belly with her eyes closed. "You really seem to like it there as a sleeping place...." Catra murmurs with a grin.
"Just make sure you don't drool all over me again."
"Can't promise." The blonde mumbles and sighs happily.
"And don't you dare sleep fighting!"
Adora giggles, but doesn't reply anything.

Instead, her breathing becomes calmer and her muscles relax completely. Just when Catra thinks Adora has fallen asleep, the blonde mumbles sleepily once again, "Y´know...the day you didn't go with me was the worst of my life…"
Catra's heart seems to stop.
She would never have believed to hear such words from Adora,

even in a drunken state. For a moment she stares at the blond back of her head on her stomach, speechless. Tentatively, she reaches for a strand of hair and brushes it behind the sleeping woman's ear as tears well up in her eyes.
"Mine too..." she whispers, certain that Adora can no longer hear her.

Somewhere, far away, in the heart of the Fright Zone, at the same moment, a young woman is searching for a bug in the system that she accidentally installed. With a furrowed brow, she stares at her pad that is analyzing the data for her 65% faster. Shortly after, it makes a 'ping!' sound and displays the error. Relaxed, she types some new data into a keypad before updating the system. Absently, her pink pigtails reach alongside for the small plate of mini-portions her robot Emily brought earlier.

Her eyes are glued excitedly to the screens in front of her as she sees the system begin to run error-free. She enthusiastically mumbles into one of her recording devices, "Day 12 in the attempt to develop software for Project 'Alpha First One.' It's three minutes past midnight. I've just been able to locate and fix the bug in System 4.8, though there don't seem to be any results yet." Concentrating, she sorts through the data racing across the monitor in her head.

"It appears that greater capacity is still needed to adequately measure the sensor activity of the target. Note to self: Prevent possible system overload by developing two more components. This should take about ten hours, assuming my physical endurance is not limited." She takes a quick glance at her watch. "Following the human cycle, I should give my body a rest." she murmurs, almost feeling something like disappointment inside her.

Then she has an idea. "But if I go right ahead, there's about a 42% better chance that the systems will be immediately compatible with the processor and thus need less rework. So I'll choose the latter option." With that, she ends her recording and turns her full concentration to the large screen. Before she can start, however, she is interrupted by a voice. "Entrapta!"

Hordak's loud voice echoes through the lab, and though she wasn't expecting him, Entrapta doesn't even flinch. She's grown accustomed to his loud voice and his reckless appearance. With a broad smile, she turns to her lab partner. "Hordak! You're just in time!" The Horde Lord approaches and regards the princess silently for a moment. Entrapta isn't sure, but she thinks he looks a little tense. "How is the project going?" he wants to know.

The princess holds out the pad for him to analyze the data himself. "We're making progress! There are still some systems missing that I need to reprogram to ensure the necessary stability in execution, but that should take me two days at most. Assuming we don't need energy fields to protect the environment from overload." Hordak listens to his lab partner's words, and his mood brightens a little.

He knew from the beginning that it would be a risky experiment and that appropriate precautions would have to be taken, which would take time. Nevertheless, he seems to be getting more impatient every day. Only Entrapta's optimism keeps him from doing something stupid. And he trusts his lab partner. He knows she's doing her best, and that's enough for him.
Part of him even quietly enjoys the fact that the project can't be done right away. It gives him more time with Entrapta.

Over the past year, she has become more and more important to him, and by now he even considers her a friend. It's a strange feeling that regularly causes a struggle inside him between the desire to simply be with Entrapta and the duty to remain loyal and serve his master, Horde Prime. But right now, he pushes away all gloomy thoughts and smiles contentedly at Entrapta. "Well done. It won't be long now."

The woman with the pink braids grins broadly at him before turning back to her data. Hordak glances at the center of the room, where a sword is placed. Soon, he thinks with satisfaction. ´Soon I can make my master proud. Then I can show him that I am worthy of him.´

His gaze wanders back to Entrapta, and as she types a few notes into her pad, he notices the dark circles under her eyes. She must not have slept for a while. His body itself does not need sleep, but he knows that it is vital for the inhabitants of Etheria to give their bodies extended hours of rest. That's why he puts a hand on the technician's shoulder. "Entrapta, you should rest. You've done a lot today."

The princess tears her gaze away from the pad and looks at him, tired but full of euphoria. "Oh, but I could do so much more! There are so many mysteries still unsolved! If I keep working now, there's less chance I'll miss something!" Hordak hesitates. He understands Entrapta's point of view, but doesn't want her to collapse from exhaustion. "Fine." he finally decides and moves a few steps away.
"But don't take too much longer."
"Why not?" Curious, Entrapta looks at him.

He finds it difficult to formulate his thoughts into words. "I don't want... you to overexert yourself and feel bad." The princess tilts her head.
"Are you... worried about me?" Hordak hesitates before nodding. "I think that expresses it best."
To his surprise, Entrapta smiles again. "That's... very kind of you. I do appreciate it. And I promise to rest soon." She walks over to the sword and points to it. "I just want to find another way to unleash the energy of this technology."

Satisfied with that answer, Hordak nods. He then leaves the room. Entrapta, meanwhile, has turned her attention to the sword. She Ra's sword. Presumably the most precious First Ones technology that still exists on Etheria. Fascinated, she circles the sword, as she has done so many times in recent days. Concentrating, she

squints her eyes and soaks up every visual detail of the weapon. She must have missed something.

She has developed ways to link the sword to her own technology, but she can't activate it. There are no typical triggers. Most likely because the sword is the conjunction of technology and magic. Therefore, the trigger must be either a combination of both, or just magic. Entrapta knows about technology and loves to research the combination of the two components, but she does not have sufficient expertise in the single component of magic.

However, she knows someone who might have that expertise. Without further ado, she leaves the room and heads for the cells.

Not many light sources exist in the prison wing of the Fight Zone. The cells are illuminated only with a dim green light. There are two people in one of them. A young man is leaning against the wall, watching his cellmate as she angrily bangs against the bars again. "This is maddening!" she curses and angrily kicks her leg against the wall. "Glimmer" the young man tries to placate his friend.

"Let it go. You're only hurting yourself." Frustrated, she turns to her friend. "But we have to get out of here somehow!"
"We'll find a way." "Oh, yeah, Bow? You've been saying that for -"
Glimmer stops as she realizes she doesn't even know how long they've been here. It's hard to tell the difference between night and day here.
That's why she groans in annoyance, "- since we've been here!"

"And I will continue to say it. Have a little faith." Reassuringly, Bow reaches out a hand to his friend. As she looks him in the eye, all frustration suddenly falls away from her. She snorts, and lets Bow pull her to his side. Lovingly, he puts an arm around her, and she puts her head back. "It's driving me crazy just sitting here, not being able to do anything."
"I know." Bow strokes her hair, comforting her a little.

If only she had a little magic left! She could easily teleport herself and Bow out! But they have already tried that and failed miserably. Shortly after they were locked up, Glimmer had two jumps left with the last of her magic and teleported out of the cell with Bow. But she didn't know the Fright Zone well enough and therefore couldn't get far enough away with the second jump, so they were quickly caught again and locked up. Bow was stripped of his weapons and since then Glimmer has been stubbornly trying to come up with an escape plan. In vain.

The friends remain sitting like this for a while until they hear someone step in front of their cell. Glimmer feels Bow tense up, then suddenly two pigtails wave at them. "Hey guys! Do you have time to help me with an experiment?" Entrapta smiles happily at the two. "Entrapta!" exclaims Bow in surprise. Glimmer can hear in his voice that he is glad to see the princess well. Despite the fact that she works for the other side, he can't help but worry about her.

Glimmer, on the other hand, is not so thrilled. "What do you want, Entrapta?" If the tech princess notices Glimmer´s bad mood, she doesn't let on. Instead, she begins to explain, "I'm currently researching She Ra's sword, but I can't find a clue on how to bind its energy, which is because I lack expertise in magic. But you must know something about it, right?" She looks expectantly into the cell.

Glimmer crosses her arms defiantly. "No, and even if we did, we wouldn't tell you." Entrapta seems confused. "Why not?" "Because anything Hordak wants to do with that sword is dangerous," Bow explains. The princess tilts her head, still not seeming to understand. "Oh, but Science always is! And I'm in the process of taking safety precautions right now. According to my calculations, with your potential knowledge factored in, the risk of an accident should be reduced to a 27% chance!"

Glimmer hides her face in her hands. The frustration makes itself felt again. "That's not the point! Can't you see that the Horde is hurting Etheria?" "Hurting? But Hordak doesn't want to harm

anyone. He's just trying to fix things."
"What things?" Bow wants to know. "And what's he trying to do with Adora's sword, anyway?"

Entrapta opens his mouth, but then covers it herself. "Hordak has forbidden me to talk to anyone about it." She confesses. "It's all veeeery secret. And complicated. I could try to explain it to you, but apparently not many people understand math." Entrapta seems to stray from the topic, which only makes Glimmer more upset. She snorts in frustration and slaps her hands over her face.

Confused, Entrapta asks, "Are you...mad?" "YES!" Glimmer exclaims, throwing her hands in the air.
"But...why?"
"Because we've been sitting here for I don't know how long, and we don't know what's going to happen to us, and all you care about are your experiments!" Bow puts a hand on Glimmer's shoulder from behind.

Now Entrapta seems not only confused but also.... hurt? "I..." she begins, as if she doesn't know how to formulate her words.
"You sound like you're in a bad way or you have been hurt. But I don't see anything physically wrong with you. I asked Hordak not to hurt you because I thought we were friends.
I'm sorry if I upset you. I'm not good with people. Or with relationships. I don't understand that.
But I understand technology. I haven't made many friends in life, but Hordak, Hordak is one of them. He understands me. He shares my passion for technology, and I can talk to him about other things.
He doesn't get angry when I .... don't understand things.
He has a problem, and I want to help him because that's what friends do. With technology, I can do that. I assumed because we're friends too, you guys could help me with that."

She blinks and looks down at the floor, obviously tears coming. Her voice sounds dull and intimidated.

Glimmer is shocked, speechless. She didn't expect this reaction. No longer so upset, but still disgruntled, she replies, "Friends don't stand on different sides. And they don't try to hurt the other."
"I don´t want to hurt you!" Entrapta contradicts, clutching the pad in her hand. "But to help Hordak, I need the science. And science comes with risks. Risks I have to take."

"Not all risks are worth taking." Bow explains, clearly calmer than Glimmer, but serious.
"Sometimes there's too much at stake."
"What variables do you base that on?" Entrapta wants to know.
"On the well-being of a person." Bow looks her firmly in the eye.
"How do you know what's more important?" Attentively, the tech princess looks at him.

"You trust your gut. Not your mind, but your conscience."
Silence reigns for a moment.
"I'm not good at feelings. I rely on facts and data." Entrapta explains hesitantly and turns away.
"But that's an interesting thesis. I'll think about it." Then she walks away.

Glimmer does not miss the fact that the head of the princess hangs down. She almost has a guilty conscience. She knows that Entrapta has difficulty understanding things that others take for granted. But it must be clear to her that one should never endanger the life of a living being!

"She must understand that no science in the world is worth supporting such horrible things as the Horde!" the princess speaks her thoughts. "Must she really?" retorts Bow, as Glimmer turns to him. "Remember, she said it herself, technology is all she has. It's her way of seeing the world. It's her life. And... as strange as it may sound.... I understand her somewhere. She says she is friends with Hordak and that he understands her. She's just trying to be a good friend."

Shocked, Glimmer looks at her friend. "Are you serious?! Then she should be a good friend to us and let us go!" Anger speaks from

her, anger and frustration at the situation, not at Entrapta herself. Bow looks at her seriously. "I'm not saying I agree with what she's doing. Only that I understand it. And she's done what she could for us. Look at us: We're fine. No one has bothered us since we've been here. Not even Hordak himself. We're alive, and we haven't been hurt. I believe Entrapta when she says she asked Hordak to do this. We should be grateful to her. Especially considering she still considers us friends after we just left her behind."

A resigned sigh escapes the princess, and she once again sinks to the floor beside Bow. "You're right." she murmurs, "As almost always. It's just... This whole situation is getting me so fucked up. I want to do something! I feel so unnecessary! And..." She hesitates.
"Maybe I'm a little scared, too." Two strong arms wrap around her and hold her tight.

"I'm scared, too." Bow confesses and smiles. "But I also have faith in our friends. They'll get us out of here. And then you can kick some serious horde butt, okay?" Doubting, she looks into Bow's confident face. She's afraid of her own thoughts, but she speaks them anyway. "And if... if Adora doesn't make it?"

She is hugged even tighter in response, and she is so grateful to be held in that moment. "You know Adora. The word give up is not in her vocabulary. That woman is so stubborn, she'd run through the horde alone with her stubbornness if needed and get us out of here." The idea of Adora running through the Frightzone, screaming and running down anyone in her way, actually makes Glimmer chuckle. Bow's smile widens.

"See? Have confidence. She´s going to make it. But until she does, there's nothing we can do but conserve our strength, okay?"
"I hate doing nothing." Glimmer grumbles, already in a much better mood. Her friend grins. "I know. Just think of it as a really bad sleepover."
"A really, really bad one." Gimmer corrects, smirking before leaning against Bow.

Gently, he squeezes her hand. "Sleep now." "Fine." She leans a little further against the wall, resting her head on his shoulders and closing her eyes. "And Bow?" "Yeah?" "...Thank you. I'm glad to have you here with me. I wouldn't know what to do without you." "I know. Me too." Slowly, her breaths quieten, and enveloped by Bow's warmth, Glimmer finally drifts slowly into sleep.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey there! This was a really long chapter, and right now i am very busy so i´ll probably take a short break from writing. But i´ll be happy to answer any questions if you have some :)

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all for your patience! Now you deserve some Catradora fluff :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora:

When Adora opens her eyes, she blinks and wrinkles her nose, grumbling. Why is it so bright?! The next moment she notices a hellish headache and moans in agony. Grumbling, she buries her face in the soft sheets beneath her.
Then she pauses. This is not her bed.

She jerks her head up and ignores the throbbing pain in her brain for a moment. Instead, she looks around the strange room. How did she get here? Only slowly does the events of last night come back to her.
They went to the inn. They ate there. Then there was a show, and the shapeshifter showed up. Double Trouble.

They drank this delicious stuff with Adora, laughed with her and talked. This drink numbed their pain and made them forget their worries. The more she drank of it, the lighter she felt. Adora remembers only fragments of the stories that Double Trouble told her. And at some point... She tries hard to remember what happened then.
How did she get from there to that room? Maybe Catra knows. Catra.

Adora straightens up with a jerk. Where is Catra? Fear seizes her. Has the Magicat left her? She remembers that they had a fight last night. Adora snarled at her and behaved impossibly, so Catra would have a reason to just leave. But would she really just leave Adora to her fate? The blonde's throat tightens.
The thought of possibly losing Catra once again is unbearable.

She was about to jump out of bed to look for the Magicat, when at the same moment the door opened and Catra entered the room. Adora's heart is lifted. "Catra!" she croaks in relief, noticing with horror how scratchy her voice sounds. The Magicat closes the door behind her and crosses her arms in front of her chest as she raises an eyebrow. "Slept well?" Her words echo in Adora's head as if through a loudspeaker. Horrified, the blonde raises her ears and squints her eyes. "Can you please keep your voice down!?"

In response, the Magicat tries to hide an amused and clearly triumphant grin. She fails. "Sorry, Princess, but I'm speaking as loudly as ever." As Adora rubs her forehead to ease the pain, Catra walks to her and sits at the foot of the bed. "How do you feel?"

Adora grunts and hides her face in her hands. "In short? Horrible. My head hurts, it's too bright here, and you're too loud! My body feels like I've been run over by one of the horderobots."
"It's the after-effects of the alcohol." Catra explains, this time without the grin. "Huh?" Adora makes uncomprehendingly. "You mean in the drinks yesterday was alcohol?"

Adora has heard of alcohol, but has never had any herself. Now she realizes why Catra didn't touch the cup. And also why the Magicat warned her not to drink so much of it.
At once, Adora is overcome by a guilty conscience.

Catra, meanwhile, reaches into the pouch she carries next to her and holds out a small pink ball, the width of a finger, to Adora. "What's that?" the blonde wants to know curiously. "This will take away your headache. The innkeeper gave it to me. You must put it on your tongue and let it melt." Obediently, Adora takes the ball into her mouth. It tastes like nothing at all, but maybe Adora has just temporarily lost her taste buds.

In any case, it doesn't take long for the ball to dissolve and Adora notices the first changes. Her headache goes away, the throbbing in her head becomes duller, and her eyes don't hurt as much from the brightness. This ball is really good!

"Better?" Catra wants to know, who hasn't moved from the spot. Adora nods enthusiastically. "Much better!" Catra nods. She seems to be absent-minded. "Good, but we'll wait a bit before we go any further. You're no help to anyone until you're fully restored."

Adora wants to protest, but realizes that Catra is right. Besides, it is not far to Bright Moon. They should even arrive today, if everything goes well. And the ball makes her feel better with every minute. That gives the blonde fresh courage, and so for once she sits down relaxed at the head end of the bed and leans with her back against the wall.

She looks at Catra, who is still sitting on the edge at the foot of the bed and now stares into space. Her tail twitches back and forth, she is clearly deep in thought. Adora thinks of something. "Catra?" Her voice sounds uncertain, cautious. The Magicat blinks before lifting her head to look at Adora. "Can you tell me what happened yesterday? I um... I can't remember everything."

She's embarrassed that she can't remember, but it's worse not to know what she said or did at all. Is she mistaken, or is Catra blushing at her words? Her hand clutches the sheet as the Magicat lowers her gaze and murmurs, "You were...pretty out of it. I brought you here. You couldn't walk anymore, so I carried you."

Spongily, Adora begins to remember. Of strong arms holding her tight. A warm crook of a neck into which she pressed her face, and which smelled so good.
Of home.
She remembers Catra tucking her into bed. "Right. And then?" she wants to know. Catra shrugs, her tail twitching treacherously. "You acted like a little kid. Wouldn't sleep, so I had to..." She doesn't finish the sentence, but she doesn't have to, because the memories flood in on Adora as if by themselves.

Catra laid down in bed next to her. The blonde snuggled up to her, just like before. The Magicat stroked her back, and it felt so good. So safe. Adora knew that nothing could happen to her with Catra.

A shiver runs down her spine.
"And...we talked, right?" she pauses, her face contorting into a grimace to help her remember.

Catra doesn't reply anything, but nods. She stares off into the distance and absently wraps her arms around herself, as if she needs to protect herself from something. Her tail curls around her own body as well. The blonde does not miss this reaction. "Catra? What's wrong?"
"Nothing." the Magicat mumbles, avoiding eye contact. It's clearly a lie.

Resolutely, Adora detaches herself from the wall and slides a bit towards Catra, touching her gently on the shoulder. "Catra, please talk to me." A guess comes to her as to why Catra is acting so strangely. Instantly she feels nauseous as she asks uncertainly, "Is it because of last night? Did I say something that hurt you? If so, then -"

The blonde breaks off as Catra turns her head to look at her. The vulnerability in her gaze takes her breath away. "Yesterday you said that you.... you missed me," Catra whispers in a strained voice. "And that the day you left.... That it was the worst day of your life. Did you..." She swallows, as if afraid of her own question. "Did you really mean it?"

Adora is caught off guard by this question. Did she really confide that to Catra? The Magicat looks at her so uncertainly that the blonde decides to think about it later. Determined, Adora looks Catra in the eye and brushes a strand of hair from her face. Without the mask, the strands fall much more easily into her forehead, and Adora loves this sight. Catra shivers under the touch, but doesn't pull her face back.

"It's the truth, Catra. I never wanted to leave you. The day I had to was the worst day of my life." Hesitantly, she brushes another strand of hair from the Magicat's face and watches as Catra closes her eyes.
Whether she enjoys the touch or can no longer stand the eye

contact, Adora cannot say.
Maybe a little of both.

Quietly, but insistently, she continues: "For quite a while afterwards, I still hoped you would follow me. That I would wake up at night and you would lie next to me, just like before. That we would be together again. That's what I always wanted."
"I thought you hated me." Catra whispers in a broken voice, unconsciously leaning against the blonde's hand.

Adora's heart grows heavy when she hears this.
"I never hated you, Catra. I was angry with you, and sad, but I never hated you." Then the Magicat opens her eyes and a few tears run down her cheeks. The sight breaks Adora's heart. As gently as she can, she runs her thumb over Catra's cheek and wipes away the tears. Catra presses herself against the palm of her hand as if trying to draw strength from it.

Then she pulls her face away with a jerk.
"Why don't you hate me? I would deserve it. I've hurt you and so many other people. I was so angry that you left me that I was willing to do everything to make you regret it. For so long I... I just wanted to hurt you. For you to feel miserable and bad. I wanted you to see that you made a mistake!" she praises and hides her face in her hands.

"I just wanted you to... to miss me."
Now it's just a whisper that escapes her, but Adora hears it clearly as Catra confesses,
"I wanted you to come back to me."

The words hit her like an arrow to the heart, and now tears come to her eyes as well. Gently, Adora raises her arms and pulls Catra's hands from her face before taking it in her own.
"I've never regretted leaving the Horde," Adora admits, watching Catra wince. That's why she adds softly and absolutely seriously, "But I regret leaving you behind, every single day."

She feels a shiver run through the Magicat's body as she stares at her, caught off guard. Then a few more tears flow as she looks at the blonde ruefully.
"Adora, I... I am so sorry. For everything."

Silence.

Adora is now the one who is caught off guard. Speechless, she looks at Catra.
Catra has never apologized before. Not to anyone. As a child, she swore she would never say those words.
And yet she does so now. For Adora.
Because she is truly sorry.
Because Adora is important to her.
Because she has changed, just as the blonde has changed.

Hot tears run down her cheek as Adora smiles. "I'm so sorry too, Catra. Do you forgive me?" A sob escapes the Magicat as she nods. The joy, relief, and hope in her eyes mirror the feelings in Adora.
"Of course, you dummy."
And when Catra embraces her, it's as if finally all the walls and distances of the last years have been overcome.

Full of joy and with her face wet with tears, Adora hugs the Magicat and holds her tight, never wanting to let her go. She has her best friend back!
For this one moment, there are only the two of them in the world. No war, no quarrel, no danger, no worries, just two friends who have finally reconciled and found each other again after years.

In all her time in Bright Moon, Adora has never felt so happy as she does at this moment.

Catra:

The Magicat has rarely felt as good as she did in the hours after they left the inn and continued traveling to Bright Moon. She and

Adora don't speak much to each other, but both have smiles on their faces the entire time. Catra can't believe it: she has apologized to Adora. And meant it, too. And Adora has forgiven her.

Absently, the Magicat puts a hand on her chest to feel her beating heart. Is this really happening? Are she and Adora really on the same page again? Can they once again become the inseparable team they once were?

No, Catra realizes, and shakes her head. She's not naive enough to think that an apology will do the trick. Or that two years of pain can just be forgotten. She knows she can't go back to the way things were then. Adora is changed. She herself is changed. And yet she feels something in her heart that she has not allowed for so long, for fear it could destroy her forever: Hope.

Hope that not all is lost. That she and Adora can build a new bond. A new friendship. A new beginning. To them doing better this time. Catra hesitates inwardly and looks to Adora, who is staring down the road, lost in her own thoughts. As happy as she is about the reconciliation, she is still afraid. Afraid of being dropped again. Afraid of letting hope grow in her heart and dreaming of something she is not worthy of achieving.

At that moment, Adora turns her head to her and smiles. It is a smile full of joy, relaxation and... and the same hope that Catra feels.
It's a smile that Catra hasn't seen on the blonde for a long time. Determined, she swallows her doubts, at least for the moment, and smiles back. Whatever it is that prevails between the two now; she wants to enjoy it, at least for this one, peaceful moment.

As she walks, Adora's hand brushes the Magicat's fingers as if by chance. It doesn't take long before she finally reaches out tentatively and intertwines Catra's fingers with hers. Out of a reflex she has had since childhood, the Magicat squeezes the

blonde's hand lightly and smiles as well before the two continue their journey together.

Sometime around noon they reach the Whispering Woods, and Adora almost sighs with joy. "Now it's not far to Bright Moon!" she exclaims and runs into the woods with renewed energy. Not letting go of Catra's hand, the Magicat stumbles after her in surprise. She laughs. "Adora, you don't have to run all the way to the castle! You're acting like a little kid!"
"I'm not!" protests Adora, leaning her head back at the same moment to stick her tongue out at Catra. Then she lets go of the Magicat's hand and sprints forward. "Whoever makes it through the forest last has to eat Ration Bars for a week!"

"Not fair!" exclaims Catra, with a big grin on her face, before following Agora into the forest. Her ambition is aroused as she picks up speed with a few graceful sentences. A goal-loving tingle runs through her fingers as she extends her claws a little further to find better footing on the ground. The smile on her face grows even wider as she catches sight of the blonde mop of hair in front of her, getting closer and closer until she effortlessly overtakes Adora.

"Still the world's slowest person!" she laughs over her shoulder at her before sprinting deeper into the forest on all fours. She doesn't know her way around here, but she knows which direction to run. Adora's indignant protests behind her only spur her on, and she feels something coursing through her body.
A foreign sensation. Or rather, one that she hasn't felt in a very long time.

She's run through Crimson Waste so many times. Even in the horde. She always used her speed, always pushed it to its limits. For tasks, or just to clear her head.
But this time, something is different.
She runs, but she doesn't run AWAY.
Not anymore.

For the first time, running seems to be having the effect she was hoping for: the feeling of freedom is rising inside her. Of lightness. As she gets over some bushes on all fours and hears Adora laughing behind her, Catra wonders: is this what happiness feels like?

Before she has time to think about it, something suddenly grabs her by the feet. Stumbling, the Magicat falls to the ground, and before she can get up, someone jumps on top of her. Someone with long blond hair and a triumphant laugh. "Ha! Got'ya!" Adora laughs above her, propping herself up on the ground with one hand. Outraged, the Magicat shakes herself and pushes Adora off of her. "That was cheating!" she indignantly shouts, crossing her arms as she stands up.

Adora only laughs harder. "Duh! How else am I supposed to keep up with you? You've always been faster than me since we were kids!" Rolling her eyes, Catra walks over to Adora, who is still sitting on the ground, but she doesn't hide her grin as she kneels down to her. "Well, you were just always slow."

She holds out a hand to Adora, and the blonde lets her help her up. As she stands, her dorky grin disappears briefly and she screws up her face as her arm jerks to her hip. Catra doesn't miss it. She becomes serious for a moment. Glancing at the hidden wound, she asks, "Are you okay?" Adora nods. "I'm fine. I just need to remember that I can't be so thoughtless about everything."

Then her serious look disappears and that playful grin spreads on her face again.
"Why, are you worried about me? Do you liiiiiike me?"
"Shut up!" Catra murmurs , nodding lightly at her uninjured side. As she does so, she looks down at the floor. 'Of course I like you, Adora,' she thinks.'Can't you see it?'

Again the Magicat crosses her arms and looks at Adora searchingly. "What's gotten into you? You behave like the little child back in the Horde." Adora shrugs as she places a hand on

the back of her neck. "I don't know. I guess I just...found new courage. New hope, thanks to you, Catra."

The look Adora gives her is so insistent that Catra can't withstand it. So she looks away and replies, "Now don't get sappy on me. Come on, we still have to make it to Bright Moon. And this time, NOT through an unfair race."
"For you or for me?" Catra gives her a smirking sideways glance.

Adora grumbles. "All right, but it was fun!" "It was." admits Catra, thinking of all the racing they did in the Horde, before adding with a smirk: "Shadow Weaver would have taken that to the ceiling sooner!"
She can't help but chuckle at this thought. Oh, it would have been so much fun to see that woman's angry face! Although the punishment for that wouldn't have been so funny. But Adora's laughter had been worth every single time.

At the mention of Shadow Weaver's name, Adora stops. When Catra also stops and looks back at the blonde, the mischief is gone from her eyes. "Adora?" irritated, Catra walks towards the woman who looks frozen. The blonde suddenly seems to feel anything but at ease. "Catra," she begins, fiddling with her belt. "I have something to tell you before we get to Bright Moon."

She is nervous, perhaps worried, the Magicat recognizes in confusion. "Okay? "she replies tentatively, trying to ignore the knot in her stomach. Adora scratches her head. "It's about Shadow Weaver..." Catra doesn't want to, but out of instinct her fur bristles and her ears perk up. "Spit it out already, princess." Catra demands, sounding annoyed to hide how nervous she is.

Adora fiddles with her clothes for a while longer before finally exhaling and looking Catra straight in the eye. There is concern in them.
"Shadow Weaver lives in Bright Moon."

Catra would not have thought it possible, but for a moment the earth was silent.

Then she perceives a single sound:
CLASH!
That's what it sounds like when the bars of a cell slam shut.
Her cell.
In an instant, all the good feelings, all the security she felt seconds ago seem to be robbed from her.

Catra's ears begin to ring. No, she thinks. This can't be happening. It MUST not be.
Shadow Weaver must not be allowed to live in Bright Moon. Because that would mean… that she betrayed her. Again. That the Magicat was abandoned in a much crueler way than she thought.

"Catra?" Adora asks cautiously. There is not only concern in her gaze, but guilt.
Adora. She has known. All along. She's known, and yet she hasn't said a word.

Catra is overwhelmed. Doesn't know what to feel, what to think. It's like her world is collapsing.

"Catra..." Adora repeats, wanting to take a step towards the Magicat, but Catra backs away, her eyes widened in shock. The guilt and helplessness in Adora's eyes are too much. "Catra, please..." Adora's voice is occupied, she sounds hurt, but Catra can't focus on it.

She takes another step back following her instincts. "I..." she begins to stammer breathlessly. "I have to get out of here." "No, Catra, please -" Adora wants to stop her, but Catra can't hear it anymore.

The roaring in her ears is too loud. Quick as lightning, she turns and disappears between two thick bushes. Then she runs deeper into the forest.
"Catraaaa!"

She runs away.

Chapter End Notes

Ooops. Did I say fluff? Sorry… I´m a sadist.

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

WARNING
This chapter contains the beginning of a panic attack.

Catra:

Hot tears stream down her face, clouding her vision, but Catra doesn't care. She doesn't care where she runs. She just wants to get away. Away from everything. Away from Adora. Away from herself. She doesn't know how long she has been running through the forest, but when she trips over a root on the ground and falls down, she doesn't get up again.
She can't. She has no strength.

Her body shakes as she curls up into a ball on the dirty ground and squints her eyes. Adora's words ring in her ears again, circling in her head like a dark mantra that saps her strength.
Shadow Weaver is in Bright Moon.
She didn't just flee the Horde. She left purposefully. If Shadow Weaver had simply walked out of her life, the Magicat would have been hurt, but not like this. Not in that way. Not like this betrayal.

Catra doesn't want to believe it. At the same time, she feels betrayed by herself. She should have suspected it. Shadow Weaver has left her. For Adora.
Because Catra is not worth staying.
Doubts grip her. If Shadow Weaver hasn't changed, why should things be any different with Adora?
Why shouldn't Adora leave her too, as she did once before?

Catra clenches her fists as her heart tightens at this thought. Her doubts overtake her and stifle the spark of hope in her body.
She can trust no one. She will only get hurt, again and again.

How did she think she could feel hope? That her life could one day take a positive course? That once, just once, she could be happy?

She was wrong. She doesn't deserve any better. It's as if Shadow Weaver is regaining her power over Catra, from which she has tried so desperately to free herself over the past year. Why does it hurt her so much that this bad woman left her? Why, after all Shadow Weaver has done to her, does she still desire her affection and approval?
Because she is weak, Catra bitterly realizes.

The Magicat is not enough. Not even for the woman she hates so much, and from whom she always wanted nothing but a sign of recognition, affection. A real one, not a manipulation.
Catra hates herself for it.
Hates herself for placing value on this woman's thoughts.
Hates herself that this realization hits her so hard.
Hates herself because she can never be enough.
Hates herself because she feels the familiar fear rising in her again.

The fear of being alone. Of being betrayed and abandoned by everyone. And to have deserved it. Because she is not lovable. She never was. What was she thinking, to be able to feel hope? A whimper escapes the trembling Magicat, and she presses her face into her knees in despair.

Her thoughts begin to circle, holding her, not letting her go. Her body stiffens as her eyes turn to cold panic and her throat rises. She sees the shadow woman's face before her, hears all the insults in her head, feels every injury this woman has ever inflicted on her, and every gentle gesture dripping with manipulation and lies.

Her breathing becomes shallower, more irregular. Catra gasps, but she cannot move. Not again, she thinks in panic, wanting to get away, out of her horrible body. But she can't. She is stuck, curled

up on the damp ground, somewhere alone in the forest. A pitiful whimper escapes her, a silent plea for help.

Then she hears bushes being pushed aside. The voices in her head are loud, but suddenly she hears another voice. One that does not come from her head.
"Catra? What are you doing here?"
Blinking, she opens her eyes; it's all she's capable of. Her vision is only blurry, she can barely make out more than a silhouette.

This silhouette kneels down to her, hears her soft whimpering. Then a hand touches her on the shoulder. The body of the Magicat flinches.
"There there, shhh, it's okay, dearie. Breathe." The voice sounds old, a little scratchy, but not unpleasant. The hand moves to her head and strokes her hair in quiet, steady strokes.

The touch has a calming effect on Catra. The voices in her head become quieter, her muscles begin to relax, and her lungs expand again.
"Don´t be scared." the voice continues. As Catra blinks and her vision sharpens again, she recognizes an old woman kneeling in front of her. She has long white hair and huge eyes that look at her kindly.

Catra should be startled. She has never seen this woman before, and yet she is not afraid. In fact, she notices how the panic slowly leaves her and recedes, until all that remains of Catra's seizure are the wet tears on her cheek and a few sobs.

The woman seems to notice that the Magicat is getting better. She pulls her hand from Catra's head and holds it out to her instead. Uncertainly, the young woman stares at it for a moment before grabbing it and letting it help her sit up until she is leaning against a tree trunk.

The woman sits down next to her. Catra now has more time to observe her and notices that the woman is holding a staff in her hand. And are those butterflies flying around her? Meanwhile, the

big eyes scrutinize her worriedly. "What are you doing alone in the forest, Catra?"

The Magicat blinks and frowns. "You know my name. Do I know you?" Now the woman looks confused. Then she laughs heartily. "Of course I know your name. Silly question. Now, where is Mara, dearie? Did you two fight?" Mara? Gradually Catra begins to doubt the state of mind of the woman.

"Who is Mara?"
"Eh?"
The woman has turned away and lowered her head to one of the bushes. It almost seems as if she is listening to the plant. Only then does she raise her head and turn her attention back to the Magicat. "I didn't say Mara, I said Adora! Where is the child anyway?"

Even more confused than before, Catra forgets her pain for a moment. "Adora? You know Adora?" The woman waves it off as if Catra is just asking silly questions.
"Of course I know Adora! So, dearie, where is she? And why aren't you with her?" Catra is too overwhelmed to answer.
How is it that an old, strange, probably slightly confused woman knows Adora and her?

"Who are you?" Catra wants to know, but the woman doesn't seem to hear her. Instead, she suddenly shouts at a tree. "I have my glasses on, so don't yell at me like that!" Then she pauses in silence for a few moments before her gaze becomes concerned and she looks back at Catra.
"Oh, I see. You two fought, didn't you?" „How -“ Catra wants to know, more confused with every second.

The old lady points to the tree she yelled at earlier. "The Woods told me. They are always whispering." The Magicat doesn't know whether to find this woman quirky or creepy. But strange as it is, inside she feels that this person is not a threat to her. Meanwhile, the woman sits down next to Catra again, her eyes watching her almost lovingly. "Now tell me, dearie, why did you two fight?"

"I...we didn't fight." Catra gulps as she thinks of how she fled from Adora. She doesn't know how to feel. It's not Adora's fault that Shadow Weaver betrayed her, and yet she can't help but feel betrayed by the blonde. And she just couldn't stand her presence at that moment. Not with everything that's going on inside her right now.

"It's just" Catra begins hesitantly, not sure why she should pour her heart out to the old woman. But at least she seems to know her, and she just helped her. The Magicat sighs and draws her knees to her chest again.
"Why am I never good enough?" she wants to know quietly. She doesn't expect an answer, and yet her heart has been begging for an explanation for years.

"Everyone leaves me, Why can't I be happy? Why am I not worthy of being valued? Why am I not worth... To be loved?" Tears almost come to her eyes again. Then a wrinkled hand rests on her knee and the Magicat flinches. Except for Adora, she is sensitive to touch.

"You know," the old woman begins, looking into the distance. "A long time ago there was a saying. 'You're only worth as much as you can gather berries.' Wait, no, that was the beginning of a recipe. How did that go again.... ´The tree bears only so many leaves until it looks beautiful`. No, that wasn't it either."

The woman shakes herself, as she does so the butterflies around her scatter and re-sort themselves. And as the old woman continues to puzzle and try to remember, Catra can't help but smile. The woman's manner somehow cheers her up.
"What's your name, anyway?" the Magicat wants to know, interrupting the woman's thoughts. The old lady looks at her uncomprehendingly again.

Then she suddenly hits Catra on the head with her staff.
"Ouch!" the Magicat exclaims, startled, and grabs her forehead, although it didn't really hurt. Stunned, she looks at the woman.

The old lady is completely unimpressed. "How can you forget old Razz, silly?! You memory is almost worse than mine!"

Then suddenly her eyes get even bigger, as if realizing something. "Ohhh, is this the first time? Oh dearie, I'm sorry. Sometimes I get a bit confused." "I didn't even notice." Catra murmurs as she rubs her forehead. But she's not really mad. Razz, meanwhile, seems to regain her composure as she slides a little closer.

"If it's the first time, then you don't know yet, right?" "Know what?" Catra has never been so confused in her life, and it annoys her that she seems to keep losing the thread of this conversation, when she's actually the one with the clear mind here.
But Razz continues undeterred. "Listen, dearie: You worry too much. The only one who should love you but doesn't, is you."

This sentence catches Catra completely off guard.
"What?"
"How can anyone appreciate you if you don't yourself? The first and only person you need to show that you can be strong, smart, lovable, and caring is you. Stop thinking of yourself as a burden."

A hand touches Catra's cheek. She jerks back. It reminds her too much of Shadow Weaver. Of feigned emotion. Of lies. Razz's touch feels different. More real. Comforting.
Almost like...like Adora's touches. Razz looks at her with her big eyes, really looks at her.

Her gaze is clear and she smiles. "You're scared, dearie. I understand that. It's scary to admit feelings. To trust. It makes us vulnerable. But it doesn't make us weak." Smiling, her hand wanders further, stroking Catra's head. "Get over your fear. You will see: It's worth it."

Breathless, Catra stares into the eyes of the strange woman. Her words touch something inside her.

Then she hears bushes being pushed aside again and flinches. "Catra? Catra! There you are! I was so worried about you!“

Adora sounds incredibly relieved when she appears a few feet away from the two women. Razz's clear gaze seems to dim, and as she turns away from Catra, she beams at Adora as if nothing had happened. "Mara, dearie!"

As if it were a matter of course, she rises and walks towards Adora before embracing the blonde. . Adora looks at her in surprise. "Razz, what are you doing here?" She doesn't seem to care about the answer, because the next moment she hugs Razz back, smiling. Catra is confused. So Adora actually knows the old woman. And well, it seems. "And I'm not Mara, I'm Adora, remember?" she asks almost affectionately as the blonde breaks away from the hug.

Razz waves her hand. "Yes, yes, of course I remember. Tell me, dearie, did you bring Finn with you?" The old woman looks around searchingly, as if expecting someone else to appear. Adora, too, looks confused. "Who?" Razz frowns before she seems to think of something. "Oh right, nevermind."

Adora blinks a few times before turning her attention to Catra, who is still sitting on the ground. The worry in her eyes returns as she approaches her. Catra doesn't dare look at her, so she lowers her gaze. "Are you all right? Are you okay?" Adora asks cautiously, kneeling down next to Catra with some distance to give her space in case she needs some.

Although her look betrays that she would like to take Catra in her arms. Uncertainly Catra lifts her head and looks at Adora, really looks at her. She is sitting here, in front of Catra. She has followed her, has not left her alone. And the concern in her eyes is real. Razz's words echo in the Magicat's head, along with her doubts, rekindled in the last half hour.

But Adora is not like Shadow Weaver.
She's always been bad at lying because she wears her heart on her sleeve. When Adora says something, she means it. Catra shouldn't compare her to the woman she was raised by. And it's

not just the Magicat who was hurt by Shadow Weaver. The blonde has also carried scars from her childhood.

And now she's here. With Catra. That's all that matters.

"No." the Magicat answers Adora's question honestly, because she wasn't okay. In order not to worry Adora unnecessarily, she gives her a hesitant smile. "But I WILL be fine." It seems that the blonde has been holding her breath all this time and only now is she exhaling.

Then she says, "I'm so sorry, Catra. I should have told you much sooner, but so much happened and I didn't think about it and -" "It's okay, Adora." the Magicat interrupts, taking a deep breath before looking her in the eye. She's telling the truth.

She's not comfortable with the thought that Shadow Weaver is in Bright Moon and she's going to have to face her. But she doesn't blame Adora for that.
Not anymore. That time is over.
And Razz's words have touched something inside her. Something that could possibly reignite that spark of hope. And Adora's relieved look adds to it.

She sees something else in the blonde's look. That's why Catra rolls her eyes and flattens her knees before murmuring, "Come on, do it already, princess." Adora isn't even surprised that the Magicat is reading her like an open book, but just beams as she slips out a bit more on Catra and wraps her arms around her.

And because it's an instinct the Magicat has had since she was a child, she presses herself against her friend as well. In doing so, she enjoys the liberating feeling that spreads through her and displaces even the last dark thoughts.
´Friend´. Just one little word, that means the world to Catra.

It's her who eventually breaks free of the embrace and murmurs, "We still have further to go, remember, Princess?" Adora nods and helps Catra to her feet. Looking around, the Magicat asks

confused, "Where did that Razz go now?" To her surprise, Adora begins to laugh.

"Ohh, Razz appears and disappears as she pleases. That's just the way she is. Don't worry, she'll be fine on her own." Then she takes Catra's hand in hers and smiles. "Come on. Let's go." So the two continue their journey through the Whispering Woods. On the way, Adora tells Catra the story of how she met Razz.

Adora:

It is not long before they leave the forest and finally - finally! - catch a glimpse of Bright Moon. Adora could howl with joy. Now they can finally start rescuing Glimmer and Bow. 'Hang in there you two,' she whispers in her mind. 'We're coming. I'll save you! 'Together they run to the castle, and as they stand before the gates, Adora is about to enter when Catra holds her back.

"What?" she wants to know. The Magicat looks around, her ears twitching. „Something is not right here. I think we're being watched." At the same moment, something lunges at the two women from the side, slinging the Magicat a few feet away and knocking her to the ground.

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora:

At first Adora is frozen with surprise, then she quickly scans the surroundings for danger, but all she finds are four familiar people who have surrounded her. Her heart makes a relieved leap when she looks into the faces of Perfuma, Spinnerella, Netossa and Mermista. "Guys!" she exclaims in relief, until she sees the alarmed expressions of her friends.

"Adora! Are you alright? Are you hurt?" Perfuma asks worriedly. The others look at something behind Adora. Confused, she turns around. "What-" she begins, before spotting Frosta behind her, which has knocked Catra to the ground and locked her up to her shoulders in a block of ice.

Her expression is ready to fight as she raises her fists and warns Catra, "Stay away from our friend, or I will-"
"Frosta, wait!"
Adora quickly sprints between the young princess and the Magicat, who is perplexed and furiously trying to wriggle out of the ice block. Furious, she hisses at Frosta.

Hastily, the blonde explains, "It's a long story, but Catra is with us now. She is not the enemy, okay? So please free her." Frowning, Frost first looks at Adora, then to the other princesses for help. They seem puzzled. "Is this a bad joke?" Mermista wants to know, crossing her arms. Netossa and Perfuma also look confused.

Spinnerella asks hesitantly, "Are you sure this is a good idea? That's Catra we are talking about!" "Yes, I'm sure. Frost, would you please free her now?" The young princess is currently engaged in an eye duel with the prisoner, and seems to either take no notice of Adora or not want to give in.

"Frosta!"
"All right!" she grumbles, waving her hand.

Instantly, the ice around Catra disappears and the Magicat indignantly shakes a few last shards of ice from her fur. Relieved, Adora kneels down beside her and extends a hand to help her up. The others eatch in confusion. It must be a strange sight for them to see two women, who were always at each other's throats before, now being so familiar and peaceful with each other.
As if there had never been any bad blood between them.

Afterwards, they stand there for a moment without anyone moving. Adora can feel the uncertainty, the curiosity, and the confusion. Perfuma is the first to break free from her rigidity. She takes a few steps towards Adora and warmly embraces her. "We're so glad you're back!"

Adora also puts her arms around the flower princess and smiles. "Me too. You wouldn't believe how much I missed you!" Now the others also snap out of their confusion and give Adora a group hug. "You sure kept us waiting." Netossa asserts with a smile.

Adora shrugs and grabs the back of her neck. "Well I didn't do very well on my own. But I had help on the way back." Smiling, she turns her head to Catra, who stands a little apart, looking uncomfortable. Mermista looks to Catra as well. "This" - she points to the Magicat - "You'll have to explain."
Adora nods. "I will."

"So, have you been able to get reinforcements from the Crimson Waste? Or is ... um... that it?" Perfuma asks, looking apologetically at Catra.
"No offense."
"Sure." The Magicat snorts and rolls her eyes arrogantly as she crosses her arms in front of her chest. However, Adora thinks she sees uncertainty in her posture.

She quickly replies, "It's best if I explain everything to you right now, but maybe we should hold Queen Angela to it first. And go

into the castle. Agreed?" The others nod. Then Spinnerella's gaze lingers on Adora's hip. "Adora, is that blood on your waist?!" she asks in alarm.
Immediately, all eyes move to her hip.

Appeasingly, the blonde raises her arms. "It's nothing bad, I promise. I'll tell you about that, too. But first: inside? Please?" The princesses seem to see that the long journey has taken its toll on their friend, so they put aside their questions and move inside the castle.

Adora looks back and holds out a hand to Catra, giving her an encouraging smile. Hesitantly, the Magicat follows the princesses and takes Adora's hand. Her tail twitches nervously back and forth, but the blonde doesn't comment on it. Of course, Catra doesn't immediately feel at ease, surrounded by all these new people she originally fought against, and who now clearly distrust her.

But Adora hopes that this would quickly subside. For Catra, for her friends and for Glimmer and Bow. If they want to save their friends, there can be no tension between them. That's why the blonde hopes that she would be able to get that out of the way quickly.

Together, the women make their way until they reach the large meeting hall. Inside there are three figures: Sea Hawk, Queen Angella and -
"Swift Wind!" Adora exclaims joyfully, releasing Catra's hand to run toward her noble Steed and embrace him. The alicorn neighs delightedly.

"Adora! You are back! I missed you so much!" "Me too!" She presses herself tightly against his neck, feeling the warm wings close around her. Then Sea Hawk hugs her from behind. "Adora! I'm glad you're back safe! You must tell me all about your adventures!" "I will!" promises Adora with a laugh. She is so happy to have her friends around again.

As the boys break away from her, Queen Angella steps in front of her with a warm smile. "It's good to see you back safe and sound, Adora." she greets the blonde in a soft voice before pulling her into a tender embrace. This comes as a surprise, but in the next moment Adora returns the embrace warmly. Angella is the closest thing she has ever had to a mother figure. A real one.

That's why it's hard to bear her hopeful look when the queen pulls away. "I hope your journey was successful." Then her eyes fall on Catra, who has been keeping to the background, and her expression changes to puzzled. "And who are you?" Right, the queen and Catra have never faced each other in person before.

"This," Adora explains hesitantly. "Is Catra." The queen raises her eyebrows and opens and closes her mouth before seeming to compose herself. "You must have some things to report." she states afterwards, and the blonde nods. The others have already sat down at the large round table and Adora and Angella now take their seats as well.

Since Glimmer and Bow are missing, Sea Hawk and Catra can also sit down. The latter hesitates, however, when Adora gives her an encouraging look and tells her to sit down next to her. Only reluctantly does she follow the request, perhaps in the hope that then all eyes would no longer be on her.

Angella, meanwhile, gives Adora an apologetic look. "I know you and your... company, you must be exhausted, but I hope you understand that-" Adora just nods. "I know." Of course she understands. It's about her best friends. And for the Queen, it's about her only child.
So sleep and rest can wait.

That's why she begins to report. As succinctly as possible, Adora tells that Catra is the leader of Crimson Waste, thus no longer working for the Horde, and has agreed to help in the fight against Hordak. But also that no one else will come.

"Why not?" Mermista asks uncomprehendingly, casting a reproachful glance at Catra.
"After all, if she's supposed to be their leader, she could send a whole army!"

Catra hasn't said a single word all this time, but now she crosses her arms and looks challengingly at the sea princess.
"SHE will not risk the lives of people who have nothing to do with this battle. Besides, the Crimson Waste doesn't work that way."
"She has a point."

All eyes dart to the front door, where a new person has just entered the room.
Huntara leans serenely against the wall and crosses her arms as she looks around the room. Surprised, but with a joyful smile, Adora stands up and walks toward her. "Huntara! What are you doing here?"

Huntara smiles too, though hers looks more like a dangerous grin. "Perfuma thought it would be a good time to bring me in to support you. I understand you're going to defeat the Horde? Maybe you could use another strong arm or two." To emphasize the point, Huntara raises her arm and tenses it to demonstrate her muscle mass. Adora looks just a moment too long before beaming at her friend. "We're grateful for any help we can get!"

Together they walk back to the table, where the other princesses greet them as well. Huntara went with Adora, Glimmer, and Bow to Bright Moon back then, determined to help in the war against the Horde. Since then, she has lived in a village near Bright Moon and taught some troops useful hand-to-hand combat techniques.

Adora is honestly glad to see her again now. The blonde takes a seat in her chair again and Huntara stands to her right. Adora quickly glances to her left, where Catra is still sitting tensely, eyeing Huntara suspiciously. Therefore Adora, addressing the Magicat, explains: "This is Huntara. She's from Crimson Waste and was...uhm...the leader there for a while."

She is kind of uncomfortable explaining what Huntara's place is in this story. She feels as if she might offend Catra by doing so. Apparently she is not wrong, because the Magicat's suspicious look does not disappear. Therefore, Adora turns to Huntara and explains: "Huntara, this is Catra. She was the leader of the Crimson Waste over the last year, and now she's here to help us."

Huntara crosses her arms and eyes Catra curiously, almost as if she were an insect. "So, you are the strongest of the Crimson Waste, yes?" The skeptical, almost amused tone doesn't escape Catra, so she hisses back, "Why? You got a problem with that?!" Huntara doesn't seem impressed in the least, only muttering, "I'm just surprised at how lightly that spot seems to be given out these days. In my day, you had to EARN it."

A ghastly squeak sounds as Catra's claws travel across the table and she stands up to speak at eye level with Huntara.
"I HAVE earned this title. I fought for it."

Huntara snorts snidely. "Oh yeah, against who, Tung Lashor? He's already tripping over his own feet, there's no art to bringing him down." No one seems to notice, but Adora sees Catra's fist begin to tremble. "Oh yeah?" she mutters snidely. "At least he fought. YOU, on the other hand, just took off, I hear." Adora senses the tension on both sides and quickly places herself between the two.

"Okay, that's enough! We don't have time for petty wars, understand? We're on the same side, so act like it!" They both cast each other withering glances for a moment before Huntara exhales and turns to face the blonde.

"Alright. Just for you, Adora." For some reason Catra seems to tense up even more at these words, but she says nothing but sits back down in her chair.

Adora also sits down, clearly relieved, and looks to Huntara, who now clears her throat and addresses the rest of those present. "To return to the original topic: As much as I hate to admit it, but the cat is right." Adora realizes that Huntara is deliberately trying to

provoke Catra, so she carefully places a hand on her friend's arm before looking to Huntara and correcting her,
"Magicat. She is a Magicat. And she has a name."

Adora likes Huntara, but she doesn't tolerate her friends putting each other down. Especially not when Catra is already having a hard time. Adora's words and her touch seem to help the Magicat not burst at any moment. She says nothing, but she gives Adora a quick, grateful look.

Huntara just shrugs her shoulders. "Whatever. Anyway, you can't mobilize the inhabitants of Crimson Waste. Even the strongest can't. The inhabitants still have their own minds, their own motives. Even if they were ordered to join in this war, they wouldn't be loyal because it's not their fight. They would give up at the first opportunity. That's why there has to be another plan."

Frosta sighs in exasperation and sinks deeper into her chair. "So no army."
Concerned, Perfuma looks around. "But what should we do then?"
Adora shrugs, but her mind is made up. "We'll go back to the original plan: we'll head out to the Horde on our own."

"Great plan." murmurs Mermista.
"It's never failed before, after all."
"We'll fix it. We´ll make the plan better until ´s perfect." Adora assures her and herself.
"But Adora, how are we going to do it?" interjects Queen Angella, who has so far only listened silently.

Her voice is calm and her expression controlled. But she can't keep the worry out of her eyes as she adds," Without my daughter and Bow, we have two warriors less. And you can't use She Ra. We are more vulnerable than ever. How are you going to compensate for that?"

The mention of She Ra feels like daggers being rammed into her stomach. Angella's question is non-judgmental, non-accusatory, and yet Adora can't help but be overcome by a wave of guilt.

"It will work, It MUST work." Because if it doesn't.... Adora doesn't want to think about it, but she can't help but feel that pure, sheer desperation rising inside her.

Images flood into her head, images from her nightmare of Bow and Glimmer screaming in pain. In her lap, she clenches her hands into fists, so tight that her knuckles turn white. Then she feels a feather-light touch. Confused, she looks down and sees a tail tip brush her fingers. Only very gently and tentatively, and so quickly that no one but she notices, but it helps Adora to free herself from her thought prison and step back into the here and now. Gratefully, she looks to the side, but Catra looks stubbornly at the tabletop and pretends not to notice.

"Well, so let's assume we actually have a well-developed plan to overwhelm the horde and free our friends." Sea Hawk begins thoughtfully. "Then that's all well and good, but how do we get there?"

Silence falls in the room. Without Glimmer's powers, it would take them days to travel to the horde, and that takes time. Time they don't have. Frosta looks to the queen and asks, "With respect, your majesty, but you wouldn't happen to have the same powers as Glimmer?"

Angella sighs and shakes her head. You can tell she hasn't slept much in the last few days. "No. Teleportation is Glimmer's ability. Possibly we could use a spell with a similar effect, but I'm not a Sourceress. The only one who might be strong enough is Castaspella. But until she would arrive here, we lose too much time, and we don't even know if such a spell would actually work."

The mood in the room becomes thoughtful. Feverishly, Adora begins to search for a solution. Then a familiar voice breaks the silence.

"Maybe I can help."

Chapter End Notes

Finally the other princesses made an appearance! I tried to express their original characters while following my story. Hope you like it!

Chapter 22

Adora:

Adora looks toward the entrance of the hall and spots Shadow Weaver walking toward the meeting circle, relaxed. Catra tenses at the sight of her and her fur bristles. Adora quickly puts a hand over her tense fist, but not even that seems to help.

Shadow Weaver, meanwhile, has arrived at the table and stops in front of Adora.
The blonde also tenses up and reflexively assumes a more upright posture as Shadow Weaver eyes her, a habit she can't break.
"Adora" the woman greets her almost affectionately and strokes her cheek. The blonde flinches and looks at her warily.

"Glad to see you're back safe and sound from your trip."
She casts a quick, disapproving glance at Catra.
"I see you brought someone with you. So that's what took you so long. I guess I should have guessed. Hello, Catra. I didn't think I'd ever see you again."

Catra also stands up and scowls at her. "Why? Because you knew I'd be sent to my doom for your treachery?" Unmoved, Shadow Weaver looks down at the Magicat. "You seem to have survived it. Although, given your lousy skills, that's very surprising; after all, there'd be no Adora to save you."

A low, hateful growl comes from the Magicat's throat. She seems ready to jump at the shadow woman's throat at any moment, so Adora quickly puts herself between the two.
"Enough, Shadow Weaver. Catra is on our side. And I will not allow you to speak to her like that."

The rumbling behind the blonde grows quieter, but the Magicat growls, "I can defend myself." Adora is not sure if she should be hurt by these words. Before she can respond, someone at the

other end of the table clears their throat. It is Queen Angella, who now attracts the attention of those present.

"I would like to ask you to put your disputes aside for now and focus on saving my daughter. Shadow Weaver" Now there is clear distaste in her voice. "You were going to tell us about an idea. Please, continue." With a final, disapproving glance at the Magicat, Shadow Weaver pulls away from her former charges and circles the table until she is standing next to the Queen. "Of course, your highness."

Catra snorts spitefully as she watches the two women, as does everyone else. Shadow Weaver begins to narrate, "Princess Glimmer is the child of an immortal and a powerful mage. Her abilities to teleport are therefore extraordinary and actually unique. Unless..."

She takes a dramatic pause. Even with her mask on, Adora recognizes that the woman is gazing triumphantly into the round. "Unless what?" Frosta inquires impatiently, folding her arms. Adora eyes her former teacher suspiciously, yet is as curious as the others.

"There is a way to recreate this particular kind of magic." she continues. "With it, I could transport all of you to any place in the world in the blink of an eye, including right into the heart of the Horde."
Hope begins to grow in Adora, at the same time she doesn't trust her former mentor's words. They sound too beautiful. There must be a catch.

"However, this requires strong magic." continues Shadow Weaver, folding her hands together. "Magic that I do not have on my own.The only way to form teleportation magic is to combine moon magic with sorceress magic.“
Adora holds her breath as she guesses where this is going, and Angela also frowns before Shadow Weaver finishes,
"So I need access to the moonstone."

"No!"
There is a reflex in Adora as she jumps up and looks Shadow Weaver in the eye. "We can't just let you have a powerful energy source like that." Serenely, her former mentor looks at her. "I don't think you have much of a choice. If you want to save your friends, you'll have to hurry."

Adora's hands form into fists. "But-"
"Adora!" interrupts Angella, looking at her seriously. "I don't like this idea any more than you do, but we have no choice. To save my daughter and Bow, we have to take this risk." At the mention of her friends, the blonde abruptly unclenches her fists and her protests fall silent. Like it or not, Angella is right.

The queen turns to the shadow woman beside her and takes one deep breath before declaring, "You have my permission to use the moonstone. But only for Glimmer and Bow's rescue." The others at the table look equally unenthusiastic, but they nod in agreement. The welfare of their friends is paramount. Even if that means giving Shadow Weaver more power....

"You can't be serious."
All eyes turn to Catra, who is participating in this discussion for the first time.
Her face speaks volumes as she stands up and crosses her arms. "How can you just trust that woman like that?! She's just hungry for power!" Adora understands the Magicat's anger all too well, and she feels such helplessness to do anything about it.

In an attempt, she explains, "Catra, I don't like it either, but-" "So far, she's always been helpful." interjects Mermista.
"And it's about our friends!" adds Netossa, standing there full of beans.
"So what?! She was in the horde. All that woman does is manipulate others for her own gain!" Unimpressed, Shadow Weaver crosses her arms.

"And YOU`RE the one to talk."

Adora can almost see how hard these words hit Catra. She tries not to let it show, and maintains her scowl.
"She`s not wrong." Netossa agrees. "You haven't made it easy for the rebellion these past few years."
"You've been just as deceitful as she has. Why should we believe your words any more? Maybe you just want to keep us from rescuing our friends in time!" suspects Frosta, looking at the Magicat suspiciously.

"With your jealousy and envy, you have always prevented others from reaching their full potential," Shadow Weaver comments unapologetically. Catra grits her teeth angrily.
"You don't have to trust me, you have to use your wits. This woman" she points at Shadow Weaver. "Can't be trusted for a second. She will stab you in the back as soon as you no longer see it coming!"
Only Adora notices the underlying pain in her voice, her heart tightening.

Spinnerella props both arms on the table. "We have no choice. We will save our friends. And since we barely know you, we can't trust your words." A frustrated grumble escapes the Magicat before she clenches her hands into fists.

"Spinnerellla is right!" agrees Perfuma. "We don't know you. You might want to slow us down, and we can't risk the lives of our friends. Besides, you've been anything but nice to us these past few years!"
"Hordak only made it this far because you supported him and drove him in your anger towards Adora!" Mermista crosses her arms angrily.
"Do you know how many people have lost their homes because of you?"
"Exactly! Why should we listen to you?" Frosta asks challengingly.

All eyes are on Catra, whose shoulders begin to shake.
"Fine," she presses out. "Then do what you want."
She turns away. "I need some fresh air."
"Catra, wait!" Adora reaches out an arm to stop her friend, but

the Magicat hurries out of the room without looking at anyone again.

Furious, the blonde turns to her friends. "You should be ashamed of yourselves!"
Accusingly, she looks at the faces of her friends, who don't really look remorseful. Maybe because they didn't realize how much they hurt Catra with their words.

Netossa crosses her arms. "Why? We were just speaking the truth. She is not one of us. She hurt us, and now all of a sudden we're supposed to just forgive her like that and she's going along with us like nothing's wrong?"
"You have to admit, it's a lot to ask." Spinerella agrees with her wife.
"I really want to believe that Catra changed and that she wants to help us." Perfuma admits, with a milder mood than the others. "But how would we know?"

Adora clenches her hands into fists. "I agree, you all have a reason to be angry with Catra and to not trust her." Adora lowers her eyes to the table and squints. "But none of you have been hurt by her the way I have. Catra was my best friend. I grew up with her, and for 18 years we struggled through life together. Until the day I became She Ra and the person who meant the most to me turned against me."

Silence.

Shadow Weaver looks bored, the princesses look embarrassed, and Angella looks sympathetically at Adora. "That's exactly why you must understand how hard it is for us to just forgive and forget. How can we be sure that she is actually on our side? And that she won't betray us - YOU - again?"

The blonde raises her eyes and looks firmly at each person in turn. "In the Crimson Waste, Catra could have held me captive. I was at her mercy. She could have done whatever she wanted with me. And yet she helped me. She led me out of the desert, kept

me from danger, and saved my life several times.She didn't leave me alone when things got hard. Without her, I would not be here anymore.
You may not trust her, but you trust me. So believe me when I tell you that I know Catra. I know she means business.
She has apologized to me and I have forgiven her. If I can do that, so can you.
And if you can't, we may not be the rebellion I joined years ago anymore."

Adora pushes her chair back. "If you'll excuse me, I'm going to check on my friend. Your Majesty? I promise to think about a mended plan." She bows briefly to the queen, ignoring Shadow Weaver's call to stay.

The princesses remain silent as Adora also leaves the room and begins looking for Catra. Only when the hall closes behind her does she allow the enormous worry and fear for Catra to rise within her.

Catra:

This palace is frustratingly large, and the potential to get lost here is not small, but somehow Catra finds a door that leads outside. It's not the same door as before, but she doesn't care at the moment.
She needs air.

Forcefully, she pushes open two large doors and wants to rush outside, but she doesn't get far. She is standing on a balcony. Breathing heavily, she runs to the railing and grabs hold. The balcony is huge, bigger than her former dormitory in the horde. And yet it seems to the Magicat like a ventilated prison.

Desperation rises in her and she grips the railing so tightly that her claws leave deep furrows in it. Her gaze glides searchingly over the railing, out into the vastness of the land. She recognizes

the manicured gardens of the palace, and a little distance away, the edge of the Whispering Woods.

By now it is dark, but the Magicat can see everything without any problems. Involuntarily, she compares the sight in front of her with the nightlife she can observe from her window in the Crimson Waste.

Should she perhaps have just stayed in the desert? No one would have rejected her there. She would have been in charge. And no one there had the power to hurt her. If one of the Crimson residents had spoken to her the way the princesses did, she would have clawed his eyes out for it and been angry with herself afterwards.

But that Catra no longer exists. At any rate, she is making an effort to do so.
Still, she feels the anger at the princesses' words, and at Shadow Weaver's disapproval.
How dare they pass judgment on Catra! To decide who she is and what she deserves?

At the same time, she feels the shame left by the accusations. Because they correspond to the truth.
These princesses have not thought it necessary to whitewash anything.

Catra's breathing becomes shallower, and she sinks to the ground. No matter where she goes, she will not escape her past, she realizes. And now that she's trying to make up for it, she's too weak to bear the opposition.

Her lungs seem to constrict, and panic rises in her. 'No!' she thinks in fear and clutches her hand to her chest. 'No, please. Not again! Pull yourself together, Catra!' Her breathing becomes more irregular, and her body begins to tremble. The exhaustion of the trip, the attack a few hours earlier, the encounter with Shadow Weaver, and the accusations just now are too much for her.

She can already feel herself beginning to lose control of her body, and her tail twitches back and forth uncontrollably. Meanwhile, the familiar panic spreads through her like poison and creeps through her veins. Then she hears a voice.

"Catra? Are you here?"

Her vision isn´t blurry yet, so the Magicat sees Adora enter the balcony and find Catra slumped in the corner. Dismayed, she kneels in front of her.
"Catra! Oh no, what's wrong?" Catra can't answer, her body is tense and her arms are pressed tightly to her chest. With only her gaze, Catra silently pleads with the blonde for help. Adora understands.

"It's happening again, isn't it?" she whispers, upset, probably thinking of the incident in Zeras, where Adora witnessed one of her panic attacks. Catra can't nod, she can't speak either, only a whimpering sound escapes her. But Adora doesn't need an answer, she understands.

Carefully, so as not to frighten the Magicat, she slides a little closer to her friend and closes her arms around her. If Catra could, she would have pressed herself tighter against Adora to feel her warmth. But as it is, she just lies motionless in her arms and greedily sucks air into her lungs, breathing in Adora's scent as well.

The blonde naturally places Catra's head on her shoulder and begins to stroke her hair. At the same time she murmurs soothing words. "Hey, everything is fine. Breathe. Take it easy, I'm here. You're safe. I'm not going to leave you, okay?" Adora's presence has always provided the most comfort for the Magicat, and even now it acts as a healing agent as her cramped limbs slowly loosen, her breathing calms, and the panic recedes.

Adora continues to hold her, stroking her hair and murmuring gentle reassurances. "Very good. Just breathe. I'll hold you." she promises, and Catra can't help but wrap her shaky arms around

Adora and bury her face deeper into the blonde's shoulder.
She's with Adora. She is safe. All is well, she reminds herself, and can't believe how comforting these thoughts are to her.

But it's true: In Adora's arms she feels safer and more secure than anywhere else. Because she trusts Adora.
Catra doesn't even flinch from this thought anymore, because it just feels RIGHT.

Adora has also noticed that Catra is feeling better. Lovingly, she strokes her head again and asks, "You alright?" Catra doesn't dare use her voice yet, so she nods and takes another deep breath before pulling back from the embrace with a heavy heart.

Adora's surprised face looks almost disappointed, but she doesn't comment on it but positions herself to sit next to Catra on the floor. After a while of silence, Adora asks, "Do you want to talk about it now?"

Catra thinks about her answer for a moment. A week ago, she would have refused at any price to confide in anyone about her attacks. She would have had to admit a weakness.
But now? She trusts Adora. She knows she would never condemn her for it.
And yet she is nervous. What will she think of her when Adora learns how weak she really is? But it's Adora. The person Catra knows best. If she can talk to anyone about it, it's her.

So she clears her throat. "I've always had these...attacks. Even back in the horde."
Surprised, Adora raises her eyebrows. "I never caught that?"
Catra shrugs and looks to the ground. "When it happened, I hid in some dark corner and waited for it to pass. I didn't want anyone to see me like that. Mostly it happened after Shadow Weaver.... punished me."

A sympathetic hand on her shoulder gives her the strength to keep talking. "These attacks have always come when she has made me feel particularly weak and helpless. However, they have

only been really bad since.... since a while. Whenever... when I lose control and everything becomes too much for me. A panic rises up in me and I can't move anymore. Most of the time I can't breathe. I always think I'm going to die."

She pulls her knees to her chest and stares at the floor. She has never felt so vulnerable as she does now, as she reveals her weakness to Adora. For a moment, there is silence. Then Adora asks, "And does anyone else know? What about Scorpia?" Catra shakes her head. "No one knows."
"That means... you've always had to deal with it alone?" To this, the Magicat gives no answer.

Adora exhales air in disbelief. "Catra...I'm so sorry." The Magicat didn't expect that. Astonished, she lifts her head and looks at Adora. On secound thought: of course Adora would find fault with herself. Even with something that doesn't concern her at all. Sometimes Catra can't believe how unconsciously selfless this woman is.
She doesn't know whether she wants to shake her head or to ki - stop! Hastily, she interrupts her own thoughts.

"It's not your fault, Adora." She doesn't mention that she suffered a panic attack from Adora's appearance in the Crimson Waste. After all, she is not responsible for that either. The blonde remains insistent. "Nevertheless. No one should experience this alone. I can't even imagine how strong you had to be for that."

Surprised, the Magicat perks up her ears. "Strong? Adora, these attacks make me vulnerable and weak."
"And yet you always overcome them. That takes strength."
Unsure, the Magicat looks into her friend's blue-gray eyes. "I always wanted to be strong. But for a while now, I think I've always just been fooling everyone. Even to myself."
Suddenly, it's so easy for her to speak frankly.

Catra thoughtfully puts her head back and closes her eyes before continuing to speak. "What the princesses said earlier...It just

confirmed it for me." A hand rests on hers, and when Catra's eyes open, Adora looks at her resolutely.

"They shouldn't have said that. The past is past. They don't know you. Not like I do. They're wrong in their assessment of you. I'm sorry I didn't stand up for you sooner. You've always been strong, Catra. Even though you may not believe it." Catra is unconvinced, so Adora adds, "You have SURVIVED, Catra. The Horde, Shadow Weaver, the Crimson Waste.... and no matter what you had to experience, no matter which... paths you have gone."

She clears her throat before looking at Catra again with determination and squeezing her hand tighter. "You have not been broken. Despite all that, there's still the Catra in you that I have known and lo- CARED for my entire life. That takes immense strength. The others may not see it yet, you may not see it yet, but one day they will."

Adora speaks with so much emphasis in her voice that Catra realizes she is speaking from the depths of her heart. The blonde means it. As the Magicat lets her gaze wander over the determined features of her friend, Catra remembers the words of the old Razz: "The only one who should love you, but doesn't, is you. Overcome your fear. You will see: It's worth it."

Unconsciously, she smiles and squeezes Adora's hand as well. "Thank you. For... not giving up on me."
"Never." she promises, sounding so determined, and smiles. Despite the darkness, the two women seem radiant. It is a moment full of peace, and Catra decides to keep this moment in her heart forever.

They sit like that for a while, enjoying each other's closeness, until Catra can't suppress a yawn. Immediately Adora jumps up. "It's already late. We should go to sleep."
"What about the other princesses?" Catra wants to know. She feels a little sick to her stomach at the thought of possibly having to go into that hall again. But fortunately for her, Adora waves it

off. "That's settled. Come on" She holds out a hand to Catra and helps her stand up.

Then she suddenly becomes embarrassed. "I can show you to a guest room for the night if you want."
"Oh, um... sure." Catra tries to hide how scared she is at the thought of being alone. In a building she doesn't know. Detoured by people who don't like her. At night. With new, strange, loud noises.

Perhaps Adora senses how unpleasant the idea is for Catra, because she adds. "You know... I mean... Would you mind sleeping in my room? I don't know if I can find a spare room in a hurry..." With that, she sheepishly places a hand on the back of her neck.
Catra brushes a few strands of hair from her face, relieved, and tries to shrug her shoulders as indifferently as possible. "Sure. Whatever. I've been sticking with you for days, I can take one more night of your stink."

Together they walk back inside the castle, with Adora indignantly frowning and crossing her arms.
"I don't stink!"
"Adora... When was the last time you showered?"
"...Okay, maybe I stink A LITTLE. So what? You haven't seen a bathroom in just as long."
"Wrong." Catra corrects, grinning. "This morning, while you were sleeping off your hangover, I took a cat wash."

Adora opens her mouth and closes it again. Then she gives an offended murmur, but they both know that the blonde is not seriously disgruntled. In truth, they both enjoy the lightness of their conversation. Something that would have been unthinkable just a short time ago.

A few hallways and stairs later, they are standing in front of a door that Catra could not have distinguished from the others. Yet her orientation normally works well. Adora opens the door and

tells Catra to go in first. Now a little uncertain, the Magicat follows the request and enters Adora's bedroom.

Dimmed light falls through large windows from outside, leaving the room in semi-darkness. Catra's sharp eyes nevertheless recognize every detail of the huge room. She can't help but instinctively compare it to her room in the Crimson Waste and the dormitories in the Horde. This room is much larger. There are decorations on the walls and ceiling that seem to serve no particular purpose. And is that a waterfall in the middle of the room? Does it serve as a shower?

The most obvious difference, however, is the bed: It is so large that all the cadets of their former dormitory could have easily fit on it. And Catra is sure she has never seen so many pillows in one place. She doesn't know what to make of the sight. Whether Adora's room is supposed to say something important to her at all, or if it has no meaning. At the moment, however, she is too tired to think about it.

Adora, meanwhile, walks to the bed and smoothes the blanket. She looks nervous. "Okay, good. You can take the bed. I'll sleep on the floor and just get a second blanket real quick and then-" "Adora," Catra interrupts her friend. The blonde stops herself immediately and looks at her questioningly. Hesitantly, the Magicat strokes the surface of the bed before letting herself sink onto it. Then, shaking her head, she looks at Adora, a smirk on her face.

"Don't be an idiot. The bed is huge. And you already drooled twice ove me within a week, a third time doesn't matter." "O-okay." Adora blushes, but then starts to take off her jacket and boots. Catra does the same and gets rid of her jacket. She hesitates before also taking off the belt with her weapons and dropping it next to the bed.

Immediately she feels vulnerable, naked, but with a glance at Adora she assures herself that it's okay. That she is safe here. While Adora is still struggling with one of her boots, Catra slides

around on the mattress as a test, pushing a few pillows out of the way until she gets used to the surface.

Then Agora also crawls into bed with her and lies down next to her on her back, crossing her arms behind her head. Catra sits next to her and looks at her for a moment. The blonde has her eyes closed and sighs. You can tell how happy she is to be home again. The tension from her shoulders has mostly disappeared and her expression seems almost relaxed.

Despite the hardships of the journey, Adora is still so beautiful. For a moment, Catra examines Adora's face, which looks so peaceful, the tousled hair shining in the dim light, and the muscles tightening on her arms. It may not be a typical beauty that everyone recognizes at first sight. But Catra sees it.

Of course Adora is attractive, she always has been. But there is something else that makes her beautiful. Something about her charisma. This calm, strong and yet at the same time so gentle being in her. Adora may be lying there sweaty, disheveled and exhausted, but for Catra this sight is perfect.

Only one thing disturbs the Magicat. Adora opens one eye and sees Catra staring at her.
"What?" she wants to know uncertainly.
Wordlessly, the Magicat reaches behind Adora's head and pulls the ribbon out of her hair, which then spreads openly across the bed.
"That's better. You can't always sleep with that ponytail, Adora. Otherwise your hair will fall out."
"Hmph." the blonde grunts, blowing a strand out of her face before shrugging her shoulders.

Then she tilts her head.
"Better?"
Something about the way Adora looks at her makes Catra embarrassed, and she looks away.
"Better." Then she, too, lies down. She turns on her side and looks directly into two bright blue eyes. Adora has turned to her as well, and after a hesitation, slides a little closer to the Magicat.

For a while, the two simply stare at each other in silence in the semi-darkness. To relieve that strange tension in the air, Adora whispers, "Catra?"
"Huh?"
"To sleep you must close your eyes."
Catra smirks. "Pff, dork. Your eyes are still open, too."
Adora grins, too. It's that goofy grin that owns a part of Catra's heart and makes it beat faster.

"Suggestion: I close my eyes when you close yours." "Deal."
Almost simultaneously, both women pinch their eyes shut and giggle softly.
And Catra just feels at ease.
That's when she feels a hand tentatively close around her own. In silent response, the Magicat's tail settles on the blonde's legs and lingers there.
It is not long before only the deep breaths of the two women can be heard.

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 23
Catra:

Catra wakes up even a little earlier than usual, the sun seems to be just coming up. At first she doesn't know where she is, but when she discovers Adora's sleeping face in front of her, she relaxes. In the night, the two have moved a little closer together, and for a moment Catra considers just lying there and delaying the moment as long as she can.

Then, with a heavy heart, she decides against it. After all, they have a task ahead of them. Since they are in no hurry today, Catra decides to wake Adora more gently for once. Therefore she lifts her tail and tickles Adora with it under her nose. The blonde twitches, wrinkles her nose and opens her eyes. When she sees Catra, her expression softens.

For a moment, the two women simply look at each other before Adora sleepily murmurs, "Why are you always the first one awake?" The Magicat shrugs her shoulders. "My body recovers faster." A beeping sound is heard next to the bed, and reflexively the Magicat puts up her ears.

But Adora sleepily reaches behind her and explains, "That's my tracker pad." Leisurely, she pulls the device toward her and opens the message that is displayed. It's only a few lines, but her expression changes from relaxed to thoughtful and...disgruntled? Catra tries hard not to be curious. "Are you okay?"

Absently, the blonde turns off the pad and sits up before rubbing her face. "There's a meeting in the great hall in an hour. We'll decide on the details of the rescue plan then."

"Oh." Catra isn't sure if the 'we' includes her. She's also not sure she wants it to after last night's fiasco.

Adora smiles warmly at her. "You don't have to come if you don't want to. But I'd be happy if you did. We - ... I could really use your help. And I don't want to do this without you." Catra can't resist that warm smile. Besides, Adora gave her new courage last night. She will show these princesses that she is not so easily intimidated.

That's why she rolls her eyes and declares, "All right." She smirks before adding:
"But this is not because I like you!"
"Of course not."
Adora has put on her dorky grin again, and by now at the latest Catra would probably have done anything the blonde asked.

Just a week ago, this effect would have made her furious, but now? Now it is simply a fact for her. Although one that she would never admit to anyone else.

Full of energy, Adora stands up and brushes her open hair out of her face. "Well, let's get ready." She points to an adjoining room. "There's the bathroom. And over there is my closet. Help yourself. I'll see if I can rustle up something to eat." Catra nods and watches as Adora leaves the room to get breakfast.

The room feels stranger again without the blonde, but the Magicat pushes the feeling away and heads for the bathroom. She throws her clothes into a corner. Briskly she washes herself, taking care not to stay wet longer than necessary. The myriad soap smells and scents overwhelm her fine nose, but it is far more pleasant than some smells she has experienced in the horde.

After only a few minutes, she returns to the room wrapped in a towel and gathers her clothes. As she ponders what to wear and what to replace, she is amazed at how softly the large bath towel wraps around her body. In contrast, the towels from the horde

resemble a pile of sandpaper. Even the towels in Crimson Waste weren't this soft.

As she looks thoughtfully at her now worn bodysuit, she hears the door open behind her and flinches.
"It's just me, i found some - Oh!" Adora comes into the room with a small tray full of food. When she catches sight of Catra, her face takes on the color of a tomato.

The blonde swallows once and looks down at the floor in embarrassment. "Sorry. I didn't know that you - um...well. Anyways. I have some food here. When you're ready. If you're hungry, I mean. Oh boy. Well, I better get into the bathroom. I need to towel - ahhh I mean shower!" Stammering, the blonde sets the tray down on the bed and disappears into the bathroom, her head high.

Shaking her head, Catra watches her go. What was that? Then she turns away and runs towards the closet that Adora has shown her. While she's not happy with the idea of putting on someone else's clothes, she realizes that most of her clothing is already very worn out and it makes sense to change.

So she enters the closet, which turns out to be another room. Do they have a problem with open spaces here in Bright Moon? Impressed, Catra wanders past huge racks full of clothes. You could outfit the entire Crimson Waste with this! Who needs so many different clothes?

Above all, Adora always seems to wear the same uniform. Maybe this stuff was here before? Or Sparkles gave it to her. Maybe it's some kind of princess basic outfit. In any case, the variation and the taste is very broad, which is why Catra is relieved to find that she doesn't have to put on a glittery dress.

After a few minutes, she finds a pair of tight-fitting black pants and a light red top with a boobie window that suits her taste. She gets dressed and then slips on her black jacket from Crimson Waste. She also keeps her belt with the weapons before standing

in front of the large mirror in the room. Amazed, she notices how different she looks.

Her appearance has never played a role for her. In the Horde, it was important to function, not to be fashionable or attractive. Here, in front of this mirror, she notices a change for the first time.
The change she was already looking for in the Crimson Waste. She looks more grown up. More mature. Stronger. And somehow... more relaxed.
As if she can see for herself that she has shed her constant restlessness.

For the first time in a long time, she is satisfied with her reflection.

If only it weren't for the loose hair. Without the mask, it always falls into her face. But it was the right decision to give it up. It represented a chapter of her life that she wants to close.
Without further ado, she ties her hair into a ponytail. It is an unfamiliar sight, but not unpleasant. A few strands still frame her face, but that doesn't bother the Magicat.

Satisfied, she leaves the closet and almost runs into Adora.
"Whoops!" Adora shouts and takes a step back in surprise. Her eyes grow wide as she looks at Catra. "Oh wow, Catra. i see you found some fresh clothes. You look... great!"
The Magicat is embarrassed by the words, she is not used to getting compliments on her appearance. Or for other things, for that matter.

Possibly the look in Adora´s eyes would have even made her blush, but something else catches her attention: the sight of Adora. Now she is the one whose body is covered only with a towel.
Instantly Catra gets hot at the sight of her. Her gaze falls on strong upper arms clutching the towel. Wet strands of hair frame bright eyes and cheeks flushed from the heat of the water.

"Sorry!" stammers Catra, unable to avert her gaze. "I didn't know you wanted to...go in there."
"It's okay." Adora assures, smiling and brushing a strand of hair from her face. Befuddled, Catra leaves the closet and makes room for Adora to enter. While the blonde gets dressed, Catra sits down on the bed and tries to NOT think of what she just saw.

So she surveys the tray full of food before popping some unfamiliar fruit into her mouth. A surprised sound escapes her. Is it possible that a fruit can taste like a place? If so, this one tastes like Bright Moon. Unfamiliar and foreign, but also sweet and pleasantly fresh.
And does glitter have a taste?

While the Magicat is devouring some more fruit, Adora comes out of the closet. She, too, wears different clothes: a similar light-colored long-sleeved shirt as before, but over it she wears a dark red jacket without sleeves or shoulderpads. Her belt is the same, and also pants and boots are similar, though not exactly the same as Adora's original pieces.
Her hair is tied back into a ponytail, and perched on top of her head is the hairpoof, which Catra simultaneously loves and finds incredibly silly.

For a moment, the Magicat looks at her silently. The blonde looks... simply like Adora.
Somehow the thought makes her happy. The certainty that no one controls the blonde, but she is free to determine for herself what she does. And if it is only the choice of clothes.

Adora writhes sheepishly under Catra's scrutinizing expression and begins to fiddle with her belt. "Does the jacket sit crooked? Did I not tie my shoes properly? Or is my hair already falling out of my braid?"
Catra snaps out of her stupor and shakes her head before smiling tentatively.

"No, you just look...pretty. Like yourself." It's hard for Catra to just hand out compliments like that. Even if they come from the

depths of her heart. She'll have to get used to that. But Adora's reaction is worth it: embarrassed, the blonde grabs the back of her neck and smiles, too. In the past, she couldn't handle compliments that didn't have anything to do with her skills. In the meantime, she seems to have improved, but she still seems a little perplexed and unsure how to react.

Therefore, Catra takes the pressure off her and, glancing at the tray, asks, "Have you eaten yet?" The blonde nods. "Just after I got out of the shower. What about you? Are you full? Or would you rather I look for something else? I could -"
"Adora," Catra interrupts her friend with a grin. "It's fine, I'm full. Seriously."
"Oh." Adora seems relieved.

"Okay. Then, um, we should probably get going. Not that we're going to be late." "The blonde turns toward the door, and Catra gets up to follow her as well. Just before she can leave the room, the Magicat grabs the blonde's wrist and holds her back.
"Adora? Wait a minute, please."

Questioning, the blonde turns her head to her friend, "What is it?"
"I..." Catra looks to the ground before taking a deep breath and looking into the blue-gray eyes before her. "I might have an idea." An idea that began to form in her brain last night. However, she doesn't know how Adora will react to it. She has assured her of her help, but does that include making decisions? Is she entitled to do that? Or does it only serve as a fighting tool?

Catra does not know the limits, does not know how far she may go. On the other hand, she is Catra, and boundaries have never interested her. And yet she can't ignore the uncertainty inside her, because this isn't about disobeying a rule that could get her a curfew.
This is about her relationship with Adora.
The Magicat doesn't want to and mustn´t mess that up.
Not again.

A warm smile spreads across Adora's face and she takes a step away from the door and towards Catra. "I'm all ears."

_____

"It worked!" exclaims Entrapta enthusiastically, jumping for joy on the spot. Her robot Emily next to her rolls around once in a circle, blinking excitedly as she shares the joy. The tech princess has just uploaded the latest update to the software, completely overhauling the systems, which means her programs are now optimized.

At least that's what the numbers on the pad in her hands say. Excitedly, Entrapta looks at her lab partner, who is also standing next to her and even smiles with satisfaction.
"Very good work, Entrapta." The princess places a hand on Hordak's shoulder. "We did it together! Now we just have to manage to unleash the energy of the sword."
"Do you have any idea how we're going to do that?" Hordak wants to know.

Concentrating, she fiddles with some cables before answering, "Honestly, I don't have an approach yet. It must have something to do with magic, that's for sure. I've asked Bow and Glimmer, but they can't help me." Hordak pauses and looks to the princess.

"The prisoners?"
"Yup." She types in some numbers on her pad, not paying attention to Hordak. After some hesitation, the Lorde of the Horde wants to know, "Did you tell them about our project?"
She shakes her head. "You asked me not to. However, maybe knowing why this is so important to you would convince them to help us."

Hordak almost laughed. "I doubt it. The Etherians wouldn't understand." Now Entrapta does stop her work for a moment to

look at Hordak.
"I'm from Etheria, too."
Hordak tilts his head and asks, "And do you understand?"

She considers for a moment. "I can follow your train of thought, that you want to prove yourself to Lord Prime and give him Etheria so he will recognize you as worthy. However, I still think you shouldn't have to prove yourself to anyone. We are also friends and accept each other as we are. Right?" Slowly, Hordak nods. Of course, Entrapta is his friend. But it's different with Prime.

"Lord Prime is not my friend. I am his subject. I must prove to him that I am worthy of him." Absently, Entrapta puts her pad away. It's rare for her to actually focus fully on a conversation, that's why Hordak notices how important this is to her.
"And if you ... wouldn't prove yourself?"
The question catches him off guard.
A little speechless, he asks, "...What?"

"This experiment requires some risks that we can't prevent. Which may possibly harm many people and have unforeseen consequences for Etheria." She hesitates, not seeming to know how to express herself. Hordak frowns. "I've been reading through some old reports, of the Horde's conquests. You have... hurt quite a few people." she notes. It doesn't sound accusatory, just ... surprised. As if she's seeing her world from a different perspective for the first time.

The leader feels queasy at her words. Why doesn't Hordak want Entrapta to think badly of him? "It was necessary." he clarifies, hoping that the princess will not put him in further distress.
"But is it all worth it?"
Entrapta looks at him, and there is no judgment in her gaze about his actions, only... Hesitation. Doubt. Uncertainty.

"Prime didn't treat you well. You were not accepted by him for who you are. So why would you want to go back to him? You've built something for yourself here. And... you have me. Isn't that

enough?" It's the first time Hordak has had to justify his actions to someone else. And... it doesn't feel good, he notes.

"I...It is my duty, Entrapta. You don't understand, but I have to do this."
"...Okay. If that's what you really want, that's what I'll continue to help you do."
Relief floods his defective body and he places a hand on the little princess' shoulder. "Thank you. For your loyalty."
"No problem!" Suddenly, the serious expression on her face is gone and she seems to be back to her old self. "We are Friends, aren't we? And friends don't let each other down."
The lord nods and smiles before walking out of the room, leaving the princess alone with her technology.Hordak is relieved that Entrapta continues to stand by him, even as her words haunt him.

'If that's what you really want.'

What he wants… This is a question he has never dared to ask. Why should he? It's not about what he wants. He serves Prime, even when whole galaxies separate him. His sole purpose of existence is Prime, and the fulfillment of his ideas.

He himself is only a clone. Albeit a defective one. This gives him even less claim to formulate his own desires. And yet, his friendship with Entrapta has changed something.

'Your imperfections are beautiful.'

She was the first to make him feel something other than this miserable ongoing certainty that he is worthless. She made him feel... valuable. Like he was actually an individual who had a right to formulate choices and needs in his own best interest. As if this is not a sin that makes him impure, but a natural process in life. A process that makes life worth living.

For the first time in his life, he asks himself what he wants.

Quickly, he dismisses the question again, out of fear.
Fear that the answer would not match what Prime had in mind for

him.
Fear he might get cocky and forget his place.
Fear he might develop doubts about a plan and an ideology that has kept him alive from the beginning of his existence.
Because if that was taken away from him, he wouldn't know any longer what was keeping him alive.

Entrapta, meanwhile, turns to some large screens and is about to check some systems when she realizes she's off her game. Her own words echo in her head.
'Friends don't let each other down.'
Like a mantra, it circles through her head, filling her consciousness and keeping her from reaching her full potential at work. Try as she might, she can't shake her thoughts.

Finally, she turns away from the screens and picks up the recorder in one of her hair strands before recording. "Day 14 in the attempt to develop a software for Project AlphaFirstOne. It is 10:32 am. The software should be able to compensate and direct the enormous energy of the sword, thanks to the new programs I have developed for the various systems.

The question remains whether the sole use of technology is enough to fully control this object. My predictions say that without the use of magic, there is an 11% chance. It remains unclear how to solve the problem. We need magic, but I continue to lack sufficient knowledge about this component."

She pauses for a moment because her mind is still elsewhere before hesitantly continuing, "I've asked Bow and Glimmer about this, but they won't help me because.... because they don't think this experiment should be done. It could do too much damage."
She takes one deep breath. She realizes that this is no longer part of her project, but it can't hurt to record her other thoughts as well. It will help her sort herself out and make a clear decision.

Determined, she continues, "They claim the Horde is evil. But how do you define something like that? Yes, the Horde has done a lot of damage in Etheria. I've read about that myself. But I think

Hordak only harms the inhabitants because he sees no other way out. Maybe he never learned anything else. He didn't grow up on Etheria. Does that make him someone evil? And the rest of the Horde is just following orders. Most of the people here are nice. Admittedly, I've mostly talked to Emily or computers so far. But I sometimes overhear conversations among Horde soldiers that suggest they're not really different from other Etherians.

I'm unsure what to do.
Hordak is my friend, and friends are helped, but Bow and Glimmer are my friends too. Aren't they? They left me, but I still like them. Bow is still nice to me, and I don't think they left me on purpose. But Hordak is still important to me, and the experiment is important to him, so I should support him in it.

I don't want to hurt anyone with this. Why is this so complicated? I don't mind complicated, that's what makes things interesting, but this feels different than usual. Science has always been clear to me, the facts have spoken clearly and been a good benchmark. But Bow has given me another yardstick by which he measures his actions: feelings.

I'm not good at feelings, they confuse me and are often irrational. On the other hand, feelings are a big part of the human species, so I don't think they can be left out when it comes to people. So if I'm going to make decisions based on how I feel, I need to know how I feel first." She pauses for a moment to listen inside and explore her feelings.

"I think I feel...sad. Maybe pressured, too. I really want to help Hordak, but not hurt anyone in the process. Also, I'm... insecure. I have nothing more than Hordak's own narratives that vaguely pass for facts, but my feelings tell me...that Prime is not good for Hordak. I don't understand why Hordak would want to go to someone who doesn't accept him, who even sent him away. I have my doubts if going to Prime is the best thing for Hordak. I think... I'm worried. About him."

Again, she pauses before continuing. "But what does all this tell me now? What am I supposed to do with these fuzzy feelings and thoughts? How am I supposed to judge my actions based on that? Bow would have an answer. He's good at feelings. He could give some advice. Maybe I should ask him again?

He said that the welfare of a living being takes precedence over any experiment. From a purely logical standpoint, the likelihood of anyone being directly harmed by the execution of the experiment is relatively low. But I think... if I go by my gut feeling, I think Bow means something else. That perhaps the effects are not just about the immediate, but also the consequences, which in turn can be harmful. Like, for example, what Lord Prime will do to us Etherians when Hordak turns the land over to his master."

Entrapta takes a deep breath. It feels good to speak out and record her thoughts, so she continues. "Hordak is not an evil creature. Misguided, perhaps, but not evil. Otherwise he wouldn't be my friend. But what about Prime? He... I think he can harm Etheria. More than Hordak ever did. Does that make what Hordak did any better? Should I abandon the experiment?

It feels unusual to judge a situation mainly from feelings. I don't know if I'm ready to make a decision merely based on how I feel. Especially such an important one. I think I'm even more confused now than before. But I'm also kind of relieved. It seems like expressing my thoughts has a positive effect on my concentration.

My conclusion? I don't know yet how to proceed. I won't make a hasty decision, but..." She hesitates briefly before finally confessing, "I think I'm starting to be able to relate to Bow a little bit about what he says about feelings. Although I still prefer facts and figures. If any new insights present themselves, I'll get back to it."

Click. Recording ends.

Entrapta looks at the device for a moment before putting it away and finally turning her attention to the big screens.

Chapter End Notes

Soo this was a little insight of Entrapta and Hordak, I hope it wasn´t too boring.
And Catradora got new clothes! (And we got ponytail Catra, hehe)

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora:

"Okay, you know what to do?" Adora echoes as she ran her fingers through Swift Wind´s mane. They stand together with Catra at the palace gates. Her noble steed looks at them confidently. "Why, sure. You've only explained it to me about ten times."

"Right,right" The blonde nods, visibly nervous. She's not comfortable with the idea of sending Swift Wind off on his own. But he can take care of himself. And she's needed here now.

"Hey" The alicorn nudges Adora gently with the tip of his nose.
"I'll be back before you can say 'She Ra'." Adora smiles and strokes his neck once more before taking a step back. "Take care of yourself."
"You too." Swift Wind nods to Catra, who is standing slightly off to the side, winks at Adora one last time, and then spreads his wings before flying to the sky.

In just a few moments, Adora has lost sight of him, though she blinks hard.
"Do you think he'll make it in such a short time?" Catra steps up beside her and puts a hand on her shoulder. "We'll find out." Then she tugs lightly at Adora's new jacket. "Come on, all the princesses will think I kidnapped or captured you."

The blonde has to grin as she stumbles after the Magicat and walks back into the palace. As she does so, she scrutinizes her friend's upright gait. She seems much more confident today. Less intimidated.
Good. That's the Catra she knows.

Furtively, she looks at Catra's new outfit as they wander the aisles. She looks so much more... mature. And Adora can't help but notice how well the clothes hug the Magicat's curves. She quickly turns her gaze forward and concentrates on getting to the great hall quickly. They're already running late anyway.

But it is not long before they reach the hall and enter together. The other princesses are already present. Huntara and Sea Hawk, who have taken a seat next to Mermista, are also there. With a mumbled apology, Adora approaches the table and takes a seat. This time Catra sits down next to the blonde without being asked. Her posture is also more upright than the day before. The others murmur a greeting and eye Catra still skeptically, but not as hostile as the day before.

Adora takes this as a good sign. Shadow Weaver has taken a seat next to the queen as a matter of course, taking little notice of the rest. "Where's Swift Wind?" Sea Hawk wants to know, staring at the empty seat next to her. Evasively, Adora explains, "He had something important to do, but he should be back soon." No one was to know about Catra's plan if it didn't work. "Good," Angella begins. "Then let's get started."

Over the next half hour, the princesses develop a plan, which goes like this: They will attack by day, since no one is expecting it and the Horde will be accordingly unprepared. "We can take one of the side entrances, like last time when Catra captured Glimmer and Bow at the Princess Prom," suggests Mermista, giving the Magicat a sideways glance, which she studiously ignores.

Adora quickly continues the conversation. "That would be a possibility" agrees the blonde. "The guards there aren't as attentive, and besides, they aren't as numerous. It should be easy to overpower them without making a big fuss."

Frosta doesn't seem pleased with this suggestion. "I say we blow the whistle on sneaking up on them and attack with full force!" she roars with motivation, pounding her fist on the table. "Let's let them feel our fury and slay them right at the front door

with our concentrated power! They'll be so overrun that the rest will be a piece of cake!"

"I don't know, Frosta," Angella interjects. "Our plan is actually to remain undetected for as long as possible. That's safest for all of you. I don't want anyone to put themselves in unnecessary danger."

"Frosta's idea isn't so bad."

All eyes turn to Catra in surprise.

The Magicat has folded her arms and looks relaxed in the round. "Think about it: Why were your friends kidnapped in the first place?"
Silence.
Probably none of the people present had thought about this in more detail.

Not even Adora, as she now realizes with shame. She was only focused on getting her friends back as quickly as possible. She never thought about WHY they had been lured into an ambush. The answer to that question might give her valuable clues on how to save her friends. Nausea rises in Adora.
How could she have missed this simple but important detail?

Perfuma, meanwhile, suggests, a little perplexed, "Well... the fewer of us there are, the easier we are to defeat. So... they were probably kidnapped to weaken the rebellion?"
It was more of an uncertain question than an answer. Catra shook her head and crossed her arms. "I've been working with Hordak for quite some time. That you are weakened may be a nice side effect, but this goal is too simple, too plumb for this approach. Hordak also has no use for princesses or interest in their abilities. He is focused only on his plans."

Catra's bringing up her former role in the Horde is surprising. Remembering that she worked directly with the enemy is unlikely to convince the princesses to like or trust Catra more. However, it

also emphasizes a very concrete advantage on her part: she knows Hordak, and can thus better assess him and his plans, unlike the others in the room. Even Adora never got to see the Lord of the Horde himself. And Shadow Weaver would never bother to share her knowledge if it weren't for her own interests.

"And...that means?" Mermista pauses almost reluctantly. "Think about it: Hordak knows full well that you princesses will do anything to save your friends. So he's already expecting you." Skeptical or not, everyone is now hanging on Catra's lips. The Magicat doesn't seem to mind, it's as if she's back to being the old, confident Catra. Except now she's on the other side of the war.

"That means you're walking right into a trap. The Horde is counting on your rescue attempt, they're practically provoking it. So they'll be watching the back entrances extra closely. But" She pauses for a moment and turns to Frosta. "You least expect a frontal attack on a rescue attempt. So they'll be surprised."

Adora can only sit and listen to the Magicat in amazement. You can think what you want of her, but Catra has always possessed a sharp mind and tactical thinking. Before, she made life difficult for the rebellion, now she may help them out of a big mess. The other princesses must realize this as well.

Shadow Weaver, on the other hand, is completely unimpressed. "With this, you are throwing yourselves to the monster! This is a foolish and unimaginative plan!" Catra looks her in the eye and tightens her shoulders. "I don´t care about your opinion. And if you have no suggestions for improvement, then shut up."

Impressed, Adora looks at her friend. She seems to be making a real effort not to let Shadow Weaver get close to her anymore. Pride grows in the blonde, and a smile spreads across her face as she watches Shadow Weaver look almost perplexed before sinking back into her chair with an indignant sound.

In the Horde, Shadow Weaver would have punished and tormented Catra for her forward behavior, but here she can do nothing. She has little magic of her own left, and Angella would not have allowed it. But the queen also has reservations about Catra's idea.

"If we attack from the front, we won't be able to get inside the Horde because we'll be exposed. We might be able to surprise the Horde that way, but we wouldn't last long. Sooner or later we would have to retreat, and my daughter and Bow can't be saved that way." The Magicat smiles. It's a sly feline smile that Adora knows from earlier, when Catra and she played tricks on other soldiers.
"I never said that."

Adora eyes the Magicat and curiously notes, "You have a plan." Catra gives her a sly look, as if to silently ask, "You expected me to, didn't you?" before turning to the group.
"Indeed."

Over the next half hour, Catra explains her plan. "It's pretty reckless... but it might work." Huntara comments reluctantly, nodding appreciatively as Catra finishes. The Magicat nods back, seeming almost grateful to be backed up. Adora places a hand on her friend's shoulder and smiles.
"Reckless is our cue. I'm in."
For a moment the two women look into each other's eyes, and the blonde can feel the bond of support and trust that binds and strengthens them.

Then Catra smiles, too, and averts her eyes to look around, waiting. Frosta is the first to stand up. Motivated, she rubs her hands together.
"I'm in too!" Surprised, but full of joy, Adora looks at the ice princess.
"This is gonna be a great adventure! Count me in!" Sea Hawk agrees, earning an indignant look from Mermista.

Perfuma, Spinnerella and Netossa also agree to follow the plan. Even the queen agrees, although her concern for those involved is written all over her face. I the end, only Mermista remains on her chair, who is now looked at by everyone, waiting.

Finally, she groans and rolls her eyes before standing up, like the others before. "Urgh, alright. If we're going to run into a trap, at least let's do it with our eyes open!" The blonde could have sworn the corner of the sea princess's mouth twitched at that.
At that moment, Adora's heart fills with love for her friends. No matter how hard times are, or what disagreements there are, they stick together. She can't be thankful enough for that.

Shadow Weaver snorts. "If you want me to lead you to your deaths at all costs, then fine. Your choice." She stands up, then looks directly at Adora. "But keep in mind that you are weakened." "Glimmer and Bow are powerful, but we've saved them before." Adora erives firmly, holding her former mentor's gaze.
"Yes, but I'm not talking about them. You guys had help back then. What was that little one's name again? Entrapta, wasn't it? You know, the princess who now works for the Horde, and who used to be your friend."

With her words, she drove an ice-cold arrow into the heart of everyone in the room within seconds.
Entrapta.
Adora hasn't heard that name in so long. Instantly, she is overcome with a mixture of anger, guilt, and sadness. But she swallows her feelings resolutely and looks bravely at Shadow Weaver.
"We can do it without her. She didn't have magic."
"True, but you had some, didn't you?"

Silence.

In one sentence, the previously hopeful mood in the room seems to have been shattered. Shadow Weaver continues unapologetically, "Without She Ra, I don't think you should have

much chance of saving your friends."
All eyes in the room are on Adora, unsure of what to do or feel.

Coldness spreads through the blonde's body. And again, the shadow woman manages to corner Adora with just a few words. Giving her the feeling of not being enough.
Unfortunately, this time she can't do anything about it. She can't train, can't improve herself to satisfy others. No training in the world would succeed in bringing She Ra back.
Not without the sword.
The sword that Hordak now possesses.
Adora tenses and clenches her hands into fists before looking to the ground.

Shadow Weaver... is right.
Adora has failed.
Without the sword, they are lost. And if she fails again, not only would her friends be lost, but all of Etheria. Because of her alone.
But if she had already failed as She Ra, how could she NOT let everyone down as simple Adora?

Suddenly a warm hand reaches for hers and holds her tightly. Surprised, she looks beside her and finds Catra's eyes looking at her confidently. "Do you remember what I told you when you had the nightmare?" she whispers so softly that only Adora can hear it, although the hall is still silent. The blonde thinks about the night she snuggled up to Catra and cried because she had been so distraught.

She remembers her words.
'You're not weak. Stop worrying or doubting yourself. You have your friends, and you have me. Together we'll figure this out.'
The coldness inside her dissipates, and instead she smiles gratefully at Catra, who winks at her before addressing the group. "We'll get the sword back, too. And then we'll kick the Horde's butt!" Adora has to grin, because Catra has used the exact same words before.

And the confidence in her words tempts the blonde to think just as confidently. Silently she squeezes Catra's hand, and the Magicat returns the gesture. Netossa, meanwhile, shrugs her shoulders and says, "We've gotten through worse situations. We'll get through this, too."
The rest of the princesses also seem to have regained their confidence, as they now raise their hands in the air and shout, "Down with the Horde!"
Shadow Weaver shakes her head, but no one pays attention to her anymore.

A few hours later, around noon, the princesses, Sea Hawk, Queen Angella and Shadow Weaver gather in front of the Moonstone in the palace. All of them have prepared themselves in their own way for the upcoming mission. Sea Hawk even has a small crossbow with him that can shoot flammable arrows. Bow gave it to him just a few weeks ago.

Adora smiles sadly at the thought of her friend. She herself is armed with her extendable staff and stands with Catra a little apart from the others. The Magicat doesn't seem to be fully with it as Adora catches her frowning at the horizon. The blonde suspects where her thoughts are going. "I guess he won't be back in time." she voices her thoughts, watching Catra's reaction.

The Magicat tears her gaze away and doesn't even seem surprised that Adora saw through her so easily. Instead, she looks at her ruefully. "I'm sorry, Adora. I really thought he could do it." Adora smiles reassuringly and places a hand on the Magicat's shoulder. "Hey, it's okay. Your plan was good, it was worth a shot. And I wouldn't have let Swift Wind come along anyway."

The Magicat hesitates and lowers her eyes. "I just wanted to.... I thought... I didn't want to disappoint you again." Surprised, the blonde watches her friend before a comforting warmth spreads through her chest.
"You didn't."
The Magicat perks up her ears and looks to Adora. She winks

encouragingly at Catra, who seems to have a small weight lifted from her shoulders and is now smiling as well.

Their moment of togetherness is interrupted when Angella approaches Adora with a worried expression. "I'm not comfortable sending all of you into this dangerous area." she confesses. Adora had only with difficulty been able to persuade the queen to stay in Bright Moon, along with Huntara, in case they were attacked.

The blonde had also included her in Catra's original plan, just in case Swift Wind returned in her absence. While the queen was not exactly thrilled, she had not spoken against it either. Bravely, Adora now looks at Angella. "We will get Glimmer and Bow back, I promise."

"I know you will." the queen replies, now looking confident as well.
"Just... Take care of each other."
Glancing at Catra, she adds, "ALL of you."
Surprised, the Magicat blinks before Angella moves away and says goodbye to the other princesses as well. Catra looks after her thoughtfully. "She...cares." she murmurs. Adora agrees. "To her, we're all like her children, I think." Catra replies nothing, and finally Shadow Weaver's unnerved voice rings out, "Are we done cuddling then, and can we finally focus on what's important?"

Angella approaches the shadow woman, who is standing right next to the moonstone, and nods, now with a clearly distant expression. "You have my permission." There is a clear warning in her gaze.
"But should anything happen to these children at your hands, you will wish you had never set foot in Bright Moon."

Unmoved, the shadow woman returns the queen's gaze.
"Relax, your highness. I would never risk any harm coming to Micah's child." Then Shadow Weaver turns away and waves her hands. "Stand around me and join hands."

Everyone does as commanded, while Shadow Weaver turns almost reverently to the moonstone and places a hand on its huge surface. The stone begins to glow and connects with shadow-like tentacles that rise around the mage. The surrounding area is bathed in a purple light, and a sigh escapes the shadow woman as the powerful magic courses through her veins.

She then tears her gaze away from the stone without releasing her hand from the artifact, and extends her hand to Adora in a summoning manner. Hesitantly, the blonde beside her looks to Catra and first intertwines her hand with her friend's before they walk together towards Shadow Weaver. Slowly but purposefully, Adora takes Shadow Weaver's hand and looks into the circle of her friends, waiting.

Perfuma is the first one to step up beside Catra and takes her free hand. The Magicat twitches briefly, but quickly relaxes and nods to the flower princess. Perfuma even gives her a determined smile. Then the others approach and join hands, forming a human chain. At the beginning of this chain are Shadow Weaver and the stone.

"Good, now hold on tight and be still. This spell requires a lot of concentration." With a furrowed brow, the woman closes her eyes. For a few moments, there is complete silence. Then Adora hears a small pop as the purple light suddenly grows brighter and expolions, blinding the blonde. For a moment she has her eyes closed and feels strangely weightless. Then, when she opens them again, the feeling is gone.

Her friends still form a circle and still hold hands, however they are no longer in the palace, but surrounded by some trees and bushes. After a few moments, Adora recognizes the forest border of the Whispering Woods. The part that directly borders the Frightzone. Frosta is the first to wake up from her daze and break away from the others to push aside some bushes and plants. Almost excitedly, she whispers, "Guys, look!"

The others also loosen their hands and follow Frosta's gaze, which leads out onto the barren plains outside the gates of the

Frightzone. They are really here. Adora can hardly believe it. It is strange to see her former home again. Foreign and familiar at the same time. Beside her she feels the presence of the Magicat and looks to the side.

Catra's gaze is also on her old home, but her brow is furrowed and her nose wrinkled. The blonde begins to wonder what she feels at this sight. Both women left this place a long time ago, but Adora did it voluntarily. Catra, on the other hand, was kicked out. Sent to her death. Just the thought of her friend's fate makes Adora angry and hot to face Hordak. He would pay. For all the suffering he had caused her and her friends.

Catra seems to have felt the blonde's gaze, because she has turned to her and is now looking at her questioningly. Adora puts a hand on her shoulder, a silent assurance that she is there. The corner of the Magicat's mouth twitches in response, and her expression softens before she nods. Adora then turns to her friends and puts on a dangerous smile before muttering,

"Come on! Let's go rescue our friends!"

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter will be packed with action, which means it might take me a bit longer to write. Just so you know :)

Chapter 25

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

Together, the team sneaks up to the Horde's fortress and hides behind a group of trees some distance from the main gate. Adora then gives the signal to start, whereupon Perfuma, Frosta, Netossa, and Sea Hawk come out of hiding and stroll toward the entrance so relaxed that the guards there don't even register them as a threat at first.

With her sharp eyes, Catra watches as Sea Hawk finally stands just outside the gates and waves.
"Good evening! I heard you are in need of some excellent inspectors! Well, don't you worry, here they are!"
Meanwhile, the soldiers have reacted and started shooting at Sea Hawk, but before any of the projectiles can hit him, vines shoot out of the ground and build up in front of him to form a protective wall.

At the same time, Frosta yells at the top of her lungs, "Attack!" and in the next instant hurls a volley of icicles in the direction of the entrance. Protectively, most of the soldiers raise their arms above their heads, but some remain undeterred and continue to fire at the small force.

The Magicat sees two of the soldiers leaving their posts to sound the alarm, when they are suddenly caught and trapped by a huge net. What follows is a chaos of attacking creepers, raining ice chunks, fiery arrows and magic nets that eventually draws soldiers from the other entrances and leads to the main entrance. Perfect.

The Magicat smiles contentedly before looking at Adora, who is watching the whole event as well. They should not lose any more time. It's not clear how long Perfuma, Netossa, Frosta and Sea

Hawk can keep the soldiers at bay before they have to retreat. Adora seems to have the same thought, because she takes her eyes off the spectacle and tells the others to come along.

Together they sneak under cover of the trees to the western side entrance into the Frightzone. Only Shadow Weaver stays behind. She should wait until the team comes back to be ready for the escape. The only question is whether she would actually be there, Catra thinks bitterly. But she swallows the gloomy thoughts and concentrates on the task ahead of her.

By now they have a clear view of the much smaller entrance. As expected, there are ten soldiers standing there, the usual number of guards, although some have already moved to the front gate as reinforcements. That means they actually expected the princesses to try to enter here. Catra's eyes wander to the small, round indentation a few feet away in the wall. From it trickle small rivulets of sewage, which Mermista is already looking at with a dangerous grin.

Everyone waits for Adora's signal, who waits intently for the right moment. A few seconds pass, during which everyone holds their breath, before Adora finally nods to Mermista and extends her arm. The sea princess reacts immediately and draws a circle with her arms, looking at the sewer. The water reacts immediately. It begins to pile up until a huge wave rears up and rushes menacingly toward the soldiers. With a wave of her arm, Mermista washes away half of the soldiers.

The rest of them are so surprised that they look around frantically. At that moment, everyone jumps out of hiding, and Adora tackles the two soldiers standing closest to her. Spinnerella spins one around in a small tornado, and Catra effortlessly scratches the face of a soldier in front of her before giving him a heavy kick and knocking him out. Beside her, Adora just flings a guard to the ground.

Catra grins. "Not bad. But I was faster!"
"That´s not true!" the blonde protests. Spinnerella stares at the

two women, uncomprehending.
"Are you really turning this into a contest?!"
"Why not?" Catra grins and at the same moment turns around in a flash to give a chinlock to a soldier approaching from behind. Then she sees that some soldiers are getting up again, who were already lying on the ground, and leans forward, ready to fight.

"So, if this is a contest" Mermista's voice sounds at the entrance and she again makes a circling arm motion. A second wave crashes down on the remaining soldiers and washes them away mercilessly, without the men being able to do anything about it. This time the wave still reaches deep into the forest.
Satisfied, Mermista crosses her arms.
"Then obviously I have won."

Spinnerella just shakes her head before joining Adora in tampering with the door lock.

Although the Magicat disliked the Sea Princess the least at first, she can't help but smile at Mermista's behavior now. The Sea Princess notices her look and shrugs her shoulders, but it doesn't seem hostile. More like a step towards.... Acceptance? Catra can't quite describe it, but this brief, silent interaction feels.... good. Like a step in the right direction.

Meanwhile, Spinnerella and Adora have managed to open the lock. As unobtrusively as possible, the women slip through the door one by one and enter the interior of the Frightzone. Adora automatically takes the lead, with the Magicat bringing up the rear.
Carefully they sneak past marching troops and soon reach the center of the Horde.

They end up in front of one of the entrances, which is unguarded but blocked with a numerical code. Adora pauses and frowns. She doesn't seem to have expected this. How good that Catra is here. Silently, she walks past the other group members and quickly types in a combination of numbers. As she does so, her fur stands up in case the door sounds an alarm and the team has to retreat.

But in the very next moment, the keypad glows green and two sliding doors pull apart.
"How do you know the code?" Spinnerella whispers softly, but surprised. The Magicat shrugs. "Hordak never bothered to develop or change the numerical codes himself. That was MY job. I already suspected that he didn't bother to change them after… I left."

Adora gives her an appreciative look, but there is something else hidden in it.
A smile that is for a time from her childhood days.
She saw exactly how Catra typed in her favorite number. Catra quickly returns the look, it feels like a secret exchanged between the two before the group continues the journey and Catra takes the lead. She knows her way around here better than the others. Adora grew up here with her and knows roughly where the cells are, but as ordinary cadets they were never allowed to enter this wing.

Catra, on the other hand, as a former Force Captain (and prisoner herself) knows her way around this part of the Frightzone. That's why it doesn't take long until they walk through the first corridors full of cells. Most of them are empty. As mentioned before, Hordak usually doesn't care about prisoners.
At least not as long as he can't lure a very specific rebellion here.

Knowing that a trap could be lurking around every corner, everyone walks even slower and more cautiously after Catra. Then, finally, the Magicat discovers a cell that is filled. At first glance, she sees two figures sitting on the floor, leaning against each other.
At second glance, she sees pink glittery hair and a belly shirt.

Behind her, the Magicat hears a relieved sigh, and the next moment Adora rushes past her to the cell. The others do the same.
"Glimmer! Bow!" Adora shouts in a whisper. Two heads shoot up and look toward the exit of the cell. "Adora?" Glimmer asks in disbelief, and in the next moment runs to the transparent wall to

be as close as possible to her friend. Her dress is dirty and a little torn, but she seems unharmed.

Wide-eyed, she puts a hand on the glass and looks at the blonde. "Are you really here?"
"Of course. We would never leave you hanging!" the blonde confirms, smiling, before also placing a hand on the appropriate spot on the glass . She has her back to Catra, but the Magicat is sure she has tears in her eyes right now. Even Mermista smiles. "So glad that you are well!" Spinnerella says, relieved.

Bow now steps up as well and puts a hand on the glitter princess' shoulder. His look is a little exhausted, but his wide smile speaks for itself. "We knew you guys would come. It's so good to see your faces!"
"Are you guys okay?" Adora wants to know with concern, quickly letting her eyes wander over her friends in an examining manner. "Yes, everything is fine, I promise." When she can't detect any injuries, her shoulders relax.

Glimmer snorts. "Pff! All right, my ass! Those bastards are going to get something to hear from me! Where are they? I want to get them in the - "
"Later." Adora cuts in, now nodding to Mermista and Spinnerella. The two princesses then tamper with the lock of the cell door. "First we'll get you out of here."

Catra keeps a few meters distance and watches the action. She also makes sure that no unpleasant surprise awaits them so close to the finish line. However, when the two princesses now leave their place in front of the window, they give the occupants a view of the Magicat.
Bow discovers her first. Confused, and also alarmed, he raises his eyebrows.
"Is that...Catra?" Glimmer's eyes dart to the Magicat and immediately contort into a suspicious grimace. "What is SHE doing here! Adora, watch out!"

Adora raises her arms and steps a little closer to the glass. "Shhhh, it's okay. Catra is with us." The looks the blonde gets in response are ones Catra would have loved to capture in a photo. It's a mix of huge eyes, open mouths and brows raised to the hairline.
"What?!" Glimmer shrieks, and is silenced by Bow in the next moment. After all, they shouldn't be drawing too much attention to themselves here. But even if Bow isn't yelling, he looks doubtful. "I don't know, Adora. Are you sure?"

Confidently, the blonde smiles. "It's a long story and I guess you have many questions. But yes, I am sure. You can trust her, I promise." Indecisive, the prisoners look to the Magicat, who awkwardly waves at them and mutters, "Guess we're on the same team now, Sparkles."

"We're almost done. A few more minutes." Spinnerella comments, whose eyes are on the cell's keypad. Together with Mermista, she tries to cause a short circuit and thus cause the cell to open. It's complicated because the technology is actually protected against moisture, so it requires concentrated wind magic to get into the inner, non-waterproof systems.
Impatiently, Glimmer moves even closer to the glass and watches the princesses as they concentrate on passing two twisted strands of air and water through a tiny gap.

Catra uses this moment to take a few steps towards the cell and step directly behind Adora.
"Hey."
Gently, she places a hand on the blonde's shoulder, who turns to her questioningly in response. Looking unprepared so close into the gray-blue eyes, Catra has to swallow before murmuring softly, "I'm going now, then."
"What?! Where?" Adora is confused. They didn't discuss this part of the plan.
On purpose, Catra thinks, as she senses how hard it suddenly is for her to talk to the blonde about it.

But she bravely withstands her gaze.
"To Hordak. He's probably in his lab, so I'll go see him there."
"That wasn't part of the plan!" the blonde protests, and the Magicat can hear the concern in her voice. As calm as possible, she replies,
"Yes it was, I just didn't tell you."

Is that fear in Adora's face? Worry?
"You can't face him alone! What if something happens to you?"
That the blonde has so little faith in Catra's abilities offends Catra. Firmly, she looks her in the eye as she replies in a monotone voice,
"I'm not defenseless, Adora."

"I didn't mean it that way, but -"
"I have a score to settle with Hordak, remember? Besides, someone still has to get your sword."
Quickly, Catra is about to turn away and leave when Adora grabs her wrist. Her gaze is stubborn and determined.
"Then we will face him together. I won't leave you alone again!"
Before she can avoid it, the Magicat swallows hard and looks to the ground. She ignores the looks of the prisoners at the touch of the two women.
"Yes, you will."

With a jerk, she withdraws from Adora's touch before smiling. It feels wrong.
"You need to keep your friends safe. I'm the perfect distraction. No one will care about you. And Hordak doesn't know I'm on your side. The confusion is perfect!" One more time Adora reaches for her friend, but Catra is quicker and eludes her touch.

With heavy steps she turns away and walks a few meters away from the cell, when Adora's voice sounds once again softly but pleadingly behind her.

"Catra, please...stay."

The Magicat stops and turns around. Seeing the desperation and fear on Adora's face, she would have loved to turn back here and now and throw herself into her arms.

Quickly, she puts on a smile that not even she is convinced of, and tilts her head.
"I'll catch up, okay?"
Without waiting for an answer, she finally turns around and runs away.

At an incredible speed, she races through the corridors, which are so familiar and strange to her at the same time. Only in a small side corridor, far enough away from the prison wing and where she cannot be discovered, does she stop. She takes a deep breath and tries to dispel the heaviness in her chest.
It doesn't work.

Finally, she swallows resolutely and looks around warily before stepping out of the side corridor and continuing on her way to Hordak's lab. Every step feels wrong. Over the past few days, Catra has become so accustomed to the blonde's constant presence that now it almost feels as if she is leaving a part of herself behind. Almost like right after Adora left the Horde.

Resolutely, she pushes this thought away and concentrates instead on her surroundings. Twice she has to dodge a small troop of soldiers. The troops both march at a walking pace and do not seem concerned in any way. Good. This means that Perfuma and the others have managed to turn off all outside cameras and other attempts at information, and are really only concerned with the outer defenses.

Here, inside the fortress, they had no idea what was going on. Very good. That meant Hordak would not expect an attack. Just then Catra reached the corridor where Hordak's laboratory was located. There is not a soul here. Typical. Except for Entrapta, Hordak never wanted to see anyone here.

Entrapta.
She gulps as she thinks of the tech princess. What would it be like to see her again after a year? What kind of feelings does she have toward her anyway? She didn't think about that. Entrapta is the one who made the suggestion to send Catra to the Crimson Waste and thus to her death. On the other hand, she was just trying to save the Magicat from execution. So how does Catra feel about her?

She has always repressed everything about her past. That these questions are catching up with her right now is more than just inconvenient. With a quiet snort, she shakes the thoughts from her and sneaks sideways to the open entrance to Hordak's lab.

Holding her breath, she presses herself against the wall and sets her ears to listen. Some sounds she recognizes. The typing on a keypad, the blinking and beeping of a monitor, the crackling of some screws being tightened. She also hears scattered footsteps. Two people barely moving from the spot, she concludes.

She swallows, closes her eyes and takes another deep breath to collect herself. Then she opens her eyes, detaches herself from the wall and enters the room. The lab is quite large, though the equipment has changed since the last time she saw it. At first glance, she notices a few monitors on the wall and the usual pipes running along the ceiling and across the floor. In the center of the room is a plateau on which is a huge ring set up vertically. Several cables run out of the ring and spread to all corners of the room. Catra's fur automatically stands up at the sight of it.
Whatever this is, it doesn't bode well.

Then the person standing in front of the ring with his back turned to the Magicat demands her full attention. At first glance, he doesn't seem to have changed. A dark cape with the Horde symbol is draped around his shoulders, and his white skin seems to glow almost ghostly in the harsh lab light. His head is lowered and his gaze is engrossed on something in his hands that Catra cannot see.

He hasn´t noticed her presence yet. All at once, the Magicat becomes completely calm, inside and out. She has been waiting for this for a year. That's why she leans against the doorframe, relaxed, and crosses her arms, mocking,

"I didn't know you redecorated."

As her voice echoes through the room, Hordak's head snaps up and he jerks his torso around. When he sees Catra standing so casually at the doorway, his red glowing eyes widen. The Magicat suspects a mixture of surprise and anger, but exactly she can't place his look.

"Catra."

She grins provocatively. This was going to be funny.

"Hey, Hordak."

Chapter End Notes

> Okay, so, I decided to split the rescue in two parts, because it was mentally easier to focus on them. Does that make sense? I don't know. Sorry for the cliffhanger, but I could have been meaner and cut on a far worse point (uhhh foreshadowing hehe) Anyways I hope you liked the more action packed part :)

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

Hordak frowns and lowers the tracker pad in his hands.
"You're alive."
There's no emotion in his voice, just as if he doesn't care. And yet, the raised eyebrows at least signal that her appearance is unexpected.
"Surprised?" Leisurely, she steps into the room and takes a few steps toward him. The lord does not take his eyes off her for a moment.

Watchfully, he looks at her and asks, "What are you doing here?"
As lightheartedly as possible, she raises her arm and examines her claws. "Oh, you know, just thought I'd stop by, say hello, and bust your ass on the side. Be gone in a minute, then." It seems like Hordak wants to say something back, as the Magicat's ears begin to twitch.

A rumble sounds, and immediately a pink head emerges from behind one of the large screens. Entrapta. Her hair is holding various tools in the air, and her face is directed at the cables sticking out of the monitor. "Done! It should work again now."
Ignoring the other two people in the room, she leans her upper body forward and pats her hands. As she straightens back up, she spots the Magicat.
"Oh, hello Catra! Did you bring the First One's tech I asked for?"

A wide smile graces her face, and her voice sounds so carefree. So cheerful. Like they just saw each other yesterday. Her lightheartedness irritates Catra. And it makes her angry. Hurt.
In retrospect, Catra never cared for a close bond with the tech princess, but the two spent a lot of time together anyway. The

fact that Entrapta doesn't seem to have minded that Catra was absent and possibly dead for so long, ... bothers her.
The Magicat´s muscles tense, but before she can say anything back, Hordak intervenes.

Without taking his eyes off Catra, he mutters, "Entrapta, you'd better get out of here."
"Why?" Confused, Entrapta's gaze wanders back and forth between Hordak and the Magicat. This time Catra answers for him.
"Because I want to have a little talk with Hordak that might get a little out of hand." She crosses her arms.
"And believe me, you don't want to be there."

Entrapta tilts her head. She doesn't seem to quite understand what Catra means. Hesitantly, she looks to Hordak and waits for him to nod his head before finally shrugging her shoulders and leaving. "All right. I have to get some spare parts from the warehouse anyway."
After Entrapta leaves the room, Catra lets her gaze wander over the many cables and devices.
"It's been a while since I've been in here. I guess you still don't let anyone in here."

Frowning, her gaze lingers on the huge metal ring set up.
"What are you up to with all this stuff anyway? Is this supposed to be some weird art I don't have an eye for?"
She tries to make her voice sound casual. Indifferent. By doing so, she hopes to provoke Hordak and thus get him to talk.
It seems to work: The lord clenches his hands into fists at her words. "This is not art, but sophisticated technology that will do incredible things."

Bingo, we're getting closer.

"Yeah, right. Let me guess: You let Entrapta do all the work so you could later boast about her skill and ingenuity." Momentarily, Hordak lunges forward and seems about to reach for Catra, but the edge of the plateau he is standing on stops him. Therefore, he

just looks at her with hostility.
"Watch your cheeky stupid tongue! You don't even know what you're talking about." Slowly he steps backwards to the huge ring without taking his eyes off the Magicat. Purposefully and almost lovingly, he places a hand on the metal beside him.

"I have been drawing up plans for such a machine for years. It will surpass anything this world has seen before." Catra, too, begins to move. She circles the plateau like her personal prey, eyeing the ring skeptically. As she does so, her tail twitches back and forth.
"And what is that supposed to be, please?"
A cocky smile appears on Hordak's face.
"Something you couldn't imagine in your wildest dreams."

When Catra replies nothing, he continues, "Have you ever heard of Sandros? Or Derix? Carthania?"
Catra frowns. She doesn't know what Hordak is getting at. She's never heard of those terms.
"Those are names of planets." Although she doesn't mean to, the Magicat feels Hordak's words having their effect and throwing her off.
Confused, she asks, "What planets? There's nothing except Etheria."
"True." The smile on Hordak's face widens.

"In THIS dimension."

For a moment there is dead silence in the lab, in which Catra's thoughts seem to rattle so loudly that they should be audible for the whole Frightzone.
Then it goes 'click'. No, she thinks, stunned. He can't be serious.
"...You want to travel through dimensions with this thing?" Her casual facade crumbles.

Hordak gazes at the Magicat's bewilderment with satisfaction and strokes the metal of the ring almost lovingly.
"I will send this whole contaminated planet back to its original dimension and unite with my brothers. No one will be able to stop

me!"
To Catra, it all sounds like a big-headed lust for power, and she understands only half of what he says, but she can make sense of the principle: this machine is dangerous. For all of Etheria. Whatever exactly Hordak wants to do with it, it must be stopped.

Taking a deep breath before regaining her mask of composure, she straightens her back.
"Well, I think you overestimate yourself. After all, that's exactly what I plan to do, and I can assure you, I'm going to enjoy it. Every, single second until you beg me for mercy."
Hordak's smile disappears when he hears this threat. However, he doesn't look worried in the least. Instead, he raises an eyebrow almost boredly.

"Aren't you being a little dramatic?" Catra almost gasps, so indignant is she.
"Dramatic?! You tried to kill me!" she thunders angrily.
Coldly, the lord retorts, "You had it no better coming. You failed me, so you have to live with the consequences. That's how this world works, deal with it. And thanks to Entrapta, I was still gracious."

He actually seems to mean it. Catra can hardly believe it.
"GRACIOUS?" A bitter laugh escapes her throat. What else could she have expected from Hordak? Remorse? He seems to have never heard that term before.
"You don't even know what you're talking about. But never mind." She recovers her composure, gets to her knees, and extends her claws.
"I don't want to talk anymore. It's time to let you feel my vengeance. Let's see if you're the one who gets 'dramatic' then."

No sooner does she finish her sentence than she lunges at Hordak.

Adora:

"It's working!" Memrista exclaims excitedly, as in the very next moment small flashes dart across the keypad and the device soon begins to smoke. At the same moment, the divider dissolves and Glimmer and Bow step out of the cell. "Free at last!" the glitter princess exclaims in a whisper, drawing her fists to her chest. Her body seems to quiver with energy as she looks at her liberators, waiting.
"What now? Do we have an ambush planned? Or do we just roll over Hordak?"

But Spinnerella shakes her head, taking the wind out of her sails. "Nothing like that. We're going to get out of here now." "But-" Glimmer protests disappointedly, but Adora interrupts her by placing a hand on her shoulder.
"We can't risk losing you again. We'll put this off for another time, okay?" Bow seems to read the silent request in Adora's eyes, because he nods resolutely at her and puts an arm around Glimmer. "Okay. Then let's get out of here."

Glimmer grumbles, but doesn't protest further, instead letting Mermista and Spinnerella lead her through the corridors along with Bow. Adora brings up the rear. All are very quiet and careful not to draw attention to themselves. Adora is circumspect, but can't fully concentrate on the way to the exit. Again and again, the last conversation with Catra haunts her mind. The thought that she left her alone to go to Hordak makes her stomach hurt, but she tries to ignore it.

Catra can handle it. She is the best fighter Adora knows. She trusts her.
And yet... It feels wrong not to be with her. Those few days with her were like a wake-up call, reminding her that life with Catra by her side is just.... better. Right.
They've been through so much together. This wasn't going to be any different.

"How do you know which way to go?" Bow whispers at one point, after they've dodged a small troop of soldiers. Mermista keeps her eyes on the wall beside her, as if she sees something hidden from

the others. "We follow the course of the sewage. It's like a compass that guides our way out."
"That's... awesome!" remarks Bow, impressed.

It had been Catra's idea, Adora recalls. She asked Mermista at the meeting how her magic worked. If it was possible for her to feel and detect water without seeing it. Mermista, frowning, told her it was possible, and when Catra suggested the unusual but entirely plausible use of her gift, Adora could have sworn she read a hint of admiration in Mermista's eyes.
Typical Catra. She thinks of things and possibilities that others miss.

Catra... ´ I wonder if she's fighting Hordak right now? Or was she possibly caught? Injured?´ Again, the Magicat is haunting Adora's mind, and there is nothing the blonde can do about it. Frustrated, she sighs before resolutely focusing on her surroundings. If they get ambushed because Adora wasn't attentive enough, the blonde could never forgive herself.

However, all goes well. The friends get to the side exit they used as an entrance before without any problems. There are no guards in front of it, which means that the soldiers are probably still wandering around in the forest. Good. "Let's go, who knows how long the others will be able to distract the soldiers." Spinnerella whispers and tells the others to follow her. Bow still has his arm protectively around Glimmer and eagerly pushes his friend behind Spinnerella.

Mermista is about to join the group when she sees that Adora has stopped. "Are you coming?" she wants to know. Adora hesitates, looking out at her friends who are already disappearing into the forest.
Then she exhales loudly before confessing, "I can't."
The sea princess frowns. "What?"
"I can't leave Catra alone. I have to go after her."
Mermista tilts her head. "She'll be fine. She's been a pain in our ass for years, do you really think she's going to make it easy for Hordak?"

Mermista is right, of course Catra can take care of herself. And yet there's this nagging feeling inside Adora that she can't suppress, that she just HAS to go to her. That she has to be there for her. When the Sea Princess sees the doubt in Adora's face, she sighs and murmurs, "She'll be fine. She'll come when she's ready. And we'll wait for her, I promise."

The blonde hears the unspoken assurance, 'We won't make that mistake again.'

But it reminds her of a promise she herself made so long ago: 'You look out for me, and I look out for you.'

This phrase moves something in Adora and permeates her body, as if something settles into place. Determined, she looks at Mermista and takes a step back.
"I can't let her down again."

Whatever the sea princess reads on the blonde's face, it makes her raise her eyebrows in amazement. And then - she smiles. A nod.
"Well then. I'll let the others know you'll be late."
Relieved, a smile spreads across Adora's face as well. Mermista turns away and waves goodbye before running off into the forest.
"Good luck!"
Adora wastes no time, but runs back through the corridor, into the heart of the Frightzone.

Catra:

The Magicat ducks just in time before a projectile flies by just above the tip of her nose. Breathing quickly, Catra jumps back to her feet to leap toward Hordak, but he keeps her at a distance with his handgun. The bullets he shoots are made of some kind of concentrated energy and explode as soon as they hit resistance. A few times, these bullets have missed the Magicat's body by a hair's breadth.

Nevertheless, she already bears traces of the fight: Since she always has to dodge so quickly, she already has some scratches and bruises from objects that got in her way during her evasive maneuvers. Hordak has been able to keep her at a distance for the most part so far, but he, too, already bears traces of the fight. His cape is torn, the few hairs on his head are a mess, and Catra is particularly proud of the huge scratch above his eyebrow. Still, if she doesn't get to him more often, this fight will quickly tire her out and make her careless.
Then she will be lost.

As another bullet rushes toward her, she dives to the side and takes a quick look at the black mark the bullet left in the wall. How long has she been fighting here? A few minutes? An hour? She can't gauge it anymore. All she knows is that she has to change her strategy. Otherwise, Hordak would win. When the lord points his gun at the Magicat again and pulls the trigger, Catra doesn't dodge.
Instead, she sprints straight at the bullet.

At the last moment, she stretches her body into the air and barely leaps over the trajectory of the bullet. It lands with a bang in the wall behind Catra, but she pays no attention to it and focuses on Hordak, who looks at her speechlessly as she sprints towards him. He wants to raise his gun again and aim at her, but this time she is faster: As soon as she reaches him she throws her foot up and kicks the gun out of the lord's hand.
It clangs as it hits the ground a few feet away.

Before Hordak can react, Catra angrily slams her fist into his face. Hordak ducks and goes to punch her in the side, but she dodges and kicks him in the knee from behind instead, knocking him to the ground. "Without your weapons, you are nothing." Catra triumphs, breathing heavily, before lunging with her claws and aiming for his face. However, Hordak manages to dodge and get back to his feet.

Now he is angry, too. With his claws he tries to grab Catra. She dodges him, but he catches her tail and pulls on it. Startled, Catra

hisses and her fur stands up. The sudden pain has distracted her so much that she can't avoid the next punch. With full force, Hordak punches her in the stomach, forcing her to the ground. As he stands over her, he looks down at her, breathing heavily. "And you are nothing without your cheeky sayings."

An angry snarl leaves her mouth and she goes to stand up, but Hordak has placed a foot on her chest and forces her to remain on the ground. Growling, she stretches out her arms and gets hold of the weapon Hordak dropped earlier. Without further ado, she grabs it and hits the lord in the face with it with full force. He instantly lets go of Catra and staggers back a few steps. Catra drops the weapon and leaps to her feet before lunging at Hordak again, claws extended to give him a deep cut that extends from his nose to his collarbone. Hordak lets out a sound that Catra has never heard before. But it sounds painful.

For a moment, she allows herself to look away from her enemy and get her bearings. By now they have reached the back of the lab. In the corner, right against the wall, a sword has been hung. Catra would recognize it anywhere. With its warm colors, it clearly stands out from the cool greens and blues of the rest of the environment.
"What a pretty sword." Catra remarks, looking to Hordak, who is just regaining his composure.
"I think I'll take that as a souvenir."

Immediately the lord's expression stiffens and his voice takes on a dangerous tone. "Oh no you won't!" But Catra is already jumping backwards and rushing towards the wall. In no time at all she jumps up, claws, grabs the sword and releases it from its holder before dropping and landing with both feet on the ground. A little breathless, she looks at the sword in her hand. She's done it. Now she just has to -

Swish!

A bullet hits her wrist and rips the sword from her hands. The weapon is flung across the room and bounces off the opposite

wall before coming to rest on the floor. Catra gasps in pain and reflexively pulls her hand to her chest. Hateful, she looks to Hordak, who is gazing contentedly at his victim with his weapon in his arms. "Seems you're not as good as you thought after all," he comments. She is about to retort something when one of the screens suddenly announces a call and moments later a soldier's face appears on it.

"Lord Hordak! We are under attack! The rebellion has been attacking the front gates for half an hour!"
"What?!" For a moment, Hordak seems flustered.
"Why didn't you inform me sooner!"
"We tried, but the princesses prevented us every ti -"
Suddenly an icicle looms behind the soldier, the image blurs, and the call ends abruptly.

For a moment, the room is silent.

Then Hordak looks angrily at Catra.
"This is your doing, Magicat, isn't it?!" The rage that is now obviously boiling inside him causes a certain satisfaction in Catra, masking the pain in her hand. Triumphantly, she shrugs her shoulders.
"You know, I could go on and on right now about how you've been hoodwinked, but unlike you, I'm not stupid enough to reveal my ingenious plan to you."
It seems to only make Hordak more aggressive. However, he suddenly pauses and takes a deep breath before smiling.
"How fortunate that I don't even need to know your plan to eliminate you once and for all."

No sooner have the words left his mouth than he takes the gun in both hands and presses a small button on it. Suddenly, Catra feels differently. She's been a Force Captain long enough to know what that button stands for. It works like an upgrade, causing the energy balls to be encased in lightning, allowing them to do far more damage.
As he points the gun at her, her muscles tense again to dodge in

time - as she is distracted by approaching footsteps at the entrance to the lab.

Her ear perks up, and for a millisecond her gaze jerks to the entrance. There she spots a blond mop of hair. Incredulous, she looks closer and for a moment forgets about the guy with the gun in front of her as she looks into Adora's worried face. The blonde is standing at the entrance, panting from having run earlier. Strands of hair have come loose from her ponytail and she looks a little exhausted, but the gleam in her eyes when she meets Catra's gaze erases any fatigue.

Catra is... She doesn't know herself exactly what she feels. She didn't expect Adora to follow her.
She didn't dare to hope.
On the other hand, should she really be surprised? It is exactly what Adora is doing.
And Catra is so grateful to her for it at this moment. Just seeing her gives her new energy. Even the corner of her mouth twitches as she looks at the blonde.

What she hasn't considered is that Adora's appearance has made her inattentive for a moment.

One moment too long.

Suddenly, she feels a blast wave that jerks her body to the ground.
Someone shouts. "CATRA!"
A hot pain spreads explosively through her chest and shoulder.
She doesn't perceive more before she is pulled into a deep blackness and loses consciousness.

Adora:

As fast as she can, she runs toward Catra, but she is too late. She watches in horror as the Magicat is hit by one of the energy balls and knocked to the ground. Panic spreads through her body like

an electric shock as Catra does not move. Hordak looks at her from several meters away, almost satisfied, but although he still holds the weapon in his hands, Adora only has eyes for Catra.

Finally she reaches her friend and falls to her knees in front of her lifeless body. The Magicat's head is turned to the side, her ribbon has come loose and her hair lies spread out on the floor like a fan. A dark wound gapes on her left shoulder, smelling suspiciously of burning.
Horrified, Adora takes a closer look.
At the edges of the wound she discovers burnt fur, and in the center she sees open, bleeding flesh. The injury extends from her cleavage to her left breast.
Much too close to the heart, Adora thinks fearfully.

"Catra..." she whispers, reaching out a hand toward the Magicat's face. No response. Her eyes are closed and her mouth slightly open. Is she still breathing? Panicked, the blonde puts a hand on her friend's chest and almost starts crying with relief when she feels a very slight lifting and lowering.
But Catra still does not stir. Who knows how much longer she can hold out. Adora is not familiar with wounds, especially of this kind. Catra... Desperately, she strokes the Magicat's cheek. 'Why didn't you let me go with you?!'

A voice interrupts her thoughts. "'Ah, you must be Adora. How nice to meet you in person. Or should I rather call you - She Ra? I must say, you look far less annoying without your sword." Anger seizes her. Anger at the one who did this to her friend. She tears her gaze away and turns to the Lord of the Horde instead.
"What did you do to her?!"
Hordak shrugs. "What she deserves. It's her own fault." The indifference in his voice makes the blonde almost sick. Adora clenches her hands into fists.
"Leave Catra alone. Your quarrel is with me."
"True."

As Hordak points the gun at her and fires, she manages to throw herself aside just in time. The bullet, however, narrowly misses

the Magicat's motionless body before exploding against the wall behind it. The blonde's heart clenches in fear. Catra must not be hurt any more! She must get away from the Magicat, lest Hordak accidentally hit her.

With a heavy heart, she runs in the opposite direction and just barely escapes another passing bullet. With a furrowed brow, she doesn't take her eyes off Hordak. She has to take that gun from him, but to do that she has to get to him and she can't do that as long as he keeps shooting bullets at her. That's why she can't do more than dodge and run across the lab, always looking for cover. Feverishly, she thinks of a way out, but she can't concentrate properly under the constant fire.

When another bullet shoots at her, she dodges it, but looks to the side and is horrified to see that she is standing only a few feet away from Catra. Unconsciously, she must have moved in a circle once. Panic seizes her as the bullet hits the ground just next to Catra's leg and explodes.
"Catra!" she cries in fright, reaching out to her but unable to move to her as Hordak continues to point the gun at her.

Now, however, he raises an eyebrow in surprise. "Oh."

He looks back and forth between Adora and Catra for a moment before curling his lips into a grin.
"For years I tried to find She Ra's weakness. I believed that if I removed the source of your power, that would be the end of it. It seems I have just found another weakness."
Quick as a flash, he points the gun at the lifeless Magicat.

"NO!"

Adora runs as fast as she can and rushes between Hordak and Catra, shielding her friend with her body. She sees the bullet coming towards her, everything happens so fast.
But whatever happens, she would protect Catra.
If it had to be, even with her life.

Then the blonde suddenly feels something begin to glow inside her. Something seems to awaken. Power unleashes in her chest and floods her body with a glistening light. Just as Hordak's bullet is about to strike her, the pulsing energy inside her seems to explode, forcing Adora to throw her head back and push through her back.
A glistening wave of light leaves her body, so bright that tears well up in Adora's eyes, but she cannot close them. She is as if in a delusion.

Only peripherally does she notice how the bright wave of energy spreads through the room and hurls Hordak several meters through the air.
She can't think a clear thought, all she feels is.... Power. Strength. Warmth.

Then - as quickly as this feeling has come - it disappears.

The pulsating light retreats and disappears inside her, as if locking itself away. Adora is able to move on her own again and slumps to her knees from the sudden loss of strength. She takes a few deep breaths in and out, trying to clear her head.
Confused, she puts a hand over her heart. What was that just now? It felt similar to the outburst in the She Ra Ruin.
Almost like... No, she can't think about that now. She has other things to worry about now. 'Focus, Adora!´

Blinking, she looks around. Hordak has been thrown against the opposite wall and now lies unconscious on the floor. The weapon has been ripped from his hands. She continues to look around. The energy wave has caused some damage. Some rocks are breaking down from the ceiling and the floor is vibrating. It is dangerous to stay here. She must leave immediately!

Quickly Adora rushes to Catra and raises her upper body when her eyes fall on something shining.

'My sword' she thinks in surprise and relief before her thoughts cloud over again. The sword is at the other end of the lab, and

the room could collapse at any moment. Hesitantly, she glances at Catra, who hangs her head and doesn't move. She can't get them both out of here.

Once again she glances at the sword - at her chance to be She Ra, a chance to save the world.
Then she takes one look at Catra's face, and determination grips her.
Quickly, she grabs her under the knee and back and lifts her up before rushing out of the room.
She doesn't look back.

Instead, she runs through the corridors, barely noticing the soldiers she encounters. They are busy elsewhere and pay no attention to the intruders, distracted and confused by the vibrating earth. Some run around screaming, others stand perplexed waiting for orders, but Adora doesn't care about them. She focuses on getting Catra out of here. The Magicat needs help by a healer, and urgently.

It couldn't have taken more than a few minutes, but to Adora it feels like hours before she finally arrives at the exit and steps outside with Catra in her arms. Out here the earth no longer vibrates, but the guards at the entrance have determined that something is wrong with the inside of the Frightzone, so in the confusion no one notices two figures disappearing into the bushes and leaving under cover of the forest.

Out of breath, Adora finally reaches the agreed meeting place, where the others are already waiting for her. Perfuma, Frosta and Sea Hawk have also arrived there.
"There you are! Did you-" Glimmer begins as her eyes fall on the Magicat in Adora 's arms.
"What-" she asks, confused, but stops herself as she looks into the worried face of the blonde.
"She needs a healer." Is all Adora can say.

That's when Shadow Weaver appears next to the others. "Adora, what took you so long?" When she too spots the Magicat, her look

turns snide.
"Seriously? You brought the others in danger for HER?" Though Adora feels anything but like talking, and her thoughts turn solely to getting Catra treated as soon as possible, she does now tighten her shoulders and look her former mentor firmly in the eye.

Under other circumstances, her words would have manipulated her and made her feel guilty.
But not anymore. Not on this occasion.
"I won't leave anyone behind ever again!" There is silence for a few moments before Shadow Weaver finally asks contritely,
"And what about the sword? Where is it?"

The others look at her intently as well. The mention of the sword causes an uncomfortable twinge in her chest, and Adora has to lower her eyes. It's as if Shadow Weaver has a gift that always shows her what words she can use to hit those around her the hardest.
Adora could curse her for that, but she has other things to worry about now.

Fortunately, Bow comes to her rescue.
"Well, we can work that out at home. Let's get out of here first." Gratefully, she looks at Bow, who smiles at her, but she is in no condition to smile back. The others nod in agreement, and Shadow Weaver, while not looking besotted, holds out his hands in invitation. Spinnerella and Mermista reach for it, and the others join in.
Perfuma and Frosta stand at Adora 's side, each clasping one of the blonde's arms as she still holds Catra. "Hold on." The shadow woman orders, before purple tentacles spread and Adora feels that strange tingling sensation again.

A blink later, she is already in the garden of Bright Moon Castle. She wastes no time, stumbling inside the palace with Catra in her arms. The Magicat still hasn't given any sign of life. The knot of fear in Adora 's stomach seems to grow with each passing moment. 'Hold on, Catra!' she pleads inwardly. 'Hold on!'

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for keeping you waiting, but this was the hardest chapter to write for me yet. I´m not good at writing action packed scenes, but I think I did okay on this one.

Chapter 27

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Entrapta:

The earth has stopped shaking.
Entrapta rushes through the corridors, almost running over a few soldiers. Finally, she arrives in front of the laboratory and looks around anxiously as she enters. It looks exactly as the monitors showed: The lab is devastated, sporadically the walls show black stains from explosions and some pieces have fallen from the ceiling.

Only the metal ring that she placed vertically on the pedestal in the middle of the room is still standing and seems to have sustained no damage. In the far corner, the princess finally spots the figure she has been looking for.
"Hordak!"
Concerned, she rushes to him and kneels beside the lord, who lies dazed on his back on the ground. He too has some damage to his body, Entrapta notices, but nothing seems particularly bad. At least not at first glance.
Of course, she'll examine it more closely.

As the princess jiggles her friend's shoulder, he awakes and coughs a few times before opening his eyes.
"En...trapta?"
"You're okay!" she groans in relief, helping him sit up.
"Are you in pain?" He shakes his head, his eyes grow wide as he looks around searchingly.
"The sword..." he mumbles hoarsely, before looking at Entrapta in search of help. "The sword! Did she... Is it..."

Entrapta looks around now, too, and spots a soft golden glow at the other end of the room, obscured by some debris. Without

hesitation, she walks up to it and clears some debris to the side before spotting She Ra's sword. Without a scratch, it lies there, seemingly waiting to be used.
Quickly, the princess bends down and picks it up before walking back to Hordak with it to show him. When he sees the sword in her hands, his worry lines smooth out. "Ahh. Very good."

As he takes the sword from her hands and looks at it, Entrapta says quietly, "I watched your conversation with Catra over the security cameras.... And also, everything that happened after." Appraisingly, Entrapta eyes the lord, watching his reaction. Hordak pauses, but does not raise his eyes or respond.

The princess is not sure what to think. The images transmitted to her were horrifying. Experiencing Hordak so brutally has left her.... unsettled. Catra's behavior has also frightened her. At the same time, she can understand the actions of both.

She doesn't know how to feel, so she distracts herself with facts.

"I saw Adora use her power!" she continues, and there is now an enthusiastic tone mixed into her voice after all. Hordak, on the other hand, grits his teeth.
"Yes. I've experienced that, too. As it seems, She Ra is not completely powerless without the sword."
However, Entrapta shakes her head. "That seems to be true, but that's not what I mean."

Frowning, Hordak looks up. It has not escaped his notice that the princess seems to want to share a realization with him. She doesn't keep him in suspense any longer, but tells him enthusiastically, "The moment the energy wave went out from Adora, the sword started glowing. It was only for a moment, but I'm pretty sure now that the sword was activated by She Ra's power!"
"How interesting." Entrapta can see the lord's gears begin to turn in his mind as well. Enthusiastically, the princess continues to speak.

"I am now certain that the trigger for the unleashing of the energy is solely She Ra himself!"
"So, in order to activate the sword and thus create the portal, we need Adora!" concludes Hordak, frowning. Entrapta considers.
"How unfortunate that she's gone again. Now how can we convince her to come here again?"
"We don't have to." Hordak doesn't seem the least bit perturbed as he takes the sword in both hands and watches his reflection contentedly in the edge.

"She Ra was here to get her sword and failed. So she won't let up until she gets it."
His face contorts into a sly grin.
"Let's just let her come to us. We'll wait for her and give her a proper welcome."

_____

Adora:

Inside the castle, some guards approach them with a worried look. "You're back again! Is something -"
"She needs a healer right away!" Adora blurts out, pointing her head at Catra. The guards understand and go for help. A few minutes later, which seem like an eternity to Adora, a healer arrives with two helpers wheeling a cot in front of them.

The healer's dark skin contrasts with the white kimono he wears. Adora has seen him before. His name is Razon, if she remembers correctly.
"What happened?" Razon wants to know.
"She...she took a ball of energy. With...with lightning. I..."
Suddenly the blonde feels so helpless.
But the man muses at her kindly from his deep brown eyes.
"I see."

He beckons his two helpers to push the cot next to Adora and points to the Magicat.
"Please put her down." Resistance stirs in Adora and her fingers tighten, pressing into the Magicat's thighs.
She doesn't want to let go of Catra. Not again.
But she has to realize that the healer can help her better. So she bends down and carefully drapes Catra on the cot, careful not to touch her wound.

Absently, she looks at the Magicat's face. If it weren't for the gaping wound, you'd think she was just sleeping. Out of reflex, she brushes a strand of hair from Catra's forehead. Then Razon stands in front of Adora.
"We have to take her to the treatment room now."
"Can't I come with you?" Adora asks timidly, squinting past the healer so as not to take her eyes off Catra. She gets the shake of the head anyway.

"Unfortunately, no. But we'll let you know right away if anything happens, alright?" When Adora doesn't respond, Razon gives her shoulder a quick squeeze and looks at her reassuringly.
"She's in good hands." The blonde doesn't manage more than a nod.
It's enough for the healer, as he then turns and leads the two helpers back into the hallway from which they came.

Adora watches as Catra is pushed away until she disappears behind a corner.
Then she is alone. She feels her muscles give way and she sinks to the floor.
Whether from fear, worry, or exhaustion, she can't tell.

She doesn't know how much time has passed, sitting on the floor and staring at the spot where she last saw Catra. In any case, at some point she is jolted out of her trance by a touch on her shoulder.
She flinches, and when she looks up, Glimmer and Bow are standing next to her.

"Hey." Glimmer murmurs cautiously, looking at her with a furrowed brow.

Immediately, Adora feels the guilty conscience gnawing at her. In all the commotion, she almost forgot about her two best friends. How could she?!
"How are you guys doing?" she wants to know honestly, grabbing one of her friends' hands each. Bow smiles and kneels on the floor with her.
"We're fine. The others have gone to rest." He hesitates. "Maybe you should too?"

Shaking her head fiercely, Adora turns her gaze again to where she last saw Catra.
"I can't. I have to wait for Catra. Someone has to be with her when she wakes up. Surely I may go to her any moment now." At the last words, she can't stop her voice from beginning to tremble and her muscles from tightening. She feels her eyes moisten as she looks at her two friends.
"Nothing's going to happen to her, right? She's going to be okay?"

Glimmer and Bow look at her uncertainly. The blonde is aware that she sounds like a naive little child. But she can't help but cling convulsively to the childish hope that everything will be okay. That Catra will be fine again. Because if it doesn't, then....
Adora doesn't want to think about it.

Her friends seem to notice how desperate she is right now, because now Glimmer also sits down on the floor next to her and puts a hand on her shoulder.
"Hey." Her features are soft, but you can see her struggling to find the right words. She's obviously having a hard time comforting her best friend, who is currently fearing for her former enemy.
"You know Catra. She's not that easy to defeat." The glitter princess gives Adora a small, confident smile.

"She'll be fine."
"Right." Bow agrees with her and puts an arm around Adora as well.

"Catra is one of the...strongest people I've ever met. And she's in good hands with our best healer."
Alternately, Adora looks at the confident faces next to her and feels her heavy heart lighten a tiny bit. On impulse, she wraps her arms around her two friends and pulls them close.
"I missed you guys so much!"
"We missed you too!"

The three of them just hold each other for a while, giving each other strength. Then Bow loosens the embrace and smiles at Adora.
"So, you and Catra..." There is no judgment, no evaluation or assumption in his words, but this sudden change of subject and the way he phrases it make heat rise in Adora's cheeks.
"What do you mean?" she asks as innocently as she can, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. She must look terrible by now, but she couldn't care less right now.

Glimmer answers for Bow and tilts her head.
"Well, you two were mortal enemies and were at each other's throats on a regular basis. Then Catra disappears for a year and suddenly you two come out of nowhere and act as a natural team to save us, like it was never any other way." she sums up the situation and raises an eyebrow.
"You have to admit, there are quite a few holes in that story for us."
"Well, when you put it that way..." Adora agrees, sliding around a little unsteadily on the floor.

Bow gives her an encouraging smile.
"Do you want to tell us how it happened?" Adora thinks for a moment. She doesn't know if talking about the Magicat right now will do her any good. On the other hand, she needs a distraction and her best friends deserve an explanation. So she takes heart and nods in agreement. In response, Glimmer and Bow also slide around on the floor to find a more comfortable position before looking at the blonde in wait.
Adora takes a deep breath before she begins.
"Shortly after you were kidnapped..."

Adora tells her friends in detail how she met Catra in Crimson Waste and persuaded her to join her in fighting the Horde. She also tells how the two of them became closer on their journey. Purely platonic, of course. The thought that it could be any other way brings a blush to the blonde's cheeks, so she hurriedly goes on to tell how the two have become friends again.

Glimmer frowns in disbelief. "Just like that? You hated each other for years!"
A small twinge arises in her chest as Adora thinks of the long time she was separated from Catra, but she has to contradict the princess.
"I never hated Catra. I was often angry with her or disappointed in her, but..." Waiting, her friends look at her.
How can she make Bow and Glimmer understand? How can she describe this bond that has linked her to the Magicat for a lifetime?

Hesitantly, she begins, "I KNOW Catra. I´ve known her all my life. She was my best friend for 18 years. And even though she has made mistakes in the past.... I can't help but forgive her. I just feel that it's.... right."
Bow's expression softens. "I think I understand what you mean. When you've known someone your whole life, you can't just forget them." Meaningfully, he looks to Glimmer.
"Not for any argument in the world."

Glimmer also looks at him and gives him a warm smile. when she looks back to Adora, she seems concerned.
"I guess we never really asked you how you felt about the situation with Catra. She was your best friend, after all, and suddenly you had to fight her. I... never paid attention to that fact." she admits.
Adora tilts her head. "Well, I guess I'm not exactly the type to ask for emotional help either."
"True."

For a brief moment, the three of them laugh before Glimmer continues, "I admit, it's...hard for me to think of Catra as a good

friend. But what you tell me about her tempts me to give her a chance."
Surprised, Adora looks at her. "Really?"
Glimmer nods. Bow smiles, too. "Your friend is our friend, too."
"Hey, I never said we were instant friends!" Glimmer protests, but it's only half-heartedly meant and makes Bow and Adora laugh.
"Thank you, guys." the blonde mumbles, hoping her friends hear how much relief and gratitude is in her words.

Then a voice interrupts their little fellowship.
"Glimmer?"
In the next moment, Queen Angella enters the room and lets her eyes wander searchingly through the air. When Glimmer spots her mother, her eyes moisten.
"Mom!" she exclaims with a mixture of wistfulness and relief as she jumps up and runs toward her mother.

The queen also has tears in her eyes as she wraps her arms around her daughter, as if she never wants to let her go.
"Oh, my child! My little daughter!"
"Mom!" Glimmer complains, but it sounds more like a relieved sigh.
"I missed you so much!"
"I missed you more!"

With a smile, Adora watches the reunion between mother and daughter. After a while, the queen also pulls Bow into her arms, who is a little surprised, but hugs her afterwards.
Finally, Angella looks at Adora, who is still sitting on the floor, and approaches her with a smile.
"I thank you, Adora. For bringing my daughter back to me."
"It was my pleasure, your majesty." The queen extends a hand to the blonde and helps her to her feet before giving her a quick hug as well.

"The others told me that Catra was injured." she murmurs close to Adora's ear, and immediately the warmth the blonde felt a moment ago disappears. The queen notices Adora tense up, and pulls back to look at her lovingly.

"I assure you, she'll get the best treatment we can provide. I'll see to that personally."
"Thank you, your majesty." That's all she can produce. Too afraid her concern for Catra might engulf her.

Encouragingly, Angella squeezes her shoulder. "You should get some rest. But first, I have one more request." Puzzled, Adora raises an eyebrow.
"Swift Wind returned from his journey a few hours ago.... successfully."
If the blonde were a Magicat, her ears would be perking up right now. Instead, her body straightens and she looks in surprise at the Queen, who points down the hall.
"He's waiting for you in your room."

Adora is about to leave when she looks back to Glimmer and Bow once more, hesitantly. But the two assure her with a glance that it's okay to leave them here. So Adora turns away and walks to her room with mixed feelings.
In all the commotion, she almost forgot Catra's first idea. Without the Magicat by her side, she doesn't know how to act, but she doesn't have time to think about it for long, because the next moment she has arrived in front of her room and enters.

There she sees Swift Wind and another person sitting in the middle of the room, talking eagerly.
"...And he said if he heard me sing one more time, he'd throw me off a cliff!" the guest laughs, and Swift Wind snorts hilariously.
"No way! That kind of thing happens to me all the time too!" The guest's eyes widen.
"Yeah really?"

Adora interrupts the two with a clearing of her throat. When Swift Wind turns his head toward her, he beams at her.
"Adora! You're back!"
His joy tempts her to smile as she walks up to him and wraps her arms around his neck.
"I am. I'm glad nothing happened to you." She glances at the guest and tilts her head uncertainly.

"I see you accomplished your mission."
"A little late, but yes." he replies, looking proudly at the guest, who suddenly seems less comfortable under Adora's gaze.

"Uhm... Hi! I am Scorpia." she greets Adora sheepishly.
"I know." the blonde replies, looking at the woman indecisively.
"I... am Adora."
"I know." There is silence for a few seconds, during which Swift Wind looks perplexedly back and forth between the two women. Then finally Adora says, "Thank you. Uhm, for wanting to fight the horde with us."

"No problem!" Scorpia replies quickly, smiling sheepishly.
"I'd do anything Catra asked me to."
She says it so openly, so honestly, as if it's just the simple way Scorpia ticks. Somehow this sentence stings Adora's chest, and not because of the state the Magicat is in right now. Before she can think about this strange feeling, Scorpia seems to remember something.
"Speaking of which... Where is Catra?" Once again Adora's chest begins to sting, but this time she knows exactly why. Uncomfortable, she bites her lip and looks to the ground.

"She... Hordak hurt her." Scorpia's expression changes from friendly and nervous to worried and alarmed in a second.
"WHAT, oh my - is she all right? How did this happen? Has she been taken care of? Is she badly hurt? Where is she? I really need to help her!"
The rush with which the tall woman in front of her suddenly speaks, the huge gestures she makes, and the blonde's own worries are too much for Adora.

She doesn't know how to deal with Scorpia. Before, they were enemies. She doesn't know much about the woman, except that she was close to Catra. Which is saying a lot, considering it's the Magicat.
"She would have needed me, wouldn't she? I should have been there sooner. Maybe we would have gotten there on time if I hadn't packed a few more things and..." She babbles on, but

Adora can't really listen.
She doesn't feel in a position to adequately comfort the Scorpion woman, and at the same time, her obvious concern stirs up the blonde's fears even more.

Before she can react, someone knocks on the door of the room and Perfuma pokes her head in.
"Adora? Sorry to bother you, but the queen told us that Swift Wind -"
She stops herself when she spots the alicorn along with Scorpia still babbling to herself.
"Oh." is all she makes and enters the room. Seeing the distressed face of Adora, she tilts her head questioningly.
"Are you all right?" Adora can't manage more than a shake of her head and a desperate look at Scorpia.

Perfuma then turns to the tall woman and smiles kindly at her.
"Hi. You must be Scorpia. Catra's friend, right?" The plant princess' voices snaps Scorpia out of her babbling.
"I... Yes, I am."
"I see." Her smile remains as she takes one of the tall woman's arms in her hands.
"Don't worry, your friend is fine. A healer is taking care of her."
The worry lines on Scorpia's face smooth out a bit.

"I'm Perfuma, by the way. We've met a few times before." Scorpia seems distracted from her worries for a moment.
"Ohhh, right! You always create those giant plants and dangerous vines when you fight!" Perfuma giggles, and it sounds like she's actually amused by Scorpia. Adora can only watch, speechless.
"Well, that's true, but my magic can do more." With a wave of her hand, she makes a small flower appear in Scorpia's scissor hand, which the tall woman looks at in amazement.

"Wow, it´s beautiful. You know, I love flowers, although I haven't seen many yet."
"Really? I'm sure you'd make a great gardener!"
"You think?" Now Scorpia is smiling too, and before she knows it, Perfuma has taken her gently by the arm and is about to lead her

out of the room.
"Come, I'll show you the royal garden. There are thousands of flowers there!"
"Wow, so many ? I can't imagine!" Just before they step out of the room, Perfuma looks at Adora again and gives her an encouraging wink.

She saw exactly that Adora is overwhelmed, and took the helm. Then the two of them are gone.
"Wow. Well, that went great!" remarks Swift Wind contentedly, but Adora pays no attention to him but drops onto the bed, exhausted. Frowning, the alicorn walks over to her and nudges her with his muzzle.
"Is everything all right? Would you like me to sing you a song?" Tiredly, the blonde smiles at her noble steed to reassure him that all is well. Gently, she strokes his nostrils.

"No, thank you. I think I just need some time alone." Swift Wind hesitates, but pulls back.
"All right, if you say so. If you need anything, you can find me in the kitchen looking for apples." Adora replies nothing as the alicorn leaves her room as well. As the clatter of hooves fades, there is a sudden silence in her room.
It feels like the world stops.

The silence around her does not match the inner storm of thoughts she is carrying. Groaning, she rolls around on the bed until she lies with her stomach on the mattress and presses her face into a pillow.
Involuntarily, she can't help but think of the last time she slept in this bed with Catra. She takes one deep breath. The pillow even still smells of the Magicat.

Absentmindedly, she detaches her face from the pillow and presses it to her chest instead. She feels as if the peaceful morning was half an eternity ago. The many thoughts in her head and her worries exhaust her so much that at some point her eyes fall shut as if of their own accord.

A knock jolts her out of her dreamless sleep.
"What?" she exclaims, confused, and sits up.
"Miss Adora? It's me, Razon." The healer. Faster than her feet can carry her, she jumps up and stumbles toward the door before practically yanking it open. The healer blinks in surprise for a moment, and before he can catch his breath, Adora asks, "Is Catra all right?!"

With a patient look, Razon nods. "According to the circumstances, but yes. She's not in any danger of dying." A whole load of stones seems to fall from Adora's chest when she hears these words, and she breathes a sigh of relief. "However," the healer continues, and Adora feels the knot in her stomach tighten once again.
"However, what?" she huffs in alarm.

Razon strokes his beard once and then folds his hands.
"The wound to Catra's shoulder nearly grazed her heart. The bullet burned much of her fur on her shoulder and neckline and injured some muscle strands. It should heal well with time, but the Magicat should definitely take it easy on her shoulder as much as possible over the next few weeks."
Slowly, Adora nods as she soaks up every word the healer says. His diagnosis doesn't necessarily sound pleasant, but all that matters is that Catra gets better. Adora would make sure of that. At any cost.

Uncertainly, she looks at Razon and asks, "And.... uhm... can I see her?" A knowing smile forms on the healer's face as he nods.
"She's already asked for you. I'll take you to her. She's awake, but I'll have to ask you to keep your visit short."
Frowning, the blonde bites her lip, but nods. As long as she can make sure Catra is okay, she'll take anything.

The healer leads them through some corridors towards the medical area of the palace. Finally they stop in front of a door and Razon makes a hand gesture inviting Adora to enter. She nods at him and waits until he has left before gently knocking on the door

to make herself known.
"Come in!" chimes from inside. The blonde opens the door and hesitantly enters.

The room is smaller than her bedroom. The walls are a light blue, and there is nothing in it except a small dresser and a couple of chairs. And of course the bed that stands against the wall. The Magicat is lying in it, staring at the ceiling. Her gaze is strained, restless, as if it costs her strength to lie still and not jump up and do something. The twitching tip of her tail confirms Adora's suspicions. When Catra tears her gaze away from the ceiling and spots the blonde, her eyes widen a little.

"Adora! You're okay!" Her voice is a little rough, but otherwise she seems fine. Almost in disbelief, Adora lets out a laugh as she steps up to the bed.
"I'M fine. You're the one who got hit by Hordak's bullet and was unconscious for hours!"
In response, the Magicat just sits up and shrugs, but then winces and a hiss escapes her.

Now that she has pushed the blanket off of her, the bandage around her shoulder is clearly visible. Startled, the blonde realizes that the bandage extends to her neck. In addition, the Magicat's right hand is bandaged. She didn't even notice that Catra hurt herself there too. Concerned, Adora frowns and sits down on the edge of the bed.

"It's not as bad as it looks." is the simple answer of the Magicat, who now tries to keep a neutral expression on her face. But Adora knows her well enough to recognize Catra biting her lip in a tense way.
"You know as well as I do that's not true. Hordak almost hit your heart!"
"But he didn't!" Catra deflects, avoiding the blonde's gaze. For some reason the Magicat is disgruntled, Adora realizes with surprise.
"What's wrong?" she wants to know anxiously.

"Nothing!" Catra snorts angrily, crossing her arms. The painful hiss that escapes her afterwards only seems to make her angrier.

Startled, Adora looks at her friend. Has Adora perhaps done something wrong? Said something wrong?
Seeing the blonde's shock and uncertainty, Catra's posture relaxes a bit before she sighs and lowers her gaze.
"I'm … sorry. I didn't mean to snap at you like that. I'm just..."
She exhales air in frustration and clenches her hands into fists. "... angry!"
"At...me?" Adora echoes uncertainly, but the Magicat shook her head.
"No." She continues to avoid the blonde's gaze before quietly admitting.
"At me."

"Why is that?"
"Because... I'm vulnerable!" she hisses between clenched teeth, frowning as she stares at the white blanket in her lap.
"I don't want to be weak. I wanted... I wanted to prove to myself that I could do it on my own. That I can go up against Hordak and at least be his equal. That I'm better than... than what others say about me."
With one hand, she crumples up the blanket.
"But I failed. I made a stupid mistake and now -" She doesn't finish the sentence, but points demonstratively at her shoulder.
"If you hadn't gotten me out of there, I probably would have died." Catra admits quietly.

Adora has been watching her closely the whole time. When she sees the Magicat's surrendered look, her heart tightens and she reaches for her friend's healthy hand.
"You don't have to prove anything to anyone. And if it weren't for me, you never would have been distracted! I'm convinced you still would have kicked Hordak's ass good and proper."
Her choice of words makes the Magicat smile for a moment.
Adora squeezes her hand a little tighter.
"And the Catra I know doesn't let a little setback get her down."
Now the smile does remain permanently on Catra's lips, and she

squeezes her friend's hand as well.
"True."

Finally, she looks Adora in the eye, and for a moment she is completely spellbound. The intensity with which Catra looks at her takes her breath away. The gold and blue of her eyes seem to radiate and the loose brown waves caress her face. Almost imperceptibly, Adora leans forward to be closer to Catra's face. The Magicat lets it happen.
The tips of their noses are almost touching, and the blonde can feel the blush rising in her cheeks, but she can't look away.
She would only have to lean forward a tiny bit more to -

the door opens without warning and a voice sounds.

"Catra! Oh I - I'm so glad you're okay!"
Jerking away from each other, the two friends look at the newcomer. Scorpia stands in the doorway, looking honestly relieved. Surprised, Catra raises her eyebrows.
"Scorpia?" she asks. Is Adora imagining it, or does Catra really sound happy to see the big woman? And why does it bother the blonde so much?

Scorpia beams at the Magicat and approaches her.
"You know, the doctor told me you woke up and I could come see you, but I didn't know if you wanted to see me so I thought I'd just stop by and see if maybe you needed something or-"
"Scorpia." Catra interrupts, and immediately the woman falls silent. The corners of the Magicat's mouth twitch as she points to the other edge of the bed.
"You can stay. I... It's... nice to see you."

The tall woman's eyes begin to light up as she steps thoughtfully closer and sits down by the bed. Suddenly feeling uncomfortable and redundant, Adora quickly stands up and mutters something apologetic before leaving the room.
Catra looks after her, but doesn't get a chance to reply, as Scorpia starts talking again.
"It's so good to finally see you again! I was wondering when..."

That's all the blonde gets as she closes the door behind her and walks away from the hospital room. At the same time, she can't repress the strange feeling that has come over her.
What the hell is wrong with her? It's perfectly legitimate for Catra and her friend to deserve a few moments alone to catch up. After all, Scorpia is just as worried about Catra as Adora is. And the two haven't seen each other in a while.

So why does that look Catra gave Scorpia bother her? She didn't show it, but Adora saw exactly how happy Catra is to see Scorpia. Catra used to only llok that way … at Adora.
Shaking her head, the blonde dismisses her thoughts and resolutely represses this unpleasant feeling before marching back to her room.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey everyone! I just wanted to let you know that I'll probably won't post a chapter within the next 2-3 weeks, because I got the idea for a short story that cannot wait to be written. Sooo I'll be busy the next weeks with writing that story first, but don't worry, as soon as I am finished I'll return to this story :)
> (Btw the short story will be from The Owl House, so if you're interested I'll upload it here as well^^)

Chapter 28

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

"The guys have been asking about you. I don't think they want to admit it, but they miss you a little bit." reports Scorpia with a smirk. She is about to tell Catra about what she has missed in her absence. In doing so she gestures wildly in the air with her scissor hands to punctuate her words. Catra thinks it looks terribly silly, but at the same time she feels the warmth envelop her as she watches Scorpia sit beside her sickbed and talk incessantly.

A week ago it would have been hard for her to admit it, but the truth is: she has really missed Scorpia. For the last few years she has always been by her side, and it was unusual to suddenly not have her around for the last few days.

However, she only listens to her with half an ear. Her head still hurts from the impact of the fall, so she takes Scorpia's babble more as a pleasant murmur, and concentrates instead on what she sees.
A quick muster shows the Magicat that Scorpia looks little changed. Nothing seems to be wrong with her, nor is she injured. Aside from her concern of Catra, her mood seems good as well. Good. That means she has been able to lead the Crimson Waste without any problems.

Before Catra can stop it, a small smile creeps onto her face. It feels good to know that she can still rely on Scorpia. It's also a little strange to be sitting here with her. In a hospital room in Bright Moon. Her mind wanders to the plan she originally had. She asked Adora if it might be possible to send Swift Wind off to bring Scorpia here. Adora was surprised, and agreed in confusion before Catra explained her idea in more detail.

She told the blonde about the Black Garnet that Shadow Weaver once used as the source of her power, and about how Scorpia once told her that this stone was once owned by her family and gave her powerful abilities.

It occurred to Catra that they could use this power.
If Scorpia obtains this magic, the rebellion would gain another powerful warrior. And if they had activated this stone during the rescue mission, there would have been additional confusion and chaos that they could have used to make their escape.

Adora had been thrilled with this idea. Catra's mood instantly worsens as she thinks about how it obviously didn't work out the way she wanted.
When she takes another look at Scorpia, her mood softens again. Scorpia is here now. That's all that matters. And she doesn't need magical abilities to be a dangerous warrior.

"Hey, are you even listening to me?" Scorpia wants to know, eyeing Catra. Torn from her thoughts, the Magicat blinks a few times before touching her forehead.
"Sorry, Scorp. I still have a bit of a headache."
Wide-eyed, the white-haired woman looks at the Magicat. At first Catra doesn't grasp the strange reaction, then it dawns on her: She's apologized. And admitted a weakness.
Without even thinking.

'This is Adora's fault,' Catra thinks, only half frowning. 'She made me lower my walls'.
She decides not to correct herself, and waits until Scorpia seems to have regained her composure.
"Uh... no problem!" she finally says, and Catra feels relief that the tall woman is not commenting on this change.

"Should I leave you alone?" huffs Scorpia, frowning, but Catra shakes her head. Another change since she's been here: She doesn't push company away every chance she gets. Relaxing, she leans back and mutters, "I'm just not in the mood to talk much. Can you just stay here for a while?"

Judging by the gleam in her eyes, Scorpia is more than happy to do that.

For a while, the two simply remain silent, enjoying each other's company. At some point the door opens and the healer Razon enters the room.
"Miss Scorpia? You should leave now. Catra needs a lot of rest to recover." Immediately Scorpia jumps up and nods to the healer.
"Of course!" Then she looks to Catra. " It's already the middle of the night, after all. I'll just check on you again tomorrow then, okay?"

Catra nods and watches as the tall woman wants to follow the healer outside. At the door, she stops her once more.
"Hey Scorpia?" Questioningly, she turns her head to the injured woman.
"I never told you this, but.... Thank you. For being such a good friend."
It is silent for a moment.
Two.
Three.

Then a bright smile spreads across her face.
"You're welcome, Wildcat."
Catra returns the smile before Scorpia waves goodbye and steps out of the room.

As soon as she is alone, the Magicat's pain seems to get stronger. Doggedly, she lowers her eyes and stares at the bandage on her shoulder. Testily, she lifts her left arm, although the doctor has actually forbidden her to do so, and immediately takes a hissing breath as a sharp pain drives into her chest.

Growling, she drops her arm again and leans her head back before glancing at her bandaged hand and opening and closing it a few times. Works. It hurts as well, but it's only a few minor burns and a small bruise. It'll heal quickly. It has to.

Frustration grips Catra, and she claws her hands into the white sheet. She can already hardly stand sitting quietly in one spot doing nothing. How long would this last? A few days? Weeks? Months? She dreads the thought. Exhausted, she rubs her face and seems to be suddenly overcome by fatigue.

As Scorpia has already said, it's the middle of the night, and whether she likes it or not, her body needs rest. That's why it doesn't take long for her eyes to fall shut and she sinks into a light sleep.

When she wakes up, it's already noon.
A quick glance around the room tells her that someone has been here. Probably the healers. There is a tray of food on the small table beside the bed, and although she has tossed and turned during the night, the blanket is spread neatly over her.

Immediately, unease creeps up her spine. The thought that more strangers might have touched her while she was unconscious does not please her at all. Even if it's only well-intentioned. And why didn't she wake up from that? She hurt her shoulder, not her ears!

In addition, she slept for a long time, but very lightly and restlessly. She should have noticed when someone strange came near her. Or have her defenses already lowered to the point that even her body is throwing all concerns to the wind? The thought does not please her at all.

Grumbling, she straightens up in bed and, glancing at her wounds, first does a quick update on herself. No change. Frowning, she stares into space. What is she supposed to do now? She hasn't even been awake for five minutes, and it already feels like fleas are dancing across her fur.
She wants to move, for crying out loud! Who cares about the opinion of a healer?

Determined, the Magicat knocks the blanket aside and stands up. She grits her teeth as she does so, leaning only on her right hand,

but it works. For a moment she feels dizzy because she has been lying there for so long. Then her body gets used to it and she starts to walk a few steps. It works. Satisfied, she walks to the window. Why shouldn't it work? After all, her legs are intact.

The window in the hospital room is comparatively small, but large enough for Catra to get a decent view of the garden. The midday sun illuminates the bright colors of the plants and even warms a little of Catra's face. A feeling of relaxation runs through her as she closes her eyes and focuses only on the sunbeam touching her face.

It feels like it did back in the Crimson Waste. Like the countless times she wandered the desert alone. In which, like now, she held her face up to the sun and paused, searching for a moment of peace. She didn't find it then. But now... now she feels hope welling up inside her. Like the soft flicker of a flame, it glows in her mind. Faint and tentative, but it's there.
Perhaps it can grow with time.

The Magicat's ears twitch as the door opens and someone enters. Immediately, Catra jerks her head around.
"Miss Catra, what are you doing? You're supposed to stay in bed and rest!" It is one of the helper who watches in shock as the Magicat leans against the window, relaxing.

"I've never been good at following rules." she replies simply, shrugging her shoulders, causing an exceedingly painful twinge in her left shoulder. The helper notices and shakes his head before stepping closer.
"Then you should start now. This is your health you're putting at risk!"
"Pfft!" Catra makes and reluctantly lets the helper shoo her back to bed.

He doesn't leave the room again until she is comfortably seated in bed and has eaten something. Shortly after, Razon comes in briefly to change her bandages. He is friendly and very careful

with her wounds, but Catra is not in the mood for conversation, so there is a simple silence most of the time.

When Razon has taken off the bandage for her shoulder and her wound is exposed, she can't help but stare at it.
It looks ugly, she can't describe it any other way.
Ugly and repulsive. But well, then it matches the rest, Catra thinks bitterly.
Razon has noticed the Magicat's gaze and murmurs, "That's going to leave a scar."

This time Catra resists the urge to shrug, instead retorting, "Doesn't matter."
And it's true. Who cares about this new scar? It doesn't stand out among the countless others on her body. The healer eyes her with a look that says he knows exactly what is going through her mind. Of course, the many scars have not escaped his notice either.
But Catra doesn't care what he thinks. As long as he doesn't call her on it.

He doesn't.
Instead, he quickly applies the new bandage and puts her left arm in a sling to keep it still and thus spare the injured shoulder. He then takes his leave, saying that he will have a couple of guards placed outside the door for safety, so that the Magicat doesn't get the idea of overexerting herself. Catra's answer consists of an indignant snort, but he has already left the room.

She spends the next few hours restlessly shifting back and forth in bed. A few times she tries to slip out of the room, but as Razon said, each time there are two guards outside her door to keep her from doing so. If it weren't for her shoulder, Catra would be able to overpower or trick them with ease. But as it is, she has to accept her fate of persevering in this miserable little room.

As evening falls, and she wanders restlessly around the room, she finally can't stand it any longer and runs to the window. She pushes it open with one hand and breathes in the fresh air that blows in. Dusk has already begun and the yellow and pink sky is

starting to turn purple. Appraisingly, her gaze wanders downward, along the palace wall. It must be thirty feet down. There aren't exactly many cracks and crevices for her to cling to.

However, she is a Magicat and thus born to climb. She doesn't need any ways to hold on. Her claws will do the job just fine. At least, she hopes so. Resolutely, she steps back to the small table to exchange the plain hospital clothes for her own. Then she ties her hair again, which turns out to be very complicated with only one hand, and returns to the open window.

Elegantly, she swings first one leg out of the window, then the second, before climbing out into the open. With her right hand she extends her claws and clings to the smooth wall, leaving her left hand in the arm sling and pressing it tightly against her belly so as not to impede herself. Then she begins her descent. She won't lie, it takes far more effort to shift her weight, and it also takes longer than normal, as she has to search for a secure foothold after each step down.

But it works. Catra can feel the pain in her hand and the burning in her muscles, but it feels good. To feel that she is doing something. In the last few feet, she pushes off the wall and leaps down in one bound before landing gracefully in the grass. As she does so, her tail twitches back and forth to keep her balance.

Slowly, she straightens up and looks around.
Ah, freedom!
Satisfied, she takes a few steps away from the wall and quickly disappears behind some trees. Her absence would surely be noticed soon, and since they might even lock the windows in the future, she doesn't want to get caught in the first place. A smirk steals onto her lips. This feels a little like the old days in the Horde. When she hid from Shadow Weaver, snuck out of the dorm at night, or shirked boring tasks.
Some things just don't change.

When Catra is sure that she can't be spotted from her room anymore, she starts to wander relaxed around the castle garden.

At this time of the evening, hardly anyone is here, so she can marvel at the many flowerbeds, bushes and trees in peace. It looks so different here from what the Magicat is used to. Neither in the Frightzone nor in the Crimson Waste were there so many colorful plants in one place.
The Magicat realizes that she likes the sight.

Lost in thought, her fingers graze a deep red blossom on the side of the path. Who would have thought? The former Force Captain delights in the sight of flowers. Stealthily, Catra looks around to make sure no one is watching her. Although she can't see anyone, she withdraws her hand as a precaution and continues walking.

That's when her ears begin to twitch as a sound cuts through the silence. Someone's gasp can be heard. Then air being cut by something. Frowning, the Magicat follows the sound until she arrives at a small clearing between a group of trees.

A figure stands there in the middle, with a staff in her hand, fighting an invisible opponent. The blond ponytail is unmistakable. Adora has her back turned, so she has not yet noticed the presence of the Magicat.
Catra takes advantage of this to simply observe her for a moment.

The last rays of the sun pass over Adora's body as she twists and turns lithely, dodging invisible blows and seeking gaps in her opponent's cover. Her brow is furrowed with concentration, small beads of sweat glisten on her skin and a few strands have broken free from her braid, bobbing along with her movements.

She has taken off her jacket and top and wears only her sports bra on top, presumably to have more freedom of movement. A side effect is that Catra can see the sinewy muscles on her arms and stomach.

Inevitably, the Magicat feels her mouth go dry and the blush rise to her face.
When was the last time she saw Adora so lightly dressed? It must have been years ago. Except for the incident a few days ago,

when she had to doctor the blonde. That doesn't count though, after all it was half dark and Adora almost bled to death. So Catra really had other things to worry about than gawking at the body of her former best friend.
Unlike now.

Adora is engrossed in her exercises and still hasn't noticed her, so the Magicat isn't pressed for time. She can't help but not take her eyes off the blonde and memorize every detail. In general, Adora's movements cast a kind of spell over her, giving her the feeling that here, in this small clearing bathed in sunset, without another person far and wide, time would stand still.

Catra is so spellbound that she doesn't even notice how Adora turns to her in a spin and stabs a blow directly in her direction. As her arm snaps forward, the blonde's eyes travel down the path of her punch's finish line and meet Catra's.
Within a second, her concentrated expression gives way to startled eyes.
"Catra!" she exclaims in surprise.
Reflexively, she jerks back and loses the balance of her position before falling backwards, ungently, into the grass.

"Ouch!" she groans, rubbing her butt, but her eyes fix on the Magicat leaning against a tree trunk. Catra looks apologetic, but can't suppress a smirk as she breaks away from her seat and rushes to her friend's aid.
"I didn't mean to disturb you." she explains, extending her bandaged hand to the blonde to help her up.
"You didn't." affirms Adora, but hesitates and looks at the bandage around the Magicat's hand. When Catra doesn't budge, the blonde finally gives in and lets herself be pulled to her feet.

"Very elegant landing." comments Catra, eyeing Adora with amusement, trying to cover her embarrassment at being caught staring. The blonde's expression darkens for a moment and she boxes the Magicat's healthy arm.
"Shut up." Catra snorts, still amused, and watches the blush rise

in Adora's cheeks. It disappears in a moment, though, and a worried frown appears instead.

"What are you doing out here? Shouldn't you stay in bed and rest? Did the healer even allow you to do that?"
At her question, Catra's muscles tense slightly, but she suppresses it and looks to the side.
"If I had stayed in that little room one second longer, I would have either shredded the furnishings or suffocated." Appraisingly, Adora eyes her friend.

Then she drops her shoulders and smiles surrenderingly.
"Actually, I should have guessed that you would run away at some point."
The Magicat crosses her arms, which isn't easy or painless due to the arm sling, but she manages it and covers the pain with her answer.
"And you're the one to talk."

Silence.

Adora's expression changes, becomes more distant. Guilty.
Shit.
The words had just come to Catra's lips, without thinking. She didn't even mean them. As the blonde turns away, Catra quickly puts in.
"Adora, I didn't mean - "
"It's okay." the blonde replies, but avoids looking the Magicat in the face.

Instead, she bends down in the grass to reach for her staff. When she has it, she straightens up, but her posture remains to the side. An oppressive feeling grips Catra. She is afraid that she has inadvertently put in danger the delicate bond that is forming between them.

She didn't mean to hurt Adora. How can she fix it? She has no experience with this. With good, healthy interpersonal relationships.

'I only know how to break things,' Catra thinks bitterly. 'Not how to put them back together.'

She is about to say something to apologize when Adora asks, "How was your reunion with Scorpia?" Adora seems to have decided to just skip the subject. To repress. Typical Adora.
But the strange coldness in her voice draws the Magicat's attention too much to her actual question to notice the previous one.

Confused, Catra frowns.
"Quite well, I suppose. Honestly, I'm glad she's here."
"Fine."
Again, Adora has adopted that strange tone. Frowning, the Magicat watches as the blonde crosses her arms and turns her head away so Catra can't see her face.

"Is everything all right?" inquires Catra, circling the blonde so she can look her in the eye.
But Adora rounds with her.
"Sure."
Okay, that means nothing is all right at all.
"You don't believe that yourself. Spit it out: What's wrong?"

"Nothing!" affirms Adora with a vehemence that only betrays her more.
Determined, Catra overcomes the distance between them and grabs the blonde's shoulder to keep her from turning away. Inquiringly, Catra looks into her face, which she still keeps lowered.

Huffing, she releases her other arm from the sling and slides two fingers and Adora's chin to lift it. The Magicat's suppressed moan causes Adora to give up her resistance and obediently lift her face. As Catra gazes into the familiar blue-gray, she recognizes quite a few emotions flitting across it. Guilt, discomfort, worry, embarrassment....
But one of them, the most present, she has never seen before.

Researching and fascinated, she pulls Adora's face a little closer and doesn't notice the blush developing on the blonde's cheeks because she is so focused on the strange emotion.
Suddenly it makes 'click'.
Surprised, Catra lets go of Adora's chin.
"Wait, are you... jealous?"

The blonde's eyes grow wide and she staggers back in surprise, as if she needs to gain safe distance.
"What?! Noooo!"
At the same moment, Catra knows she's right. She realized it because she knows this emotion all too well herself.

That's why she looks at Adora with a raised brow. She practically pierces her with her gaze. In the meantime, surprise is joined not only by astonishment, but also by curiosity.
Who is Adora jealous of? And why? She also feels a spark of hope.
Could SHE be the reason? Could Adora perhaps lo-

Her thoughts are interrupted as Adora's expression cracks under Catra's probing gaze, changing from defensiveness to surrender.
"Okay... maybe I am. A little."
Catra blinks. And blinks again. She's guessed it, but having it confirmed kind of overwhelms her.

"Of who? Scorpia? But... Why?" she asks, indirectly voicing the question that seems to be her whole being right now: ´What do I mean to you?´
Embarrassed, Adora grabs the back of her neck. The blush on her face does not disappear.

"Well... I mean, don't get me wrong, I don't begrudge you your time with Scorpia and I'm glad you're comfortable with her. But when I saw the two of you, that's... that's when I realized that you've spent the last few years together. Scorpia has always been able to be with you and I... I couldn't. She got to be a friend to you, and I missed it all because I..."

She lets the sentence hang in the air, since they both know what she's going to say anyway.
'Because I left the horde.'
"So I guess I'm jealous of your friendship. That's all." She seems to be telling the truth.
"Oh."

Catra doesn't want to let it happen, but she feels all the hope inside her slump, leaving a disappointing emptiness. At the same time, she is angry with herself. Adora's explanation makes sense. Why should it have been any different? What was she hoping for? Before the blonde can notice any of the inner chaos, Catra quickly shakes off all thoughts and focuses on the essentials.

Slowly, she takes another step towards Adora.
"It's true, Scorpia has been a really good friend to me these past years. I... needed that after you left. Even if for a long time I didn't want to admit it and I fought against it." Because who could have assured her that Scorpia wouldn't leave too, as soon as she let her get too close?

Swallowing, she looks into Adora's eyes, where there is similar pain.
"But I can assure you that this friendship with her? It could never keep up with you."
Suddenly Catra feels naked and vulnerable. She quickly places a hand on the blonde's shoulder, careful not to back down.
"No matter how thoughtful and caring she is, she.... she's not you."

Adora's eyes widen in surprise before her face begins to glow. The Magicat can feel the blush rising in her cheeks, so she quickly follows it up as nonchalantly as she can,
"I mean, no one can be an idiot like you. Or replace your hairpoof."

This makes Adora burst out laughing.
"Right!" Grinning, the blonde wipes a tear from the corner of her

eye and looks clearly relieved. Catra has to grin, too.
There's the real Adora again, the one she knows.

"Besides, she can probably barely keep up with me at fighting!" boasts Adora, sticking out her chest in satisfaction, which elicits a laugh from Catra and puts a satisfied grin on the blonde's face. Apparently, that had been exactly her plan.
However, Catra then turns serious, and her laughter dies. The subject of fighting reminds her of something. Adora also notices the change in mood and frowns worriedly.

"Adora, I... I still wanted to apologize to you." The wrinkles in the blonde's forehead deepen.
"Apologize? For what?" Uneasily, Catra places her bandaged hand over her arm .
"For failing to retrieve your sword. That was MY part in the plan, and I didn't fulfill it. In the process, I had it in my hand for a moment, but.... I dropped it. Even though I knew how important it is. And in the end, you even had to save me -"

"Hey" Adora has overcome the remaining distance to the Magicat and carefully reaches out her hand to Catra. She waits until Catra looks her in the eye before declaring in a firm voice,
"I would have done it again every time. We'll get my sword back. But you were more important at that moment." Gently, she touches the Magicat's cheek.
"I've told you before and I'll do it again: Never again will I leave you behind. Especially not for a stupid sword."

The intense gaze with which Adora fixes her takes Catra's breath away. At the same time, her heart beats faster as she notices Adora slowly leaning forward, the tips of their noses almost touching. The last rays of the sun flood Adora's face and make it glow. Wisps fall into her forehead, but she doesn't seem to notice. Her attention is completely on Catra.

The skin on her cheek, where Adora's hand rests, begins to tingle gently. At that moment the blonde's gaze is completely open, and all that can be seen in it is warmth and affection.

And Adora does not step back, on the contrary: very slowly she bends her face even closer to that of the Magicat.

Catra instinctively wants to pull back because, along with the palpitations, she feels her fear creeping up. Fear of misinterpreting something and being hurt. But she does not move. Her body is frozen. Maybe because Catra doesn't WANT to move away.
She wants to see what is happening, wants clarity at last. So desperately that she is willing to let her guard down.

Automatically she curses herself for this weakness.

Curses herself for the fact that after everything she's been through, she's still willing to take the risk and finally let the shriveled remains of her heart be torn apart too, just to have those few moments of affection. Just to feel valued and... loved… for a few moments.

And she curses herself for still not being able to let it happen after all this time.

For still falling into old patterns of behavior. Still doubting. She can't deny it: she is afraid. Of having opened her heart too wide. Maybe to be hurt after all.

That's why she pulls herself out of her rigidity, gently disentangles herself from Adora's touch, and steps back before clearing her throat.

Adora blinks as if waking from a dream. Then she looks questioningly at Catra, and for a moment the Magicat thinks she sees disappointment and pain flashing in the blue-gray eyes.
"I, um... I'd better get back inside now. I'm sure the guards are already looking for me." murmurs Catra in an occupied voice, trying to explain her behavior.

Before Adora can say anything back, the Magicat turns away so that her emotional chaos won't be seen.
"See you." she murmurs softly, hoping that the trembling is not

noticeable in her voice, nor on her body.
"Catra..."
She quickly runs off, disappearing among the trees before Adora can stop her.

When she eventually spots a small wall and makes sure no one can see her, she leans against it and lets herself sink to the ground. All at once, she feels so exhausted. Her body is still shaking, so she pulls her knees to her chest and wipes her eyes.

'Don't weaken,' she admonishes herself, `Stay strong, Catra!'
But when she thinks of how close Adora has been to her, her heart tightens.
Almost... Almost their lips touched.

Would Adora have wanted that? What would have happened then? Would a little of her radiant warmth perhaps have passed to the Magicat? Would she have finally found that for which she has been subconsciously searching for years? Or would Catra have been dropped and sucked into a dark hole whose darkness and cold would have swallowed her for good?

She doesn't know.
But she hates herself for not having had the courage to find out.

Adora:

Adora has messed up.
Angry at herself, she clenches her hands into fists and stares at the empty spot where Catra was standing just a moment ago.
Why did she do that? She let herself go. She wasn't even aware of what she was about to do until Catra pulled back.
And by then it was too late.
Adora screwed up.

She knows best how the Magicat reacts when you get too close too fast: She closes herself off. She shuts down and doesn't let anyone get close to her.

Exactly the opposite of what Adora wants. She wants to be close to her. To be there for her. To hold her and protect her, to laugh and cry with her.
But perhaps by her rash actions she has just destroyed her chance and put this precious friendship in danger.

Angrily, she raises her fist and hits the nearest tree. What was she thinking?
She was about to kiss her best friend.
How weird is that??
Adora pauses and looks at the scratch in the tree bark left by her fist.
Was that what they were? Best friends? Or could... Could there be more?

Adora thinks back to that moment just now. She remembers the warmth that permeated her when the sunlight made Catra's eyes shine. The blush that rose to her cheeks when she noticed her face instinctively getting closer and closer.
And she remembers the sudden urge to know how the Magicat's lips felt on hers.
Whether they are really as soft as they look.

The blonde thinks she read the same desire on Catra's face for a moment.
But then suddenly a shadow of fear and horror has settled on her features. Gritting her teeth, Adora mentally repeats the moment when Catra so hastily moved away from her.
As if she couldn't get away from the blonde fast enough.

Adora shakes her head resolutely.
'No,' she thinks, her muscles tightening. 'Catra clearly doesn't feel the same. And that's the end of any discussion.'

Because it doesn't matter how Adora might feel.

It's about Catra, her feelings, and her well-being comes before anything else. ´I have clearly frightened her with my behavior. Possibly even driven her away for good. If that's the case, I could

never forgive myself.'
She resolves to make amends. At any cost.

Even if that means for Adora to continue lying to herself.

Chapter End Notes

I felt the urge to comment something on this chapter… but honestly I don´t even know what xD
Things are getting complicated.
As if it wasn´t complicated before. But what would be a good story without drama, right?

Chapter 29

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

The healer's rant the next morning has it all, and Catra would have even been impressed if she hadn't been thinking about the almost-kiss the whole time. And about her own cowardice. She barely returns a word until Razon finally lowers his shoulders and leaves the room, sighing.

He seems to have realized that the Magicat has a mind of her own. Or he's run out of steam and will rant on later. Either way, Catra is glad to be alone again. After a few moments, her mind changes, because immediately her thoughts circle unhindered around a very specific person.

Frustrated, the Magicat hides her face in her hands.
She doesn't want to think. It will only make things worse. Her head should just shut off.
Maybe she could ask Razon for some kind of sleeping pill? She'd just take enough of it to keep her unconscious for the next few weeks.
Maybe then she could forget.
But does she want to?

Her insides fight back against the thought of forgetting even a single second with Adora.
Just as fiercely as it has resisted before. Back then, shortly after Adora left. Catra could barely handle seeing Adora go. The fear that her memories of her might leave her as well dug deep into her heart.

No matter how much she manipulated and suppressed her feelings and thoughts about Adora in the years that followed.... her memories she left untouched.

Buried, repressed and locked tightly in her heart, but always there.

A knock snaps her out of her stream of thought, and her heart tightens.
Who is it? It can't be the healers, they just enter after knocking briefly.
And Scorpia usually announces herself loudly beforehand, in case Catra doesn't want her to enter. That was already the case in the horde.
So that leaves only one person, which she definitely doesn't want to see right now.

"I'm not here!" Catra shouts, and at the same time she wants to slap herself. That was a mistake. Now Adora knows she is responsive. She should have pretended to be asleep instead!
There is another knock. Now Catra rolls her eyes.
"Adora, I said I'm not here!" Irritation rings in her voice, masking her nervousness and confusion.

The door opens a crack, and contrary to her expectations, a pink head pokes its way into the room.
"Hey, we um... We're not Adora, but can we maybe come in for a minute?" Perplexed, Catra stares at Glimmer. What is the princess doing here? Is she trying to sound Catra out? Checking to see if she's a danger?

Never mind, whispers a voice in her head. The main thing is to be able to occupy myself with something else for a short while.
"That depends on who 'we' are" the Magicat replies suspiciously.
The door opens a bit more and Bow pokes his head in. On his face sits the usual glow you've come to expect from him.
"Just Glimmer and me."

The Magicat's confusion grows and she blinks a few times.
"Did you guys get lost? Adora's room is somewhere else." Glimmer frowns, but Bow replies, "No, we wanted to talk to you. Is that all right?" Motionless, Catra stares at the two people in the doorway

before finally giving in and groaning exaggeratedly.
"Alright, if you must."

As Bow pushes the princess and himself into the room and closes the door behind him, Catra struggles to keep a neutral expression. She hopes the uncertainty doesn't show on her face. With Adora by her side, she wouldn't be so insecure.
Stop, don't think about Adora!

"We wanted to ask how you were doing." The skepticism in Catra grows. The other princesses treat her with respect by now, but that's it. Except for Adora and Scorpia, no one has visited her. And that's all right. Catra can't handle too much positive attention at once. Like now. That's why her answer is curt and dismissive.
"Good, never better. Anything else?"

Her attitude seems to provoke Glimmer, as her face contorts from careful and polite to annoyed and strained. Frustrated, she runs a hand through her hair.
"Aarrgh, you're really making this so hard!" Okay, is it just the Magicat, or is this scenario getting weirder by the second?
"What?" Catra wants to know impatiently. She's starting to get upset that she feels like the dumb one in this situation.

Bow steps closer to Catra's bed and calmly explains "We heard from Adora about everything you did for her. And that you two are friends again. So we wanted to offer you our friendship." The Magicat tilts her head and looks at the two visitors.
This is a joke. It has to be one, right? The two of them, along with Adora, have been Catra's strongest enemies for years, and unlike the blonde, they have no history with Catra to make a friendship palatable to her.

But neither Sparkles nor Arrow Boy look like they're joking. Inwardly, Catra shakes her head.
Funny people there are in Bright Moon. Offer friendship to their enemies.
But as much as it surprises Catra, at some point she realizes that it's not just astonishment that leaves her speechless. Uncertainty

also gnaws at her.
For a moment, she wrestles with herself about whether to overplay it before deciding to lay her cards out on the table.

"I... I'm not good with friendships." she explains quietly, not managing to look the others in the eye.
"So far, I've always just chased away the people around me. And no one has ever offered me their friendship so directly. I don't know what to do or say now." The wrinkles on Glimmer's face smooth out, and her posture relaxes. Clearly, she is both amazed and soothed in equal measure by the frank words.

For a moment, she scrutinizes the expression in the Magicat's eyes. Whatever she finds in them seems to convince her. That's why she walks up to Catra and sits down beside her on the edge of the bed before holding out her hand.
"That's okay." she replies and smiles, any harshness gone from her voice.

"For now, you can simply accept our offer and let it come to you. Friendship is about trust, honesty and loyalty. You're there for each other and have each other's backs. If you stick to these values, you can't do much wrong. Everything else will come out over time. You can learn, and we can help you."

Now it's the Magicat's turn to look in amazement at the glitter princess. Who would have thought that behind her small, pink, aggressive warrior there is also a serious and gentle woman? Bow also looks at Glimmer, and there is pride and recognition in his gaze.

Lovingly, he places a hand on her shoulder and squeezes it gently before turning to Catra.
"We want to be here for you." He pauses for a moment and smiles encouragingly.
"If you'll let us."

Hesitantly, Catra looks at Glimmer's outstretched hand. Then she makes a decision. Adora trusts these people. And the Magicat

trusts Adora.
She's had enough of sabotaging herself.
So she grabs Glimmer's hand, whose warm fingers hold her tight. When she looks up, Glimmer smiles and Bow beams from ear to ear.

"Welcome to the Best Friend Squad." An unfamiliar warmth floods Catra as she hears these words, and she returns the smile.
It feels good. The thought of being able to be part of something. Maybe not being alone in the future. The smile turns into a grin as she withdraws her hand.

"You do know this won't make you lose your names, Arrow Boy and Sparkles?" Surprisingly, Glimmer chuckles and punches Catra in the healthy side.
"Of course not, Horde Scum." Catra grins as she hears her nickname, and it feels like something clicks into place between the two women. A piece of the puzzle that was previously in the wrong place and has only now been pushed into its proper place.

Then the moment passes, and uncertainty catches up with Catra again. Not as massive as before, this time it's more perplexity.
"And... what now?" Glimmer shrugs. "I don't know. There's a meeting at noon today. Do you have anything planned until then?"
Catra mirrors the gesture. "Not really."
'Except hiding from Adora,' she adds in thought.

A wide smile forms on the glitter princess' face.
"Good, then we can bother you a bit. The best way to start a good friendship is with a pajama party!" Bow frowns.
"Glimmer, it's early in the morning."
"A pajama party without pajamas, then. Don't act like we've never done this before!"

Catra can only look silently back and forth between her new friends. She doesn't understand what the princess is talking about, but doesn't want to say it. It makes her uncomfortable to be at a loss for seemingly self-evident terms. She wonders if Adora felt the same way when she first came here.

The archer notices the furrowed brow and smiles warmly at the Magicat.
"I'm sure you'll like it. We should add Adora, then the whole squad can celebrate the introduction of the new team member."

The mention of the blonde causes Catra's muscles to tense. Even the ones in her shoulder, and she has to suppress a painful hiss. Before Glimmer can like this idea, she quickly mutters, "Ahh, that's not a good idea."
Immediately, the glitter princess loses her wide smile. Instead, she frowns and looks alarmed.
"Why not? Did you guys have a fight? Or did you do something to her?"

Automatically, her hands clench into fists, ready to defend Adora. The piercing look makes the Magicat nervous, so she lowers her gaze.
"No, I didn't do anything to her. Nothing happened." A lie with which Catra tries to reassure herself rather than the others. Before she can fall into another vortex of self-doubt, Bow pulls her out.

He seems to sense that the subject makes her uncomfortable, so he puts a hand on Glimmer´s back and suggests, "Well, maybe it's better if the three of us get to know each other better first."
Glimmer wants to protest. "But-"
"Glimmer" As Bow looks at the princess with a stern expression, she finally drops her shoulders in surrender.
"Fine, maybe you're right."

Her face brightens as she looks back up at Catra. "This is actually the perfect opportunity to ask you about embarrassing stories about Adora! You used to squat on each other all the time, didn't you? You must have some funny stories to tell."
It amazes Catra that Glimmer would ask so bluntly. But the thought of her shared memories with Adora as a child makes her smile. Even grin.

"Well, there was this one time when we were racing through the Frightzone and Adora ran full speed into a post. In front of all the other cadets." Glimmer´s eyes grow wide.
"You're kidding!" Imperceptibly, she scoots a little closer to Catra, who laughs at the memory.
"No, I am not! She fell over like a stiff board, and had a red streak running down her face for the whole week afterward, right down the middle!"
Glimmer laughs up, and Bow giggles, too.

What Catra keeps to herself is that later, in the dorm room, she gently licked Adora across the forehead to soothe her wound. It had been an instinct. Adora, however, had not been prepared for it. She winced and turned away in shame, giggling nervously as she did so.
The two of them had still been children, but now a blush rises in Catra's cheeks when she thinks of it.

Instinctively, she raises her arm to cover her blush, but it's the wrong one. A stabbing pain drives through her shoulder and seems to paralyze her entire body for a moment. Doggedly, the Magicat groans and squints her eyes. Startled, her visitors look at her.
"Is there anything we can do for you?"
"I'm okay." Catra presses out, taking a few deep breaths as the pain recedes. The others are still looking at her. Something has changed in their expressions. Is it concern?
"Wait, best lean against the wall. And let's sit down properly."

As she speaks, Glimmer slides a little more onto the mattress and makes herself comfortable. Bow walks around the bed and sits on the other side. After they are both sitting comfortably, Glimmer beams at Catra again.
"So now I want to hear the story from earlier again. But please with all the details!"

The Magicat is so confused by the whole situation that she decides to go with it and just starts telling. Bow and Glimmer then also tell her a bit about what it was like when Adora came here.

It's surprisingly refreshing to talk so casually with the people who were originally her enemies. The two of them manage to distract Catra from her pain and especially from her current situation with Adora, and eventually Catra gets to the point where she just sits back, relaxed, and enjoys the atmosphere.

She gets along surprisingly well with the little pink warrior, and Bow is also sympathetic. He is more reserved and clearly calmer in his manner, but it is precisely this that also calms the Magicat. Around noon, the three of them leave the hospital wing together, and since there is an official meeting to which two important members of the rebellion accompany them, the healer Razon cannot raise any objections.
Even though he is visibly reluctant to see his patient on her feet again.

As the three of them make their way through the corridors toward the conference hall, Catra loses more and more of her composure and her thoughts wander restlessly to what is inevitably ahead.
To the person she will have to face.
Her emotional chaos due to the almost-kiss is still raging inside her, that's why she wanted to avoid Adora as long as possible.

She doesn't know how to act towards her. Pretend that nothing ever happened? Ignore her? Cover up her embarrassment? Or suppress her feelings with anger and irritation?
At least, those are the methods she's familiar with. But they feel wrong.
Catra doesn't want to repress any longer. But she is afraid of making a mistake. So she prefers to do nothing. Not until she got her head cleared.

Frowning, the Magicat notices that her hands are shaking when they finally reach the door. She quickly clenches them into fists. ´I can't face Adora like this,' she says contritely, feverishly thinking of an appropriate excuse for not attending the meeting.
But the door opens and Glimmer and Bow lead her into the room.

Adora:

To say she was nervous would probably be an understatement. Adora hasn't seen Catra since last night, and it's driving her crazy. All this time, she's been torn between the urge to go find her best friend and sort things out, and the knowledge that if Catra wants to be left alone, she'd rather not be bothered.

In the end, she pulled herself together and didn't show up outside the hospital room, even though it cost her immense willpower. This is about Catra, she keeps repeating. If she needed distance, she would give it to her.

But now, as she sits in the conference hall and watches Glimmer and Bow enter alongside the Magicat, she is about to throw all her resolutions to the wind and throw her arms around Catra's neck. She feels as if she hasn't seen her in ages. The gaze of the Magicat almost instantly finds that of the blonde, but just as quickly she turns her face away again.
Almost as if she were afraid to look at Adora.

A stab goes through her heart, and all her energy seems to leave the blonde. Some of it must have read on her face, because suddenly someone puts a hand on her shoulder.
"Are you all right?" It's Spinnerella. Quickly she nods at her and tries a smile.
"Yeah, sure. I´m fine."
Her fingers clench around the tracker pad where she had earlier called up some plans and maps, but her eyes remain glued to Catra.

Adora waits for the Magicat to take a seat next to her. Maybe she can take small steps. Throw her a smile, encourage her if she brings suggestions for the upcoming mission. And after the meeting, she could approach Catra and finally talk to her, explain to her that -

It doesn't even get that far, because before Catra can sit down, she is approached by Mermista. Surprised, Adora looks at the two

of them. She can't hear what they're talking about, but the sea princess' expression seems as bored as ever, while Catra's face changes from skepticism to surprise and then relief.

The two walk together to Mermista's seat, where there is another empty chair. Confused, Adora lets her gaze wander for a moment before realizing the reason: Perfuma has moved and is now sitting next to Scorpia, for whom another chair was brought in.
As a result, the seat next to Mermista is now free - and is now taken by Catra.

It feels like someone is stomping on her chest, Adora notes grimly. On top of that, Catra still avoids any glance in her direction.
Oh man, the blonde really messed up. She needs to fix this as soon as she can.

But not yet, she reminds herself. Later. Right now, she needs to focus on planning the mission.

As if on cue, the queen rises and opens the meeting.
"First, I want to thank you all for bringing my daughter and Bow back safely. I am aware that you put your own lives on the line. I will not forget that." Angella gives Catra a meaningful look for a moment. Catra stares back, awkwardly, but the corners of her mouth lift slightly. Then the queen continues.

"However, this battle is not over. Our strongest weapon, She Ra, is still not ready for use. The sword could not be saved, so this is still ahead of us. Adora"
The blonde almost flinches as all eyes turn to her.
"Please bring us up to date."
She nods to the queen and clasps her fingers a little tighter around the tracker pad.

"I saw the sword." she begins hesitantly, clearing her throat to make her voice sound firmer. "It was in Hordak's lab. Now that we've broken in, the lord will probably have it more closely guarded."
"What does he need your sword for anyway?" Frosta wants to

know, frowning. When everyone's eyes dart to her, she shrugs. "I'm just saying, if he only took it away from us to render She Ra harmless, he could have just locked it in his basement or hidden it under his bed. He even could have tried to destroy it."

The reminder that She Ra was rendered harmless stirs a discord in Adora. Frosta is right. She can't transform. And yet there were those isolated moments when Adora felt something. This power, this confidence to be able to protect. It felt like She Ra, if only for a few moments. But was it really possible? Or was Adora just imagining things?

The blonde doesn't like the direction her thoughts are taking, so she quickly pushes them away and refocuses on Frosta, who continues.
"So why is he stashing the sword in his lab? What does he want to do with it?"
"A good point," Netossa replies, scratching her chin before looking to her side.
"Glimmer, Bow, did you perhaps find out anything during your captivity? Did you overhear a conversation, or did Hordak even tell you something once?"

The two look at each other, baffled at first, then shake their heads. Bow rubs the back of his neck.
"We were left completely alone. Only once did Entrapta come to us and ask us how to activate She Ra's sword."
Adora opens her eyes in alarm. She didn't even know about this.

"And what did you tell her?" Mermista inquires, frowning.
"Nothing!" Glimmer snorts indignantly. "We don't even know how Adora always does it!" Before the whole thing can escalate, Adora quickly steers the conversation in another direction, thinking out loud.
"What could Hordak need my sword for?"

No one knows the answer to that. And unless the Lord of the Horde plans to sqash himself into a white and gold superhero gown with a tiara, Adora can't think of a plausible answer either.

Silence reigns at the table as everyone hangs in their own brooding thoughts.
Until a voice breaks the silence.
"He probably wants to use it as an energy source."

Catra has been holding back until just now, staring at the table with her body bent over, but now she lifts her eyes and looks around the table. Past Adora.
Her face is serious, a dark shadow has crept on it that the blonde can't place. Frosta looks at the Magicat in confusion.
"And why? Is he trying to build himself an oversized night light?"
Dimly, Catra shakes her head.
"I was talking to Hordak when we were fighting each other. The idiot told me his plan, at least the gist of it."

Everyone in the room seems to hold their breath tensely as they wait for the Magicat to continue speaking. Catra takes a deep breath before reporting,
"He wants to create a portal to use it to teleport Etheria into another dimension."

For a moment, there is dead silence in the room.

Adora is also enormously shocked. Is this true? Why hasn't Catra told her about this until now? Then everyone seems to call out at once.
"What?!" "Are you serious?!" "He wants to teleport an entire planet?!" "Why would he want to do that?!" "But there aren't any portals left!"

Like raindrops, the words rain down on the Magicat from all sides, and like a rock, she remains immobile in her place, not moving as she continues.
"I didn't understand all of his plan. Most of it sounded more like megalomania. But I suspect this is his way of handing us over to his allies, who can then take Etheria."

"He has allies?" Mermista asks in alarm. The others look shocked as well. Catra looks like she wants to shrug, but stifles it and just

replies, "That's about what he said, anyway. I think he called them 'his brothers'."

"That's not good at all," Bow mutters, scratching his chin. "A portal that size could collapse at the slightest difficulty, and the shock wave would destroy the planet." Angella frowns.
"We must prevent that at all costs."
The others nod in agreement.

"So, as I understand it, Hordak needs the energy of the sword to create the portal," Perfuma interjects, looking questioningly at Adora.
"But will he even be able to activate it? So far, only She Ra has been able to do that, right?" The blonde's expression darkens.
"We just heard that Entrapta herself is taking care of it. She's brilliant, and a genius at combining technology with magic. She'll find a way to activate the sword even without She Ra."

"How do we know she hasn't already found it?" Sea Hawk wants to know, and Catra cuts in.
"I guess we would have picked up on that. However, since there was no sense of a global earthquake or any other disaster, Etheria obviously hasn't moved from the spot. So we should still have some time."

"But how long?" Netossa interjects, looking anxiously at her wife. She returns the look and squeezes her hand firmly.
A silent assurance that everything will be all right.
Adora feels a strange urge to be able to hold Catra's hand now as well.
To make sure she's there. That they will get through this, even if logically no one can assure them of the future.
But that touch would at least provide comfort.

Longingly, the blonde casts a glance at the Magicat, who is completely absorbed in her thoughts. For a moment she is overcome by her feelings.
She must make sure that Catra and the others will be safe.
She WILL make sure of that.

Resolutely, Adora swallows her emotions and looks around.
"We can't take any risks. We must attack immediately and prevent this portal from being activated."

"I agree with you, Adora." declares the queen. "But how are we going to do that?"
"Hordak will not make it easy for us." Mermista elaborates on the Queen's thoughts.
"Surely he has at least doubled the number of guards. And we can't get in through the old way this time, they know it now."

"What do we do then? Really through the front door this time?" pokes Frosta, and though her eyes light up at the thought of being able to storm the Frightzone, Adora also detects the spark of fear in it. Frosta may be a princess and a powerful warrior, but she's also still a child. Her heart tightens.

"Do we have any other choice? The other entrances are just as well guarded now. Hordak probably even has the sewage guarded, just to be safe." Spinnerella ponders aloud.
"With something this important, he's not going to leave anything to chance."

Icy silence settles over the room. Everyone is feverishly thinking of a solution. Adora can literally feel the smoke billowing from her ears.
Frustration grips her. It can't be that she can't think of a solution! She's She Ra, for crying out loud! It's her job to protect this world! To protect her friends! She just HAS to think of something.

Glimmer´s determined voice is suddenly heard.
"We're not going to let this get us down. I've been sitting in this stupid cell forever doing nothing, this stops now. We're going to fight! So far, a challenge has never deterred us, has it?" Bow leans closer to the princess, as if to silently support her, before he too looks resolutely around.

“Glimmer is right. We are the rebellion! We will not be defeated. We will enter the Frightzone, destroy the portal and take Adora's

sword. With it, we will defeat the Horde once and for all and bring peace to the realm!"
Still no one says anything, but Adora can almost feel hope quietly rising in the room.
Therefore, she straightens up a little and looks at her two best friends.

"I will give everything to save Etheria." she promises and places her palm demonstratively on the table. Glimmer and Bow smile before repeating the gesture.
A sigh is heard. All eyes turn to Catra, who rolls her eyes in annoyance.
"You heroes are always so dramatic." Skeptically, she eyes Glimmer and Bow and lets her eyes flutter - just for a brief moment - to Adora.

Then she sighs again.
"This is going to be a suicide mission." Demonstratively, she places a hand on the table and a grin creeps onto her face.
"But I'm in."
"Me too." Scorpia places one of her scissor hands on the table and Adora catches the Magicat giving her friend a grateful look.

Perfuma follows Scorpia's lead. And the others get in one by one until all the hands are on the table. Swift Wind has even hoisted a hoof onto the table.
Only the queen's hand is still missing. The worry lines in her forehead speak volumes.
"I don't like the idea of sending you on such a dangerous mission again."

Glimmer looks pleadingly at her mother.
"Please, mom! We can do this, trust us!" Mother and daughter look at each other for a moment before Angella also sighs in surrender and puts her hand on the table.
"Very well, let's save this planet."

Glimmer´s cheers break the solemn mood, followed by the giggles of a few princesses. Even Mermista puckers her mouth as Sea

Hawk puts an arm around her shoulders in motivation. Then her expression darkens again as she says, "Okay, we all want to save the world. Fair enough, but we still need a plan."

This time Adora raises her voice. She tells of Catra's original idea that Scorpia could activate her powers. This would give them a suitable diversion and at the same time add a powerful warrior to the rebellion. The others listen to her, meanwhile casting occasional admiring glances at the Magicat. She ignores these silent compliments, obviously not yet able to handle positive feedback. Adora tries not to let it distract her as she finishes her explanation.

"So with Scorpia, Glimmer, and Bow, we're even stronger this time."
"You might indeed have a chance." agrees Angella, yet she frowns. "But the question still remains: how will you get into the Frightzone?" Everyone thinks hard. Then suddenly there is a 'click'. Adora pauses and quickly goes through the plan again in her head. Yes, it could work.
A tentative smile forms on her lips.
"I think I know someone who can help us."

Chapter End Notes

> Just in case you were wondering what happened to Shadow Weaver in this scene: Well, she missed the meeting. She wanted to take care of her garden. After all, what better moment to water flowers than in times of a possible end of the world? Okay, maybe she didn't necessarily miss the meeting of her own volition. Maybe Adora excluded her to make Catra feel more comfortable.

Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

The meeting goes better than expected, and after Adora proposes her idea, a plan began to form. After less than an hour, the meeting ended and the princesses leave the room with growing hope on their faces.

Catra, too, is feeling better. Both in regards to the upcoming mission, and the matter with Adora. The Magicat didn't even dare to look in the blonde's direction at the beginning. But the thing with the portal gave her the opportunity to turn her thoughts in another direction and to suppress her feelings at least temporarily.

Focusing on another problem felt as if the veil of confusion and uncertainty in her brain had been torn away, clearing the view for clear thoughts. As she listened to Adora's words, one thing became clear to her: No matter how Catra twists and turns the situation, she always ends up with one fact that cannot be changed:

She wants to be with Adora. And she doesn't want to be afraid of it any longer.
Her whole life has consisted of a single escape, a race between her and her feelings. This time she wants to dare to let the feelings win. Hoping not to regret it.

'I'm strong' she calls to herself as everyone but Adora and the Magicat have left the room. 'I can do this'.
"Hey, Adora? Can I talk to you for a second?" The blonde turns to her as jerkily as if she had only been waiting for this moment. Her blue-gray eyes are wide with anticipation, and she looks a little nervous.
"Yeah, sure."

Hesitantly, Catra takes a few steps towards Adora. 'Don't back down now,' she admonishes herself, taking a deep breath. Adora seems at least as tense as Catra feels, only at least the Magicat can hide it. But when she looks into the blonde's face, the words stick in her throat.

Damn it! Come on, Catra, don't be a wimp! You've survived Shadow Weaver, conquered Crimson Waste and fought the Lord of the Horde, this is nowhere near as dangerous!
However, this situation is a thousand times scarier.
Quickly, the Magicat lowers her gaze. Staring at the ground, she can concentrate better.

"Look, about what happened..." she begins, noticing out of the corner of her eye how Adora's muscles tense. Before Catra can continue talking, she is interrupted by the blonde's nervous voice.

"Oh that, haha! Don't worry about it. I guess we were both pretty tired yesterday. I have to apologize, Catra. I had no control over myself and got you in trouble with my behavior. That was a mistake and shouldn't have happened. It's my fault. But I hope this isn't something that can destroy our friendship, right?"

All warmth is drawn from her body as Catra stares at her friend. It feels like a cold hand is reaching for the Magicat's heart in an attempt to crush it. Her ears begin to roar.

Mistake. Mistake. Mistake.

Adora thinks it was a mistake. She didn't want this almost-kiss at all. She didn't want HER.
"Catra?" echoes Adora hesitantly. Blinking quickly to pull herself out of her stupor, the Magicat contorts her mouth into a wry grin. It seems more like a grimace.
"Right." she presses out, but her voice sounds shaky and hollow.

Still, she forces herself with an iron will to keep the grin on her face before lifting her head with effort. She can't interpret the

expression on Adora's face; she's too busy trying to get the ramparts inside her back up.

Mistake. Mistake. Mistake.
This was a mistake. One that almost cost her her heart and a friendship.

Catra doesn't have time now to think about how heavy the disappointment and pain weigh on her shoulders, trying to push her to the ground. 'Get a hold of yourself!" she admonishes herself, and finally, through years of practice, manages to suppress her feelings and appear completely calm on the outside.

She even manages to box Adora in the shoulder with her injured hand. The blonde flinches. "As long as it doesn't happen again, idiot." the Magicat mumbles, puckering her lips a little more.
Her cheeks hurt.

Relief is evident in Adora's face as she exhales bated breath and smiles.
"Got it." If the Magicat hadn't been so busy with herself just now, she might have noticed the sad shadow in Adora's eyes.
But as it is, they simply stand in front of each other for a moment, helplessly silent.

Until Catra can't take it anymore.
"Well, I'll be off then. Got some things to prepare for when we leave tomorrow." The mention of tomorrow awakens a change in Adora's mood. Suddenly she seems serious, but also strangely embarrassed.

"About that..." Catra frowns. Oh no, that expression never means anything good.
"Yeah?" she inquires, forgetting her sorrow for a moment.
Nervous, Adora scratches the back of her neck before explaining, "I think you'd better stay here."

The roar in Catra's ears disappears.

"You´re kidding."

Adora replies nothing, but merely frowns. Exploring, Catra searches the blonde's face for some sign that is really just her cruel sense of humor on display. But there is nothing.
Shocked, Catra looks at her.
"You're really serious about this."

"It's for your own good. You're still hurt!"
"It's nothing, I'm fine!" contradicts Catra snottily, grabbing her injured shoulder. The thought of being excluded from the mission and sitting here idly creates an incredible rage in her belly. Adora seems composed but determined.

"This mission is dangerous, maybe the most dangerous we've ever had! I can't risk anything happening to you!"
"You don't seem to have that concern with your other friends. Don't you trust me?!" Adora's muscles also tense.
"That's not the point at all. I just don't want-"

But Catra interrupts her. The Magicat's nerves are on edge. She doesn't want to argue anymore.
"I'm coming with you, end of discussion."
"Out of the question." The blonde's tone is harsh and unyielding, just like her expression at that moment. She's only ever seen Adora this serious on the battlefield, back when they fought each other. It only annoys Catra more.

"I can take care of myself!" she snorts angrily, earning Adora's bitter laughter in return.
"Oh yes, we can see where that got you last time!"

The whole palace seemed to hold its breath for a moment.
It is so quiet in the room that Catra can hear her rapid heartbeats. But she is too preoccupied with the noise inside her. Her body is frozen in horror, and she can't help but stare at Adora with her eyes wide open.

Adora, too, now realizes the magnitude of her words. Regret spreads across her face. No doubt she sees the pain in Catra's

face.
But the damage has already been done.

"You really don't believe in me. Just like everybody else." Catra mutters, stunned.
Her voice is dull and powerless, and consists of only a fraction of the volume she used before. The Magicat has already suffered a thousand knockdowns in her life, but this one can't be compared to any of them.

No one has ever believed in her. Not Hordak, not the cadets in the Horde, and certainly not Shadow Weaver. Even the inhabitants of the Crimson Waste had to be convinced of her abilities with deeds several times.
Most of the time, not even the Magicat believed in herself.

But experiencing this setback from Adora feels different. More serious. Like the foundation pillar of a building being knocked over.
The one person in her life who has always encouraged her, who has always believed in her, is now doubting her. This pain feels like a terrible betrayal and brings the barrel of crushing feelings dangerously close to overflowing.

"Catra," Adora puts in, her face contorting with guilt.
"I didn´t -"
"Cut it out." the Magicat retorts sharply, turning away.
"If that's how you feel, we don't need to talk at all. Then I know where I stand now."

"Catra!" Adora wants to stop her, but the Magicat is faster and flees the hall.
Too much. All too much. Her thoughts swirl wildly, and her emotions threaten to erupt at any moment and cause her to collapse.
Air. She needs air.

Like a hunted woman, she runs through the corridors of the castle, ignoring everyone she meets. But instead of stopping at the castle garden, she fights her way up. There would be people in the garden, and she must be alone now. But in the small hospital room she would suffocate, and Adora's room is the last place she wants to be right now.

Nevertheless, her path leads her to this exact room. Determined, she pushes open the door and runs through the room as fast as she can, afraid Adora's strong smell might bring tears to her eyes if she's not careful. But in a flash, she's on the balcony and turns to face the castle wall. Within moments, she has climbed the wall until she is sitting on the roof of the castle.

There is no one up here except a few birds. Breathing heavily, Catra sits down cross-legged and carefully massages her shoulder. The climb has left her with a burning twinge, but she doesn't care right now. To distract herself, she lets her eyes wander over the vast land.

From here, she sees the edge of the Whispering Woods and automatically wishes she could just disappear into its sheltered canopy right now. Dejectedly, she lifts her gaze and watches the passing clouds in the wide sky.

Up here, everything is so still and quiet. So quiet that the volume in her head becomes unbearable.
And finally she allows herself to let go.
Her dam breaks and a torrent of emotions bursts over her, taking away her breath. The tears begin to flow and her body trembles. Everything is crashing down on her.

Adora does not feel the same as Catra. She doesn't even believe in her.

Maybe she was mistaken about the blonde.
Maybe the Magicat should never have let herself open her heart.
Maybe she should have never dared to trust people.
There she had the phenomenon she's been going through over

and over again all her life: people only hurt you if you let them get to you.

And yet, even after all this time, Catra still hasn't learned. Made the same mistake again. Again, let her heart be torn to pieces. Will there be anything left of it at all, or will Catra be nothing but an empty shell once the tears have dried up and the last feeling has been expressed?

She doesn't know. She just wants it to finally stop. This pain. This feeling of having been betrayed. And this stubborn, stupid longing not to be alone. To be held.
How stupid she was to think she'd ever had a chance with Adora. To experience happiness maybe once in her life.
She should have known better.

Doggedly, she pulls her knees to her chest and wraps them around her so tightly it hurts. But she barely notices. At that moment, she feels all alone in this world. And for the first time she feels how painful this thought is.
Pain again.
When would it stop? When would she finally feel something other than this old familiar, horrible pain?

Adora:

Even when she reaches her room, her hands have not stopped shaking. Dazed, she sits down on the edge of the bed and stares into space. She has had an argument with Catra. In her concern for the Magicat, she made things worse.
Would she be able to fix it this time? She dreads the answer.

A whimper escapes her. Why is everything going so wrong now? All she wants is.... she... she wants...
Frustrated, the blonde moans. She doesn't even know what she wants anymore. What she REALLY wants.

Why does everything have to be so complicated? For the first time, Adora wishes she had never become She Ra. Then she would have stayed in the Horde, with Catra. Together they would have climbed to the top and eventually ruled the Horde.
Perhaps they could have made nice with the other countries. This war would have ended peacefully.

And there never would have been a fight between her and the Magicat, there never would have been this huge gap between them. A gap. That best describes what Adora is feeling right now. As if when Catra stormed out, she took a part of her heart with her, too.
Now there is a void there that her body is trying to fill with pain. Pain and despair.

Why can't something work for once in her life without disaster? Without her having to give up something? Immediately, a guilty conscience catches up with her. Adora is She Ra, she reminds herself. What happens to her doesn't matter. If she could manage to save Catra from harm, she would give anything to do it. Even if it meant the Magicat might never speak to her again.

Just the thought makes Adora sick, but her personal happiness doesn't count.
SHE doesn't count.
As long as she could protect the others, she would. No matter what the cost.

Noisily she takes a breath to push back the overwhelming feelings inside her.
But it has little effect. When she is startled to notice a single tear rolling down her cheek, she hastily wipes it away and forcefully suppresses the storm of emotions inside her that threaten to take over at any moment. For she is afraid that if she can no longer maintain the barrier, her feelings will erupt, overwhelm and suffocate her.

And she can't let that happen. Not now, when everyone is counting on her. When the world needs her. She has to stay

strong. Even if it feels like she's suffocating her own heart.
But she is She Ra. She must function. She must perform. Succeed.
Only... Why is the price of success so high?

A knock on her door makes her flinch. Clearing her throat, she scratches her neck and looks at the door.
"What is it?" she calls, hoping her voice isn't shaking too much. As Glimmer and Bow enter the room, the blonde drops her shoulders in relief.

"Hey, we just wanted to ask if we could come for tomorrow - What happened?" Glimmer asks in shock when she sees Adora's face, which must be reflecting a thousand emotions right now.
"Nothing." Adora replies curtly, trying a pitiful smile that slips. Bow frowns and stands in front of his best friend along with the princess.
"You sure? You look pretty banged up. Something must have happened."

Under the prompting but gentle gaze of her friends, Adora feels herself losing control of her emotions after all. Tears she can no longer hold back roll down her cheeks, leaving a wet trail on her skin. Startled, the two friends kneel in front of Adora and take her in their arms, not knowing what is going on at all.

They have never seen Adora cry before. It almost scares them to see how the blonde is no longer in control.

All the more they feel the urge to be there for her. Sobbing, Adora leans into the hugs and murmurs softly, "I screwed up."
That's all she can get out. Nor does she need to say more, because Glimmer and Bow are there. They hold Adora tight and don't let her go.

They stay with her and wait while the blonde lets her uncontrollable sobs shake her and draws comfort from being near them. It works only moderately, but Adora is grateful not to be alone.

When she can speak again, she tells in brief words what happened. And when she ends, Bow takes her in his arms again and Glimmer murmurs soothing words. Words without meaning, words that would not make her situation better, Adora knows that. But Glimmer´s soothing voice causes her to become calmer as well, until she finally falls asleep from exhaustion next to her two friends.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter is a bit shorter, the next one will be longer again (and it will cost me all my nerves, haha).

Chapter 31

Adora:

At night, Adora sleeps poorly. Her dreams are distorted and blend into a single chaos of horrible images that always end with the fall of Etheria and Catra's death.
The next morning, the rings under her eyes are as gray as her shadow. At the same time, her face is swollen and reddened from the many tears she has cried over the past few hours.

When the blonde sees her face in the mirror, she almost recoils herself. She looks horrible. There is no more beautiful way to describe it. For the last few years, she has always managed to keep it together, never losing her composure. Until yesterday.

The feelings that have been building up inside her and that she has suppressed and repressed for years have erupted from her and have now left clear traces. A miserable sigh escapes Adora. She can't face anyone like this. Especially not today. The mission is about to begin.

That's why she quickly gets into the shower and then brushes her wet hair. After tying it into her usual ponytail, she tends to her face. Glimmer has provided her with a few little things this morning, including a cream that works wonders on her skin.

When the blonde has also put on her clothes and looks in the mirror again, there is hardly anything left of her dejection. Very good. Looking neat would also help her keep a better grip on her emotions. Today, more than ever, it is important not to lose control:
Today, the Rebellion would defeat the Horde. Once and for all.

Adora resolutely leaves her room and closes the door behind her when she notices something scurrying away out of the corner of her eye and disappearing behind a junction. Frowning, she turns her head, but she can't see anything. Vigilantly, she walks down

the hallway toward the corner behind where something has moved.

Her fingers twitch to the staff at her belt, ready to defend herself if necessary, as she turns the corner and a familiar face appears directly in front of her. She almost stumbles backwards in surprise, but regains her balance in time.
Her emotions, however, seem to be swinging wildly.

"Catra! W-what are you doing here?" the blonde stammers, her eyes wide as she tries to suppress her excitement. The Magicat is casually leaning against the wall with her arms crossed. The collision with Adora doesn't seem to have affected her in the slightest. She almost looks bored as she examines her claws.

"Oh, hey Adora." Her voice sounds casual, almost normal, had it not been for that twinge in her eyes with which she now scrutinizes Adora.
"I was looking for the queen." she explains simply, crossing her arms again. Adora frowns. Something is not right. Of course the atmosphere between the two would be different after yesterday, Adora is aware of that, but somehow.... there is something more.

For a moment there is silence, then the blonde notices the change.
"Where is your arm sling? And your bandages?" Catra blinks before shrugging her shoulders.
"Took them off. I'm perfectly fine, as you can see." Suddenly, she pushes herself off the wall and takes a step towards the blonde.

"You, on the other hand, look pretty crappy. Had a rough night?" Adora is so speechless that she doesn't know what to feel first: Anger, indignation, or shame. Catra has never held back her opinion before, but this.... This is something else. Her words feel very personal and cruel. As if Catra has suddenly changed her personality. Adora didn't expect the Magicat to be nice, but to react like this....

Catra begins to circle her. "Whereby I must add that nothing can actually disfigure your ravishing visage."
Her rapid heartbeat and the blush that rises in her cheeks must have been noticed by the Magicat, because she stops in front of Adora and just grins. It somehow doesn't match her face, but Adora can't really focus on it with the chaos of emotions inside her.

Catra seems to find this one-sided conversation quite boring all of a sudden, so she pats Adora's shoulder and walks past her. "Anyway, I really have to go now. It was nice talking to you, darling. See you around!" Jerkily, Adora raises her head and turns around. Quick as a flash, she grabs the Magicat's wrist and presses her against the wall.

Her counterpart's pupils constrict in surprise.
"Catra would never take the word 'darling' in her mouth," the blonde murmurs dangerously softly and looks at her opponent warily.
Now she also realizes why this encounter has felt so strange all along: This person looks exactly like Catra, but it's not her. Her subconscious has sensed it.

The gold and blue of her eyes don't gleam as much as the original, and the mischievous grin is missing. So is her unique smell. For a moment, the stranger looks at Adora in amazement, then Catra's lips twist into a grin, exposing a row of fangs.

"Not bad. I admit that was a careless mistake." a familiar voice declares before Catra's body changes, trading its curves, thick hair, and cat ears for green skin, yellow eyes, and a lizard tail.
"Double Trouble!" Adora hisses half angry, half relieved that it´s not the real Catra standing in front of her.

DT giggles gleefully after the blonde loosens her grip around their wrists.
"What´s that all about?!"
"A little experiment of mine.." DT explains, amused. "I wanted to see if I could imitate someone already, even though I barely know

them." Satisfied, the shapeshifter clutches his chest. "And I think, apart from the little faux pas at the end, I've managed quite well, haven't I? I'm open to any criticism!"

An expectant twinkle enters their eyes as they clasp their hands together. Frustration grips Adora. Frustration and shame that she let herself be fooled. And that DT has so obviously seen through her.
"What are you doing? I called you here for an important mission, not to play your games with me."

Defensively, DT raises his hands. "Alll right, calm down. I just wanted to see if I could crack the mysterious Magicat after spending just one evening with her. Apparently I still need to tweak it a bit, but it doesn't matter. Speaking of Catra, where is that grouchy little cat? Is she still such a buzzkill? Probably. Hmm and judging by your mood, she's rubbed off on you."

When DT sees Adora's outraged face, they giggle again.
"Geez, now don't take everything personally. Alright, I see there's a lot of heat between you two right now?"
"Where did you-"

"Your reactions were clear, Sweety. You're not a very good actress. Admittedly, when I arrived this morning, I considered trying my experiment on the Magicat. Now I'm glad I didn't, after all. Her mood must be even more atrocious than yours. Knowing our Catra, she would have bitten my tail with rage. But well. Let's change the subject, shall we? I have to say, I was really surprised that you contacted me so soon. Not that I wasn't pleased. And when you told me about your mission..."

Dramatically, DT throws his arms in the air. "Sweety, I can't tell you how exciting this all is. I haven't had a mission this challenging and exciting in a long time! Well, and one that makes me so much money, of course."

The shapeshifter's torrent of words overwhelms Adora a bit. She decides to focus on the essentials and clears her throat.

"That means you already know the details of the plan and your role in it?"
"But of course. I do my homework before an assignment. A young lady named Perfuma was kind enough to brief me. Lovely woman, really. Just now I was on my way to see the Queen, but to be honest I got a little lost and happened to run into you."

DT looks at Adora expectantly. She blinks before pointing down the hallway.
"Up the stairs, then the third door on the left. That's where the queen should be right now."
Nodding, DT takes a step away from the blonde.
"Thank you very much. I'll say goodbye then. And we'll talk later, all right? You know I'm addicted to gossip, and the Rebellion sounds like a goldmine of drama and tragedy!"

They wave again and wink at her before turning and disappearing into the hallway. Shaking her head, Adora watches the shapeshifter go. She knows DT is the right man for the job, she has seen with her own eyes how good they are.

However, the shapeshifter seems to enjoy having fun with their clients way too much. This could be dangerous. For the mission, but especially for Adora's poor heart, which is completely overwhelmed by the recent events.

Frowning, the blonde closes her eyes for a moment. What would she have done if she had just met the real Catra? What if Catra really will behave so coldly and apathetically towards her? Would she be able to cope with that?
Swallowing, she opens her eyes. She would have to. After all, she has no choice.

Resolutely, she strides down the hallway. She would continue to suppress her feelings. Because there is no time for that now. First she would save Etheria and her friends and get everyone to safety.
After that, she can deal with herself and try to straighten things

out with Catra.
That is, if she survives this mission.

Catra:

With trembling fingers, she loosens the sling around her neck and frees her left arm, which falls to her side. A painful twinge drives into her shoulder, but the Magicat bites down hard on her lower lip and makes no sound as she sets about undoing the bandage around her right hand.

Burnt fur and an ugly wound are revealed underneath, but it is closed and only superficial. No scar would remain.
Unlike her shoulder. Pondering, Catra looks into the mirror in front of her and struggles with herself for a moment, wondering if she should also loosen the bandage around her shoulder.

The sight underneath would hardly convince the others that she has recovered. On the other hand, she's been carrying that bandage around long enough. Magicats heal very quickly, so walking around without a bandage shouldn't be a problem.
And Catra certainly doesn't want to look weak.
Never again.

Resolutely she loosens the wide bandage around her left shoulder with one hand, ignoring the burning sensation. When there is finally no longer any visual protection, the Magicat looks at the exposed wound for a moment. A star-shaped mark sits on her collarbone and extends from her shoulder down her cleavage to her neck.

The doctor has removed the fur around it to better treat the wound.
Yep, not a pretty sight. This is going to leave a scar. A huge, ugly scar.
But well, better than dying, Catra thinks bitterly and gets up to put on her clothes.

She decides on a pair of black pants and a dark halter top that covers at least part of the scar. Finally, she carefully slips on her jacket from Crimson Waste and ties her hair into a ponytail, focused on not making a face. When she ignores the pain, it will go away. Inside and out.
At least, that's what she hopes.

Hesitantly, her eyes fall on the small cream jar Bow handed her this morning, along with a cup full of warm, sweet broth. From the look of pity on his face, he's already heard from Adora about what happened yesterday, and instead of siding with her and going off on the Magicat, he simply gave her an encouraging smile and said that he's there if she wants to talk.

Possibly he would have closed her in a comforting embrace, but he seems to have seen that Catra would not have been able to cope with that. That's why he settled for a smile and disappeared from the room.

Nevertheless, his kindness and the sweet drink improved Catra's mood, at least for a little while. And the cream has taken away from her face all traces of tears from the last hours, so now you can't tell how miserable she actually feels. She didn't say it, but she is really grateful to Bow for this small gesture. Maybe she'll be able to convey that to him later.

Satisfied with her appearance, she puts on her gun belt before leaving the room. She had asked for a new room late in the evening, since she had insisted on being released from the hospital wing. This new room was decorated in a similarly pompous and tasteless manner as the rest of the castle, but Catra has gradually begun to get used to it.

Besides, she really has bigger things to worry about right now than her room.
On her way to the Moonstone, which is the meeting place for departure, she peers into an open room, lost in thought - and almost trips over her own feet.

Blinking, she stops and walks back a few steps to take another look at what's happening in the room. Almost, just almost, the Magicat's jaw dropped. In the middle of the brightly lit room was a small pedestal with a tall figure standing on it. A person all too familiar to the Magicat.

However, it does not fit into this environment at all. Frowning, the person looks at her image in a huge mirror and turns back and forth.
"Don't you think this cloak makes me fat?" Hordak asks accusingly, eyeing his hips and shoulders almost uncertainly.

After Catra recovers from the minor shock, she also spots Perfuma and Scorpia positioned to his right and left. Scorpia shakes her head violently and claps her scissor hands together.
"Absolutely not, you look great, really! Your skills are amazing!"

Her eager compliment obviously embarrasses the supposed Hordak. He makes a throwing away hand gesture, which looks really strange.
"Oh stop it! You're too kind, really!"
"I agree!" Catra interjects dryly, as she leans against the doorframe and crosses her arms.

She ignores the uncomfortable tugging in her shoulder. All eyes turn to her. Hordak's eyes find her first in the reflection before he turns and begins to beam.
"Catra! How good to see you, darling!"
With difficulty, the Magicat suppresses an eye roll and mutters, "Hey, Double Trouble."

The shapeshifter grins mischievously and steps off the pedestal, but remains in Hordak's form. With large strides, they stride towards the Magicat.
"It seems like an eternity since we last saw each other! I see you're still a bit of a curmudgeon."

Their voice is now their own and now more than ever does not fit the image of the Lord of the Horde. Although the Hordak has no

pupils, the Magicat feels DT watching her intently. With their usual predatory gaze, analyzing every movement. She noticed it already at their first encounter, how attentive the Shapeshifter perceives others. Whether it is due to their curiosity or their zeal as imitation artists is irrelevant.

What is certain is that the Magicat feels threatened by it.
She doesn't want to be analyzed by anyone. Especially not by someone she hardly knows. No one has the right to know her that well if she doesn't let them. Before the shapeshifter can be tempted to ask her dangerous questions or get on her nerves with his over-the-top behavior, Catra quickly clears her throat.

"What are you doing here?" Fortunately, DT elaborates.
"I'm rehearsing my role. Oh, dear, this assignment is so exciting! And challenging! So far, I've never imitated anyone I haven't met and studied in person. I haven't had this much fun in rehearsals in a long time! The ladies here were kind enough to help me rehearse the role."

Skeptically, Catra raises an eyebrow and squints at Perfuma and Scorpia.
"And how successful have you been so far?"
Her tone makes it clear how unimpressed she is with DT's performance so far. Scorpia scratches the back of her neck in embarrassment.
"Well, I described to him as best I could what Hordak looks like. To the... uh... Behavior and such, we haven't gotten to yet."

Perfuma seems to have an idea.
"Oh, but you can certainly help us there! You spent most of your time with him, after all!"
Her excited expression changes to uncertainty as she meekly continues, "You know, when you were Force Captain...."

Her words pique the Shapeshifter's interest as he leans down to Magicat curiously.
"So...you used to be one of Lord Hordak's lapdogs?" Reflexively, Catra extends her claws and grabs DT by the collar before pulling

their face toward her with a jerk. With a razor-sharp gaze, she stares at him.

"Remember my words: I am not, have not been, and will NEVER be anyone's lapdog, understand?"
DT doesn't flinch, but the mischievousness is gone from their eyes as they meet Catra's gaze.
"Understood."

The seriousness in their voice was almost frightening. Is it because they recognize the sore spot in their countenance in addition to the irritation? The Magicat is not distracted by this unusual behavior.
"I was a feared leader in the Horde for two years before I was cast out. Now I fight on the other side, and that's all you need to know."

She reveals as little information as possible to make her point, but DT still seems to make up quite a bit about her. At least that's what she reads in their overly intelligent eyes, which are their own for a moment. Then she lets them go and waits until they have taken a step back.

For a moment DT examines her seriously, like a puzzle to which they can now add a few new puzzle pieces, then their mischievous expression returns.
"Well then, you know I'm open to instructions. So fire away, what do I need to know?" Expectantly, the shapeshifter looks at Catra. No longer like their prey, but more like a student awaiting instructions from their teacher.

The Magicat looks questioningly at Scorpia.
"What have you told him so far?" Scorpia looks a little overwhelmed.
"Well, that Hordak is pretty irritable and mostly hunkers down in his lab."
So pretty much nothing useful. But Catra doesn't voice her thoughts, just nods and steps into the room.

The shapeshifter follows her.
"Okay, now listen to me carefully. For the mission to work, you must appear convincing. The soldiers must not detect any anomalies. I'm going to tell you, as best I can, the usual behaviors of Hordak. Implementing them is up to you."
She takes a deep breath before beginning her lecture.

A few hours later, it's time to leave. Catra has done her best to prepare DT for their role, and she has to admit that they are really very professional and have a quick grasp. In the end, they really look deceptively real. Any mischievousness, any amusement has gone out of the red shining eyes, no sign points to the shapeshifter anymore.

Instead, the proud, fierce Lord of the Horde stands before the women, striding across the room with a smugness that impresses even the Magicat. Scorpia claps enthusiastically.
"So impressive!" notes Perfuma in fascination as well, before frowning.
"But maybe you should change back for now, because roaming the palace corridors like that could get you accidentally arrested."

Double Trouble, no, Hordak gives the princess a disdainful look before sighing.
"Pathetic soldiers. It would be a futile effort." Determined, he raises a fist in the air.
"No one could stop me, the future ruler of Etheria!" Then he withdraws his hand and his posture loosens before he clears his throat.

"But I suppose you're right. Now then" His stature changes, becoming smaller and more graceful, until finally the Shapeshiter stands before them again with a wide grin. "Let's go then, ladies."
Willingly, Perfuma and Scorpia hook up with him and leave the room, Catra following them at a little distance.

As the Flower Princess and the Shapeshifter are engaged in conversation in the hallways, Scorpia glances back at the Magicat and frowns worriedly. Without taking her eyes off her, she

disengages from DT and steps to Catra's side.
"Hey, you okay, Wildcat?" Her question seems to bring out in Catra the tiredness she has been feeling all along. The lack of energy.

"Sure." She lies, unconvincingly. "Why do you ask?" The tall woman tilts her head.
"You seem pretty... downcast. It's not like you." Catra lets out a grunt.
"I've been down before."
That's an understatement.

Scorpia grins before turning serious again.
"I know, but you've never been so.... unenergetic. You look like you've had every ounce of strength sucked out of you." She hit a nerve. In fact, the Magicat feels like the fight with Adora has made her.... Tired. Lifeless.
Before, when she was upset, she used her anger to get extra energy. She could have run, fought, or moved mountains for days when she was furious.

But now? All she feels is emptiness. This fight was different, that's why it affects Catra differently. It has made her tired. Paralyzed her fighting spirit. It's scary what Adora can do to her without meaning to.
"I... had an argument with Adora." Catra admits quietly, not looking at Scorpia. The woman next to her takes a hissing breath.

"Oh wow. That's... um... surprising. I thought you guys were one heart and soul now. How-"
She stops herself abruptly, probably because she can see the anguish on Catra's face. Instead, she clears her throat.
"Is there... do anything to make you feel better?"

Now the Magicat is the one who is surprised. Astonished, she looks up at Scorpia. No one has asked her that before. For the first time that day, she smiles tentatively as she looks into the wide eyes.
"I'll be fine. But... thank you, Scorpia. Really."

Scorpia beams at Catra before they reach the platform together, where the Moonstone is placed.

At first glance, it seems that everyone else has already gathered. Glimmer stands off to the side with her back turned to the troupe and her hands positioned on the Moonstone to absorb its power. Under her mother's guidance, she would transport everyone to the Frightzone today.

While Scorpia joins Perfuma, who introduces the Shapeshifter to the others, Mermista walks towards the Magicat. The sea princess wears blue armor and holds a trident loosely in her hands. Her gaze is bored as usual, but her eyes sparkle. Looking at the lack of bandages, the corners of her mouth even lift as she nods to Catra.

"You seem to be doing better." Catra lifts the corners of her mouth as well and tilts her head.
"I'm not going to admit defeat that easily."
"I knew you wouldn't."
She doesn't know why, but somehow a strange bond has formed between the two women over the past few days. A silent understanding. And Catra likes it.

Almost Mermista seems to give her a smile.
"Well then" Amicably she pokes the Magicat in the healthy side. "On to the battle."
"Don't get yourself killed." Catra murmurs as the sea princess turns away. She turns to the Magicat once more and winks.
"Oh please. I'm Sea-Ra! I won't be killed that easily. But the same goes for you, understand?"

Catra's response consists of a nod. Satisfied, Mermista turns away and walks to the pirate, who is clearly pleased to be near her. Then the Magicat's gaze falls on a blonde woman who is talking to the queen.
Immediately her body tenses and her heart contracts. Adora looks like she always does. Except for the slight tension that surrounds her, but given the upcoming mission, even that is normal.

Catra doesn't know why she is so disappointed. Maybe she was hoping that this fight would get Adora down just as much. That she would have as much trouble pulling herself together as Catra. That she wouldn't be able to think of anything else.
But that doesn't seem to be the case at all.
At least not until the blonde's gaze brushes Magicat's and her expression freezes.

Catra immediately recognizes that the blue-gray eyes are hiding emotions from the outside world, but she can't tell what they are. Discomfort spreads through her. Is Adora angry with her for showing up? Disappointed? Does she even want to have anything to do with Catra anymore?

And why the hell do these thoughts hurt so much??? The Magicat herself has decided to retreat, after all. She has seen it herself: Being close to Adora only brings pain. She should be happy when Adora distances herself from her.

This fact does not seem to have reached her heart yet. In fact, it bounces treacherously with excitement when Adora suddenly moves away from the queen and walks toward Catra. The Magicat is frozen, caught by the gaze that Adora never once takes from her. When she finally stops in front of Catra, no one says anything for a while.

Until Adora finally gives in.
"Catra." It sounds neutral, but Catra thinks she can hear a trace of uncertainty.
"Princess." she presses out. Adora winces.
Does it feel as painful to her as it does to Catra? She hasn't used the nickname in a while. It stands for everything, which is why she wanted to stay away from the blonde. A reminder to herself that she needs to keep her distance.

For a moment, the two women eye each other in silence. The tension is almost palpable. Adora looks like she wants to say something, but holds back. Her gaze is conflicted, as if she is

struggling internally with how to act before one side finally wins the battle.

Audibly, she exhales and glances at Catra's neck. The small part of the scar, unconcealed by the top and jacket, raises a frown on Adora's face.
"I don't think you-" Catra cuts her off by declaring with a scowl, "I'll come with you. I'm going to fight, and you're not going to stop me. Accept it or live with it, that I will attach myself to this mission like a deadly shadow."

Her voice is so cold and incisive that probably even Shadow Weaver would have paused. Adora looks as if these words have struck her like an arrow in the chest. At the same moment, however, she shakes any emotion from herself and takes a step back before nodding.
"Very well." She wants to turn away, but she hesitates.
"But please... be careful."

As she looks back, her eyes soften for a moment, filled with concern. Outwardly, Catra remains steadfast, not a muscle stirring as she loses herself in the depths of those blue eyes. Only her fists betray how much she struggles with her emotions. When the Magicat replies nothing, Adora lowers her head in resignation, turns away and walks away.
Only when she is out of earshot does Catra whisper tremulously, "You too."

Her fists loosen, and she turns away, not wanting to be tempted to stare after Adora any longer. Taking a deep breath, she then joins the circle of princesses that has since formed. As before, they all join hands, only this time the end of this chain is formed by Glimmer, which glows pink with energy. It's a friendly glow, no comparison to the eerie tentacles Shadow Weaver gave off last time.

Catra connects her hands to Scorpia and Spinnerella this time. She studiously ignores the fact that she is facing Adora in a circle.
"Okay, is everyone ready?" Glimmer wants to know much more

enthusiastically than Catra feels at the moment. Everyone nods.
"Good, hold on!"
A soft, glittering glow envelops the Magicat and draws them away.

Chapter 32

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora:

"Ouch, that hurts!" Glimmer complains in a whisper behind Adora. Automatically, dozens of admonishing "Shhhh "s sound from all sides. Grumbling, she replies, "Sorry. I'm just saying, you guys could have loosened up the handcuffs a little."

Reflexively, Adora twists her wrists in front of her stomach and feels the slight chafing that the metal handcuffs cause. True, they are really not comfortable, but they are part of the plan.
"And risk getting busted right away?" Catra shakes her head. "Grit your teeth and keep walking, Sparkles, we'll be right there."

Adora, Catra, and Glimmer walk in single file behind each other through the forest just outside the Frightzone. Each of them is wearing the same handcuffs, each being held by one of the princesses they have circled. Except that Spinnerella, Frosta, Perfuma, Scorpia, Mermista, Netossa, Sea Hawk and Bow are still wearing Horde uniforms over their usual clothes. Their faces reflect the tension that the blonde feels inside.

At the head of the small squad, DT walks ahead. Or rather: Hordak. With a proud but serious face, he leads the group towards the main gate of the Frightzone. As they exit the forest, Adora quickly mutters, "Helmets!"
Immediately, the "soldiers" around them put on their helmets so as not to be recognized.

"And now, no more sound!" warns Catra, and although she walks behind Adora, the blonde could have sworn she was just stabbing Glimmer with her gaze. A snort confirms her theory a few seconds later. DT assumes an even more upright posture before leading the group to the entrance of the Frightzone as a matter of course.

The soldiers, who have been posted as sentries, nearly drop their jaws when they catch sight of their leader.
"My Lord! W-what are you doing out here?"
Glowing red eyes lower their gaze to the soldier closest to him.

"Are you demanding an account from your lord?" Hordak asks in an icy tone. The soldier begins to tremble.
"O-of course not, master. I was just thinking-"
"Thinking is not your job."

Arrogantly, Hordak pulls his head back and looks to the other soldiers, waiting.
"Open the gate!"
"B-but sir, you said yourself that under all circumstances it should be locked-"
Hordak seemed to almost grow in size as he punished the soldiers with a piercing stare.
"You dare deny me entry to my own fortress?"

His voice grew louder and louder, and Adora nearly flinched herself. The Shapeshifter's skill is truly extraordinary. The poor soldier broke out in a sweat.
"Never, master!" With a sweeping gesture, Hordak points behind him, revealing the rest of the group.
"You're lucky I'm in a good mood today. Through my brilliant move, I've managed to grab some valuable loot and weaken the rebellion."

His expression turns ice cold again.
"However, my mood can change again very quickly. So if you don't spurt IMMEDIATELY and open this gate, I will drag you to my lab and reduce you to test subjects."
The soldiers look like they're going to collapse at any moment. Even as a cadet, Adora has already learned to fear Hordak's lab. She can understand the fear of the men, who are now stammering apologies and actually entering the code into an input field.

Shortly thereafter, there is a squeak and the gate opens. With a last, sinister glance, Hordak looks at his subjects before he turns away with a snort and marches with his head held high into his realm. Like willing puppets, the rebellion follows him. Adora, Catra and Glimmer take care to keep their heads down and look as unwilling as possible, while the rest of the princesses follow the Lord of the Horde in a single unit.

Catra has described to him the way where they had to go, and as soon as they get to a side corridor of Hordak's fortress, their shoulders relax and Hordak turns around with a big grin.
"Ohhh, that was great! I've rarely enjoyed myself so much! This role suits me brilliantly, don't you think?"
Netossa and Spinnerella release us from the handcuffs, while Glimmer rolls her eyes but smirks.
"I must say, you were really impressive."

Grinning mischievously, Hordak then transforms back into DT. The princesses take off their uniforms, as they are too heavy and bulky, then everyone looks at Adora eagerly. The blonde bites her lip.
"Okay, phase one is done. Well done. We'll proceed as planned: Scorpia, you go with Perfuma to the Black Garnet and activate your powers." Those addressed nodded.

"Mermista, Sea Hawk, Netossa, Spinnerella, and Frosta: you'll cause trouble and chaos. Be sure to draw the soldiers away from the lab."
"Got it. I can´t wait!" Frosta rubs his hands together eagerly.
Adora turns to Catra.
"Catra -"
"I'm escorting Scorpia and Flower Princess." the Magicat explains coldly, looking past the blonde.

Adora clenches her hands into fists, ignoring the twinge in her chest.
"...Okay, then. Be careful."
Everyone nods before turning and disappearing through different

directions. Catra hesitates for a moment, her gaze lingering on Adora before she too turns away and sprints off.

It feels wrong as Adora watches her disappear into the dark. Didn't they get in trouble last time for not being together? But she probably couldn't have possibly convinced the Magicat to stay with her.
'How do you know?'a soft voice sounds in her head. 'You didn't ask her. You didn't tell her that you wanted her with you.'

Guilt threatens to overwhelm her. It's true. Adora caused this mess. She made Catra feel unwelcome. She didn't care enough to show her how much she ....
Stop. Later. Resolutely, Adora shakes her head and runs off as well. She would fix this. But not now. Now she has a mission to accomplish.

Determined, she walks toward the lab and presses herself against the wall when she reaches the entrance. For a moment, she stands rigidly there, not moving. Nothing can be heard. This is unusual. Frowning, Adora risks a glance. At first, she doesn't recognize much. A large part of the lab has been destroyed and there are boulders lying around everywhere and destroyed machine parts.

But in the center, unmoved, is the pedestal on which the huge iron ring stands. The portal. And in its center, her sword. As if the sword could sense her presence, it suddenly begins to glow, as if to greet her.
As if magically attracted, Adora's gaze clings to the sword as she enters the room.
And is promptly pushed aside.

Roughly, she hits her side on the floor and groans, before picking herself up in a flash and looking for the attacker. A few feet away stands a robot, a little taller than herself. She realizes with horror that it is one of the Horde's battle robots. And that its sensors glow pink. It must have been modified by Entrapta.

This is not the first time she has faced a battle robot. However, this time she has no She Ra forces to help her. Doggedly, she tenses up and wants to go after her opponent, but it has already fired an energy ball in her direction. She barely escapes the line of fire and rushes towards the robot. It wants to aim at her again, but she is faster.

She gives it a kick, but misses as he dodges. With her fist, she lunges and goes to aim at one of it´s arms when something grabs her and yanks her backwards. A second fighting robot has appeared and is holding Adora down. The first robot has meanwhile regained its footing and comes to its side to hold Adora as well.

Desperately, the blonde writhes under the iron grips. Strained sounds escape her throat, and sweat forms on her forehead. But in vain. The robots do not give in for a second. An amused snort echoes through the destroyed laboratory. Adora stops struggling and looks up.
Just in time to see Hordak emerge from behind a piece of debris.

With his hands clasped behind his back, he steps up to her.
"Oh, Adora. You didn't think I'd make it that easy for you, did you? But I must thank you for accepting my invitation. Really, without your help I wouldn't be able to put my plan into action."

Angry, Adora stares at the lord, but she is confused. What help? Her eyes wander to the sword on the pedestal, which continues to glow.
Then the scales fall from her eyes.
"You wanted me to come," she states tonelessly. "My presence -"

"Activated the sword, that's right. I must say that I am truly fascinated by the wondrous workings of First One technology, and I confess that I cannot fully comprehend them myself. But what I do know is that with your help, I am finally able to harness the limitless power of She Ra, put my plan into action, and - finally - return home to my master."

His eyes take on an unhealthy gleam as he approaches the pedestal backwards.
"Prime will deem me worthy again once I offer him this world to conquer. Then I will finally be allowed to be part of the Brotherhood again and serve him!"
Adora doesn't understand much of what Hordak is saying. What scares her is that he sounds insane.

She must stop him.
Determined, she tugs at the robots' handles, but their grips do not loosen. Helplessly, Adora must watch as Hordak climbs onto the pedestal and pushes a button, whereupon a switch is released from the iron ring.

The way Hordak looks at this switch, it is clear: as soon as he flips this switch, the portal will be activated.
The world will be destroyed. And there will be no turning back.

With a triumphant grin, Hordak puts his hand on the switch.
Adora squirms in exasperation.
"No!"
Just then, a shadow darts across the room, faster than anyone could react. In the next instant, Hordak is knocked off the platform and comes crashing to the ground a few feet away.

Standing above him is the Magicat, looking down at him with a grin.
"I'm sorry to burst your dreams, but that won't work."
"Catra!" Adora can't hide the surprise, nor the relief and joy in her voice. Casually, Catra turns to Adora and gives her a look. Only briefly, but not as coldly as before.

Then she focuses on the two robots holding Adora. Without further ado, she lunges at the first one and gives it a powerful kick that sends it reeling. Catra seizes the chance and destroys the sensors with her claws in a single blow. Whirring and twitching, the robot lets go of Adora and goes down.

The second one continues to hold Adora while it goes for the Magicat, but the latter is faster. Within moments she has disassembled the robot into its parts and Adora is free.
Blinking, the blonde stares at her.
"Why... Why aren't you with Scorpia?" Catra shrugs, noticing Adora's suppressed hiss, and avoids looking her in the eye.

"Well, I was there, but they can manage without me. I realized that this plan will never work if you're all alone. And I just can't stand it when you claim all the fun for yourself."
The words leave her mouth so easily. So playful. They almost sound like the old Catra.
And for the first time Adora clearly hears the serious tone. Trying to hide something much more weighty under a mountain of sarcasm and jokes.

The blonde tilts her head. When they were both cadets, she could sense when Catra was feeling bad. At least, that's what she thought. But now it occurs to her how often she might have overlooked it. Or wanted to overlook.

Before she can say anything back, they are interrupted by a cough. Both heads snap in the direction from which the sound came. Hordak is just getting back up, glowering at the Magicat.
"You." he growls, barely able to contain his anger.
"How many times do I have to kill you before I finally get rid of you!"

Relaxed, Catra looks at the Lord of the Horde and grins, extending her claws.
"Good luck trying to get rid of me. It may take a while yet. Cats have nine lives, remember? Better start trying a little harder from now on. Because I've got a good mind to rip you to shreds right now."

Just for a moment Catra's gaze twitches to Adora - and Adora understands. Then the Magicat focuses on Hordak, who charges at her with an angry roar. Adora dodges him, but he barely pays

attention to her. Good. That plays into her hands. Prudently, Adora makes her way toward the portal.

She keeps her eyes on the fighters. Catra will distract Hordak, buying Adora enough time to reach her sword and destroy the portal. Adora trusts that Catra can do it. That's why she takes her eyes off them and finally charges towards the portal.

When she reaches the pedestal, she is a little out of breath, but she doesn't care. Her gaze is fixed solely on the sword in the center of the ring, from which a soft glow emanates.
She stretches out her hand.

"Adora, watch out!"
Too late comes Catra's warning. Adora doesn't have time to turn around as a hot pain explodes in her back and she's flung a few feet across the room before hitting her front on the floor.
"Adora!"

Her ears ring and her vision blurs. Blinking, the blonde tries to get back up and braces herself on her arms, but they shake and immediately buckle away. Only then does she notice the pain in her back.
Hordak must have fired an energy ball at her.

Dazed, Adora tries to stand up again, but her muscles shake with the effort and fail her.
"Adora!" The Magicat's panicked voice snaps the blonde out of her daze. Her vision clears, and she sees Catra rushing toward her. The unmistakable concern in her eyes steals Adora's breath for a moment.

Catra drops to her knees and gently touches the blonde on the arm.
"Can you stand up?"
Her gaze twitches to the blonde's back, and the expression she gives in response does not bode well. She quickly averts her gaze. Adora tries to stand up one more time.

"I have to stop him!" she gasps, shakily bracing herself on her knees. Her muscles give way and her face nearly gets slammed into the floor, but Catra grabs her upper arms and keeps her in position.
"Slow down." the Magicat says unusually gently, eyeing every little movement the blonde makes.
"That son of a bitch totally got you."

Adora contorts her mouth into a pitiful smile as she notices the scratches and scrapes on Catra's body. And, of course, her scars.
"You look pretty bad yourself."
She interrupts herself with a gasp as another wave of pain travels through her body. Whatever's going on with her back, it's nasty.

Trembling, her eyes dart to the podium and her sword, which seems so infinitely far away despite the few feet. Horrified, she tears her eyes open.
"Hordak!"
The Magicat's head whips around to the pedestal where the Lord of the Horde is reaching for the switch.
"No!" Adora reaches out, trying to stop him, but it's too late.

He flips the switch.

And the world is ripped from its hinges.

Chapter End Notes

Only two more chapters to go, guys! :O

Chapter 33

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora:

Maybe it's the after-effects of the fall, but for a few seconds it was completely silent. As if someone had swallowed every sound in the world, in the whole universe. Then suddenly the portal shines with a dazzling light.

At the same time, a force appears out of nowhere, pushing everything and everyone to the ground. The suction is so strong that the air escapes from Adora's lungs and she wants to cough, but cannot.

The blonde feels a hand reach for hers. Catra, who is pressed to the ground next to her in the same way, has her eyes squeezed shut and holds her hand tightly, whether consciously or not she can't tell.

Then something explodes. No, not just something: the room around her. The suction force dissipates. A huge shock wave emanates from the portal and hurls everyone in the room through the air. Even Hordak is not spared and is pulled down from the pedestal. With a bang, Catra and Adora are hurled against the wall, neither breaking free from the other's grip.

As they both hit the floor hard, Adora can't bring herself to utter more than a pained groan.
Never in her life has her body had to endure so much, that's for sure.
But it is not over yet. An ominous rumbling passes over the ground and makes it tremble.

Eyes wide open, Adora stares at the portal from where a huge crack has formed in the floor, dividing the room in half, its maw

leading to a deep, endless nothingness. For a few moments the fortress shakes so badly that sheer fear tightens around Adora's chest.
She's sure she's going to die.

But then the tremors subside - and it's quiet again.
Stunned, Adora turns her head to Catra, who kneels over her, breathing heavily, shielding her with her upper body. Dazed, she looks around. Apart from the huge crack in the floor and the fact that the room looks even more destroyed than before, one might think that nothing has happened.

But Adora can sense the change. It seems to be in the air.
The planet has moved.
It has been teleported to another dimension. Adora can't describe how she knows this so clearly. She just feels it.

Does it have anything to do with She Ra? No.
When she looks into Catra's shocked face, she knows that the Magicat can feel it too. The change that would be Etheria's downfall. Trembling, she discovers the Lord of the Horde lying on the ground. He must be unconscious.

But that doesn't change the facts: Hordak has done it. He has achieved what he wanted.
Soon this world will no longer exist. It will be destroyed.
Because Adora could not stop it.

"I failed." the blonde whispers croakily, clawing her fingers into the broken ground.
"No!" Catra's voice is just as taken, but determined instead. Adora barely hears her. Fear and the awareness of her failure tighten like a noose around her neck.
She has doomed Etheria to its demise. She has not succeeded.

"Adora! Adora, look at me!" Two hands clasp her face, forcing her to look into two gold and blue eyes.
"It's not too late, do you hear? You can still stop Hordak."

"How?" whispers Adora powerlessly. A whimper escapes her. She feels so weak. So helpless. It almost suffocates her.

But Catra holds her gaze.
"The Adora I know doesn't give up. Never. She finds a way, no matter what or who stands in her way. She doesn't stop until she wins. Got it?!"
Breathless, Adora stares at her. It's as if Catra's words displace the darkness and despair and awaken new energy within her. Unable to speak, she nods.

The Magicat almost seems to breathe a sigh of relief.
"Good, then come. Let's save the world together!"
Catra braces herself and then holds out her hand to Adora. For a moment, the blonde just looks at her in admiration.

The Magicat is covered with scrapes, scratches and fresh scars, her clothes are torn and dirty, and she can tell from the slight tremor that Catra doesn't have much strength left either. And yet she is up and ready to fight on. Adora's eyes twitch to the Magicat's outstretched hand before she asks, "Promise?"

A small, genuine smile forms on Catra's mouth, and her eyes begin to glow with emotion as she replies, "I promise."
The words not only set off a storm of emotion in Adora, but act as an energy boost. She also smiles as she grabs Catra's hand and lets her help her to her feet. As soon as she stands, her legs threaten to buckle away, but Catra is there to hold her.
Stays with her. Doesn't let her go, but leads her past debris and destroyed screens toward the portal.

The sword on it is intact. Adora moves towards it in small steps, supported by Catra, who keeps an eye on the unconscious Hordak all the time. Adora tries not to make a sound. Every step produces hellish pain in her limbs, not to mention her back. But she struggles forward. When they reach the platform, it takes them a long time to climb the few steps, but they make it.

Finally, Adora stands on wobbly legs leaning against Catra, who continues to support her, just off the sword. It seems to sense her presence, because the bright glow that emanates from it grows stronger.

Adora wastes no time. She doesn't know when her strength will finally leave her, so she reaches out and clutches the handle of the sword. Immediately she feels gentle streams of magic tickling her arm. With her eyebrows drawn together, she closes her eyes in concentration.
"For the Honor... Of Grayskull!"

Her voice is neither loud nor strong, but she puts all the hope and determination she has left into this sentence. Immediately, the glow of the sword multiplies, bathing the entire room in a warm light. Adora feels the familiar sensation of transformation, feeling magic climb up her arm and spread throughout her body via her heart.

Bathed in light, the wound on her back closes and her pain disappears as if it had never been there. The scratches and dirt on her skin also soften with the magic, and instead the blonde feels the old familiar weight of the tiara on her forehead and the soft fabric of the red cape around her shoulders.

When she opens her eyes, she is no longer Adora. She is She Ra again.

A smile of relief spreads across her face. For a moment, she can block out the end of the world. She is just glad to feel the familiar power of the Warrior Princess inside her again. The mere fact that she is now a lot taller calms her nerves immensely. Automatically, she lowers her gaze to the Magicat, who now seems a good deal smaller.

Catra's pupils are swollen to double their size as she stares at She Ra. It's probably the first time Adora has caught her with her mouth open. Then the blonde's gaze falls on the Magicat's bruised form. Without further ado, Adora pulls the sword out of the

contraption, which now causes her no trouble at all, and bends down.

Catra instinctively flinches as Adora points the sword at her. That's right, she's only seen She Ra in fights so far, the blonde remembers. That's why she gives her a reassuring smile and puts a hand on her shoulder first.

Catra:

At this touch, the Magicat visibly relaxes and lets Adora carefully place the sword on the other shoulder. It is the injured shoulder, but Catra does not make a face. Only a moment later Adora lets her magic flow over the sword into Catra's body. Instantly, scratches and dirt disappear from her fur, and her strength returns.

A strange, warm feeling flows through her, giving her new strength. Her exhausted muscles stop trembling, and her wobbly legs change to a powerful stance. Catra looks up at Adora in surprise. She has experienced She Ra's power many times, but never like this. It doesn't scare or frighten her, on the contrary. It is... fascinating.

But even She Ra's power doesn't make the large scar on her shoulder go away. At least it takes away her pain. When Adora is done healing Catra, she takes a step back and smiles at her confidently.

Then she turns away and walks toward Hordak. The lord of the Horde is just about to stand up and look around in confusion. When he sees the warrior princess coming towards him calmly and unerringly like a glowing sun, his features slip for a moment.

He tries to back away, but his back hits a wall. "No," he stammers. "Stay away from me!" The long blond hair obscures the view of Adora's face, but Catra is sure she is just drawing her brows together.

"What's the matter, Hordak? Are you afraid?"
"Never." His answer doesn't sound entirely convinced, but at least he doesn't try to flee, instead pointing his firearm at the warrior.

One shot.

Faster than Catra's eyes perceive, She Ra draws her sword and blocks the energy bullet. Hordak continues to fire, but Adora is able to either dodge or block until she is directly in front of him. With superhuman strength, she grabs him by the collar and hurls him through the air.

The sheer power of the warrior is always impressive, but where before it had always seemed slightly frightening, Catra now feels nothing but.... admiration.
As Hordak now goes down, he does not get up again.

Adora seems to be finished with him, because she turns around and looks past Catra to the portal. Determined, she moves toward it and almost seems to be remote-controlled, so the Magicat gets in her way and holds her by the arm.

"What are you going to do?" she wants to know. Her throat still feels a little scratchy, but she pays no further attention. Adora frowns and fixes her bright eyes on Catra.
"I... I'm going to destroy the portal."
"WHAT? Why? What are we going to do then? How are we going to get out of this dimension without the portal?"

Now Adora is the one touching her arm. Her brow smooths, and there is a strange calm in her eyes as she answers.
"Catra... I can't describe it properly, but.... I feel it's the right thing to do. It's as if Etheria is speaking to me, saying that this world belongs in this dimension. Has always belonged."

The fear and uncertainty Catra feels at the thought are clearly marked on her face.
"What about Hordak's allies? What if they try to conquer Etheria?"
"If they do, then we will stop them. But destroying the portal is

the right thing to do now." Although She Ra is standing in front of her in full gear at that moment, the Magicat clearly recognizes her friend in the bright eyes.

"Trust me." Adora asks softly, not breaking eye contact for a second.
"...Please, Catra." There is so much emotion in her words that it takes Catra's breath away for a moment.
Trust.
Automatically her guts clench at the word, and she clenches her hands into fists, but she doesn't break eye contact either.

Can she trust? She has sworn to herself to stay away from Adora. The fact that she did eventually rush to the blonde's aid had more strategic reasons. It doesn't mean that she simply forgot all her resentment, all the pain.

And although her mind is screaming at her to run away, not to make the same mistake again, she still can't get away from the bright eyes that are watching her so intensely.
Intrigued, she notes that they have taken on a lighter shade of blue in the She Ra state.
They look different, but the look is the same that Catra has known since she was little: warm and open.
And it is precisely this that makes her hesitate to refuse immediately.

The warrior princess is a thousand times more powerful than Catra. She could have simply pushed her aside and destroyed the portal without a second thought. The Magicat would not be able to stop her.

But instead, She Ra remains where she is.
Waiting for Catra to give her consent.
Because the blonde trusts that Catra will do the right thing, she realizes.
Because she respects her opinion and trusts her blindly.

A gasp leaves her mouth, and tears may have almost come to her eyes, but Catra pulls herself together and makes a decision.
If Adora can trust her, then she too can give her a chance. That's why she takes a deep breath and steps aside to clear the way.

"Fine." For a brief moment, Adora's eyes seem to shine even brighter and a relieved smile forms on her face.
"Thank you." she replies before resolutely turning her gaze to the portal and walking towards it with her hair blowing. With heavy steps, she steps onto the pedestal and contemplates the metal ring for a moment.

Then she puts her head back and closes her eyes. As if she is waiting for a sign.
For a moment nothing happens.
Then She Ra opens her eyes and raises her arm with the sword. A hiss goes through the air.
Swish. Swish. Swish.

She draws deep cuts across the metal with the sword. The cracks begin to glow. Adora frowns as they grow brighter, then, startled, she tears her eyes open and wants to step back, but it is already too late.
The portal EXPLODES.

A shock wave hurls pieces of metal all over the room. Adora is caught by the explosion and thrown away as well. Straight towards the huge chasm formed in the floor by the teleportation.
"Adora!"

Panicked, Catra runs towards her and jumps without hesitation. In flight, she reaches out to Adora and just barely gets a hold of a few fingers before she hits the edge of the ravine hard.
But Adora has already been hurled too far through the air and hangs over the seemingly endless black depths.
All that keeps her from falling is Catra's hand, which she clutches tightly.

The weight of the eight foot tall warrior pulls and tugs at her own. With all three limbs outstretched, the Magicat claws into the ground, praying that she has enough strength to hold them both. When she is reasonably sure that the slightest movement will not send her tumbling over the precipice, she risks a glance over the edge of the ravine.

"Adora? Are you okay?" She Ra hangs on her hand like a lifeless doll, sword still in one hand. With her face hanging down, Catra can't tell if she's still alive. Panic grips her. But that's when the blonde head lifts very slowly and looks up at her.
"I think so." She sounds exhausted and powerless, but Catra's heart drops anyway.

"Good, can you climb up? I don't know how much longer I can hold you." The answer comes delayed.
"I... I don't believe so. The explosion has weakened me. I can't feel my power."
"What stupid things do you do!" Catra feels her arm getting heavier, so she claws deeper into the ground and breathes louder.

"What if you use both arms?" she digs in, suppressing a strained gasp.
"Can't while I'm holding the sword."
"Then drop it!"
"WHAT?! Never!"
Catra almost wants to roll her eyes.
"Adora, you're about to fall into a ravine and die! This really isn't the time to be vain or possessive!"

"But... I can't!" Her voice sounds so desperate. Like she's actually willing to go to her death if it means not having to part with that sword.
"You don't understand. If I drop it, it's gone. Forever! Then... then I'm not She Ra anymore."
"So what?" 'You'd be at least alive.'
That's when she hears quiet sobs.

Despite the danger of losing her balance, Catra forces herself to look down over the precipice at Adora. In fact, tears are running down the blonde's face.
Suddenly she seems so small and lost.
All anger and effort is forgotten as the Magicat's heart tightens at the sight.

"I have to stay She Ra. She is the only one who can protect Etheria in this dimension!"
It's as if a dam has been breached, as the words just pour out of her as more tears stream down her face.
"I must not abandon this world. And I can't let my friends down by losing She Ra. I need her!"

"But you are She Ra!" Catra retorts, now just as distraught as Adora. She has finally had enough of Adora placing so little value on herself.
"Listen, if you don't drop this sword, you will surely fail this world."
Her voice trembles, but she doesn't care. Adora wants to disagree.
"I can't protect Etheria without that sword!"

Catra almost laughs hysterically.
"That's nonsense! You always find a way, Adora! You are the most stubborn person I know! You succeed at everything you set out to do! And you're not alone!"
"But-"
"No, you listen to me now!" Catra thunders.
Abruptly, Adora falls silent as a few tears run down the Magicat's face as well.

"Even if you never transform again: you don't need She Ra to be special.
It's not you being nothing without She Ra. It's She Ra being nothing without you, okay? Adora, you're worth more than She Ra could ever be!

Damn, you know how many times you saved me? How you gave my shitty life meaning long before you found the sword?

Remember how you told me I wasn't a failure? That I survived the horde? The only reason I didn't rot in that place was because of you. YOU were my reason for living. And... you still are.

You were always there for me.
You are willing to lay down your life for others, no matter with or without magic. Because you have such a big heart.

You don't need that sword to be a hero. So please, I beg you, be selfish for once! Your friends need you!
Hell, I need you, Adora!

You're worth living for! Not to die for She Ra!
You make the world better because you are in it. You saved lives even before She Ra.
You saved ME.
For 18 years, you made my life better because you have been in it!
So don't you dare stop now!"

The tears are running down her cheeks so indignantly by now that Catra can only see in a blur.

She doesn't care.

She doesn't care that she just practically threw her heart unprotected and open at Adora's feet.

She doesn't care that her arm feels like it's going to be separated from her body at any moment.
She doesn't care that her tears are dripping down her face onto Adora's cheek, who is looking at her as if frozen.

All she can think about is that Adora must not die.
She just can't. Please!, she pleads inwardly.

Please, just this once.

Stay.

Adora:

Catra's words strike Adora at least as much as the open despair and fear reflected in the Magicat's face. Fear for HER. Her heart begins to flutter, and as the shock wears off, Catra's words begin to penetrate through her.

And for the first time ever, she doesn't fight back the thoughts flooding into her. As she contemplates the Magicat, a wide variety of emotions greet her. She sees the drops of sweat that have formed on the Magicat's forehead. She perceives her heavy breathing and the firm grip of her hand that trembles with effort.

And her own emotions are reflected in the open gaze of the beautiful eyes above her.
Warmth flows through her. Pure warmth.
Not magic, but... Love.

For her friends, who love Adora as she is, with all her flaws and limited abilities. Who always support her, whether she is She Ra or not.

And, of course, for Catra. The exhaustion is clear on Catra's face, but she is not ready to let go. She's not ready to give up on Adora. Neither would the rest of her family be.

The warmth spreads through her body, bringing about a peace within her that she has never known before. A truth she is only now realizing:
All her life she has fought against herself. Like a snake chasing its own tail, afraid of being too slow for others.

For the first time, Adora understands. A smile spreads across her tear-streaked face.

She loosens her grip. Catra's eyes widen.

And she can

let

go.

The sword hilt slips through her fingers and is swallowed by the darkness of the infinite depths. With a shimmer, the figure of She Ra transforms back into Adora.

At the same time, she is seized by a lightness she has never felt before. As if a weight weighing tons was lifted from her. As she lifts her second arm and looks again at Catra, she mirrors her smile and pulls on her arm.

Together they hoist the blonde over the edge of the ravine onto solid ground. On all fours, she crawls to Catra's side, never taking her eyes off the Magicat as she falters. The warmth inside her turns to something else.

Eyes wide, the blonde places a hand on her chest. Catra looks at her worriedly, but Adora can't focus on her. Instead, full of surprise, she clearly feels something emerging inside her. Something new.
Magic.
It doesn´t flow from a sword and besieges her body.
It comes from herself. From the depth of her heart. Previously hidden and suppressed by the magic of the sword, and now awakened by the overflowing love of the blonde.

Like warming rays of sunshine, the magic begins to radiate from her chest, spreading over her body with a gentle tingle. It doesn't feel like the usual transformation Adora knows. Not like a costume being put on her, a change being given to her. It feels like just another part of her being exposed. Like something of her is being added to.
It feels... better. Right.

As the magic recedes, she looks down at herself in wonder. Her hair is still in a ponytail, but it's longer and lighter. She wears a tiara that feels suspiciously like Catra's mask. Her body is taller by

several feet, but the long cape is gone and the white and gold clothing has changed as well. She is... more adult looking.

The most surprising thing, however, is the sword in her hand. Long, narrow and gleaming, it lies in her hand. But it is nothing more than a tool. The tremendous power she feels does not pulsate in this sword. It pulses within herself.

"Wow..." She's not sure which of them said it, but that expression sums it up best. A smile spreads across Adora's lips. Catra mirrors it. She obviously doesn't understand exactly what happened, but she senses that it's good.

The blonde reaches out a hand, and the Magicat grasps it. For a moment they remain in this position. The silence around them and the strange stillness are strange, but not unpleasant. The moment is interrupted when Catra's ears twitch and her gaze jerks to the entrance of the lab. Adora follows her gaze without letting go of the Magicat's hand.

Barely noticeably, she straightens up a bit and stands in front of Catra to shield her from possible danger, gripping the hilt of her new sword tighter. The next moment, voices echo through the hallway.
"Adora? Catra? Are you guys in here?"
"We heard an explosion!"
"What happened?"

Immediately, Adora relaxes as her friends rush into the destroyed lab like a swarm of princesses. Bow and Sea Hawk are also there. When they see Adora, pairs of eyes widen.
"What-"
"How-"
"You're She Ra again?"
"You look so different!"
"But good different!"

The sight of her unharmed friends immediately makes the blonde's heart feel a whole lot lighter, which is why she can't help

but grin broadly before pulling everyone into a group hug. While doing so, she still doesn't let go of Catra's hand.
"Whoa! Okay, Adora, we love you too!" Glimmer laughs, before she lets her gaze wander around the room and the others follow suit.

"You guys made quite a mess..." Shrugging her shoulders, Adora replies, "It wasn't all our fault."
"What happened, anyway? You guys really made a lot of noise."
"Yeah, what about the portal now? It was triggered, wasn't it? Is that bad?"
"What's next?"

"We can worry about that later," Netossa interrupts the others, suddenly looking serious. "First, we should take care of him." She points past the princesses to Hordak, who is still lying in the corner. Uncertain looks scrutinize him.

"Is he...?" Perfuma wants to know uncertainly, but Adora shakes her head.
"Just unconscious."
"How did you do that?"
"Long story, I'll tell you later, I promise. Netossa is right, now we should first worry about how to proceed with him."

Determined, Adora strides toward him, and the others follow her. Just in time, it seems, because at that moment Hordak stirs and sits up. On impulse, Adora raises her new sword and swings it through the air. It creates a colorful, iridescent band of magic that wraps itself around Hordak's body, immobilizing him.

Instantly, the blonde feels the astonished stares at her back. She has never used this kind of magic before. She didn't even know herself that she could do it. But strangely enough, it doesn't scare her at all. Glimmer is the first to catch herself again and stands next to Adora. With her arms crossed, she stares down at Hordak, who has regained consciousness and is staring blankly into space.

He doesn't seem to have quite come to terms with his defeat yet.
"So. What should we do with him?"
Murmuring suggestions ring out, one more curious than the other. Adora doesn't pay much attention; she's too absorbed in her own musings.
What should they do with the lord?

Even though no one has commented, she senses that she will have the final say in this decision. So she must think it over carefully. But as hard as she tries to get an epiphany, she feels nothing but indecision as she looks at the bent figure before her.

Then Hordak suddenly murmurs something. Quietly, so that the others can't hear it through their discussion.
"Don't ... don't hurt Entrapta."
His voice sounds feeble, but more surprising to Adora is the content of his words. Puzzled, she blinks at him. She did not expect.... well, what actually? That Hordak could actually think about another life? Has she possibly misjudged him?

Then the murmuring around them dies as a suggestion abruptly silences everyone.
"Why don't we just kill him?"
The suggestion comes from Mermista, who seems calm and unconcerned as she looks around. But Adora hears the suppressed anger in her voice. Her people have suffered greatly under Hordak's rule. Naturally, she feels the urge to retaliate.

"Mermista, it doesn't work that easily..." Bow hesitantly takes the floor, intending to walk towards her. She backs away, eyes lingering on the lord.
"Why not? It was easy for him. How many lives did he destroy without even thinking about it? How many did he kill because they stood in his way? Why shouldn't he suffer the same fate?"

"No!"

Out of nowhere, a pink little lightning bolt appears and throws itself between Hordak and the princesses. It is Entrapta, now

looking pleadingly at the other.
"Please don't hurt him!"
The others are so surprised by the sudden appearance of the tech princess that they don't reply anything for a moment.

Entrapta takes advantage of the speechlessness and continues speaking.
"He is very talented and full of technical knowledge. It would be a waste to just let him die. Besides, he is my lab partner and.... and my friend."
Frosta is the first to speak up. Shaking her head, she points at Hordak.
"How can you be friends with someone like HIM???"

Adora freezes.
The same question was asked of her when she brought Catra to Bright Moon.
"Do you know how much suffering he is responsible for?" Glimmer agrees. The others also look at the pigtailed princess uncomprehendingly.
"Get out of the way, Entrapta."
Mermista's voice is cold, and her gaze knows no mercy.

Even Hordak murmurs softly. “It´s no use, Entrapta. Save yourself, before you get harmed.”
But Entrapta does not move. Instead, she spreads her arms and braids, trying to shield Hordak's body from the others. Her robot Emily wants to come to her aid, but Sea Hawk and Spinnerella hold him down.

Waiting, the others turn to Adora.
"What should we do, Adora?"
"You're She Ra, what do you think?"
Adora hesitates as she sees the pleading look on Entrapta's face. Even she can see that the Lord of the Horde means something to her. And judging by Hordak's look, the two of them do indeed share something.

Entrapta didn't mean to hurt anyone, Adora is absolutely sure of that. She can be misguided quickly, but that doesn't make her an evil person. Her gaze wanders to Hordak. She remembers his insane speech as he tells of his desire to be allowed to serve his master. Is it possible that he, too, was misguided?
The longer Adora thinks about it, the more likely that possibility seems to her.

Besides, it doesn't feel right to take a life. Out of a feeling, she closes her eyes and listens within. A soft glow arises around her as the blonde tries to contact Etheria with her magic. She wants to hear the planet's opinion on this; after all, this world has suffered the most from Hordak.

A soft thumping is the answer, like a strange, quiet, ancient heartbeat. A sense of security flows through Adora. As if it wants to say: ´ Your´re doing the right thing´. Then she opens her eyes. And promptly stares into dozens of faces that look at her in confusion. Of course. They haven't been able to see what Adora has done.

That's why she nods to her friends and then kneels down to Entrapta to put a hand on her shoulder.
"He doesn't have to die." the blonde assures her. "But we can't let him get away with it either." Entrapta looks uncertain, but at least her look is no longer so desperate.

"What do you suggest?" Bow wants to know from behind her. When she turns around, his gaze is open. He trusts she has a solution. She returns his smile and turns back to the tech princess.
"Do you think Hordak can become a better person?"

Entrapta is silent for a moment, biting her lip. Finally, she replies, "I...don't know. I´m no expert in emotional or moral development."
Looking behind her, she meets Hordak's gaze, who regards her calmly but dejectedly. As if he has accepted his fate, no matter what.

"But he has always treated me with respect and shown signs of caring. I believe he can extend that same ability to others."

Adora nods and rises.
"What do you say he join you in using his technical knowledge to rebuild Etheria and give a new home to the many people who have lost their former homes?" Entrapta's eyes light up.
"Ohh, that's a great idea! We can do that! The resources of the horde could be used, and I´m sure we can tinker some awesome things out of the debris of the Frightzone."
Questioningly, Adora turns to her friends.
"Are you guys okay with that?"

There's silence for a while before Glimmer shrugs and steps forward.
"That sounds reasonable."
"If someone's looking out for him, why not?" agrees Perfuma.
"We need all the help we can get in bringing new harmony to Etheria anyway," Bow explains, stepping up to Glimmer's side with a smile.

The others agree as well, until only two people remain: Mermista and Catra.
The Magicat has her arms crossed and has barely said a word so far. Her inscrutable gaze is fixed on Hordak the whole time. Adora can't blame Catra if she doesn't like this decidedly peaceful solution. After all, Hordak has tried to kill her several times, and has also inflicted quite a few other torments on her.

The Magicat seems to feel the gaze on her, for the next moment her eyes are on She Ra. To Adora's surprise, Catra's shoulders relax and a cautious grin graces her face.
"All right. I think it's only fair that he has to clean up his own mess."
Relieved, Adora beams at her and at the same time looks for clues in her face that Catra really is serious, too. That she really has no problem with it. But there is nothing but relief in Catra's expression.

So everyone turns to the only person who has not yet spoken. Mermista, too, has her arms crossed and stares at Hordak, though she seems to be trying to kill him with her gaze. Time seems to stand still for an eternity until she finally groans.
"Alright, let's spare him. But only if he's guarded at all times and doesn't rest until all of Etheria is resplendent, understood?"

Everyone nods, and the blonde smiles gratefully at the Sea Princess. Another burden seems to fall from Adora's shoulders. It's as if she's just now realized they've won.
"So...what does that mean?" Frosta wants to know, looking questioningly at the others. At this, she sounds like a child. Adora forgets far too often that she is indeed still one.

Smiling, she looks at the ice princess.
"It's over," she declares simply. This sentence seems to make everyone breathe a sigh of relief at the same time. As if she has relieved everyone of the same burden that has rested on her all this time.

"And... What are we supposed to do now?" echoes Scorpia sheepishly.
"I'm a bit new to this 'winning' stuff, you know..."
A few laugh, and Perfuma next to her smirks. Catra slaps her friend on the shoulder, also with a smirk on her face.

Glimmer watches the scene with a grin, casting a conspiratorial glance at Catra before raising her arms in the air.
"This calls for a party!"

Chapter End Notes

> So.... I don't know if I should edit this chapter again, but for the moment I like it as it is. In two weeks I will post the FINAL chapter of the story, guys! Are you ready for the big party?

Chapter 34

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra:

Catra turns back and forth in front of the mirror. She is not sure what to make of the image that turns with her. Again, she strokes the matte black fabric. The dress clings softly to her skin and is not uncomfortable, but it feels extremely unfamiliar.

The Magicat has never worn a dress before. Nor did she ever think it would happen. She has always associated this type of clothing with spoiled, annoying glittering princesses.
And yet, here she is.

The straps of the top converge at the neck, leaving a large portion of the back exposed. The cutout in the chest doesn't even begin to cover her scar, but at least distracts the eye from the injured skin. At the hips, the black dress flares out a bit and the light fabric swings elegantly back and forth with every movement. Two slits on each side run up to the thigh and allow Catra complete legroom. The plain sandals are barely visible under the skirt.

The Magicat is sure that she has never worn anything so ... impractical. That simply serves the purpose of... looking beautiful. And it does, Catra has to admit. She has tied her hair into a ponytail, but this time she has allowed the front, shorter strands of hair to frame her face. Thoughtfully, she brushes one of the strands out of her face and continues to scrutinize her reflection in the mirror.

Slowly, pleasure rises in her. She feels strange, but also... beautiful.
She blinks as she stumbles upon this new description of her appearance. Beauty has never been a factor in her life. As long as she looked strong, Catra didn't care about the rest of her

appearance.
But it feels good to feel beautiful, she realizes.

A tentative smile appears on her face, and the Magicat in the mirror imitates her. She is pleased with the dress. Although she resolves to ask Glimmer to make a suit next time.
'Next time'.
Catra has to grin at the thought of a future. Promptly, there is a knock at her door.

"Catra? Are you in there? It's me, Glimmer!" "Come on in, Sparkles!" She smooths the fabric at her waist one last time before turning away from the mirror and just seeing the Sparkles Princess teleport into the middle of the room. With a wide beam, she looks at Catra.
"Wow, you look really stunning, Horde Scum!"
"Thank you."

Not knowing what to do, the Magicat is already tugging at the fabric again to give her fingers something to do. At the same time, she looks at Glimmer. The princess has also put on a dress, but hers is shorter and the skirt is much more flared. And it glitters. In purple. The Magicat wouldn't even dream of putting on such a monstrosity, but even she has to admit that Glimmer looks pretty with her hair combed back and bright tiara.

"You look... good, too." Catra replies haltingly, still having a hard time finding the right words to be nice. Small steps, she admonishes herself for spirit. Glimmer apparently notices her indecision, because she smiles at this clearly moderate compliment and walks towards Catra.
"Thank you. Are you ready for the party?"

Three days had passed since the victory over the Horde. Everyone had been busily informing the people of Etheria of what had happened and repairing at least the most rudimentary damage.

The teleportation into another dimension did not leave the planet completely unscathed. There have been several earthquakes and

huge fissures have opened in the earth, damaging many buildings and forests. Fortunately, with her new powers, Adora was able to repair the damage and "heal" nature, as she called it.

These days have been especially exhausting for the blonde. During the day she hardly stayed in the palace, and in the evening she fell into bed exhausted like a zombie. Since Catra can't contribute much outside the palace, she has barely exchanged a word with Adora since the victory, let alone even set eyes on her.

Perhaps that's why she's so nervous as she takes Glimmer's outstretched arm and steps up beside her. To distract herself, she mutters, "We're walking to the hall, right?"
Glimmer giggles as if she's cracked a joke. It sounds far too ominous to the Magicat's ears. "Oh please, that would be way too exhausting. Hold on!"

That's the only warning Catra gets before the princess grips her arm a little tighter and she's pulled into a swirl of pink glitter. When she blinks and opens her eyes again, they are outside the hall door. Groaning, the Magicat sinks to her knees and bends over. This teleportation felt like she was thrown into a hurricane. Surely she's going to throw up right here.
"Okay, Sparkles, now it's official: I hate you!" Catra croaks, concentrating on keeping her insides to herself.

Glimmer laughs loudly and heartily.
"I thought you would have much sooner."
Grinning, she helps the Magicat stand up.
"If I had known it would only take a few teleportation jumps to knock you out, we would have defeated you much sooner."
"You wish." Catra mumbles, but has to grin herself.

Together they walk to the entrance of the hall and when two guards open the doors for them, Catra is overwhelmed by the impressions for a moment. The hall is colorfully decorated and everywhere it glitters and shines. And there are already countless guests.

Most of them interrupt their cheerful conversations when they see the princess of Bright Moon enter. Some cheer, others clap, and still others continue their conversation afterwards, while Glimmer gives them a friendly wave. But they all have one thing in common: the relieved, free smiles on each of these faces. Everyone is happy that the horde is defeated. On this night, they let out their joy.

To distract herself from the many people around them, her eyes almost automatically wander searchingly over the crowd as Glimmer pulls them toward the buffet.
"Are you looking for someone?" the princess wants to know with a smirk, without taking her eyes off the buffet. Caught off guard, the Magicat puts on her ears and stops.
"I'm just looking for... Arrow boy. Haven't seen him yet today. Isn't he here?"

She doesn't like that knowing smile on Glimmer's face at all.
"He and Adora are coming later. I stopped by her room earlier, and it looks like our friend can't manage to get ready for a party on her own, even after so long in Bright Moon."
A surprisingly detached giggle escapes Catra's mouth as she imagines Adora drowning in a mountain of princess dresses.
"I can imagine."

Glimmer giggles as well. When a hand touches her healthy shoulder, Catra flinches but doesn't pull it away. Very lightly, Sparkles squeezes her arm and winks.
"Don't worry. She'll come."
"Glimmer?"
Both women glance beside them as Queen Angella approaches. The floor-length dress is a similar color to her daughter's, but less glittery. It's the first time she's seen the queen truly relaxed, Catra notes.

Angella regards them both with a sympathetic look.
"Mom!" Glimmer greets her mother with glee.
"What do you think of the party? Do you like it?"
"Of course I like it. You really put it together beautifully. I'm proud

of you, Glimmer."
As gently as only a mother can, she strokes a strand of hair behind her daughter's ear.
"Not just for the party."

Glimmer's eyes seem to grow brighter for a moment as she falls around her neck, visibly overwhelmed by her mother's praise, and hugs her tightly.
"Thanks, Mom! I love you!"
"I love you too."
Catra looks at the two of them silently, biting her lower lip barely noticeably. Seeing how affectionate the queen is with her daughter puts a twinge in the Magicat's stomach.

The only mother figure she's ever had doesn't give a damn about her. No matter what she did, no matter how hard she tried to get her affection. She quickly suppresses the impulse to look around her for Shadow Weaver. For she, too, is likely to be wandering around here somewhere. But Catra's dark thoughts are suppressed as the queen's gaze fixes on her, hardly losing any of its warmth.

With a smile, she carefully places a hand on Catra's healthy shoulder, just as her daughter had before.
"I know we don't know each other that well yet, but I also want to thank you for what you have done. It's not easy to face your fears and take an unknown path. I want you to know that you will always have a place here in Bright Moon if you want it."

For a moment, the Magicat is stunned. The Queen's words are sincere, and that is what so astounds her. Queen Angella knows about her past of the Horde, and has not seen for herself what she actually accomplished in the fight against Hordak. How well or poorly she did, what contribution she made.
And yet she offers her a place to live.
More than that, she offers her a home.

Catra blinks a few times before finding her voice again.
"Thank you." It is a small word, but she hopes the queen

perceives the depth in it. She seems to, because Angella's smile widens a little more as she suddenly leans over and takes Catra in her arms. The Magicat stiffens for a moment before her muscles slowly relax and she hesitantly wraps her arms around the Queen. She hopes no one sees her face as she does so, because right now she can't hide any of her emotions very well.

When Angella finally pulls away, Catra is both grateful and disappointed. That's why she clears her throat.
"If you'll excuse me, I wanted to speak with Scorpia before I go."
Respectfully bowing her head to the queen, she gives Glimmer a quick wave before turning away and disappearing into the crowd.

Then she spots a tall woman with a shock of white hair. Scorpia turns around and when she spots the Magicat as well, she waves at her, beaming. Catra smirks and makes her way to her. The tall woman is wearing a suit of turquoise that makes her red tank glow. Instead of a suit jacket, she wears only a vest that shimmers when she moves.

In her hair is a small wreath of flowers. Catra can already guess whose idea this was, and smirks even more.
Oh boy, in her short time in Bright Moon, she has smiled more often than she has in her life so far. It's almost creepy.

"Hey, Scorpia!"
"Wildcat! Wow, you look gorgeous! I've ever seen you in a dress! Man, what a party! Very different from the Crimson Waste, huh?"
The contents of the glass that Scorpia is carrying has already spilled half over because she is gesticulating so much. Catra quickly takes it from her scissor hand to at least save what's left in it, and sets it down while she ponders her friend's words.

It's true, this party is very different from the ones celebrated in Crimson Waste. More civilized. More colorful. Not worse or better, but just.... different. Scorpia seems to have the same thoughts.
"Not that I didn't like them! It's just, you know, everyone seems so chill here ..."

Scorpia babbles on, and actually the Magicta had intended to listen to her, but she loses her train of thought when she sees the hall doors open another time and someone calls out over the roar of the crowd,
"Ladies, gentlemen and non-binary guests, please welcome the hero of Etheria: She Ra!"

All conversation falls silent and all eyes turn to the entrance where Adora enters alongside Bow. Loud cheers erupt, Scorpia also claps, but Catra barely notices. With one look, her world seems to shrink and consist of only two people. As if frozen, the Magicat stands there and does not move, but soaks up the sight like a sponge.

Adora wears a simple white dress with golden straps. Her blonde hair flows openly over her shoulders and on her forehead sits a delicate golden tiara that unmistakably identifies her as She Ra. She looks simply breathtaking.
But the most beautiful thing about her is the smile on her face. It is reserved, but carefree. Relaxed.

Well, almost. Except for the fact that she's holding Bow's arm a little too tightly, and there's also the slight nervousness in her eyes that comes from having the attention of a huge crowd glued to her. But the permanent, heavy tension is gone. Something rises and spreads in her chest when Catra sees Adora like this. Neither fear nor pressure nor anger, but warmth.

Involuntarily, she remembers the confession she made to Adora only a few days ago. Until now she has avoided it, but now the urge to talk to Adora about it arises in Catra.
To clarify things.
And when she sees dozens of people moving towards Adora to congratulate her, she decides to start immediately.

Adora:

Overwhelming probably best describes the blonde's inner life right now. She has been standing in the middle of the hall for an eternity and hasn't moved from the spot, because the mass of people who come up to her and want to talk to her just don't seem to stop.

Not that she is not pleased by the many warm congratulations, but it also overwhelms her. She mostly dodges compliments and tries to steer the conversation towards the rebellion in general, as she feels uncomfortable with the thought of accepting all the praise on her own.

And as she shakes hands with what must be the thousandth person, she feels the gradual exhaustion rising. She can only stay in one place and do the same thing for so long without going insane.

In addition, much of her thoughts take up a person she has been on the lookout for, but has yet to discover. Admittedly, it's hard to look for the Magicat with her naked eyes when her vision is obscured by hundreds of people around her. But at some point, as an older gentleman is about to tell her how the horde formed in the days of his youth, Adora's eyes catch a gap in the crowd around her, revealing a view of a corner of the room.

And when she sees Catra standing there, she forgets to breathe for a moment.
Her mouth goes dry as her eyes travel up and down Catra's body. She looks simply breathtaking. Although the Magicat has never worn a dress before, she moves in it with a naturalness as if she had never done anything else. The black fabric fits her skin like a glove and elegantly hugs her curves.

The slits in the dress drive the blonde's blushes into her cheeks, and she inhales sharply as her gaze falls on the neckline.
She has to swallow.
Of course Catra looks stunning. What else did Adora expect? The Magicat could have appeared in a potato sack and still looked better than anyone else in the room.

However, it's not just her choice of clothes that leaves Adora so speechless. What really captures her gaze is the expression on the Magicat's face. It is the smile that makes her heart beat faster and fills her chest with happiness.

In the horde, Catra rarely smiled. Laughed, yes, when they had fun as children or pranks were successful. Grinned, sure, when she felt superior to someone, gloated, or tried to hide her true feelings. But Adora only experienced that kind of smile in rare moments, when they were both alone and indulged in their dreams for a moment.

And after Adora left the horde, she never saw that smile again. Oh, how she missed it! It still has the same effect on Adora as it did then. Automatically, her own smile widens as she continues to look at the Magicat. At the Princess Prom a few years ago, she had forbidden herself to think further about Catra's beauty.
Now she is allowed to.
And she is overwhelmed as she feels the fierceness of the rising emotions within her.

Catra has not noticed her glance, she has been talking to someone the whole time. Only now can Adora take her eyes off the Magicat and realize with surprise that the other person is Huntara. For the fact that the two couldn't stand each other at all just a week ago, they now seem to get along surprisingly well.

Possibly that slight pressure on her chest that suddenly forms would have grown even more if she hadn't been distracted at that moment.
"Don't you think so?"
"Huh?" Averting her eyes and looking at the gentleman in front of her, Adora is ashamed to realize that she has completely forgotten her world.

Hastily, she searches for an appropriate response so as not to offend the man, when a shock of pink hair appears to her rescue.
"Please excuse the interruption, sir, but we need to speak with She Ra for a moment." The man bows to Glimmer and Bow, who

are about to step up to the blonde's side.
"Of course, Princess Glimmer."

In response, Glimmer grabs Adora's hand and pulls her and Bow along with her, away from the people around them.
"You are my salvation!" Adora groans in relief, looking gratefully at her friends. Bow grins. "We know. You've been drifting off, haven't you? What's got you so distracted?"

Involuntarily, the blonde's gaze twitches to the other side of the room. From here she has a clear view of the Magicat, who still doesn't seem to have noticed her. However, the blonde notices with a frown that the smile on her face has disappeared. Instead, she listens with an impenetrable expression to what Huntara has to say to her.

Immediately, Adora clenches her hands into fists to resist the urge to run across the room and bring out the smile again. Glimmer has followed the blonde´s gaze and now gives Bow a meaningful look.
"Ahh, there's our answer. I have to admit, Catra really isn't making it easy to ignore her today."

This earns her not only a caught look from Adora, but also a shocked look from her friend.
"Glimmer!" he protests accusingly, to which the princess chuckles and shrugs.
"Oh come on, I'm not blind after all! No one can say Catra doesn't look rattling hot today!" Adora has to control herself to ignore the sting in her chest and not gasp in fright at the same time. Fortunately, the reaction escapes the others.

Bow critically examines his friend's flushed cheeks. "Glimmer, could it be that you drank too much punch?" Her grin widens as she holds up her thumb and forefinger.
"Maybe just a little bit. Come ooon, it's been forever since we've really partied! So don't be a party pooper. And don't change the subject!"

Her index finger wanders to Adora. With a twinkle in her eye, Glimmer wants to know, "Adora, you can't get around this conversation. So, tell us: what's between you and Catra now?" Unsurprisingly, this question evokes the urge in Adora, trained for years, to bury all possible answers and feelings to it deep inside herself and ignore them.

But this time she actively fights against it. It costs her to overcome, which is why she doesn't answer immediately, but she manages, under the patient gaze of her friends, not to suppress her feelings, but to think seriously about this question. Unfortunately, the result is not very revealing. That's why Adora groans and grabs her head as she replies, "Ask me something easier."

While Glimmer tilts her head, Bow has to grin.
"You know, you still haven't told us what actually happened in Hordak's lab." Confused, the blonde frowns.
"But of course -"
"No, you explicitly left out the parts that explain why you and Catra went from two depressed, estranged ex-bestie-enemy-friends to two shy teenagers who keep sneaking glances at each other." Glimmer sums up so matter-of-factly that Adora has to blink a few times.

"We don't-"
Bow puts a hand on Glimmer's shoulder.
"She's right, Adora. Something obviously happened between you two. Do you want to talk to us about it?"
Adora takes a breath - and expels it. Maybe it's not a bad idea to let her friends in on her chaos of thoughts.

"I... it's complicated" she explains with slumped shoulders. "Catra has... I mean, in Hordak's lab, there... she helped me become She Ra. She..."
'... said some things that touched me to the depths of my soul'? Even if it´s the truth, it sounds way too corny for the blonde to say it openly.

"...There are a few things I want to talk to her about, but we haven't had the chance yet. I guess that's why I'm a little scattered right now." Sympathetically, Bow strokes her arm, while Glimmer murmurs, "Sure, your absentmindedness certainly has no other - salacious - reason."

But before shame can rise in Adora's cheeks or obvious jealousy can spread across Bow's face, Glimmer gives the blonde a smile. "I'm sure you can find a moment to talk tonight. If you want, we'll watch your back. And we'll be here if you need us."

Warmth rises in her chest as Adora wraps her friends in a hug.
"You guys are the best."
"We know that."
"Oh, and Adora?"

As she releases the hug, she looks questioningly at Bow, whose expression has suddenly changed. He seems to struggle with himself for a moment before shaking his head and smiling.
"Never mind."
This is unusual. Glimmer also notices that something is wrong, and frowns.
"What's wrong, Bow?"

He makes a throwaway hand gesture.
"Oh, I don't want to spoil your mood. A thought occurred to me this morning, but we can talk about that after the feast."
"We can't!" Adora objects vehemently, placing a hand on her friend's shoulder with concern.
"Not if it's bothering you."

Nodding in agreement, the pink princess next to her says, "We can tell there's something on your mind. If you talk to us about it, maybe we can take away your worries. You don't always have to take a back seat, you know."
For a moment, the two engage in a silent eye conversation that only worked if you had spent half your life together.

With bated breath, Adora watches Bow's indecisive expression melt away under Glimmer's determination and support. Sighing, he slumps his shoulders.
"It's just... I couldn't help thinking about what Hordak said. That there are others like him in this dimension who can be dangerous to Etheria. Maybe it's not our problem yet, but I can't help but keep wondering what we're going to do if there really is an entire army of Hordaks trying to invade here." he explains, placing a hand on the back of his neck.

"I'm sorry, I know we've had an insane victory and we should just celebrate exuberantly. I really don't want to ruin the mood either, just.... these thoughts just won't let me go."
Bow looks so crestfallen. This image seems so wrong that it hurts Adora's heart.

Glimmer obviously feels the same way, because she wraps her friend in a tight hug without hesitation.
"That's okay, Bow. I understand. It can be scary to think about what else we're going to face. But we'll get through it."

"She's right." Adora agrees, smiling at Bow.
"I'm sure the danger to Etheria is not over yet. But you know what? I... I'm not afraid. I know that whatever we have to face, we will handle it." Unconsciously, her smile widens as the Magicat's face appears in her mind's eye.
"Someone gave me the courage to believe that we can do anything! As long as we stay together."

"Adora is absolutely right! We are the best friend squad, remember?"
Finally, the worry lines on Bow's face disappear.
"Right. Best friend squad forever!"
"And we even have a new member!"

Speaking of... Promptly, Adora's eyes wander searchingly around the hall again. When she spots the empty spot where Catra had been standing until a moment ago, she is initially disappointed. But then she sees the Magicat coming straight at her.

A whirlwind of thoughts and feelings is unleashed in Adora as she tries in vain to interpret Catra's expression. The other friends see the Magicat coming towards them as well, and grin before Glimmer gives Adora a slight push.
"Go on, there is your chance!"
"Good luck!" agrees Bow, as the blonde approaches Catra as if by remote control.

When they finally stand in front of each other, both are silent for a moment. Neither knows how to begin.
"Hey..." Adora finally starts, clasping her hands behind her back to suppress the rising nervousness. Everything is spinning in her head. The proximity of the Magicat shows its effect and mixes with the many unspoken thoughts and feelings of the blonde.

There is so much she wants to tell her. So much that she wants to apologize for. So much that she wants to confess.
But no sound escapes her throat. Where are appropriate words when you need them?
"Hey" Catra replies with a tentative smile. The Magicat clears her throat and clasps her arm.
"Can we talk?"

Adora's shoulders relax a bit as she replies, "I was about to ask you the same thing, so uhmm... yeah, sure."
The Magicat nods and gestures for the blonde to follow her to a corner of the hall. There is hardly anything going on there, most of the guests are either at the buffet or dancing boisterously in the middle of the hall.

It does indeed seem the optimal time to finally be able to speak openly with Catra. Before her courage can leave her, Adora resolutely turns to the Magicat and blurts out, "I'm sorry, Catra! Our quarrel... I never meant to hurt you or give the impression that I thought you were weak. I know I obviously messed that up. But please believe me, the only reason I didn't want you on this mission was because I was scared. I just... I can't stand the thought of anything happening to you."

Catra's pupils have grown small as she stares at Adora in bewilderment. Such a torrent of words has flowed out of the blonde out of nowhere that she must feel quite caught off guard. Still, it feels good to finally be able to say how she feels. Resolutely, Adora pushes away the rising fear of possibly distressing Catra with her feelings and quickly continues speaking before she can change her mind.

"It was an irrational thought. Obviously. You are one of our strongest allies in the rebellion. You've proven that many times. Gosh, if it wasn't for you, I would have been dead a long time ago! We needed you! I needed you, I still do, and I know that! But I was stupid. And selfish. The truth is, I could never forgive myself if you got hurt because of me."

Ashamed, the blonde lowers her eyes and clasps her stomach. "But obviously I screwed that up, too." Narrowing her eyes, Adora clasps her belly tighter and keeps her head lowered. Although the blonde hears the party noises in the background, she perceives them only muffled. Much louder is the silence in which no answer comes from Catra.

As the seconds stretch into an eternity and Adora feels her muscles tearing with tension, Catra finally stirs.
"I...I understand."
Two words. Two words that surprise the blonde so much that she lifts her head and all her tension falls away from her.

Catra looks nervous, too. Her voice is calm, but quivering with suppressed emotion, and her gaze is fixed on the floor as she struggles to find the right words.
"I am sorry too. Maybe I got angry too fast. It's just..." She squirms and tightens her hands into fists before letting them go loose again.

"I am not... used to be taken care of. This whole time, my anger drove me to prove that I am not worthless, that.... I am not a nuisance. When you told me to stay back at the castle, I... I guess I was afraid that you would think of me as low as everyone else

after all."
Her words hit Adora deep in the heart, and not in a good way.

Without hesitation, she bridges the distance to the Magicat and puts both hands on her shoulders.
"Never. I would NEVER do that, you hear me? You are one of the most important people in the world to me!"
Catra blinks, her ears drooping. She looks as if she is testing the truth of her words in her mind.
Finally, she smiles.
"Thank you. The same goes for me. I... I really meant what I said, back in Hordak's lab."

A smile spreads across Adora's face as well. Catra's words feel like magic, flowing through her skin directly into her heart like pure, liquid sunshine. She gazes radiantly at the Magicat's face that is so close to hers. The beautiful golden-blue eyes, the curved lips and the open smile on it, revealing two fangs.

At that moment, Adora wishes for nothing else but for it to be like this forever. She and Catra, united and happy. But a thought intrudes into her consciousness that disturbs this beautiful imagination.

Catra notices the change in mood immediately and frowns.
"Adora, I hear your brain rattling. What's wrong?"
In order to speak better, the blonde leans back a bit and releases her hands from Catra's shoulders.

"Now that the war is over, are you going to..." Uneasily, her fingers claw into the white fabric of her dress before she asks the question that frightens her.
"Are you going to go back? To the Crimson Waste?"
The slight tremor is certainly impossible to ignore, and Adora is glad she can't see herself at that moment. She can probably see how pathetic the blonde feels at the thought that she might be separated from Catra again.

The look on the Magicat's face is hard to interpret, but there is a surprising calmness shining in her eyes. Apparently, she has already grappled with this question. Her gaze drifts for a moment, as if contemplating the unseen horizon.

"I was only in the Crimson Waste for a year, but I felt very comfortable there." Catra admits, oblivious to the twitch in Adora's fingers.
"Life there may be hard and dangerous, but those who persevere also see the beautiful sides. The inhabitants are rough and rowdy, but they all have their families or friends they stick by. The valleys and rocky gorges are deadly, but also wild and beautiful."

Adora notices a rare gleam in the Magicat's eyes. She can be seen how much this place is close to her heart. The blonde has already noticed that when she was guided by her through the desert. She remembers how she noticed even then how perfectly the land and the Magicat fit together. Without being able to control it, she feels the fear rising inside her that Catra doesn't want to give up this sense of belonging.

Pressed, she inquires, "That means you've made up your mind?" Her hands clench into fists and inwardly she braces herself for the inevitable when Catra finally turns her head and looks directly at her.
With a small smile, she explains, "I want what's best for the Crimson Waste and its inhabitants. That's why I've been talking to Huntara. She told me that she's going back to the desert because, for her, it's simply become her home. After a long conversation, we came to the conclusion that she... should take over my position as the strongest. Of course, only with a fair fight, in front of the residents. We agreed that I would still visit frequently to check up on things, and that I would explain my system to her, how I developed the Crimson Waste."

After a brief pause in which Adora holds her breath, Catra finally explains, "So, no. I'm not going anywhere anytime soon." Very slowly, she takes a step toward the blonde until the tips of their

noses are inches apart. Her voice is soft, but strong.
"I won't leave you behind."

Her words take a ton of weight off Adora's shoulders and she breathes a sigh of relief.
"Good." Smiling, she leans forward a bit more until their noses actually touch and her fingers clasp the Magicat's.
"Because I want you here with me."

Now Catra is the one who breathes a sigh of relief. At the same time, she doesn't take her eyes off Adora's piercing ones for a moment. The blonde's pupils twitch to the lips that seem so close within reach.
Probably she would lose herself in this moment, if at this moment a glass would not crash somewhere.

Blinking, the blonde realizes that she is surrounded by an audience. That's why she pulls back with a heavy heart and lets go of Catra's hand.
"Come on, let's go back." she mumbles, barely able to hide her displeasure. As she is about to turn away, a hand grabs her arm and stops her.
"Wait."

Questioningly, Adora looks back, barely able to ignore her accelerating heartbeat. Catra bites her lower lip.
"I want to show you something." Is that embarrassment?
"Um, okay? What exactly?" the blonde replies curiously. Suddenly, the Magicat becomes mysterious.

"It's a surprise. You have to close your eyes."
"What?" Now Adora is really curious. Confused, but curious.
"Just do it. It'll be worth it."
The blonde probably would have agreed to anything if Catra had looked at her like that.

That's why she shrugs her shoulders in an effortless manner and replies,
"Okay, I trust you blindly."

Catra rolls her eyes, but smirks and waits until the blonde closes her eyes. Then she takes Adora's hand to lead her around the hall.

The murmur of guests passes her by, blending into an indistinct murmur as her closed eyes force her to focus on her other senses. Specifically on the touch of Catra's hand, whose fingers are intertwined with hers, gently pulling her through the moving shadows.

The murmur of voices grows quieter. Presumably they have left the hall. Something squeaks. Then the air changes. It becomes noticeably cooler. Automatically, Adora is tempted to open her eyes, but Catra watches her closely and admonishes, "No peeking!!!" Grumbling, Adora pinches her eyelids tightly shut.

"How much longer is it going to take, and why is it so col- ah!" The blonde stumbles over a bump in the ground, loses her balance, and would have fallen if two arms hadn't held her with lightning speed.
"Stop whining, it's distracting me and then you'll fall."

The half-hearted rebuke has little effect as Adora is more focused on the warm chest her back suddenly leans against. Still holding her by both arms, the Magicat leads her a few more steps before Adora bumps into something stony that reaches her waist. A railing, she guesses, but she can't focus on it because Catra's voice suddenly sounds right at her ear, "So, here we are. Ready?"

Instead of a reply, Adora nods.
"Good." The Magicat's voice takes on an unusually soft undertone. "Then you may open your eyes now."
Blinking, Adora follows the request, not recognizing much at first. Then she realizes that they are on a balcony, looking out over the nighttime landscape of Bright Moon.

Instinctively, her eyes search the garden all the way to the Whispering Woods tree line, looking for what Catra wants to show her. Just as she is about to turn to the Magicat in confusion, she

pauses in mid-motion. Something is off about this view. Something is different. Everything seems a little... brighter. Friendlier.

And when Adora lifts her eyes to the sky, she forgets to breathe for a moment. There is not the usual dark, endless nothingness to be seen, but a dark blue sea filled with thousands and thousands of brilliant lights.

Tiny, sparkling sky crystals that bathe the firmament in unexpected colors. They dispel the darkness of the night and give it a soft, friendly twilight.
"Stars..." Adora whispers Adora, when she eventually finds her voice again.

The sight is overwhelming. More beautiful than the blonde could ever have dreamed of. She can't tear herself away, so she only hears Catra's voice as she explains, "I figured that because of the planet's healing, you probably haven't taken the time to look at them yet."

She hears the Magicat move a little closer to her. Suddenly, a finger slides into her field of vision and points to a small group of stars. "See that circle there formed by the stars? That's a constellation. It's called the 'ring of five.' Supposedly, people used it for coordination."

Surprised, Adora blinks and now tears herself away from the fascinating sight to look at Catra. The Magicat's gaze is fixed on the horizon, and the twinkling of the stars is reflected in her eyes. As if naturally, Catra's outstretched arm points to another spot in the firmament.

"And that one right next to it: see that? The stars here form the legs, those are the wings, and that's the head. It's a Pegasus and it's considered a protective sign. It is said that it was once alive and saved the universe, but had to sacrifice itself to do so. The stars are what's left of it, and now watch over all creatures in its place."

With her mouth open, Adora listens to the stories and myths about various constellations that Catra shows her. She hangs on her lips and eagerly absorbs the knowledge like a sponge that has been drying up for decades.

Amazed, her gaze wanders up to the sky again. For so long, she has wondered what it would be like to stand under a sky full of lights. To no longer be afraid of the dark. And now here she is, completely free of fear and standing next to the most important person in her life. Clearing her throat, Adora wants to take hold of her voice again, turning to Catra.
"How do you know all this?"

The Magicat pauses, suddenly looking embarrassed. Her fingers rub the fabric of her dress as she murmurs, "Well, since there hasn't been much for me to do outside the palace in the last few days, I've been exploring the library and finding out some interesting things."

Is this really the same Catra who used to shirk all tasks, and is now volunteering to further her education? Interested, Adora inquires. "It's really impressive, but.... Why are you doing all this?" The Magicat's answer consists of a simple shrug of the shoulders. As if it's no big deal.

"You know... even though you were always the best at everything, you just suck at fullfilling your own needs. I know you wanted to see the stars, and since you - again - have been busy with thinking of others, I thought at least someone should make sure to grand your wish. Is... that okay?"

Catra seems hesitant, maybe even afraid of the answer. But Adora cannot answer immediately. The Magicat's words make a chord in her tingle. It is as if her heart begins to quiver. The blonde has no description to express how overwhelmed and moved she is by her gesture.

It is so small. So simple. And yet, there is such a powerful message in it.

Catra is there.
She has always been there.
She thinks of Adora's well-being when no one else does. She holds her when the blonde is in free fall. She builds her up when Adora doubts herself.

She is the counterpart Adora needs to feel complete.

And that's exactly what she wants Catra to be. With tears in her eyes and her voice quivering, she replies, "That is the most precious gift I ever got, Catra. Thank you!"

Although Catra begins to beam, Adora is momentarily dissatisfied. Her words feel inadequate; they don't even begin to describe how she feels. Maybe that's exactly why she doesn't think further, but overcomes the remaining distance to Catra and kisses her.

Catra:

Frozen in place, Catra allows Adora's lips to rest gently on hers. Automatically her eyes fall closed, and when she is sure that this is not a dream, her muscles relax and her thoughts turn off for a moment.

Determined, she leans towards Adora and very carefully wraps her arms around her shoulders. A warm hand strokes the Magicat's cheek, causing a tingling sensation that extends down to her collarbone. Adora kisses her tenderly, but at the same time with an intensity that takes her breath away.

Both quiver with unspoken feelings that they put into the kiss.
And it feels so damn perfect.
So good that her heart almost aches. Almost.

They stay like that for what feels like an eternity, until they finally pull away from each other to catch their breath. Before Catra's head can catch up with her and question this situation, exposing a

possible trap or illusion, Adora beats her to it by blurting out, "I love you!"

Her mouth drops open. The Magicat is sure she has misheard. She just has to, hasn´t she?. "What?" she huffs, blinking, cursing that rising, nervous tingle inside her. But there is nothing stirring in Adora's face that indicates dishonesty. Nothing that suggests her bubble is about to burst. She really means it.

"I love you, Catra. I always have." She... always has? Speechless, she looks at Adora.
The woman who has always been at her side. Who understands her better than anyone else. Who is there for her when everyone else has given up on her. And who now looks at her with an openness that takes her breath away. Is this really happening? Is something good really happening to her? Is she allowed to get involved?

Her hesitation turns to determination as she clearly rediscovers her own feelings in the blue eyes. A liberated smile forms on her lips as she carefully brushes a strand of hair from Adora's face.
"I love you too, Adora."

The blonde lowers her shoulders and beams. As if she was afraid before that Catra might run away because of her confession.
But the Magicat has had enough of running away. She is ready to face fate.
Therefore, she leans forward and kisses Adora again, who is only too happy to return the kiss.

Despite her eyes being closed, the Magicat feels the wide grin on the blonde's lips and has to laugh because she can't stop it. It is a liberated laugh that surprises her herself. Smiling, she pulls back a bit to look at Adora.
She too seems liberated. Free from any worries.
Relaxed.
Happy.
At this moment, she is as beautiful as she has ever been.

And although Catra feels nothing but happiness at this moment, she still has to clarify one thing. Uncertainly, but with a spark of hope, she asks,
"Will you stay with me?"
The suppressed fear is hard to ignore. But Adora smiles and looks at her piercingly as she squeezes the Magicat's hand.
"Forever." she assures.

Relieved, Catra smiles a little wider and finally allows hope to spread completely within her, before pulling Adora into a hug.
"You promise?"
The blonde pulls her close.
"I promise."

Chapter End Notes

So... this is it. That's the end of the story. It feels weird to write that...
I wanted to say a big THANK YOU to you all, guys. You helped me so much during this process, always keeping my motivation and creativity up. Without you I'd probably given up at some point. You are the best! <3
For those of you who are sad this story ends: I have some short stories in mind that I will soon share on this platform.
Fun fact in the end: Originally I planned Catra to confess first, but my girl Adora was just so in awe that she beat me to it and there was nothing I could do about it, haha

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